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12 Sections



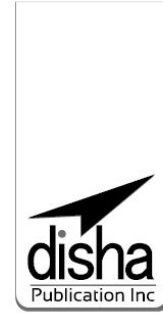
151 ESSAYS

for **IAS/ PCS**
& other Competitive Exams

An Anthology of Essays/ Articles on

- Polity & Governance
 - World Polity
 - Economy
 - Environment
 - Social Justice
 - Social Development
- Social Challenges
 - Ethics & Integrity
 - Education
 - Society & Culture
 - Science & Technology
 - Life & Philosophy

3rd Edition



151 ESSAYS

for **IAS/ PCS**
& other Competitive Exams

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Delhi 110017 Tel 49842349-49842350

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GUIDELINES FOR ESSAY WRITING

An essay is an extended piece of writing which makes a case for the validity of a particular point of view analysis interpretation or set of facts or procedures. Essays can be argumentative, descriptive, synoptic, analytical, exploratory, or a review, but they all have the common objective of presenting and defending a topic and a stance to the reader. So the merit of an essay lies not only in the validity of the facts presented but also on the selection, critical evaluation, organization, and presentation of these facts. Essay writing is a methodic exercise which demands a stepwise planning and brainstorming on the following aspects:

A. THE FORM OF THE TOPIC

1. If the topic is in question form such as "What do you think about...?" you must take an unbiased stand.
2. If the topic is a statement like "Women in parliament: achievements and prospects," you have the scope of exploring the topic from multiple perspectives, introducing relevant facts, and concluding the way you want. However, the conclusion must be balanced and justified.

B. THE APPROACH OF THE ESSAY

1. Most topics demand a balanced approach. You should be objective in expressing your opinion.
2. You must support your opinion, stance, and arguments with evidences and examples.
3. You should prioritize points according to their importance and value so that the most important points can be dealt with in the first paragraph after introduction and so on.
4. You must logically interlink the points and present only those that are relevant to the topic.

C. THE FRAMEWORK OF THE ESSAY

- 1 Introduction State the purpose of essay in the introduction A good introduction clearly tells the readers what to expect in the rest of the essay and generates the curiosity of the reader to read on
- 2 Body of Essay The main body of essay starts after introduction according to importance of points mentioned in the introduction in a paragraph form Your initial information must be true It could simply be a pertinent fact that explicitly illustrates the points you wish to make If you use a piece of startling information follow it with a few sentences in support Each point argument must be based on reasoning and logic and supported with relevant evidences and examples Make judicious use of connective and transition sentences in and between paragraphs
- 3 Conclusion A logical or expository essay must lead to a conclusion You should not repeat the content of the introduction in conclusion nor should you sum up your essay in conclusion Rather you should conclude with what understanding the points discussed in your essay have finally led to strictly in parlance with the topic of the essay

SECTION-A: POLITY & GOVERNANCE

Importance of Right to Vote in a Democracy – Electoral Malpractices & Reforms in India



India got its freedom through a long struggle. With this freedom, India achieved Universal Suffrage, which means that every citizen above the age of 18 is allowed to vote. The vision of our freedom fighters thus got embarked in the right to vote. Voting is the agent of change and is a Constitutional right of citizens over 18 years of age in India. It offers every citizen a medium of expression and the process of voting allows every citizen to have a say in what should constitute the matters of importance by voting for the candidate he or she deems fit for the purpose. Though the outcome of elections is hardly ever predictable; yet if citizens don't cast their vote then they are giving up on the chance of getting heard.

In a populous democracy like India, a voter might think that a vote doesn't matter but when this thought prevails over the nation; then citizens might miss out from helping the best candidate win the election. Both as a right and responsibility, voting lays the foundation of the Indian democracy. Citizens need to be careful about their power of casting a vote in order to strengthen the existence of the democratic Republic.

Voting is a sort of honour granted to the citizens by the founding fathers of the Constitution of India. Citizens demonstrate their respect for the history of the country through exercising their right to vote. By not casting their vote, the citizens in a way improve the chances of the unsuitable ones winning the polls. And as a whole, the voter has to suffer through poor governance at the end.

Being the most essential element of the electoral system, the right to vote is universal and equal and gives to the citizens the freedom to choose among various candidates or political parties in elections. As every vote counts, so the responsibility lies on every individual to vote responsibly. The voters in India have also been offered the provision to exercise their vote even if they aren't happy with any of the candidates. Known as NOTA- 'None of the Above' is an important vote to cast for those who aren't satisfied by any of the standing parties.

Electoral Malpractices

As the signpost of democracy, elections at regular intervals make the most significant features of a democratic polity. These act as a medium of reflection of the attitudes, values and beliefs of the people towards their political environment. Acting as the central democratic procedure for selecting and controlling leaders, elections also symbolize the sovereignty of the people and provide legitimacy to the authority of the government.

But the electoral system in India has been restricted by many obstacles and dampening factors, that encourage the anti-social elements to jump into the electoral battle.

Electoral malpractice, also known as electoral fraud, electoral manipulation or electoral rigging is the interference with the process of election in an illegal manner. It can be done either by increasing the share of the vote of the favoured candidate or by depressing the share of the vote of the rival candidate.

Electoral malpractice can be in the form of use of money power or muscle power or even manipulation through media. Right from the distribution of tickets by the political parties, the use of money power begins. Those candidates who can contribute maximum money to the party corpus and have fat bank balance to purchase votes, are given importance and this way the personal qualities of the prospective candidates get ignored by most political parties.

Clubs and organizations are given handsome donations and crowds are rented for party meetings, mad shows, rallies and campaigns. Public morality thus gets ignored this way by political parties in their struggle to capture power.

One of the biggest challenges in elections remains the use of muscle power that dictates the selection of candidates and party, forcing people against voting freely. Widespread use of muscle power can be seen in the form of heavy monetary demands to candidates, imposing ban on filing nominations, ban on election campaigns and even forcing people whom to vote for or not to vote.

Besides these, the deteriorating law and order is often capitalized by many candidates to their advantage to win elections. The free employment of muscle power has erupted election related violence at several places during the polls. Political ethics have been forgotten by most of the political parties who openly take support from banned armed groups.

Media has also contributed to the electoral malpractices in spite of playing a neutral role in a democratic society. Whereas in a democratic election, the media reporting and publication of political views including the projection of party and candidates' images impact the voting pattern directly, media plays a crucial role in the same. Favoritism and misquoting have become the recent trend of the media. Media persons are often found indulged in publication of misleading news and views.

Other malpractices include freebies, booth capturing, proxy voting, unfair means of election conducting, hate speeches against the contesting parties and vote bank politics to name a few.

Electoral Reforms

The Election Commission has expressed its concern and anxiety many a time for removing obstacles in the way of free and fair polls. A number of recommendations have thus been made and the government has been repeatedly reminded about the necessity of

changing the existing laws so that the electoral malpractices are checked.

Electoral reforms include following aspects:

- Freeing the election process from muscle and money power
- Transparency about the background of the candidates
- Prohibiting the nexus between business and politics
- Upholding the secrecy of voters
- Fair registration and recognition of the political parties without any kind of influence
- Solution of delisting of illiterate voters
- Non-partisan role of media
- Applying model code of conduct efficiently
- Expediting and rationalizing the electoral processes

India already has laws to check electoral malpractices in the form of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, Election Code of Conduct and so on.

Political party funding reform has been enacted through various changes to the Company Laws, through Money Bills, the Income Tax Laws, through Supreme Court orders and so on.

Anti-Defection Law

Passed in 1985, through the 52nd Amendment to the Constitution, this law intends to combat the evil of political defections by elected politicians for the lure of office.

SC in 2002 has directed all contesting candidates to furnish all personal information, including the criminal record at the time of filing nomination papers.

State funding of political parties by means of a National Electoral Fund or on the basis of the number of votes obtained is a valid proposal. Capping the expenditure of political parties and giving the Election Commission of India the powers to deregister unruly political

parties are few of the proposed reforms. Revisiting the Information Technology Act is also another requisite for strengthening the social media regulations and inclusion of the proportional representation system along with depoliticization of constitutional appointments by appointing of the Commissioners through a broad-based collegium makes sense.

NRC Issue and its Impacts on India's ties with its Neighbours

With the purpose of identifying the Indian citizens in the state of Assam, a register containing all the names of genuine Indian citizens was prepared in 1951, which is called the National Register of Citizens (NRC). The NRC is a list of people who have legally earned the confirmation of being Indian citizens with the supporting evidence that they came to India before 24 March 1971. This day is marked as a landmark because before this day, India's neighbouring country Bangladesh was declared independent from Pakistan. NRC became a tool to control unabated migration from Bangladesh.

It will form the basis for detecting illegal migrants and people included in this list will be provided protection against harassment and also enjoy all constitutional rights and safeguards and will also be benefitted by government schemes. The updating process has been initiated in the year 2013 under strict monitoring and supervision of the Supreme Court of India and it ended on 31 August 2015. Through 68.31 lakh applications, around 3.29 crore people were included in the verification process.

For registration in the NRC, the eligibility entails such persons whose names appear in the list of 1951 and have their names appear in any of the electoral rolls up to March 24, 1971. Descendants of such persons also fall in the list. Other than these, such persons who came from another region on or after January 1, 1966 but before March 25, 1971 and got them registered with the Foreigners Registration Regional Officer and were declared as Indian citizens by the Foreigner Tribunal also are held eligible.

Updating of the data of the legal citizens began in the 1980s in Assam due to the feeling of alienation amongst the natives in the state. So, the All Assam Students' Union (AASU) and Assam Gana Parishad submitted a memorandum seeking the demand of updating the list and also to preserve the indigenous culture of Assam from illegal immigrants from Bangladesh. Those citizens of Assam who prove their residency in the state on or before March 21, 1971 will be counted in the updated list.

Impact on India's ties with Neighbours

As per the latest list published in August this year, around 2 million people have been excluded from the list and they are posed to the threat of statelessness. It is still not clear where will such huge number of immigrants be given shelter. The irregular flow from Assam to Bangladesh can lead to additional distress and there is probability of Bangladesh perceiving it negatively.

The present ties between India and Bangladesh are tilted towards shared interests and growth. However, with NRC issue raising a speculated uncertainty regarding the settlement of the non-citizens, Bangladesh cannot be given any benefit of doubt to point fingers towards India. India already is putting forward its clever steps while talking about river water sharing, border infiltration, trade, technology and other economical ties with Bangladesh. Amidst all such healthy talks and positive bonding, any casual handling of the NRC issue and non-citizens may trigger Bangladesh's anguish against India. Thus, the current situation demands for making a wise diplomatic concession that does not hurt the sentiments of India's neighbourhood, nor does it invite unwanted attention from the international arena.

Domestic and International Implications

The voice of creation of a separate NRC list is being raised in Nagaland as well and soon the turmoil may spread to other states. This might leave many more stateless and add to the millions who

have been excluded currently in Assam. As the biggest problem points towards the battle that these excluded people will have to fight in the foreigners' tribunals; a series of litigations follow as another botheration for them. Most of those excluded are poor, daily wage earners, with little or no literacy and legal knowledge. This makes their problem worse and condition even more deteriorating.

While majority of those who did not make it to the list still have their family members in the list, concerns are raised regarding the procedural transparency as well. The whole process of updating the list and filtering of the migrants is itself a lengthy, time-taking one; involving people from government jobs doing their roles and no additional officials are hired for the same. This hinders the day-to-day functioning of the concerned government offices and thus creates more room for disorder and mismanagement.

Uncertainty looms large over the already stateless people and additional calls for updating the NRC list in other states may create a huge mess for the country as a whole. International bodies and human rights commissions may raise their concerns and India can be seen in a bad light over the pretext of human rights.

While the basic dignity of the weak, voiceless and vulnerable is at stake, the exploitation of the situation by some vested groups might open up a new dimension in the regional identity politics. India and Bangladesh do not have a deportation treaty and so it will never accept the deported persons without checking their integrity with their records. The present government has given a boost to the Act East policy of India and so there is a need for political stability in the north east as the region is crucial for investments and engaging trade and commerce.

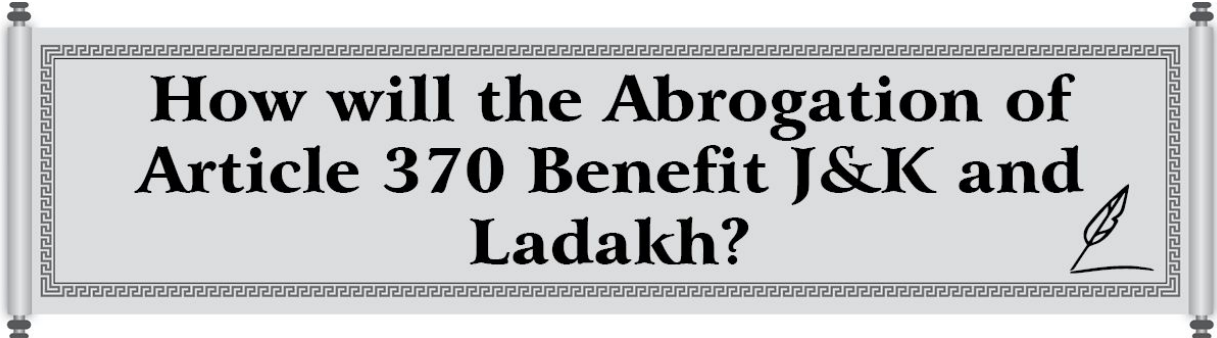
Another issue is that most of the tribal population in the state register themselves with tribal identity and not as Assamese. The campaign to update the NRC has upset everyone and the challenges of being faced by legal recourse post exclusion, will face objections and highlighting by the international community. The NRC process has

also provided the political fuel to push the demand for The Citizenship Amendment Bill, which seeks for allowing minority Hindus, Christians, Parsis, Jains and Buddhists except Muslims from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan. This can have dangerous consequences as it fundamentally remakes citizenship in India.

Tens of thousands of Bengali Muslims have been hit the worst. Bangladesh has already accepted 10 lakh Rohingyas as a humanitarian gesture and accepting anyone from Assam would be seen as a surrender to India. China may play foul in distorting relations between India and its neighbours and thus it is required that the matter which started as an internal call, should stay internal and a sovereign matter of India.

The problem requires an analytical and not compromising solution. It asks for resolution of the situation through diplomatic assessment rather than treating it as an opportunity to play vote politics by regional and national parties. Government of India must take a collaborative approach of private-public bodies to disseminate the requisite machinery to the state and those rendered stateless. Human rights must be ensured as the foremost right and rest shall follow suit. The focus of the governing bodies should be on maintaining the transparency of the system and the updating process, so that not a single innocent person is debarred from his or her genuine right of citizenship. Enhancing the systematic functioning of the procedural norms and supporting the people get their authenticated documents requisite for the same, would help both sides. India should be prepared diplomatically, economically, socially and geographically to sustain the immigrants in case of no final solution to those who are rendered stateless and homeless.

How will the Abrogation of Article 370 Benefit J&K and Ladakh?



Article 370 was included in the Constitution of India on October 17, 1949 and exempted Jammu & Kashmir from the Indian Constitution (except Article 1 and Article 370 itself). It further allowed J&K to draft its own Constitution and restricted Parliament's legislative powers in respect of J&K. Consultation of the state government was a requisite for extending central law on subjects included in the Instrument of Accession (IoA). However, the concurrence of the state government was mandatory for extending it to other matters. With the Indian Independence Act, 1947 the British India got divided into India and Pakistan and at the same time the IoA came into existence.

The Act provided to the nearly 600 princely states three options: to remain an independent country, join Dominion of India or join Dominion of Pakistan – and this joining with either of the two countries was to be through an IoA. The state willing to join was given the choice of specifying the terms on which it agreed to join.

Article 370 itself mentions Article 1, which includes J&K in the list of states and has been described as a tunnel through which the Constitution is applied to J&K. Article 3 of the J&K Constitution declares J&K to be an integral part of India.

Recent Developments Around Article 370

The contentious Article 370, which provided a special status to J&K, has been revoked recently on August 5 by the present Modi government. J&K has further been divided into two UTs – J&K and Ladakh. This far-reaching decision seeks to redraw the map and

future of a region at the centre of protracted militancy. The two UTs would come to existence on October 31.

The President Ram Nath Kovind in his Independence Day speech expressed his confidence about the immense benefits that the new law and bifurcation of the state of J&K would bring. The changes made in J&K and Ladakh would enable the people to access and enjoy the same rights, privileges and facilities as their fellow citizens in the rest of the country.

Besides progressive, egalitarian laws and provisions related to the Right to Education, people of the region would also be able to access public information through the Right to Information. The traditionally deprived communities will have access to reservations in education and employment and other facilities. The abolition of unequal practices such as instant triple talaq would serve justice to the Muslim women of the region.

Key Notes from the Prime Minister's Address Post Revocation of Article 370

- Besides helping in the development of the youth in the region, this act will usher in a new dawn there.
- Jammu & Kashmir will witness assembly elections from now onwards and people there will have a Chief Minister, MLAs and ministers who will represent them and people will also be choosing their representatives.
- After 1947, many people who came to India couldn't contest polls in Jammu & Kashmir as they had rights everywhere, except in Jammu & Kashmir. Now with the scrapping of Article 370, the rights of such migrated people will be restored.
- More so, the valley suffered from terrorism and violence where Articles 35A and 370 were often used as tools to spread the same.
- When laws were made for the entire country, J&K was always exempted from the benefits of such progressive laws.

- All J&K workers will be benefitted under the employment schemes provided by the government.
- The decision of creating two UTs namely Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh was taken by the government after constructive discussions and weighed options. The region will witness the opening of IITs and IIMs and after the normalization of condition in the region, the status of “Statehood” will be brought back in Jammu and Kashmir.
- The state can become the biggest tourist destination as the government is working on providing a peaceful environment for tourists and the creative bodies (film & theatre) to engage with the state.
- Sports will get a boost and sporting talents will be provided with the much needed infrastructure to excel.
- Many endemic plants grown in Jammu & Kashmir can be used for their medicinal properties.
- Ladakh can become a solar power house and play a crucial role in International Solar Alliance. Without any sort of discrimination, there will be development in the UT.
- The separatists and their separatists’ tendencies will now be given befitting reply by the people.
- People in the valley region will celebrate festivities without any hurdles.
- The dreams of accelerated development, effective and transparent governance and yet a smaller footprint of government in people’s everyday life would now be realized with ease.

Key Changes:

- The ending of the special status of J&K in the Indian Union will now let the government extend all provisions of the Constitution to the State in one go. Besides this, it will also allow all citizens to buy property and vote in the State.

- All Central laws, instruments and treaties will now be extended to Kashmir. The drastically altered Article 370 will however stay on the statute books.
- The Union Territory of J&K will have a legislature, but Ladakh will not have the same.
- The Bill proposes wide powers to the Lieutenant Governor of the proposed Union Territory of J&K and makes it the “duty” of the Chief Minister of the Union Territory to “communicate” all administrative decisions and proposals of legislation with the LG.
- The new Union Territories of J&K and Ladakh will see the application of all the Central laws and State laws.
- Assets and liabilities of J&K and Ladakh would be shared on the recommendations of a Central Committee within a year.
- Until all the allocations of employees of State public sector undertakings and autonomous bodies are determined, they will continue in their posts for another year.
- The police and public order is to be with the Centre.
- The notification amends the expression “Constituent Assembly”, contained in the proviso to clause (3) of Article 370, to mean “Legislative Assembly”.

Impact:

The tabling of the proposed Reorganization Bill indicates the end of the long reign of the 1954 order that had introduced a proviso to Article 3 that states that “no Bill providing for increasing or diminishing the area of the State of J&K or altering the name of that State shall be introduced in Parliament without the consent of the Legislature of that State”. That power of the State Legislature to give prior consent does not exist anymore.

With this, the Parliamentary laws including that of reservation, would apply to J&K as it does in other parts of the country. It further mandates that no proclamation of Emergency on grounds “only of

internal disturbance or imminent danger shall have effect” in the State unless with the concurrence of the State government.

This has been called by the government as the end of “positive discrimination” and the closing of the ‘gap’ between residents of J&K and citizens of other parts of the country.

Panchayati Raj: Key to Good Governance



Defined as a political system that has originated from the Indian subcontinent and found mainly in India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Nepal, the Panchayati Raj is the oldest system of local government in the Indian subcontinent. Its origin dates back to 250 CE period. Formed by combining two words 'Panchayat' meaning 'assembly of five' and raj meaning 'rule', it traditionally consisted of wise and respected elders chosen and accepted by the local community.

The Panchayati Raj has been advocated by Mahatma Gandhi as the foundation of India's political system which would feature a decentralized form of government. He gave the concept of Gram Swaraj ('village self-government'), where each village would be responsible for its own affairs. Later, India developed a highly centralized form of development and yet through decentralization of several administrative functions to the local level, the elected gram panchayats got empowered.

Conceptualized through the 73rd constitutional amendment made to the Indian Constitution in 1992, the local self government got its prominence in the Parliamentary democracy of India. Its formal organization and structure was first recommended by Balwant Rai Committee, 1957. In its report, the committee recommended the establishment of the scheme of 'democratic decentralization', which ultimately came to be known as Panchayati Raj. A three tier system at village, block and district level was recommended and Rajasthan was the first state to establish Panchayati Raj as it started from Nagaur district on October 2, 1959.

Powers and Responsibilities

The Panchayats may be endowed with such powers and authority as may be necessary by the State Legislature to enable the Panchayats to become institutions of self-government at the grassroots level. They may be given responsibility to prepare plans for economic development and social justice with regard to 29 important matters mentioned in XI schedule such as agriculture, primary and secondary education, health and sanitation, drinking water, rural housing, the welfare of weaker sections, social forestry and so forth may be made by them.

Functions

All Panchayati Raj Institutions perform such functions as are specified in state laws relating to Panchayati Raj.

The civic functions relating to sanitation, cleaning of public roads, minor irrigation, public toilets and lavatories, primary health care, vaccination, the supply of drinking water, constructing public wells, rural electrification, social health and primary and adult education are obligatory functions of village panchayats.

The optional functions depend on the resources of the panchayats. They may or may not perform such functions as tree plantation on roadsides, setting up of breeding centres for cattle, organizing child and maternity welfare, promotion of agriculture and so on.

The 73rd Amendment widened the scope of functions of Gram Panchayat and significant functions like preparation of annual development plan of Panchayat area, annual budget, relief in natural calamities, removing encroachment on public lands and implementation and monitoring of poverty alleviation programmes are now expected to be performed by them.

Gram Panchayats in certain states have also been provided the functions like selecting the beneficiaries through Gram Sabhas, public distribution system, non-conventional energy source, improved Chullas and biogas plants.

Power to Panchayati Raj means power to the people

Such devolution of power simply reveals the readiness of both the central and state governments to give real power to PRIs. The thought process behind the formulation of PRIs was the making of democracy functional at the local level. It decentralized the democratic set-up by widening political representation of different social groups, especially women. It also gave a hope of enabling the building of efficient local institutions that could plan, execute and monitor their communities' development through a participatory approach.

Almost 26 years on, these ideas have been lived by the PRI system in India and that can be seen as success indicator. Election to these local bodies has been carried out on a regular basis in the country. Furthermore, out of 32 states, 19 have taken measures and reserved 50% of seats for women in these local bodies.

According to the available data the recent figure of the elected Panchayati Raj representatives is estimated to be around three million, of which 19% were from Scheduled Caste, 12% from Scheduled Tribe communities and 46% were women. The system of PRI has thus certainly deepened the political representation in the country.

Considering the fact that the socio-cultural systems in the country are mostly caste and gender biased the inclusion and representation of women, scheduled tribes and scheduled castes is critical and appealing. If we want to focus on particular developmental issues and bring in equity, then we must vote for equal representation and that essentiality has truly been understood and followed by the PRIs.

Need of improvement

Although a well-thought-out plan through provisional set up has been laid down with regard to the PRIs in India, yet there are certain issues

which need to be resolved soon.

- The officials and state leadership are not willing to provide real power to the local elected leaders.
- Institutional structures such as the district planning boards which have been created to accelerate decentralized planning, are either non-functional or the PRIs aren't given much priority.
- There has been minimal and limited effort to empower the elected PRI representatives with their constitutional functions. On the contrary, the focus has been largely on trainings on the schemes and programmes.
- Besides the already designated functionaries of the PRIs, the state and central governments have started creating separate structures or units for implementing specific projects on education, health and so on. This has further limited the role and powers of the PRIs.
- In many cases, the PRI representatives have become just implementers and followers contrary to the idea of building them as local leaders leading local development.

Steps for making them truly effective

It is high time to shift the base from political representation to power devolution. The state political leadership needs to accept the significance of the PRIs and devolve power to them as mandated in the Constitution of India. The government should focus on their capacity building and strengthen their role as planners and evaluators in order to reap the true benefits of e-governance and good governance throughout the country.

The elected local leaders should also come together with their constituents and demand of more control and autonomy which they must be provided as per the provisions of the Constitution.

Lack of funds and structural issues always make the PRIs take a back step. Thus, bottom up planning, especially at the district level is required.

The states need to be financially incentivized by the centre so that they are encouraged to effectively devolve finances, functions and functionaries to the Panchayats.

Recently states like Haryana and Rajasthan had set up certain minimum qualification standards for Panchayat election. Such necessary eligibility can help in improving effectiveness of governance mechanism.

There is a need for holistic change in the lives of beneficiaries among the villagers through upliftment of their socio economic and health status. This is possible only through effective linkages through community, governmental and other developmental agencies.

Remedial measures in interest of democracy, social inclusion and cooperative federalism need to be taken by the government at its earliest.

Government Surveillance and Right to Privacy



The lack of data privacy protections by tech companies such as Facebook and Google recently has led to an uproar by the citizens worldwide. Studying comprehensively on the issue, it seems that it is governments which might emerge the biggest threat. The American market research and advisory company Forrester Researcher in its latest report has mentioned that India is among the list of countries where government surveillance has become a major concern from a data privacy perspective.

According to the 2019 Forrester Global Map of Privacy Rights and Regulations, the governments' autocratic access to citizen's personal data, despite protections makes the biggest concern in regard to privacy.

India has been named as a country with minimal restrictions in terms of data privacy and protection where government surveillance is a matter of caution alongside countries with high-level of government surveillance, such as China. India with nil to negligent data privacy norms in place is among the top countries where unchecked government surveillance has led to increased data privacy concerns as per the report. It also termed the surveillance carried by India and others such as China, Austria, Columbia, Kuwait and the UK to be at 'alarming levels'. Among these, India's legal and constitutional provisions for data privacy and protection were reported to be minimal.

Surveillance by law enforcement agencies has been at the heart of Indian privacy-rights lawmaking. The narrowly tailored surveillance has been established by the early landmark cases of M.P. Sharma,

Kharak Singh and Gobind; which were all concerned with physical surveillance by local police. Thus, having a careful glance over these cases depicts the need for a compelling state interest as foundational principles of Indian policy lawmaking.

In India, the fight against surveillance can be traced back to the 1980s and 90s when activists opposed the illegal phone-tapping by the state, carried out under the garb of security requirement. A nationwide outcry against phone-tapping resulted in a probe by Central Bureau of Investigation, which pointed out how the Rajiv Gandhi government used to engage in constant surveillance of the Opposition, and sometimes, members of its own Cabinet. The issue was heard before the Supreme Court after a PIL was filed by the People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL). In a landmark judgment in the PUCL Vs Union of India case (1996), the court held that illegal phone-tapping was a violation of the citizens' fundamental right to privacy. The court decision also created adequate safeguards to ensure that the state's surveillance powers were not misused.

Test of Privacy

Significant concerns for the protection of the right to privacy in India rose after an office order issued by the Ministry of Home Affairs in India on 20th December 2018, which authorized excess of security and intelligence agencies to intercept, monitor and decrypt all personal data on computers and networks in India. The Order is issued under Rule 4 of the Information Technology Act Interception Rules 2009, which gives Home Ministry the right to delegate its powers of interception, monitoring and decryption to an 'agency of the Government'.

India's privacy jurisprudence has advanced tremendously since the passing of the IT Act Interception Rules 2009 as the threshold for a constitutional privacy intrusion was increased in the Puttaswamy and Aadhar judgments of the Indian Supreme Court. These judgments depict two insights which prove the old age framework of India's surveillance.

First insight states that right to privacy is now a constitutionally recognized right. The Court in its earlier judgments was concerned with an individual's liberty interest under Article 21 of the Constitution, which is much narrower than the current conceptualization of the right to privacy. The recently recognized aspects of privacy which provide protection for the 'inner domain of consciousness', informational self-determination and decisional autonomy are violated by a surveillance regime that lacks judicial oversight or adequate transparency mechanisms. In the 2018 Aadhar judgment, the Supreme Court recognized this and mandated judicial oversight for information sharing requests for Aadhar data. It analyzed the State's imperative to access information against the parameters of the new, broad right to privacy. This way, the Court ruled that judicial oversight is a necessary pre-condition for limitation of privacy interests.

Secondly, the SC has recognized in both the cases the deeply invasive role of the internet and computers over the last few years. People's lives are deeply interconnected with technology and a vast amount of personal, financial and sensitive data passes through today's computers, at a scale incomparable to the context in which the PUCL guidelines were formulated. The legal foundation of the computer interception directive could be still challenged in court because it has not yet been considered in light of the privacy judgment. However, it is now a matter of Constitutional validity.

The nature of technological interactions today allows for very precise inferences to be drawn about people on the basis of their activity on the internet. This presents serious dangers for freedom of expression, dissent and activism on the internet, especially with all of India's law enforcement watching. Consequently, it appears unwise to deploy a framework developed in the telephone-era to modern surveillance.

One of the primary reasons for the high level of government surveillance in India could be the lack of Constitutional provisions that enable monitoring of government activity. There is very little

legislative oversight and there is little judicial decision-making around surveillance. These laws and regulations which govern government surveillance are practically very few.

Citizen's Right to Privacy

The right to privacy is the right to be free from undue surveillance by Government or anyone else. Surveillance by the State should only occur if absolutely necessary and where authorized by an independent judicial officer. Personal information should only be collected and kept by the State and anyone else for a legitimate purpose authorized by law. Once collected, personal information should be destroyed as soon as it is no longer required. Not only would this protect privacy, it would also improve security. If personal information is only collected when absolutely necessary, it is less likely to fall into the wrong hands. If it is destroyed when it is no longer required, it is less likely to become incorrect and out of date.

The majority of democratic countries have recognized that privacy is a fundamental human right which needs to be protected. An actionable right to privacy would enable individuals to take action against the inappropriate and illegal collection, use or disclosure of their personal information. It would not prevent the lawful collection and use of personal information for legitimate purposes.

The spread of new technologies such as CCTV and GPS presents new threats to privacy which have outpaced the law. It is futile to try to stop the spread of many of these technologies. However, the legal environment in which they spread should discourage the misuse of personal information. The most effective deterrent to the misuse of personal information would be a liability to compensate people whose privacy has been compromised for no legitimate purpose. The right to privacy is associated with the rights to freedom of speech, freedom of movement, and freedom from discrimination and the principle of government accountability.

Judicial Activism and Judicial Overreach in India



Courts have played a constructive and curative role in innumerable instances, for which they are highly respected by the citizens. Simultaneously, there is a thin line between judicial activism and judicial overreach. Judicial accountability has faced numerous debates in various forums in India and there is a growing dissatisfaction regarding the legislature and executive functions and their ability to deliver effective governance to meet the need and challenges of our times.

Yet, against the backdrop of all this, judiciary has been held in high esteem by the public at large is a matter of immense satisfaction. The judiciary as custodians of our people has discharged its responsibilities very well indeed.

The Indian judiciary is one of the most powerful judiciaries in the world at present and the socialist perception of it is very high. But, particularly in the disciplining of judges of superior court and the representative character of the courts, the accountability mechanisms haven't been equivalent with the power and esteem.

Judicial Review

It has been pronounced by the Supreme Court as a fundamental feature of the Constitution and is understood to be the revision of the decree or sentence of a lower court by a higher court. Testing the constitutional validity of legislative provisions and the validity of administrative actions is a power commended over to the judiciary alone in our constitutional scheme. This power of judicial review is entrusted with a vision to ensure a system of checks and balances

between the legislature and the executive on one hand and the judiciary on other hand.

Judicial Activism

Courts are no more passive and do not follow a negative attitude of striking down a law or preventing something being done but are rather adopting new attitude towards positive affirmative actions. They are issuing orders and decrees directing remedial actions.

The citizens have come to an opinion that the legislature and the executive have failed miserably in their duties towards the general public and their nearness to the people creates high expectations from the public and also draws sharp criticism whenever their actions fail to match their promises. So, with no other option left, citizens approach the judiciary to redress their grievances and under this situation the judiciary has taken an activist approach.

However, this activist approach is bound to create hostility and strain with legislature and executive.

The theory of judicial activism in India has evolved in the late 1960s or early 1970s when Mrs. Indira Gandhi was the Prime Minister of India. In order to implement her favourite slogan “garibi hatao” (remove poverty), she tried to introduce progressive socialistic measures such as abolishing Privy Purses and privileges given to previous rajas and princes of the princely states of pre-Independent India and nationalizing the 14 major banks to serve the cause of poorer sections more meaningfully.

The conservative judiciary then didn't take it thoughtfully and struck down the pertinent legislation as unconstitutional. This judgement of the Supreme Court of India was considered by Mrs. Indira Gandhi to be judicial overreach.

Judicial Overreach

Judicial activism when reaches an extreme stage where the judiciary makes arbitrary, unreasonable and frequent interventions into the

domain of the legislature through disruption of balance of powers between the executive, legislature and judiciary.

Judicial Activism in India

While dealing with the constitutional validity of the 17th Amendment to the constitution in *Golaknath v State of Punjab* (1971), the Supreme Court evolved the concept of “prospective ruling” and stated that Parliament had no power to amend Part III of the Constitution or take away any of the Fundamental Rights.

Further, in Fundamental Rights case (*Keshavananda Bharti v State of Kerala*, 1973), the Supreme Court delivered a milestone judgment which evolved the theory of “basic structure” of the Constitution while dealing with the question of extending the amending power under Article 368 of the Constitution.

Parliament according to this judgement was confirmed to have wide powers to amend the Constitution including all the articles without destroying the basic structure or framework of the Constitution.

The court has also performed its service to the welfare of the public, particularly in areas of custodial deaths, prisoners’ rights, abolition of bonded labour, labourers’ rights, fixing absolute liability on hazardous industries, condition of mental homes, regulating pollution and enlarging the scope of “right to life” to name a significant few.

Intrusion from Activism to Overreach

When the obligated functions of the political branches of government are not discharged by the legislature and executive, then confidence of the citizens get eroded from the constitutional values and democracy. The judiciary has to thence, step into the areas generally earmarked for the legislature and executive.

When the government functionaries or any other third party directly or indirectly tread on the Fundamental Rights of the people, the judges may take proactive steps of coming to their aid. They perform the task of helping the distressed citizens cited as judicial activism.

Sometimes, to fill the void created by other organs of the government and to meet the societal needs, the courts indulge in judicial legislation and thereby encroach in the domain of legislature.

The Constitution vests in the Indian judiciary the power of review in order to keep both executive and legislature within the constitutional frameworks. The judiciary can annul any law that goes beyond the legislative competence of the Parliament or violates the Constitution. In case of any illegality or arbitrariness, it can strike down any executive action. This power is encompassed in Articles 13, 21, 32, 226 and 227. On the other hand, a unique, extraordinary power is extended to the Supreme Court by article 142, to do 'complete justice' in any matter before it.

But, some critics claim that this overreach is upsetting the constitutional balance among the three state organs – the legislature, the executive and the judiciary. This judicial activism was once considered as a necessary corrective action against the failing legislature and faulty executive. However, it hasn't culminated to such state of affairs where the basic structure of the Constitution - the separation of powers is challenged.

If the judiciary considers itself the sole guardian of democracy and works on its whims and fancies to create pressure on the legislature and executive, then activism can worsen into overreach. The role of judiciary is to interpret the laws and come to a decision that collates the collective idea of the Constitutional values and nothing more or less is desirable from the judiciary.

The thin line between activism and overreach should be maintained and it should be understood that judicial activism is meant to positively enhance the failings of the executive while the overreach into its domain is akin to invading into democratic functioning.

The prominence of the legislature in policy making need to be maintained in the same manner as the independence of judiciary is

upheld. Interference by courts into their domain is a violation of the basic structure of the Constitution and this is not justifiable.

Like other domains of the democracy, judiciary is also accountable and is expected to know its own limits. The need of the hour is to strengthen the quality and speed of the judicial system, enhance the judicial infrastructure and judges' strength and build judicial competence.

RTI Act, 2005 - Implementation and Challenges



The Right to Information Act (RTI) is an act of the Parliament of India that was passed on 15 June 2005 and came into action on 13 October 2005. Replacing the erstwhile Freedom of Information Act, the RTI act applied to all states and union territories of India except Jammu & Kashmir. The act under its provisions guarantees to any citizen the freedom to request information from a public authority which needs to reply expeditiously or within thirty days. It also requires every public authority to computerize their records to smoothen the wide dissemination. The act relaxes the Official Secrets Act 1923, under which the disclosure of information in India was restricted.

The RTI act holds two key concepts to its heart. One the right of the public to request access to information and other the conformable duty of the government to meet the request unless specific defined exemptions apply.

Thus, both the government and the citizens are duty bound by the RTI. For the citizens, especially when a decision concerns them primarily, the Act entails asking information and using it effectively in the decision- making process. The right to freedom and expression as dictated by the Supreme Court includes:

1. Right to receive, seek and impact ideas and information
2. Right to disseminate and circulate one's ideas and views
3. Right to inform and be informed
4. Right to know

5. Right to reply

6. Right to commercial speech and commercial information

Matters of public interest require authentic information, absence of which may encourage wild rumours and speculations. Thus Right to Information acting as a constitutional right becomes the aspect of the right to free speech and expression which includes the right to receive and collect information. A fully informed citizen is certainly well equipped and all set to perform his duties well. It not just facilitates the participation of people in matters of public affairs by leading them access to relevant information but also empowers them for making choices that are wise and practical and logical in running the democracy.

By improving the decision-making it also enhances the government's accountability and credibility. It is a common person's right. Any individual whether poor or illiterate has the right to know if the government is fulfilling its policies or responsibilities or not. This way power is being placed in people's hands. Information acts as a tool to benefit the people's cause, even to those who are oppressed and vulnerable. Especially when in a developing economy like India, where new economic policies of liberalization, privatization and globalization are being adopted; people should be informed about such issues related to democracy. This helps in its smooth functioning.

Meanwhile, the Government in July 2018 proposed to amend the Right to Information Act, 2005. A notice of intention was given to introduce "The Right to Information (Amendment) Bill, 2018" in the Rajya Sabha for consideration and its passage during the current session of Parliament. The proposed amendments say that the tenure, rank and perks of Central and State Chief Information Commissioners and Information Commissioners will be decided by the central government.

The amendment bill, listed for introduction in the Rajya Sabha on July 19, ran into opposition and the bill had been deferred indefinitely after the Opposition threw its weight behind transparency advocates opposing the changes on the ground that these are intended to weaken the edifice on which RTI stands.

However, the Lok Sabha passed the Right to Information Amendment Bill 2019 on 22 July 2019. In the amendment bill, the government has done away with the fixed tenure of five years for the chief information commissioners and the information commissioners. Their salaries too have been altered. Both will now be separately notified by the government of the day. The opposition protested calling it as a "dark day for democracy".

In a huge step towards transparency, the Supreme Court on November 12, 2019 ruled that office of the Chief Justice of India is a public authority under the ambit of RTI Act, 2005.

Other basic rights like freedom of speech and expression and right to education are closely allied with the right to know. To achieve accountable, transparent and participatory governance, citizens must utilize their right to information. It helps them achieve people-centered development by empowering them and enhancing their control over political processes. It also acts as a deterrent against arbitrary exercise of any official power.

There are some exemptions too which are stated as general rules for refusing a request for information in case of legitimate public interest. Release of information in such cases may lead to violation of personal privacy and affect confidentiality. It may also endanger the safety of the public or an individual. It is also detrimental to the pursued of a criminal case or law enforcement. It may happen to constitute a threat to national security. Disclosure of certain information may threaten to cause substantial harm and undermine the effectiveness and integrity of government decision-making processes.

Connecting with India - the North East



India is a land of many riches. With diversified ecology, cultures, languages spoken, festivals celebrated, and foods, India stands as one of the most colourful and assorted countries. With a beautiful and divergent landscape and heritage, still some of the gems of the country are hidden. One of such gems is the undiscovered North East of the country. Bordering China, Bhutan, Myanmar and Bangladesh, it is connected to the rest of India by a narrow 20 km corridor of land. Popularly called as the 'Seven Sister States' or the 'paradise unexplored', it covers 7 per cent of the total landform of the country and is a name given to the contiguous states of Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, Nagaland, Meghalaya and Tripura. Each state is unique in its own way.

Assam is the densely populated state that occupies the plush lowlands of the Brahmaputra valley. With wide expanse, rich flora and fauna, turbulent waterfalls and aromatised tea gardens, Assam has more to offer apart from its stimulating festivals and fairs.

Arunachal Pradesh is termed as the 'Land of Rising Sun' and allures with its captivating wood locks, enchanting plateaus and deep dales. It also beckons many adventure freaks. Sitting on the foothills of the Himalayas, it attracts tourists because of its Buddhist monasteries and influences. A small and marooned state, bordering Assam is Meghalaya which is rightly called the 'The Abode of Clouds'. The state is the wettest region of the world and is covered with pine clad hills and lakes. Vibrant sunrise and sunset and a rich war history; Nagaland has a lot to attract tourists. As the Centre readies to ink the Naga Peace Accord today, Nagaland remains tense, with the state

bracing for a backlash, following threats by the National Socialist Council of Nagaland (Isak-Muivah) faction to derail the peace process, should the Centre proceed without its participation. Manipur is the 'Land of Jewels', located in between the hilly ranges and providing the most bewildering and bewitching views.

Mizoram and Tripura are lovely and fascinating with rich folklore, virgin terrains and spectacular views of the hills and valleys.

Sikkim was integrated as the eighth North Eastern Council state in 2002. Sikkim is bordered by Nepal to the west, China's Tibet Autonomous Region to the north and east, and Bhutan to the east. West Bengal lies to the south. With 610,577 inhabitants as of the 2011 census, it is the least populous state in India and the second-smallest state after Goa in total area, covering approximately 7,096 km.

Sikkim is geographically diverse due to its location in the Himalayas. The climate ranges from subtropical to high alpine. Kangchenjunga, the world's third-highest peak, is located on Sikkim's border with Nepal. It is also a popular tourist destination because of its culture, scenery and biodiversity. Sikkim's capital and largest city is Gangtok.

Being one of the most ethnically and linguistically diverse regions of the country, each state boasts of its distinct culture and traditions. With bewildering diversity and the magical beauty, the North East of the country is home to more than 166 tribes; some of which have migrated centuries ago from places as far as South East Asia. This amalgamation of different tribes has only given to expand the wide array of cultures, values and languages of the area. Thus since time immemorial, India's North East has been a meeting ground of many cultures, faiths and ethics.

Apart from its prosperous culture, North-East also has a wide range of geographical and ecological diversities which makes it quite different from other parts of the sub-continent. Lush landscapes that are veiled and carpeted by mists in winters, enchanting valleys,

dense jungles, powerful rivers, abundant rains, picturesque hills and green meadows that shelters enormous species of flora and fauna all define the paradise that is North-East of the country.

Besides, there are a large number of beautiful wildlife sanctuaries and national parks that is home to some of the rare animals, plants and birds. The region houses one-horned rhinos, elephants and few other endangered wildlife species. Apart from these, the states are also quite actively involved in outdoor activities such as trekking, angling, boating, rafting and hiking along the gorgeous river Brahmaputra.

The North-East is also seat to many small and large scale industries that are tea-based, silk, bamboo and handicrafts, crude oil and natural gas. Tea estates of the region especially Assam are world famous. Here one can experience the true aroma of tea in the most picturesque locales. All these attractions are surely fascinating to any visitor, but still the tourism in this area is not much developed. Citing security reasons due to disputed borders issues with China, inter-tribal tensions, widespread insurgencies, there are many restrictions and checks on foreigners visiting the states. This has thus hampered the tourism and hospitality industry considerably which could otherwise have been extremely profitable.

Currently, the 'Seven Sisters' have been caught in a flux. The updated National Register of Citizens has driven Assam into a ground of serious turmoil. The final NRC, released on 31st August, excluded about 1.9 million people—which is less than half of the 4 million excluded in the earlier draft list. In Nagaland, the Government cannot accept the Naga demand for a separate flag and a Constitution as demanded by the NSCN-IM for a long time.

This land of paradise is still unexplored and needs proper exposure and promotion to bring forth the hidden glory and suave gem of our country so that we can truly prove that India is truly God's own country.

Right to Privacy - a Fundamental Right



“The right to personal privacy is precious. Without it, we are all potential victims for a prying secret police”.

—Lewis B. Smedes

What is privacy? When one thinks about this term, there is no limit where we can reach. Privacy is a need of the individuals by virtue of his or her existence. In broader aspects, it can be a part of bodily integrity, personal autonomy, protection from state surveillance, informational self-determination, confidentiality, dignity, compelled speech and freedom to more or think. Privacy is the necessity in each and every phase of life.

But in today's day and age of globalisation and digitalisation, privacy is left to be a myth only. The individual space and privacy is often invaded. Internet and social media has certainly a role to play in it. With so much data and connectivity, leak of privacy is obvious. The sharing of information on internet enables websites to mine the data. Google, Amazon, Facebook, Twitter and other websites on which some or the other information of a person is shared tends to be in knowledge of biggest companies to use it as a marketing strategy. Data is the new natural resource. One will be amazed to know that world's largest taxi company, Uber owns no vehicles of its own. The world's most popular media owner, Facebook creates no content. The most valuable retailer, Alibaba has no inventory and the world's largest accommodation provider, Airbnb owns no real estate. With the hi-tech internet today, these organisations are able to figure out about our whereabouts and the places we visit frequently, about our friends, shopping habits and the places we are travelling too. This has in

some way or the other been a boon as well as a bane. This gives immense opportunities for the companies to market themselves online on the cost of hampering individual's privacy.

Privacy enjoys a sturdy legal framework internationally. Article 12 of Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), 1948 and Article 17 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), 1966 legally protects the persons against any interference with one's privacy, family, honour, home, correspondence and reputation. In 1979, India signed and ratified the ICCPR without any reservation. The Charter of Fundamental Rights of the European also recognises the respect for privacy in terms of family, home and communications. It also recognises the protection of any personal information and its collection for a specified legal purpose. Nations like United States, Canada, South Africa, The European Union and UK have recognised privacy as the fundamental right. However, India has recently joined these democratic nations in giving its citizens the right to privacy. It has now been recognised as the fundamental right of citizens of India.

24th August marks the first anniversary of the Supreme Court's reaffirmation of privacy as a fundamental right under the Constitution. The Puttaswamy judgment witnessed a nine-judge bench unanimously held that privacy is a fundamental right enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution of India.

The Constitution of India has till now considered the Right to Privacy extrinsic. Over the years, many people have knocked the doors of the court to justify the breach of privacy. But Supreme Court has denied the right to privacy citing it as alien to the Indian Constitution. The trigger to make privacy a fundamental right of the citizens came into purview after government's Aadhar scheme was questioned for breach of privacy by leakage of personal data. Aadhar was launched by the Central Government as a single identity proof and takes account of your personal details, biometrics and iris scan. Considering how government and service providers seek personal information and how this information can be exploited, the Supreme court nine-judge bench unanimously declared Right to Privacy as an

integral part of Right to Life and Personal Liberty guaranteed in Article 21 of the Constitution. Privacy has been declared a fundamental right as it is intrinsic to the right to life. The government has been asked by the SC to convince them how forcing citizens to give a sample of their fingerprints and their iris scan does not violate privacy. The judgment came out after an intense debate of the bench with legal scholars and prominent lawyers. The Government argued that the founders of the Constitution rejected the idea of inclusion of privacy as a fundamental right. While on the other hand, the petitioners were vocal about how privacy is the need of the hour in this technologically dynamic society where state or private players can intrude into one's personal space and data and how recognition of privacy as a fundamental freedom can help deter it. In fact, Justice Chandrachud aptly described the overall apprehension of the public in his words – "I don't want the state to pass on my personal information to some 2,000 service providers who will send me WhatsApp messages offering cosmetics and air conditioners... That is our area of concern. Personal details turn into vital commercial information for private service providers." Apart from the data mining and leakage, the right to privacy also encompasses the liberty to individuals to have a choice of preferences in different areas of life like what and how one will eat, the way of dressing, whom to marry, one's sexual preferences and even euthanasia. This is a huge change in the history of the country where importance has been given to each person of the society irrespective of their socio-economic background and influence.

With right to privacy in place now, several laws, rules and guidelines will have to be refurbished to make them in accordance of the new fundamental right. Some of these will include homosexuality and LGBT rights, unauthorised phone taps, reproductive right, juvenile justice etc. NATGRID, a programme conceptualised by the Home Ministry post the 26/11 Mumbai attacks which requires integration of 25 categories of database from various agencies like railways, banks, airlines, credit card companies, immigration, etc. to make it accessible to law enforcement officers, will also seek amendments in

several laws which includes transferring of data related to bank and property. This privacy judgement will prove to be in interest of the general public and the state and non-state players will have to find other ways to commercialise themselves.

The Right to Privacy will empower the citizens of the country which sometimes gets exploited knowingly and unknowingly with regard to their personal information. With society being empowered, the country will see a new rise of growth and development on the lines of equality and justice.

Right to Dissent - the Foundation of Democracy

A democracy without a dissenter in it is impossible to imagine. In the exercise of free thought, free men are sure to express free speech. So, even if such thought is revolting or its manner of expression is despicable, a mature democracy will tolerate it and encourage its publication.

Dissenting is very much a part of history of human civilization. Dissent can't be defined as anti-national. Going back to 1570, Martin Luther nailed on the door of a church in Germany, 95 objections to the Catholic faith which led to the evolution of Protestantism. Galileo challenged the Church through his statement of the fact that the Earth and other planets revolve round the Sun.

Progress of mankind is all about a history of informed dissent. History has survived innumerable dissenting voices and all sorts of high quality creative activities in various areas of human venture are nothing but dissent.

In the age that we live, democracy is favoured as the most acceptable form of governance. What makes democracy different from the colonial regime, Hitler's Germany or Stalin's USSR, is the right to dissent that democracy bestows upon its citizen. While dissent could lead to the severest of punishments or even loss of life in colonial India or under Hitler's and Stalin's rule, dissent in democracy is an exercise of one's right without the fear of victimization as long as it doesn't lead to inhuman or unconstitutional action.

Dissent can be treated as salt of democracy. Tagging the dissenters as anti-nationals has diluted the whole idea and basis of democracy

and its fundamentals.

The house arrest of five activists by the Pune Police who were allegedly suspected to be involved in the violence in Bhima-Koregaon in Maharashtra; and the questions put forth by the police on their belief system just because their house interiors had photos of Phule and Ambedkar presents a harsh reality of the modern society that we dwell in. In the same case, the Supreme Court had stated that “Dissent is the safety valve of democracy. If dissent is not allowed, the pressure cooker will burst. Compress the pressure cooker.”

In debating for nationalism and patriotism, we tend to forget that dissent is a legitimate political expression that stands as valid in a democracy. If a certain path is chosen by the society, then dissent lends an alternative route, in case the one chosen by the society turns out to be wrong or dangerous.

Dissidents, who question the system, argue with the administration and put forth their views before the government is often labeled as “urban naxals” and their voices are termed as “seditious.” This tactic works only for diverting the attention of the masses from the issues of much essential economic management and social development. The real core issues that are for the betterment of society are put on a stand-by mode and the media and political establishment put across interrogations and humiliating remarks on those who raise their voices. Everyone just stops caring about the real venomous parasites—corruption, mismanagement, unemployment and inflation- which are the real issues. Efforts are made to suppress such voices which are really a matter for the improvement and betterment of the country.

The murders of writers Dabholkar, Kalburgi and Gauri Lankesh Gauri Lankesh is proof bigotry and intolerance have put a fatal tear in our national soul. Even actors like Amir Khan and Nasiruddin when spoke their minds publicly, are termed as anti-nationals and are trolled on social media with hateful words, challenging their right to free speech. Even students are not spared from being tagged as seditious when they raise their voices against something irrational. However, thanks to the non-governmental organizations which lend a platform to civil

society to dissent in an informed and reasoned manner. Not just this, they also provides a mechanism for the ruled to keep a check on the rulers. Though not all NGOs act clean and legitimate on their part, yet there are few that operate transparently and judiciously and it is the power of such NGOs that wield support to the increased demand for real and operational democracy. Be it the Right to Information Act or the Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers' Rights Act, it has been through the support of such voices that the country is having some relief.

How can we ignore the fact that it has been the ability of India to express without fear which has brought joy to its friends and amazement to its adversaries? Nor can we forget the proclamation of Zulfikar Ali Bhutto that he made from his death-row cell in Pakistan that "India is more heterogeneous than Pakistan, but India has been kept in one piece by the noise and chaos of her democracy," in spite of his earlier advocacy of a thousand-year war with India.

The dissents expressed at crucial times in the history of this nation have given it the base of growth. The Nandas of Magadh were complacent in the face of Alexander's invasions and faced the dissent of Kautilya; who later created the Mauryan Empire. The orthodoxy of his times was dissented by Budhha and then came to revelation the "Eightfold Path". The fading of Sanatana Dharma was questioned by Adi Shankara which led to its resurrection. Further, the dissent of the soldiers at Barrackpore and Meerut led to the First War of Independence in 1857.

Those who gave us our path to an independent India were none other than a long line of dissenters, from Lokmanya Tilak to Bose, Nehru and Gandhi. Even the Indian Constitution, which has been endured through all these years, has been given to us by a man who dissented from even Mahatma Gandhi.

While we revel in the wisdom of the morrow, we must accept the fact that it was the call for total revolution by Jayapraksah Narayan, which led to the imposition of Emergency and also the consensus against the dictatorship.

The fact that the right to life was inherent in humans and not a gift of the Constitution should be reminded to us time and again. It is also a point of great significance in the current context when speaking one's mind on some issue is put across the test of fire. It should be a notion made clear in our mindsets that this right to life and dissent can't be suspended.

Rather than keeping one's thought as unexpressed, it's ideal to be voiced and rejected in the pool of ideas, no matter how imperfect it is. If all such ideas and voices would have been kept within and never have been expressed, how would we have so proudly called ourselves the citizens of world's largest and most flourishing democracy!

And for that matter, what is the true idea of democracy, isn't it the free men who willingly commit to the needs of citizenship of a free country. Who suppresses dissents and dissidents, is not one who supports and believes in democracy but rather hails from totalitarian regime.

Smart Cities for Urban Transformation



As of 2019, the total size of the Indian economy has been pegged at \$ 2.7 trillion. The Prime Minister, Mr Narendra Modi, has set an ambitious target of turning India into a \$ 5 trillion economy by 2025. In order to achieve this target, the nation needs to maintain an annual GDP growth rate of above 8%. To attain this growth rate, the government has realised that urbanisation must be seen as an opportunity and necessity rather than a problem. Various measures have been introduced to achieve urbanisation targets. One of the major initiatives by the government in this direction is the Smart City Mission.

The Smart City Mission was introduced on 25th June 2015 with an aim to promote inclusive and sustainable cities that offer essential infrastructure, good quality of life, clean environment, and application of smart solutions. Under this mission, “urban renewal and retrofitting program” was initiated to develop 100 smart cities across the country. The Smart City Mission has been envisaged to set examples for other cities to follow and catalyse development of more smart cities across the country.

Why are Smart Cities Needed in India?

In India, approximately one-third of the population lives in cities, and two-thirds of the population lives in rural areas. Despite housing only one-third of the total population of the country, cities contribute 63% of the GDP. By 2030, it is expected that 60% of the national population will reside in the cities, delivering 75% of the country's GDP. This presents a great opportunity for India wherein by

developing smart cities; more people will be encouraged to move from rural areas to the urban centres, inviting investments and starting a virtuous cycle of development and growth. In order to maximize the benefits from this trend, there is a need to ensure development of new smart cities as well as transformation of existing cities into smart cities.

How Will Smart Cities Lead to Urban Transformation in India?

The Indian government has progressed on its smart city mission steadily. Till now, various cities have been identified and several projects launched under this mission. It is expected that smart cities will usher in a new era of urban transformation in India, one which is more inclusive and self-sustainable. Here are a few ways in which smart cities will be leading the next wave of urban transformation in India: -

Technology powered governance

As more and more people will move to the cities, the development of infrastructure needs to keep abreast with the rate of migration. In order to ensure a better quality of life and sustainable growth, development of smart cities is essential. The concept of smart cities is dependent on transformation of various key aspects of urban life such as smart building, smart healthcare, smart energy, smart mobility, smart infrastructure, smart governance, smart education, and smart energy.

Smart cities aim to improve the quality of life for the residents with the help of urban informatics and technological innovations. With the help of Internet of Things (IoT) and Information and Communication Technology (ICT), these smart cities will ensure better management of a city's assets such as schools, libraries, hospitals, waste management, law enforcement, and other essential community services. With help of real-time data and information related to problems faced by the citizens, the governments will be in a better

position to discharge their duties efficiently and offer better living conditions to the residents.

Better quality of living

While the first wave of urbanisation in the country led to the development of various cities but many key aspects were ignored. In order to ensure sustained urbanisation that contributes to the growth of the economy, smart cities will offer a better quality of living. The focus under the smart cities mission is to provide improved core infrastructure elements such as:

- Affordable housing for all
- 24x7 electricity and water supply
- Superior sanitation and robust solid waste management
- IT connectivity and digitalisation
- Efficient mobility solutions including public transport
- E-Governance with active participation from the residents
- Eco-friendly growth and development
- Safety and security of the women, elderly, and children
- Better quality of health and education services

By providing these key elements in every city developed under the Smart City Mission, the government will ensure sustainable urbanisation that effectively contributes to the growth of the nation.

More employment opportunities

The problem of urban and rural unemployment has been hounding the country for last many decades. In order to achieve the desired growth levels, it is imperative for the government to reduce the unemployment levels significantly. These goals can be achieved with development of more smart cities. A smart city offers an economy of accumulation. As more people will be moving to smart cities, there will be increased demand for housing, schooling, medical facilities, and other essential products and services. When these sectors are enjoying greater demand, more employment opportunities will arise

for the residents. In order to make up for the shortfall in manpower, people from villages and rural areas will move to the cities and participate in the expanding economic activities. By setting in motion this sustained cycle of economic growth, smart cities have the potential to fight the problem of unemployment in cities as well as in villages.

Eco-friendly and sustainable growth

As per the estimates by WHO, the rising pollution levels in Indian cities can reduce the GDP of the country by 1%. This will be due to the reduced productivity of the people and higher instances of health problems. But in case of smart cities, these issues are addressed effectively. The focus during development of new smart cities as well as during transformation of older cities into smart cities is on sustainable development. By using environment-friendly technologies, the problems of urban pollution can be addressed effectively. When people would not be exposed to harmful pollutants and chemicals, their productivity will drastically improve.

Uniform growth across the country

It is not a secret that the urban growth in India has so far been concentrated to particular regions. The eastern and northeastern parts of the country have been devoid of these benefits. As a result, residents of these states have to migrate to other cities in want of better facilities. This creates various social and cultural problems related to interstate migration. With smart cities mission, the government has identified various cities in the eastern, north-eastern, and northern parts of the country which will be developed as world-class cities. As these cities will become the centre of economic activities in the region, they will control the rate of inter-state migration and also ensure uniform growth across the country.

For India to achieve its desired position at the global level, sustained economic development is imperative across all the regions in the country. The Smart City Mission is a firm step in that direction. It is expected that in the next decade, it will transform the urban

landscape of the country and will help in achieving the desired growth levels.

Criminalisation of Politics: A Grave Threat to the Indian Democracy



India is regarded as one of the largest democracies of the world.

With more than a population of 1.3 billion and millions added to the electorate every year, democracy has its roots firmly set in India. Like every democracy in the world, India too has its own share of challenges. But there is one challenge that is stopping India from becoming the greatest democracy and that is the criminalisation of politics or rather politicization of criminals. Over the last couple of decades, the number of elected representatives with serious criminal offences registered against them is steadily rising. This worrisome trend needs to be controlled; otherwise, the consequences can be dangerous for the people of the country. After all, how can criminals be allowed to decide the fate of those very people against whom the crimes have been committed by them?

What is Meant by the Criminalisation of Politics?

The criminalisation of politics in India means that more and more criminals, many accused of heinous crimes, are contesting the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. When the percentage of such candidates rises every year, it indicates towards criminalisation of the politics. The major cause of criminalisation of politics is the nexus between politicians and criminals. Politicians need criminals for their muscle power and money, and criminals need politicians patronage to conduct their activities. This mutually beneficial arrangement eventually leads to the criminalisation of politics.

Numbers Reveal the True Picture

This malice has taken its hold at both national and state level. A mere look at the following statistics released by Association for Democratic Reforms and National Election Watch will reveal the real extent of the problem.

- Out of the 543 members of the Lok Sabha, 43% of the elected members have criminal cases registered against them as compared to 34% in 2014 and 30% in 2009.
- Almost 29% of such members have serious cases registered against them, including murder, kidnapping, attempt to murder, rape and other crimes against women.
- When it comes to state assemblies, almost 31% of the members have criminal cases registered against them with 14% out of them facing allegations of serious crimes.

Reasons for the Criminalisation of Indian Politics

Ever since the trend of booth capturing spread in 1957, the importance of the criminals increased for the political parties. As a result, in present times every single political party gives tickets to candidates with a criminal background. More surprisingly, such candidates often end up on the winning side and become even ministers. It is important to understand what has led to such an impact being made by candidates with criminal charges. Some of the reasons are: -

- Corruption in political parties: - It is not uncommon to read or hear news about tickets being sold by political parties during elections. Now, in such a situation, the candidate who has more money and muscle power has a better chance of getting the ticket for contesting the election on behalf of that political party. If more such candidates are being given tickets by the party leadership, it is not a surprise that the percentage of candidates with a criminal record is increasing unabatedly.

- Winnability: - Sadly, Indian politics has become all about winning elections. Political parties are willing to go to any length to win the election they are contesting. They only see the winnability of the candidate and simply ignore the criminal background of the candidate. A recent news report suggested that a candidate with a criminal record is twice as likely to win an election as compared to a candidate with a clean record.
- Vote bank politics: - It is a harsh reality that even in this day and age political parties in India still practise vote bank politics. In most cases, candidates with criminal background have the money power and muscle power with them. With these two tools, they are able to sway the voters in their favour, by hook or by crook. In such a scenario, political parties are inclined to select a candidate who can manoeuvre the voters.
- Prolonged legal process: - The Supreme Court in 2018 made it necessary for political parties and candidates to declare their antecedents. But it is still very difficult for the electorate to find out such information pertaining to the candidate. On top of that, it can take up to decades for any legal case to reach its conclusion, so in the meanwhile candidates accused of crimes are free to fight the election on the basis of the premise that “innocent until proven guilty.”
- Lack of political will: - When all the political parties are on the same page when it comes to giving tickets to candidates with a criminal background, how can there be the political will to enact legislation in this direction. Moreover, when the state machinery is not able to deliver what is desired by the people and these candidates are able to offer what people seek, it is natural that such candidates will enjoy greater popularity as they can better secure the interests of the constituency.

How to Curb the Spread of this Malice?

That being said, it is not entirely impossible to stem this rot of the Indian political system. Some of the steps that can be taken to stop the criminalisation of Indian politics are: -

- Election Commission of India must demonstrate more proactive approach in this matter. It can take measures to break the nexus between politicians and criminals by ensuring timely audit of the finances of political parties.
- The Government must bring in legislation to ensure greater transparency in election funding and bring it under the purview of the RTI Act.
- The Government should set up fast track courts exclusively for cases pertaining to political candidates and dispose of them in a time-bound manner.
- The Supreme Court of India must direct the existing courts to deliver judgements in cases involving political parties and candidates quickly.
- The details pertaining to court cases involving political party representatives must be readily available on the website of the election commission.
- The people of the country need to be more politically aware and informed. They must take the decision to vote after due diligence and should not be swayed by money power, muscle power or caste affiliations.

There is an urgent need for a multi-pronged approach from the various sections of the society to curb the rapid criminalisation of politics and make India the largest democracy as well as the greatest democracy of the world.

**Terrorism is more of a Politically
Instigated Mental Problem than Religious
one. Do you agree? Why/ Why Not?**

“With guns, you can kill terrorists; with education you can kill terrorism.”

—Malala Yousafzai

In today's global community, terrorism is a problem that is affecting nations worldwide. It is an international phenomenon. Many countries are affected by it either directly or indirectly. Terrorism is the use of fear and violence to intimidate the society and government organisations. Terrorism is a broad term. US State Department defines terrorism to be composed of four elements. The first is a threat or act of violence. The second element is a political objective. Third is making a direct violent attack on the civilians and making them a primary target. Lastly, it is carried by supporting nation or nations of terrorism. This is a dangerous social evil which is acting as a hazard to the mankind. The main goal behind terrorism is the intention of terrorists to get their voices heard. These goals may be religious, political or ideological in nature.

However, the root cause of terrorism is thought to be religious. Many Islamic nations in the name of Holy Quran practise this evil. Some nations support it; some condone it while some stand against it with all their vigour. Islamic countries which preach terrorism have certainly not got past the first chapter of thy holy book. Their radical thinking and approach to train young lads into suicide bombers is descriptive enough of their service to their religion. Jihad is what is taught to the young Muslims in poor backward Muslim dominated nations. Anyone who is against the religion and teachings of Islam is considered as enemies. Several terrorist organisations like ISIS and

Lashkar are promoting terrorism under the cover of religion. Countries like Iran, Iraq, Syria and Pakistan are providing shelter to many terrorists and terrorist organisations. But the question arises how these poor nations and organisations are able to conduct such violent trainings and activities at such large scale? Who gives them the funding for all this? In these nations, where citizens are devoid of basic amenities of life, where are the latest gadgets and ammunitions coming from? The answer to this is politics. The root motivation of terrorism is actually the political organisations which play their game in the name of religion to achieve their goals.

Terrorism is more of a politically instigated mental problem than religious. Politicians are the real terrorists who often indulge and promote these violent acts remaining undercover. Terrorism is political. Different types of terrorism exist, but each of these has the same objective of effecting change within or in respect to a political system through the threat or violent measures. Terrorism can be regarded as a violent methodology of politics which is pursued by the weaker party in an attempt to change the policies of the stronger power. If a terrorist group attacks a nation, then it is implied that the nation is considered a stronger power by the weaker terrorists who struggle to make their demands listen. But the leaders of strong and confident nations do not engage in creating a sense of fear among its citizens. They do not compromise upon their principles and strengths and maintain a high moral ground to undercut portray of fear and violence put forth by the weaker terrorist groups.

Terrorism is driven by politics and the recruiting organisations of these terrorists are cast in religious, linguistic, ethnic and moral terms. They justify the killing of innocent people. Terrorism is not fundamentally driven by the basic theological differences between religions or legal context between a religion or state system. Terrorist groups like Al Qaeda and others didn't attack the West over theological difference between Islam, Christianity and Judaism. The motives and goals described by them are broadly political in nature and address issues of economic oppression, political corruption and

colonialism either explicitly or implicitly. To the world, the grievances of terrorists groups seem to be plastered as religious in nature, but their objectives on a large scale are political in context.

Looking forth the current world scenario, it can be presumed that terrorism will remain an integral and crucial part of the political process in the future too. With politics involved at the grass root level, the terrorism as a political act cannot be eradicated, despite claims by powerful leaders and organisations. Till the time there is oppression or the perception of oppression in the system, and inequality pertains to be the strengths of the parties of various facets of the political argument, there will be existence of people who choose violence as a ultimate road to achieve and advance towards their goals.

To tame down terrorism, secular and democratic developed and developing nations should have a shared understanding to initiate a common response to any acts of terror keeping up with the highest human principles and values. With a common response to terrorism, terrorist groups won't be able to target the potential weaknesses which exist between the nations. If a group of countries follows the militarized 'war on terror' approach, while other neighbouring countries pursue political approaches, then it would be easy for the terrorists to loop in the weaknesses. With a well studied approach, terrorist groups thoroughly work upon the strengths and weaknesses of the host countries and thereafter exploit the differences between them.

To counter this, nations need to join hands to come to a basic approach such that the nature of terrorism can be understood at the grass root level. A transnational understanding of the nature of terrorism needs to be reached. If a terrorist group operates across the national boundaries, then the countries associated should all have a clear understanding of group's objectives, strategies, tactics and ideologies. This is not only a preventive method but a strategy to counter the evil of terrorism. It needs to be understood that combined efforts of nations can only help citizens to lead a peaceful life and to

prevent them from being the prey to the political objectives. With clear understanding, nations can maintain their supremacy and avoid getting into the trap where terrorists want to see a dividing and fearful nation which is sliding down to their level so it becomes easier for them to exploit the climate of fear.

Indian Nationalism and Free Speech



Nationalism is an idea that involves a feeling of extremely strong attachment and loyalty towards one's own country. India being a diverse country where people with different religions, castes, races, languages and cultures are present, nationalism is a feeling that binds everyone together in the spirit of oneness. Nationalism helps to achieve unity in diversity. For a nation's progress and prosperity, it is imperative that its citizens rise above their regional identities and strengthen the sense of pride in their nation.

One example of nationalism seen in the pre-independence period was Quit India Movement which was launched in the year 1942. India joined the freedom struggle under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi. The entire country adopted the slogan do or die, now or never. They demanded the British to quit India immediately. It was a great movement which brought the whole nation together. Some national leaders who contributed to the growth of nationalism are Subhash Chandra Bose, Mahatma Gandhi, B G Tilak, Swami Vivekananda and many more.

Nationalism gave rise to a healthy spirit of national rivalry and thereby added to the enrichment of culture and improved standard of living. Nationalism is also responsible for the advancement of every nation politically by the intercourse of contact, competition and conflict.

Difficulties in Nationalism

In India there are a number of political parties with different ideologies. Political leaders are self-centered and opposition parties

tend to oppose even the policies made by the ruling party in the interest of nation.

It is a typical feature of India which signifies unity in diversity. But at the same time it is posing serious threat to nationalism. Communal clashes have become a common feature of Indian society.

Article 370 of the Constitution had granted a separate legal status to Jammu and Kashmir. Many enactments were not applicable to Jammu and Kashmir. Now the Indian government has on 5th August 2019 revoked the special status, or limited autonomy, granted under Article 370 of the Indian Constitution to Jammu and Kashmir. Though Jammu and Kashmir is the integral part of India, terrorism and militant activities have become burning issues which are posing a threat to nationalism.

Nationalism sometimes gives rise to egoistic concept that the laws and civilization of one's own country are superior to those of other nations. This pampers the racial feelings and degenerates into chauvinism or bellicose nationalism.

Despite all the difficulties nationalism is a great democratic ideal which continues to live as the strongest force and continues to inspire struggle for national liberation in different parts of the globe.

Freedom of speech is one of the fundamental rights provided to the citizens of India. Article 19(1) (a) of Indian Constitution says that all citizens have the right to freedom of speech and expression. It gives right to all the citizens of our country to express their ideas and share their opinions freely. Freedom of speech forms the basis of a democracy. Freedom of speech helps an individual to attain self-fulfilment. It helps in discovering the truth. It provides a mechanism by which it would be possible to establish a reasonable balance between stability and social change. It includes the expression of one's ideas through any communicable medium or visible representations such as gesture, signs, etc.

While Freedom of Speech is essential for the overall growth of the society and fellow citizens it may have certain negative implications,

too. Many people misuse this freedom. We need to exercise freedom of speech with caution and responsibility.

Internet has augmented the Freedom of Speech and Expression. The advent of social media platforms has furthered it all the more. People these days are eager to give their views on anything and everything whether they have knowledge about the same or not. They write hateful comments without caring if they are hurting someone's feelings or intruding in someone's personal space. This can certainly be termed as the misuse of this freedom and must be stopped.

Another area where freedom of speech has a major role is press and media. In India, the media have played a historical role in providing information to the people about social and economic evils. The media have informed the people about the tremendous poverty in the country, the suicide of farmers in various States, etc. However, the media have also a great responsibility to see that the news they present are accurate and serve the interest of the people. If the media convey false news that may harm the reputation of a person or a section of society, it may do great damage since reputation is a valuable asset for a person. Hence, the media should take care to carefully investigate any news item before reporting it.

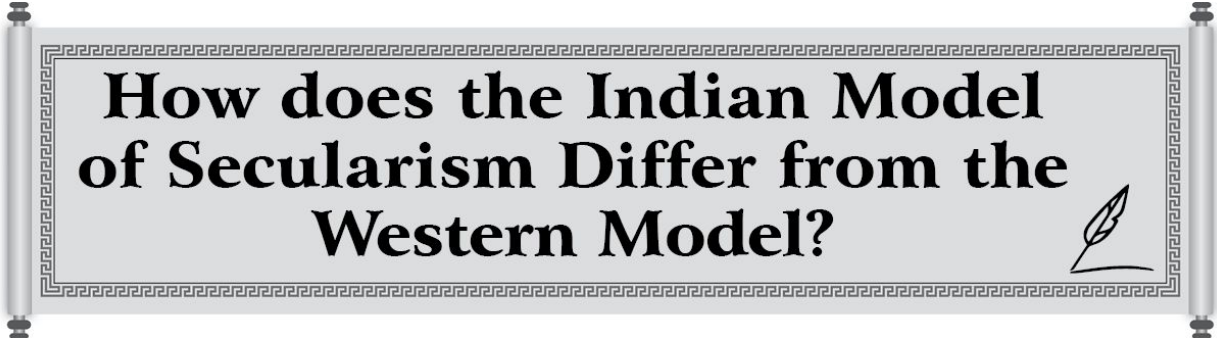
There is no such thing as absolute free speech. There is always a line that must not be crossed. It is a democratic ideal, that every citizen is free to express his/ her views, and thus influence his/ her country and even the world. Free speech is about our opinions. We have right to say what we want. However, freedom of information is also an important part of free speech. Some religious leaders with vested interest and ulterior motives misuse the right to free speech to misguide and influence masses. Spreading wrong information is against free speech because misinformation affects the society adversely. However, one needs to be aware enough to sift the truth from falsities. People have every right to disagree with rationalists, nationalists and religious zealots and fundamentalists, debate and protest in civilized ways.

To prevent the misuse of freedom of speech, Supreme Court of India has held section 66A of IT act. According to this, any person who

sends offensive messages through communication services by means of a communication device or a computer is liable for punishment.

Every country must provide freedom of speech and expression to its citizens. Freedom of speech empowers the people to share their ideas and bring out positive changes in the society. However, it should be used to strengthen the democracy and also question its stakeholders. Citizens should preserve and use this right responsibly.

How does the Indian Model of Secularism Differ from the Western Model?



In 1947, Gandhiji had said, “Religion is the personal affair of each individual. It must not be mixed up with politics or national affairs.” The foundation of secularism is its separation of religion from state. The relation between nation state and religion is very old. Secularism ensures the non-interference of state in the private religious affairs and at the same time state has no religion. Law and the Constitution are above the religion and citizens are treated equally despite their personal faith in their respective religions.

Although secularism separates religion from the state, but it does not mean that state is against the religion or religion has no role in nation building. It simply means that state shall never give special treatment to any particular religion and not force its citizens to accept any particular religion. A group or individuals should neither be deprived nor given privilege because of their faith and non-faith for any particular religion. The definition and also the way of implementation of secularism can be changed from one nation to another. The present form of secularism has evolved through long history. Indian evolution of secularism is different from the west.

Indian Model of Secularism

Secularism is the principle of separating government institutions and representatives of state from religious dignitaries and institutions. Secularism in India relates to the equal treatment by state to all religions.

India is a very diverse nation where many religions are practised and also India is birth place of religions like Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism,

Sikhism and many more. Unlike western countries where religion is totally different from state, India has always treated all religions equally. In case of religious minorities in India, the Constitution provides special provision to preserve the culture, language and their practices and minority institutions under the Fundamental Rights.

In Indian society, the role of religion is different from that in west. Religion is a way of life for most of the Indians and all the religious practices of Indian civilisation are said to be based on some scientific approach. Though there was some sort of spirituality in religious faiths but the dominating feature remained materialistic. This is why the Indian society cannot be separated from religion.

In the medieval history, only few examples are found of non-secularism like Jiziya, but it was also abolished and reimposed by different rulers. During Mughal period, Akbar made matrimonial alliance with other Hindu rulers. In the Mughal Court, there were many notable Hindu scholars and persons of eminence known as 'Navratnas' or Nine Gems and even the most of officials were Hindu.

Akbar's 'Ibadat Khana' or 'House of Worship' and "Din-i-Ilahi" or 'Religion of God' focused on reconciling the differences that divided the subjects of the king.

The term secular was not mentioned originally in the Constitution. It was added by the 42nd Constitutional Amendment in Preamble in 1976. But the Indian Constitution has always been secular and articles like 26, 27, 28 and 29 under Fundamental Rights ensure the right of minorities and their institutions.

Western Model of Secularism

Before Renaissance, the impact of Church was clearly seen on the decision-making of king. Church and Pope were above the state and the king. No one could question the order of Church. Christianity was the only religion practised by people and state was not independent from religion. Rules and laws were based on the Christian philosophy. But after the Renaissance, this trend was changed and people

started questioning the order of church and the influence of church started declining with time. Renaissance helped the people shape scientific and rational thinking.

The idea of western secularism is much based on the classical liberal concept. This concept says that people may have different faiths and the state must not promote and protect any particular belief because faith in religion is a private affair. The current secularism has evolved after the period of Renaissance.

Now in the west, religion has a separate sphere and state cannot interfere in the matter of religion and it has its own independent jurisdiction. State cannot intercept in religious ceremonies as long as they do not go beyond the law of state. If a member of temple or church forbids the entry of any individual, then state cannot force the temple or church authority for entry of that particular individual. State also cannot provide any type of aid and assistance to any religious community and any religious institution.

It can be conferred that Indian secularism is wider in aspect of its tolerance, reach, reform, acceptance, practice and promulgation. The western secularism has its own limitations and defined areas of practice with no dependency on state or government for further reform. Indian secularism has a spectrum well-defined yet with an outreach that encompasses ethics and law. Sentiments and ethos are governed by religion here and religion is often used as deterrence in many cases. However, while we look to the west, we see they have simplified version of religion that doesn't overwhelm their personal lives and also intends towards keeping law separate and unrelated to religion.

People have always been diverted in the name of religion by few people who have selective political gains. Religion remains a sensitive issue and so in the backdrop of secularism, people are conditioned to respond in a desirable way.

While secularism has been a debatable issue that has coloured politics and democracy of the Indians, it has on the other hand

granted a free-spirited life to western world. Secularism however reigns above all and is the pioneer for democracy in every form.

Caste Politics has Succeeded in India. Do you Agree? Why/ Why not?



The Constitution of India declares the country as sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic republic. It assures its citizens of justice, and equality of status and opportunity irrespective of caste, creed and religion. But caste, creed and religion are an important aspect of political and social system of the country. Caste politics in India has been prevalent since long. It is a worldwide fact that India is badly ridden with caste politics. It was assumed that differentiation on the basis of caste will vanish after independence, but it still makes its presence felt in different parts of the country. Even though our Constitution doesn't allow for it and discrimination on the basis of caste and creed is punishable under law, it is still prevalent and with the passage of time it has undoubtedly been established that caste has not ceased to play its part. It plays a significant role in politics at local level, less in state and lesser at the national level. However, its hold can be seen and felt at all these levels.

It can rightly be said that caste politics in India has succeeded. It has touched states bordering all the corners of the country. Today, there is no state left which is untouched with the influence of caste. In some states the hold of caste is more while in others a little less. It has been noticed that caste is taking a toll on the political system of the country with people voting the candidate belonging to their caste irrespective of his credibility as a leader and politician. Even the political parties are considering caste while choosing candidates for contesting elections in certain constituencies. Caste considerations are potent in elections at the panchayat and municipality level. The

citizens of the country cast their votes on the basis of this system assuming that their caste will be benefitted in some or the other way.

In India, the castes are broadly classified as forward castes or upper castes, Other Backward Classes (OBC), Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled tribes (ST). Muslims and Christians are also considered as different castes. Lower castes have various privileges attached to them and to avail these benefits several castes demand a lower rank. Caste has played a huge role in political arena and other government-run institutions like judicial system and police in order to remove the boundaries between 'civil society' and 'political society'. The position of caste in these system plays an important role in determining their worth and say in the system. If a lower caste were grouped in one area particularly, they could challenge the locally dominant upper castes. Thus, their bifurcation is utmost along the hierarchy throughout the system. In the power dynamics of caste in the politics, gender also plays a pivotal role. Socially liberal women from forward caste are more participative and active than women of lower castes. They are found to occupy political office of significance. This hierarchy of caste and its role in politics has created a caste inflicted society which is rigid in structure. Corruption is a side effect of caste politics in India. Politicians often bribe their caste and indulge in practice of vote banking, wherein people of the same caste vote for the candidate belonging to their caste. Role of castes in Indian elections have been overplayed over the years.

Caste politics is not only prevalent in the north, but has shades of deeper hues in the south. States of Rajasthan has dominance of Rajputs. In the state of Kerala, Nayar and Izhavas influence the political scenario of the state with well developed organisations and associations backing them. In Orissa, Bhumihars, Kayastha and Rajputs play politics in bringing forth the candidates belonging to their caste. Higher influence of caste politics is experienced in the state of Andhra Pradesh where the two dominant castes – the Kammas and the Reddys fight to show their dominance in the state. Bihar has four castes the Rajputs, the Brahmins, the Kshatriyas, Yadavs, Kurmis,

and the Adivasis which favour themselves to the level that their support also varies according to the election parties. The Rajputs there support Janata Party and Janata Dal. The Kayasthas and Brahmins are fighting against each other for getting power and position in the ministry making process. The Adivasis have got separated from the state and constituted the state of Jharkhand. Important castes in the state of Maharashtra are the Marathas, the Brahmins and the Mahars who fight for political power against the caste lines. Marathas make up 32% population and are asking half the reservation of 16%. Their plea is if SCs, STs, OBCs can get reservation, why can't the Marathas? Maratha groups had decided a mass blockade of the entire state. Though they planned to agitate only in a peaceful manner, it caused huge traffic jams and stalled the movement of all transports. This, in turn, had caused enormous financial losses, especially for the private sector. Conceding to their demands, Fadnavis government promised to constitute a committee to study the reservation issue.

These reservations will require a constitutional amendment but giving the Marathas reservation will open a Pandora's Box for the central government — given that the Patidars in Gujarat, the Gujjars in Rajasthan and the Jats in Haryana are demanding similar quotas for the same reasons. The fact the caste politics exists in Karnataka can be understood from the truth that personal staff of the ministers belongs to the caste to which they belong to. The ordeal that caste exists in politics in India at a very deeper level cannot be subsided.

However, the influence of caste has started to decline in the contemporary India, though at a very slow pace. The main reason is the spread of education to all the castes which has had a democratising effect on the political system. People are more awakened and have started to elect the person on the basis of their credibility, the work they have done and their educational background. But this is a long race which needs full conviction from the political system and the citizens of the country, if they want to ward off this evil. It is to be understood that reservations on the basis

of the caste strengthens caste politics, instead of weakening the caste system. No seats in government organisations should be reserved for any caste. All shall be considered equal. It is high time that the political parties in India began standing up against this weed. Only then will India be able to succeed. Caste system in politics is like cancer which is growing by day. If not stopped now, then future generations will have to bear its consequences too.

Civil Servants and Politicians: A Complicated Partnership

Who are the politicians in a nation? The government? The opposition? Or the people in the parliament? Politicians are the people who form the government and run the administration at different levels. It may be at the Gram Panchayat level, Municipal Corporations, State as well as the country. Therefore, they have a vital role with regard to development of the country. The internal policies, external policies, projects, schemes, etc. are formulated by the governing body at each level. But, it does not mean that those not directly involved in the running of a country do not come under its purview. The opposition, for instance, play a major role in shaping the policies and ideas though, indirectly. Politicians are those who represent various political parties follow or are required to follow a set of ideologies and a vision which corresponds to the needs and concerns of the state or region they belong to. Aiding the efforts of these politicians or leaders representing the public in the government are the civil servants or bureaucrats with their expertise and specific knowledge about the various departments or wings of the government.

The Indian political system has three wings namely the legislature, executive and the judiciary. This model of system is known for its unique attribute of checks and balances. The system of checks and balances is a part of our Constitution. It guarantees that no part of the government becomes too powerful. For example, the legislative branch is in charge of making laws. The executive branch can veto the law, thus making it difficult for the legislative branch to pass the

law. The judicial branch may also say that the law is unconstitutional and thus make sure it is not a law.

The legislative branch can also remove a president or judge who is not doing his/her job properly. The executive branch appoints judges and the legislative branch approves the choice of the executive branch. Again, the branches check and balance each other so that no one branch has too much power. This works as a self-evaluating and regulatory structure where politicians only have restricted area of power, expected to deliver to the public with unselfish motives.

With the command majorly resting in the hands of the politicians representing the public, the most basic question arising here is that are these bunch of politicians capable of making intricate laws and highly comprehensive policies, rules and schemes? Do they have the sufficient knowledge and expertise to justifiably execute their powers in the respective wings considering there is no minimum educational requirement for them? The answers by most shall be a no. Here is when the civil servants come to the rescue. These are politically impartial and independent of government and work in central government departments, agencies, and non-departmental public bodies (NDPBs). The Civil Service does not include government ministers. Civil Service helps the government of the day in developing and implementing its policies as effectively as possible. They provide various other services like paying benefits and pension, ruling employment services, running prisons, issuing licenses, maintaining law and order, etc. A large number of them work on policy development and implementation, including analysts, project managers, lawyers and economists.

A reliable civil servant delivers services that measure up to the standards of international economic competition and diplomacy and to the expectations of the democratic government in power as to the thorough implementation of its policies. A responsible civil service is held accountable by the majority of the electorate through the exercise of the right to vote and other forms of political participation.

Relationships between civil servants and ministers may be marred by suspicion and mistrust. Ministers may suspect civil servants of continued loyalty to an earlier regime, or despise the work ethics and practices developed then. Civil servants may think ministers motivated by short-term political interests or naive about the problems of government. Either group may think the other corrupt. If civil servants find difficulties with proposed policies, their objections may be thought political rather than technical. They may indeed be prejudiced against new policies and new ways of working. Civil servants need to understand and accept new political priorities and show total loyalty to the government of the day. But the minister's political future and the good of the nation depend on civil servants offering honest and courageous advice.

Ministers and civil servants working together may help build a national consensus on matters about which most people agree or which offer little room for political manoeuvre. Government decisions may become the subject for political controversy even where any governing party would have to do the same. The problem is exacerbated in countries having an executive president, by the need to distinguish loyalty to the president as head of state, from opposition to the president's policy. Where controversy leads to public disenchantment with politics, there is special value in seeking a national consensus on core issues such as security, drugs, terrorism, and development, education and health.

Politicians are often blamed for exercising unjustified control over the civil servants. In pursuing their political ambitions, politicians in their various capacities want to shine not only with the media but also in parliament in comparison to their party colleagues, and with constituents who elect them. They also, need to command the respect and allegiance of the civil servants. The individual motives take precedence over the general objectives of public good.

Several recommendations have been made to pass a law that fixes the tenure of the civil servants. This has its own pros and cons. Independent functioning of the Civil Service Board can be a great measure to ensure that they remain effective and free from political

forces hindering the implementation of justice and integrity in highly decisive matters. However, it is equally important that stricter laws should be made to keep the powers of the politicians under check; otherwise the whole motive behind the formation of this law shall go in vain.

SECTION-B: WORLD POLITY

India's Foreign Policy Challenges Under Modi Govt.



When prime minister Narendra Modi took the oath of the office for first time in 2014, India already had a prominent position on the global stage. Though, he undertook numerous initiatives to improve bilateral and multilateral relations and managed to further strengthen India's position as the global economic powerhouse. Though, as his second stint as the prime minister of India has not even completed six months yet, the world is a more disorderly place in November 2019. With the new foreign minister Mr S Jaishankar and Mr Ajit Doval, National Security Advisor by his side to manage relations with other countries, Mr Modi does have a potent team with him, but the challenges on hand are also equally potent.

With the unpredictable nature of the Donald Trump Administration in the US and a new style of unilateralism being propagated by the US President, the ongoing trade war between US and China has led to uncertainty in the global economic environment. Then the ongoing suspense over the Brexit deal in the Europe, growing tensions between Saudi Arabia and Iran, Rohingya migration crisis in Myanmar and Bangladesh, Belt and Road Initiative of China, Pakistan's extreme rhetoric against the abrogation of Article 370, North Korea's stubborn stand over nuclear weapons are some of the issues that the world is facing at present. Add to it the obvious strain in India's relationships with China and Pakistan, Modi Government has its hands full on front of the foreign policy.

Let's have a look at the multiple dimensions of India's foreign policy challenges under the Modi Government during the second-term : -

- Relations with the US: - India shares the status of a strategic partner for the US, the relations between both countries are getting stronger under the regime of President Donald Trump. There is a growing realisation in the US that only India can offer it a strong presence in Asia to counter the Chinese dominance. The US has made India eligible for defence-related technologies under the "Strategic Trade Authorisation." India and US are working closely on various fronts such as trade, defence, science and technology etc. Then the quadrilateral grouping comprising of India, US, Australia and Japan has been making steady progress on various fronts. But all is not rosy in the India-US relations.
- The unpredictable nature of the Trump Administration is keeping India on its toes. India is facing the problem in balancing the relations with the US and other countries. Due to restrictions imposed by the US on Iran and Venezuela, India's oil import bill has gone up. Then US is further trying to undercut India's strategic ties with Iran, creating a serious problem on the front of foreign policy. Then the persistent threat of violation of Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) is creating problems for India's bid to purchase S-400 air defence systems from Russia. Moreover, Trump Administration's plan to end the Generalised System of Preferences program does not bode well for Indian imports which will lose the preferential import duties. India has its hands full while managing the balancing act in the India-US relations. US's provocative and unilateral actions are threatening relations with other countries and creating some discontent with the Indian public.
- Relations with Pakistan: - While the India-Pakistan relations were already under tremendous strain, ever since the abrogation of Article 370, they have hit a new low. Pakistan's extreme rhetoric against the constitutionally-valid move of the Indian government is showing no signs of abating. Although Pakistan has been unable

to find traction on this matter at the global stage, it is still trying to rake up the issue. Though the recent opening of the Kartarpur corridor has been widely hailed as a peace gesture, the threat of terrorist attacks from Pakistan is still there. Moreover, there are constant attempts from Pakistani establishment to rake up trouble in Kashmir and Punjab under its notorious K2 Plan (Kashmir and Khalistan). With the Imran Khan government facing multiple challenges at home itself, India might find it difficult to make some meaningful progress in this direction.

- Relations with China: - India is struggling with the growing assertiveness of China in the region. Though the relationships with Beijing have improved significantly since the Doklam incident, still both sides suffer from a significant trust deficit. While the issues over growing trade imbalance have been there for quite some time, both countries are trying to resolve the situation. But, China's unwavering support to Pakistan over the Kashmir issue has been acting as a bone of contention between the two rising superpowers. India has always been critical of the Belt and Road Initiative of China and also recused from joining the RCEP (Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership) due to perceived threat to Indian industry from the Chinese products. Although Indian Prime Minister Mr Narendra Modi and Chinese President Mr Xi Jinping share good personal relations, that warmth is clearly missing from India-China relations.
- Relations with old allies: - India has always enjoyed friendly relations with Russia. Russia always offered unwavering support to India at global forums and has vetoed various proposals in the UNSC introduced by China at the behest of Pakistan. Moreover, the excellent personal rapport between Mr Modi and Mr Putin has helped further improve the relations. India and Russia enjoy great mutual trust on various fronts, and the friendship has stood the test of time. But the Trump Administration's unilateral policies are posing a challenge for Indo-Russia relations. America is threatening actions under Countering America's Adversaries

Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) to deter India from purchasing S-400 air defence system from Russia. Although India is standing firm on its ground, the situation is far from getting normal.

- India's relations with Iran hold special strategic importance. Both countries share historical ties and have fallen victim to the terrorist threat by Jihadi elements emanating from Pakistan. India has been one of the biggest importers of Iranian oil, but after the recent sanctions imposed by US, India has been forced to cut the imports from Iran, leading to a rise in India's oil import bill. While the Chabahar Port has been exempted from US sanctions, for now, there is a lot of uncertainty pertaining to it in the future. If this happens, then India would be staring at a big problem as the Chabahar Port offers India a direct trade route with western Asia, bypassing Pakistan. Moreover, tension in relations between Iran and Saudi Arabia is posing a problem for India's energy requirements and balancing relations with two friendly regimes.
- Relations with other neighbours: - China is using its carrot and stick approach to increase its influence in South Asia. First, it offers loans to the countries for infrastructure development, but as those countries are unable to repay the loan, Beijing negotiates for strategic control over key assets in the country. As a result, Beijing is gaining foothold in countries which traditionally sided with India. Although countries are now waking up to this threat posed by Chinese investment, India's need to strengthen its regional dominance is another challenge for the foreign policy of the Modi government.
- While India enjoys good relations with Bangladesh, there have been some issues regarding the Rohingya crisis and the NRC exercise in Assam aiming to repatriate illegal Bangladeshi immigrants.
- India has been emerging as a global superpower and can no longer afford to sit at the fence and watch things unfold. India needs to weigh in on crucial matters affecting the world, and this

would require extreme care and caution from the government as these decisions will have a huge impact on India's foreign policy.

Is there an end to the Syrian Conflict?



It seemed a little improbable a few months ago, the war or rather wars in Syria seemed to be approaching an end. Almost one-third of the country which was once under the control of Syrian Democratic Forces backed by the US, as well as the troops will be integrated with rest of the country and would come under the direct control of Damascus. While the war in Syria may be close to its culmination, there is no reason to celebrate. More than half a million Syrians have been killed, millions more have been forced into permanent exile, and millions have been displaced internally. Cities which were once prosperous and thriving have now been turned into wastelands of rubble. The signs of the destruction the war has left behind are visible all over. On top of that, the sanctions imposed on Syria by US and other countries, make the task of reviving the Syrian economy even more difficult. As a result, lucky (or rather unlucky) few who have survived the war, are now staring into oblivion.

A brief history of the Syrian Civil War

The Syrian civil war that decimated the country's economy and provoked an unprecedented humanitarian crisis is drawing to an end after 8 long years. It seems like that the President of Syria, Bashar al-Assad, might have emerged militarily victorious with the backing from Russia and Iran. The Syrian conflict started in 2011, when the existing Syrian government used violence to repress massive civilian protests. What this armed insurgency turned into was beyond the imagination of everyone. The world saw the rise of ISIS, a brutal radical Islamist organisation, which at its peak commanded control

over almost one-third of Syrian territory. Though, as of now, the menace of ISIS has been brought under control by the US-led coalition, with the killing of its leader Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, but there are still more than 18,000 ISIS fighters roaming around.

Financial challenges facing Syria

The biggest and most difficult challenge facing Syria now is the long and treacherous road to rebuilding the country. As per the latest reports from the UN, more than 13.1 million Syrians need help urgently. The magnitude of losses suffered by Syria due to these conflicts has been estimated to be around \$250 billion by the World Bank, while the estimate given by the Syrian Government is \$400 billion.

With the US already preparing to leave Syria and Assad's allies in Moscow and Tehran, not in a position, the question is who is going to foot this massive bill. With Assad still at the helm of the affairs, the person who used chemical weapons against his own people, any help from outside seems improbable at the moment.

Syria urgently requires assistance from multilateral organisations, bilateral organisations as well as massive investments from wealthy western countries. Moreover, the Russian government and the Syrian Governments have expressed their wish that the US and EU must contribute substantial amounts towards the cost of reconstruction. But so far, US, as well as EU countries, are avoiding agreeing to this demand as they adhere to the UNSC Resolution 2254 which asks for credible and inclusive government, high levels of transparency, and free and fair elections. All of these seem highly improbable under the Assad regime. As a result, without any participation from EU and US, even the World Bank might not be interested in pitching-in.

The next obvious candidates are China and Saudi Arabia. But both these countries refrain from investing in war zones. China offers assistance in the form of infrastructure construction projects that are completed by Chinese companies. It refrains from offering grants or

cash loans. Riyadh has a history of dealing with stable economies with a friendly government in place.

For now, it seems the Syrians will have to foot the bill from their own pockets. Wealthy Syrians are expected to invest in projects in government-controlled areas. Syrians who will receive remittances from abroad will use it for personal and small-scale reconstruction projects. Russia and Iran might pitch in, but their assistance will be restricted to select areas and assets that are of interest to them. Any large scale reconstruction projects funded by multilateral or bilateral organisations seem highly unlikely at the moment.

Humanitarian challenges facing Syria

With millions of Syrians displaced internally, millions have left the country, and hundreds of thousands dead due to the conflict, Syria is staring at a massive humanitarian crisis. Moreover, as the control rests with the Assad administration, the road ahead does not promise much. After all, he is the person who used chemical weapons to curb a popular revolution. Now that the US has almost withdrawn its forces from Syria, Assad might unleash another reign of terror to keep things under his tight control.

With half of the country's population displaced due to the conflict, the number of refugees has been put at 5.6 million by the United Nations Refugee Agency. Even though the conflict is nearing an end, it is still unclear if they will be able to return and if yes, then when. Till then, such huge number of refugees would continue to put strain on the neighbouring countries as well as Europe.

Moreover, the fighting is not yet entirely over. The northwestern province of Idlib is the flashpoint. With the clashes intensifying between Russian-backed government forces and Turkish-backed Islamist militia, the lives of millions of citizens are still at risk.

What lies ahead?

It is only possible to bring stable peace to Syria, with a kind of reconstruction, economic as well as human that can bond the country

and the countrymen together. With Assad unlikely to mend his ways, Syria is staring at a bleak future with stricter internal measures most likely to be put in place. This might fuel the unrest further and lead to clashes that originally started this destruction of Syria. Unless and until world bodies take cognizance of the gravity of the situation, the region will continue to face security challenges for many years to come.

India's Pursuit of Permanent seat in UN Security Council

United Nation Security Council (UNSC) is one of the six principal organs of United Nations formed on 24th October 1945. At the time of its foundation, UN had 51 member states; India was one of the founding members and now there are 193 member countries. United Nations is an intergovernmental organization that was formed after the failure of League of Nations whose main purpose was establishing peace and preventing the World War; but unfortunately it failed to do so. As successor of League of Nations, UN has the responsibility of increasing international cooperation, developing friendly relations across the globe and maintaining international peace and security and it performs its functions through its principal organs and specialized agencies.

UNSC is responsible for maintaining peace and security in the world along with the function of accepting new members to the UN and approving any changes to its charter. It's the only body of UN with authority to issue binding resolution to the member states. It has five permanent members i.e. US, UK, Russia, China and France also known as P5 (they were the winning power of World War II) and ten non-permanent members which are elected on regional basis for the term of two years on rotation basis. The permanent members of the Security Council enjoy power of veto which can be used on any substantive resolution including nominees for the office of Secretary General.

UN has been there for seventy five years and its membership has grown from 51 to 193. In these seven decades geopolitical realities of

the world has changed, many big incidences occurred including USA's defeat in Vietnam and Korean war, disintegration of USSR, fall of Berlin Wall, Arab Spring, rise of terrorist groups like Al-Qaeda and ISIS, recession of 2008, China's emergence as new economic and political power, emergence of India as major Asian power, freedom of African countries and wave of democracy across the world. These are few examples that show how the world order has changed and world is facing new challenges. In this changing world, reforms in UNSC are also required. The P5 nations always give their own priorities over the important global problems and so, resolution on important subjects could not be passed in UN General Assembly. India has been elected for seven terms for two-years each for non-permanent member seats for years 1950-51, 1967-68, 1972-73, 1977-78, 1984-85, 1991-92 and 2011-12. Recently India is elected for eighth term in UNSC for non-permanent member for the year 2021-22.

India's Claim for Permanent Member

India is the largest democracy of the world and represents more than one-sixth of world's population, is seventh largest country in the world by area and second largest country by population. India's effort towards establishing peace and promoting international harmony is notable. During the Cold War phase when world was divided into two blocs; India (also Yugoslavia) gave the formula of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) to the world which played an important role in international peace and cooperation.

India's multilateral engagement in international organisations began after the end of First World War when India signed the Treaty of Versailles which led to the foundation of League of Nations (precursor of UN), wherein India, too, was a member. On 1st January 1942, India was the original member of UN that signed the Declaration by the UN at Washington. It also participated in historic UN conference of International Organization at San Francisco in 1945. After

independence, India has been an active participant in all programmes initiated by UN and its various organs, which include talks on Agenda for Development and Agenda for peace, discussion on climate change, Millennium Development Goals and Sustainable Development Goals. India played key role in establishing the G77 which represents the developing nations. Besides this, it supported various other UN bodies in their establishment such as the UNICEF, the UNDP and UNEP.

India's contribution in UN peacekeeping forces is almost twice the number of peacekeepers deployed by combined China, USA, UK, Russia and France. Till date India has provided more than 200,000 Military and Police officers to UN peacekeepers that have served in 49 of the 71 UN peacekeeping missions around the world since 1948. Currently Indian peacekeepers are deployed to nine missions across the world which includes doctors and other specialized supporting staffs who have played vital role in capacity building of the locals. In 2007, India became the first country to deploy an all-women contingent to a UN peacekeeping mission.

G4 Nations

For seeking reforms and claiming their permanent membership in UNSC in 2005; India, Germany, Japan and Brazil formed a group known as G4 which supports each other's bids. The G4 suggested entry of two African nations in UNSC but African Union was unable to agree on two names – South Africa (economically powerful), Nigeria (most populous) and Egypt (also a powerful contender for UNSC).

India emerged the strongest candidate in terms of support but most of the times; it is opposed by China and strongly opposed by Pakistan. Recently India is facing many challenges from China on the matter of terrorism where China is seen continuously supporting Pakistan, for which India has presented enough evidences in UNSC. However, the 55-member Asia –Pacific grouping, including China and Pakistan

endorsed for India's candidature for a non-permanent seat this year for a two-year term in 2021-22.

Japan's claim is strongly opposed by China due to their past differences. Germany's claim is objected by Spain, Italy and sometimes by UK and France also. Brazil's claim is opposed by Argentina and Mexico on pretext that their GDP's size is equal to Brazil. Moreover, the German Chancellor during her visit to India in November 2019 presented a joint statement in which India and Germany reiterated their full support to each other's candidature for a permanent seat in a reformed and expanded UNSC.

Challenges Ahead

India's economic contribution to the UN is very low as compared to P5 nations and other G4 nations. USA stood first with 22 % of total funding while India's contribution to UN is about 0.74 % (22nd). India's per capita income is very low. As per the IMF, India is 142nd by nominal GDP and 119th by PPP GDP. The Global Hunger Index (GHI) annual report jointly published by Concern Worldwide and Welthungerhilfe ranked India 103rd among 119 countries, even below Pakistan and Sri Lanka and also stated that India is among 45 countries that have "serious levels of hunger". India's rank in ease of doing business has improved but isn't satisfactory. Problems in banking sectors create obstacles to the new businesses and also affect the "Foreign Investment".

India became Nuclear Power country back in 1974 and adopted the policy of 'No first use'. India is also member of strategically important international organisations like MTCR, Australia Group and Wassenaar Arrangement, economically and politically important organisations including BRICS, IBSA, G20, etc. India has played important role in establishing the Asian Development Bank and New Development Bank. These arguments of India strengthen the claim of permanent membership of United Nation Security Council.

Rohingya Crisis, Understanding its Genesis



The Rohingya are Muslim ethnic minority group who live primarily in Buddhist-majority Rakhine state of Myanmar and are basically homeless and poor people. Historically Rohingya came to Arakan – an independent kingdom and coastal region in Southeast Asia, now Rakhine State of Myanmar, starting in the fifteenth century. In eighteenth century it was conquered by Burmese empire (Myanmar). From nineteenth century to mid twentieth century Burma was in British control, many people from Rohingya community were brought from Bengal (today's Bangladesh and West Bengal of India) as bonded labourers to the region. Some Rohingya came for travel and trade with inhabitants of Arakan and later many of them settled in the region. During the World War II, Britain promised an autonomous state for the Rohingya in return for their help in World War II, but it never happened. Officially they are not recognized as lawful citizens of Myanmar and are denied citizenship under the Myanmar 1982 national law, but under the same law 135 ethnic groups were declared officially recognized by the Myanmar's government. In 2013, United Nations denoted them as one of the most persecuted minorities in the world.

After Independence of Myanmar

In 1948 Myanmar became independent but Buddhist majority Myanmar never recognised Rohingya as its citizens, even government of Myanmar won't use the word "Rohingya" for them; instead it calls them Bengalis, foreigners, infiltrators and terrorists. General U Ne Win led a military coup in 1962 and launched state-

sponsored oppression under “Operation Dragon King” officially known as “Operation Nagamin” between February-July 1978. During this period approximately 200,000 to 250,000 refugees, mostly Rohingya, fled to Bangladesh. Later Myanmar Armed Forces were accused by Rohingya of forcibly evicting villagers through terrorization, rape and murder. The government of Myanmar proclaimed that the mass exodus signified that Rohingya were in fact “illegal immigrants”. This created massive humanitarian crisis in the region especially in Bangladesh. Emergency relief were provided by The International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) and Bangladeshi government. Bangladesh urged the United Nations and United Nations High Commissioner for Refugee (UNHCR) for sending relief mission to the region. On July 1978, government of Bangladesh and Myanmar signed an agreement and 180,000 Rohingya refugees returned to Myanmar. Rohingya Solidarity Organisation (RSO) was founded in 1982 for retaliation to Myanmar Armed Forces.

Again in 1991-1992, “Operation Clean and Beautiful Nation”, officially known as “Operation Pyi Thaya” were launched by the Tatmadaw (Myanmar Armed Forces) in northern Rakhine State, similar to “Operation Nagamin” of 1978. According to government officials, the operation was for eliminating “outsiders” as well as curbing the insurgents of RSO. Retaliation by RSO resulted in huge violence, approximately 200,000 to 250,000 civilians were displaced and many fled to Bangladesh and later 150,000 were repatriated. In 2012, Myanmar Armed Forces again targeted Rohingya killing more than 200 people and making 150,000 homeless. In a nationwide census conducted in 2014 by government of Myanmar, which was also its first official census in 30 years, government denied Rohingya’s registration. Meanwhile many of them kept migrating to different countries for safe future.

Aung San Suu Kyi Regime

In 2015, fresh elections were held in Myanmar after years of autocratic military rule. It seemed that in wave of democracy

Rohingya people may get some rights but unfortunately they were barred from voting and contesting election. National League for Democracy (NLD) won the election with super majority of seats under leadership of Aung San Suu Kyi; she won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1991. Time Magazine named her one of the “children of Gandhi” and his spiritual heir to nonviolence. Along with this, she had won many awards for her leadership and contribution for democracy against the military rule in Myanmar. But when her party came into power, she didn’t take any step to resolve the Rohingya issue. According to her, “Muslims have been targeted but Buddhists have also been subjected to violence”. She further added, “This fear is what is leading to all this trouble”. Many countries and international organisations criticized her for the way she dealt with the Rohingya issue. Canada revoked her Honorary Citizenship in 2018 and some people argued that her Nobel Peace Prize should also be taken back.

In the same year (2015), Rohingya were forced to move to neighbouring Bangladesh, leading to refugee crisis in the region. According to UNHCR report, amongst 25,000 people who have been taken on boat during January to March 2015 by migrant smugglers, around 200 of them died in Malaysia while on their journey, 100 died in Indonesia and 10 in Thailand due to abandonment by traffickers at sea. They fled to different South Asian countries including Bangladesh, Malaysia, Thailand and Indonesia through Strait of Malacca and the Andaman Sea by rickety boats and were termed as “boat people” by international media. In 2017, Myanmar’s military launched a bloody crackdown with militant attacks on security post in August; approximately 700,000 of them marched to Bangladesh. United Nations had described the violence as “textbook example of ethnic cleansing”. In November 2017, through China’s effort an agreement was signed between Bangladesh and Myanmar on repatriation of the refugees.

India’s stand

Some Rohingya refugees came to India through Bangladesh and especially settled in West Bengal and Jammu and Kashmir, some 40,000 Rohingya refugees scattered across the country. India has its own concern with regard to Rohingya refugees. According to Government of India, presence of Rohingya refugees may cause serious threat to internal and national security of India; some of them have militant background and may be easy target for terrorist groups like ISIS. Government is suspicious of their actions in Kashmir as well. Rohingya's presence may create social, economical and political problem in the country. In an answer to Supreme Court, the government said that many Rohingya have acquired documents like Aadhaar, PAN and Voter-ID which is meant for only Indian citizen and this situation is dangerous.

Currently India doesn't have any specific law dealing with refugees. According to Foreigners Act, 1946 a person living in a country can be either a citizen or a foreigner. India isn't a signatory of UN Convention of 1951 or the Protocol of 1969, both of which are related with Status of Refugees and included in UHRC status. In absence of any adequate law identification and surveillance of refugees will become more difficult for securities agencies. Government is looking for ways to deport over 40,000 Rohingya living in the country illegally. However, UNHRC, Amnesty International and other international organisations asked Indian government to reconsider its decision and follow humanitarian approach while dealing with it. As Myanmar government only recognises 40,000 Rohingya out of one million, it is very difficult for Government of India to deport them. There are about 16,000 UNHRC-certified Rohingya living in India.

Currently, a large number of Rohingya refugees live in Cox's Bazar in Bangladesh. Bangladesh is also unable to manage pressure of such huge population of Rohingya refugee with its limited capacity and is seeking help from world community. Government of India helped Bangladesh to tackle the crisis by providing all amenities to the Rohingya refugees. India is also trying to talk to Myanmar to end persecution of Rohingyas. In recent months Myanmar government

showed some positive signs towards Rohingya as on 15 August 2019, Myanmar government gave clearance to 3,450 people out of 22,000 refugees, a list provided by Bangladesh. But the situation stays critical and a large number of Rohingya are still looking for justice.

The Role of UNO in Establishing World Peace



Following the devastation of the Second World War, the United Nations was conceptualized in 1945 with one central mission of maintaining international peace and security. This primary responsibility was given to the Security Council by the Charter of the United Nations.

As an international organization, the United Nations (UN) facilitates cooperation in international law, international security, economic development, social progress, human rights and achievement of world peace.

With its formation, the League of Nations was replaced in order to stop wars between countries and to provide a platform for dialogue. It carries out its missions through subsidiary organizations which work towards preventing conflict, helping parties in conflict make peace, peacekeeping and creating the conditions to allow peace to hold and flourish. Along with other UN offices and bodies, the General Assembly and the Secretary General play major, important and complementary roles.

The entire process of planning and formulating the United Nations Charter was dominated by the theme “We are going to create a collective security system and this time we are going to make it work.” The Charter provided a system for the pacific settlement or adjustment of disputes and the use of collective measures in threat or breaches of peace and acts of aggression.

The Organization & its composition

At present it has 193 member states including every internationally recognized sovereign state in the world excluding the Vatican City.

The UN and its specialized agencies decide on substantive and administrative issues in regular meetings held throughout the year from its offices around the world.

The organization has six principal organs:

- The General Assembly (the main deliberative assembly);
- The Security Council (for deciding certain resolutions for peace and security);
- The Economic and Social Council (for assisting in promoting international economic and social cooperation and development);
- The Secretariat (for providing studies, information, information and facilities needed by the UN);
- The International Court of Justice (the primary judicial organ);
- The United Nations Trusteeship Council (which is currently inactive).

Other well-known UN System agencies include the World Health Organization (WHO), the World Food Program (WFP) and the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF).

Since its creation, the UN has often been called upon to prevent disputes from escalating into war, to persuade opposing parties to use the conference table rather than force of arms, or to help restore peace when armed conflict does break out. The UN has helped to end numerous conflicts over the decades, often through actions of the Security Council.

The procedure

The UN exercises its role through the system provided by the Charter that consists of two methods delineated in Chapter VI entitled "Pacific Settlement of Disputes" and Chapter VII entitled "Actions with Respect to Threats to the Peace, Breaches of the Peace and Acts of Aggression" of the Charter.

- The first method is that of seeking peaceful settlement or adjustment of disputes and situation by peaceful means listed in the Charter.

- The second method is that of taking collective actions (measures) of a coercive nature for the prevention and removal of threats to the peace and for the suppression of acts of aggression and other breaches of the peace.

UN's peace efforts

The different instruments of the UN's peace efforts come into play at different stages of conflict. It plays an important role in conflict prevention using diplomacy, good offices and mediation. Special envoys and political missions in the field are some of its tools used to bring peace.

Peacemaking

In order to facilitate the resolution of the conflict, the Secretary-General may exercise his or her 'good offices' through steps taken publicly or in private, drawing upon his independence, impartiality and integrity. This way it tries to prevent international disputes from arising, escalating or spreading.

The UN peacebuilding architecture comprises of:

- The Peacebuilding Commission
- The Peacebuilding Fund
- The Peacebuilding Support Office

Countering Terrorism

The global fight against terrorism is coordinated by the United Nations through its eighteen universal instruments elaborated within the framework of the United Nations system relating to specific terrorist activities.

In September 2006, UN Member States adopted the United Nations global Counter-Terrorism Strategy and this was the first time that Member States agreed to a common strategic and operational framework against terrorism.

Peacekeeping

UN peacekeeping operations are deployed to support the implementation of inter-state ceasefires or peace agreements.

The first peacekeeping mission named the United Nations Truce Supervision Organization (UNTSO) was set up in 1945 to monitor an Armistice Agreement between Israel and its Arab neighbours or the UN mission on the Golan Heights (UNDOF).

UN peacekeeping is guided by three basic principles:

- Consent of the parties;
- Impartiality;
- Non-use of force except in self-defence and defence of the mandate

Disarmament

The goals of multilateral disarmament and arms have remained central to the maintenance of international peace and security since the birth of the United Nations.

These goals include reduction and eventually elimination of nuclear weapons, destroying chemical weapons and strengthening the prohibition against biological weapons and halt the proliferation of landmines, small arms and light weapons.

A number of key UN instruments which support these efforts are:

- The Treaty of the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) 1970
- The Chemical Weapons Convention 1997
- The Biological Weapons Convention 1975
- The Comprehensive Nuclear Test Ban Treaty 1996
- Mine Ban Convention 1999

Women, peace and security

Women suffer the greatest harm in spite of remaining a minority of combatants and perpetrators of war. With the adoption of resolution 1325 on women, peace and security; the UN Security Council recognized that the prospects for sustainable peace can be

strengthened by including women and gender perspectives in decision-making.

Organized Crime

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is the guardian of the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime (Organized Crime Convention) and the three supplementary Protocols on Trafficking in Persons, Smuggling of Migrants and Trafficking of Firearms.

In recent years, the UN has engaged in a series of processes to strengthen its ability to perform its core function- to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war.

Beyond the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and its ground-breaking goal on peaceful, just and inclusive societies, the peacebuilding architecture review, the women, peace and security agenda and the focus on youth and peacebuilding, its focus on prevention and the recent birth of the 'sustaining peace' agenda have brought about deep reflection on the UN's role in the modern era.

The UN peace efforts face five big challenges today:

- Geopolitical aggression and intransigence
- The practice of relabeling conflicts as counter-terror struggles
- Legacies of military intervention and regime change
- Panic over forced displacement
- Struggling humanitarianism

UN must think broadly about how to confront these by having new ideas and initiatives. It will be critical to use the vision and mandate of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) at a time when political consensus for peace is hard to build. 'Sustaining peace' should also be a moment to reclaim the policy space. UN must not settle for an inert, technocratic approach focused only on building capacity of state institutions. The SDGs is a drive for transformative change with more peaceful, just and inclusive societies helping to shape stronger and more inclusive institutions.

UN needs new champions to ensure the 'sustaining peace' agenda that achieves tangible, transformative results for all those living in shadow of violent conflict.

India's March in the Ease of Doing Business Rankings

The World Bank introduced the Ease of Doing Business (EDB) index in 2004. Economists at the World Bank Group Simeon Djankov and Gerhard Pohl created the EDB index. A report headlined "The Regulation of Entry" published in the Quarterly Journal of Economics in 2002 was the precursor to the EDB. The pilot report gave a snapshot of the regulation of entry of firms in 85 countries covering the number of procedures, cost and time taken for incorporation. The report with quantitative evidence revealed that countries with stringent regulation of entry have higher corruption and countries with more democratic and limited governments have lighter regulation of entry.

Ease of Doing Business Indicators

Ease of Doing Business 2020 report which includes data from May 2018 to May 2019 marks its 17th anniversary; the report captures 294 regulatory reforms implemented in 190 countries between May 2018 and May 2019. The ranking measures aspects of regulation affecting ten areas of the life of a business and aspects of regulation across 190 countries. A Distance-to- Frontier (DTF) score is given for each of the indicators that form a part of the statistic indicator, and the scores are aggregated. Indicators for which DTF is computed include starting a business, construction permits, getting electricity, registering property, getting credit, labour market regulation, protecting minority investors, administering contracts, paying taxes, trading across borders and settling insolvency. Data on these

indicators is collected from policymakers, chartered accountants, lawyers and regulatory experts to compare indicators across countries. EDB gives a helicopter view of a country's business environment.

India Among Top 10 Performers

India's ranking in the Ease of Doing Business Index 2020, has made a giant leap in five years, from 142th in 2015 to the 63rd rank in 2020. Thus, India has improved its rank by 79 points between 2015 and 2020; also the country is among the top ten performers for the third year in a row. Given the size of India's economy and geography, the efforts in the formation and implementation of reforms are meritorious.

The progress can be attributed to a significant improvement in various parameters. India's Distance to-Frontier score also witnessed a spike in all these years, which reflects the country has improved in absolute terms as well. The quantum jump in India's ranking is extraordinarily encouraging, and India can continue the reforms. In EDB 2020, India improved the most in four areas, and they are; starting a business, dealing with construction permits, trading across borders, resolving insolvency.

'Make in India' emerged as one of the real winners of the government's campaigns, which focused on pushing manufacturing sector, boosting the private sector, attracting foreign investment and enhancing the country's overall competitiveness.

The 'Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code'

The introduction of the 'Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC)' played a vital role in making India improve its Distance to Frontier on Resolving Insolvency. IBC adopted a reorganisation procedure for corporate debtors and facilitated the continuation of the debtor's business during insolvency proceedings. Introduction of ICDS (Income Computation and Disclosure Standards) to standardize the

procedure of computing taxable income and other tax accounting standards helped India move multiple notches in the respective parameter. Other initiative and a set of administrative measures easing compliance with corporate income tax also further contributed to the improvement in ranking.

The improvements were also driven by the introduction of the mandatory online payment mechanism for the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation and Employees' State Insurance. India's ranking in the Getting Credit indicator also seen phenomenal growth due to a reform that amended the rules on the prioritisation of secured creditors outside reorganisation proceedings. The latest procedure on insolvency provides power to secured creditors, such as banks and financial institutions, to enforce securities without the involvement of courts. In the absence of the reform, it was very tiresome for secured creditors to seize companies in default of their loans. The efficient functioning of credit bureaus in India has many positive effects and has helped collateral and default rates. Apparently, there are 50% lower default rates as well as higher operational efficiencies in the microfinance industry. Further to safeguard minority investors, the Securities Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has imposed restrictions on fundraising by defaulters.

The advancement in power distribution, supply and village electrification also remarkably improved the productivity and revenues in the manufacturing industry during the past five years.

Besides the above reforms and progress implemented over the years, the central government and several state governments have brought many changes and refined various existing processes between May 2018 and May 2019 which had a positive effect on all sets of indicators of EDB 2020.

The Electronic Submission of Documents

Starting a business in India made easier after doing away with filing fees for the SPICe company incorporation form, electronic

memorandum of association and articles of association. The process of construction permits streamlined and reduced the cost and time in obtaining construction permits in several states. The procedure for obtaining a building permit not only streamlined but also made it faster and affordable. The government also brought efficiency in trading across borders by enhancing the electronic submission of documents, integrating trade stakeholders on an electronic platform, upgrading port infrastructures and enabling post-clearance audits.

The welcome and desirable addition is that every state government in India is competing with each other to be on top of various indices so that they can attract investment. Each state is embracing change and building its own core competency in unique fields like tourism, IT, pharma, minerals, power generation and other sectors.

Due to the different rules and procedures across the states in India, business regulation is designed and implemented at various levels, including at the central, state and municipal level. Accordingly, India's Ease of Doing Business process consists of two categories:

1) Regulatory functions of the central government, the Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi, and the Government of Maharashtra. 53 and 47 are the weights used in calculating the scores for Delhi and Mumbai, the two cities covered in India, respectively. 2) Licenses, permits, procedures, inspections and policies, across all states of India. Therefore, every municipality and state has a vital role in helping India improve its EDB ranking.

India's Commitment to Reforms

The Indian government adopted the EDB indicators as a core component of their reform strategies. In 2015 the government's goal was to join the 50 top economies on the ease of doing business ranking by 2020. The government targeted all those areas measured by EDB with a significant focus on paying taxes, trading across borders, and resolving insolvency. The country's efforts have made a substantial leap upward, raising its ease of doing business and paid

in dividends. The government turned to the EDB rank and indicators to convince foreign companies and investors about India's commitment to reforms and to demonstrate tangible progress. Hence, building on recent improvements to its ranking, India can benefit from further strengthening the competitive business environment.

Notwithstanding these achievements on various fronts, India needs to give a facelift to its judicial quality, as is a significant determinant of a firm's manufacturing, exports and domestic sales performance. A business's sales and performance increases by 2% for every 10% increase in judicial quality. Further, India needs to focus on labour reforms to arrest problems such as restrictive labour regulations, labour market rigidity, youth unemployment and employment protection. It implies that the aspects concerning labour reforms have prevented India from reaping the full benefits of 'Make in India.' India can improve its score in enforcing contracts indicator by implementing these recommendations.

Merger of Public Sector Banks in India



The merger of public sector banks in India is an economic necessity for gaining a competitive edge over private sector banks, and help to make the overall economy more efficient. On the one hand, boundless opportunities to facilitate growth in the banking sector are taking place in India. On the other, state-owned banks are bleeding due to factors like enhanced corporate competitiveness, ever-changing regulatory environment, non-adoption of modern technologies, operational inefficiencies, leadership crisis, lack of quality benchmark and best practices.

The Reserve Bank of India's various fraud detection guidelines are helping to foster growth, strengthen books and bring down stress levels in bank assets. On the downside, the restrictive regulations and shackles imposed by the RBI are not only compounding the problems of the weaker PSU banks but also limiting the ability to achieve sustainable growth. For decades, the confusion was perpetuated through inadvertence.

Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) Framework

For instance, the RBI initiated the Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) framework in 2014 and 2017, under which banks with weak financial metrics will come under the RBI's surveillance. All banks with a low level of capital to risk-weighted assets ratio (CRAR) and high-level net non-performing assets (NNPA) will immediately come under the PCA.

The bank which comes under PCA will be required to reduce risk assets, unrated borrowers and limit expansion activities; ought to sell

assets and possess a recovery plan. In a nutshell, RBI closely monitors asset quality, capital, leverage and profitability parameters of banks. The PCA framework imposed on weaker banks undoubtedly helped in minimising contagion losses and other negative impacts.

Allahabad Bank, Bank of India, Bank of Maharashtra, Central Bank of India, Corporation Bank, Dena Bank, IDBI Bank, Indian Overseas Bank, Oriental Bank of Commerce, UCO Bank, United Bank of India were put under the PCA framework. A few of the banks, which had shown resistance and potential to grow, were removed from PCA after capital infusion from the government. Out of these, IDBI Bank has been acquired by LIC of India, while Dena bank was merged with Bank of Baroda in April 2019. The recent PSU bank merger proposal has brought a new dawn for Allahabad Bank, Corporation Bank, Oriental Bank of Commerce and United Bank.

Government Likely to Stick to Capital Infusion Programme

Armed with the '4R strategy' (recognition, resolution, recapitalisation and reforms), the government has been acting according to various situations. The government infused Rs 1.06 lakh crore during FY 2018-19. After cleaning up the books of the State-run banks, Rs.70,000 has been allotted for FY 2019-20. Nevertheless, it is increasingly becoming burdensome to infuse capital funding into frailest PSBs. Consequently, the health of ailing PSU banks will be dependent on the amount of capital the government is willing to infuse into these banks.

The capital infusion without reforms may lead to a rapid drawdown due to higher risk weights of such assets. The risks associated with these weaker banks in the current scenario may not diminish. Therefore, the government has decided to amalgamate some state-run white elephant banks with the golden geese. In one stroke, the government resolved the declining capital, mounting losses and rising bad assets of those white elephants.

The Asset Quality Review

The bank frauds involving PSBs increased from Rs 19,529 crore in 2017 to Rs 29,246 crore in 2018. The Asset Quality Review initiated in 2015 revealed high incidence of NPAs in state-owned banks which increased from Rs 279,016 crore in March 2015 to Rs 895,601 crore as in March 2018 (by about Rs 6.2 lakh crore). Aggregate gross advances of PSBs increased from Rs 18.20 lakh crores in March 2008 to Rs 52.16 lakh crores as in March 2014 due to aggressive lending practices, wilful defaults and loan frauds. These figures throw light on the worsening financial condition in the PSBs after which RBI had to bring several banks under the PAC framework.

In September 2018, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance questioned RBI for failing to portend early warning of stressed accounts while doing the Asset Quality Review, and take preemptive action.

Phase Wise Implementation of Mergers

The Government, without waiting for the last straw, exercised its last recourse and fourth 'R'. The consolidation of banks is a part of Bank reforms. The merger of public sector banks is based on the recommendations of the Narasimham Committee 1991.

The pilot scheme of PSBs mergers took place on April 1, 2017 by amalgamating five associate banks with State Bank of India. State Bank of Bikaner & Jaipur, State Bank of Hyderabad, State Bank of Mysore, State Bank of Patiala and State Bank of Travancore were merged with State Bank of India on April 1, 2017. The mega-merger made SBI a mammoth bank that accounts for a quarter of all outstanding loans in the Indian banking sector.

The second tranche of PSBs merger occurred on April 1, 2019 which was the amalgamation of Dena Bank and Vijaya Bank with Bank of Baroda. While this marks the first-ever three-way merger of the banks in India, Vijaya Bank is the only bank among the three to post a net profit in the latest financial year.

In the next tranche, Oriental Bank of Commerce and United Bank of India will be amalgamated with Punjab National Bank. Allahabad Bank will join with Indian Bank, Canara Bank will swallow Syndicate Bank, Andhra Bank and Corporation Bank will merge with Union Bank of India. The merger exercise will be concluded by March 2020.

The Pillars of Merger Strategy

Ideally, the mergers and consolidation of banks must be strategically chalked out based on the core banking system, norms and ratios determined by the Basel, competitiveness, brand potential, size, synergies, market power, market position, economies of scope, technology platforms, geographical origin and other factors. Several steps must be taken to ensure robust performance and clean functioning.

The amalgamation or merger exercise should be carried out by experienced M&A professionals with autonomy. The wrong selection of a merger candidate or an anchor bank could destroy the enterprise value. However, unlike that of corporate mergers, Bank mergers cannot only focus on core competencies and synergies. Basel and RBI guidelines will be the chief priority for the bank mergers. Hence, the merger model that was adopted by the government does not support factors like the market-facing decision, customer-centric approach, shareholder value creation theory.

The Metrics Behind Public Sector Bank Mergers

The government carefully conceived the merger model where one or more weak PSBs are combining with a stronger counterpart to form one powerful bank. The three vital parameters for amalgamation are the merged entity's combined common equity tier-I (CET) ratio must be 7%, the combined entity must have a minimum CRR ratio of 10.875 and NPAs below 6%. Preferably, the merger candidates should use the same core banking system. The merged entity may take more than two years to synchronise financial products and

customer applications, standardise core technology, and integrate the backend technology.

How will the PSB Mergers Affect Bank Customers

With high Current And Savings Account (CASA) ratio and strong lending capacity, the merged entity's synergies, physical outreach, human resources and unique strengths mutually reinforce value creation. On the flip side, the better performing bank compensates for a weak bank. Ultimately, the question is this will the mergers entail efforts to enhance lending growth and profits, defend the market position, attempts to overcome inefficiencies?

The merged entity has to deal with cultural differences among its employees as well as social integration and psychological factors among customers. Can the acquirer banks continue to charm and retain the customers of the acquiree banks? Customers of acquiree bank may not be enthusiastic about availing services of the merged entity, after losing the emotional touch. Moreover, the decision will not go down well with the shareholders of the acquirer bank, though it will bring cheer to the acquiree bank shareholders. Given the government's catch-22 situation, the PSB mergers, except for minor side-effects, are undoubtedly a welcome step in the right direction.

Why India Opted out of Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership?



Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) was initiated by China to link half the world's people and to gain supremacy in Asia-Pacific. Set afloat in 2012, RCEP is a free trade agreement in the APAC region between the member countries of the ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) and their six free trade partners from Asia and Australia. Until recently the pact was christened as ASEAN Plus Six. The RCEP member countries are Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam, Malaysia, Australia, China, India, Japan, New Zealand and South Korea.

RCEP's Objective

The RCEP group took birth intending to bridge the trade barriers and to cover 30 percent of global trade. The centrepiece of its agenda is to give unrestricted access to each member's markets to other members. India was part of the RCEP trade agreement, which was constituted to connect 3.5 billion people across the 16 countries. The exclusion of the United States from RCEP remained as a significant talking point for the past seven years. The RCEP pact is an intriguing story, whose 16 member countries would account for 46 percent of the global population and 35 percent of the world's gross domestic product.

China Using it as a Counterbalance to its Tariff War

The RCEP free trade agreement was scheduled to be signed by all members in the recently concluded Summit in Bangkok. The entire world was eagerly watching with all eyes on the fate of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. Thailand hosted the 35th ASEAN summit, and the venue also served as the 3rd Summit of RCEP.

Out of the 25 chapters in the RCEP free trade agreement, 20 chapters have been agreed by all the members. Several crucial chapters, such as rules of origin and trade remedies, E-commerce remains to be resolved and concluded. However, the commerce ministers of RCEP member countries continue discussing outstanding issues. China is confident of signing the agreement next year even in the absence of India. China is in a hurry, and the country badly needs the deal to be operational, by hook or by crook, as a counterbalance to its tariff war with the United States.

India brought up a string of issues and raised a slew of demands at the RCEP summit in Thailand. However, India announced its decision to withdraw from RCEP. The main point of contention is "Why did India opt-out of Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership?"

It will probably be signed in 2020, in the RCEPs fourth Summit on the sidelines of the ASEAN to be held in Vietnam, when Vietnam takes over as the chair of ASEAN. If signed, the trade agreement would become the largest free trade deal in the world.

The Latecomer Walks Away with the Prize

India has been a World Trade Organisation member since 1 January 1995 and a member whereas China joined as a member of the World Trade Organization on 11 December 2001, after the agreement of the Ministerial Conference. Hence, China's past, concerning world trade, is of no consequence. India's foreign trade (export and import) stood at a meagre \$42 billion in 1990-91, which jumped to \$890 billion in 2018-19. On the other hand, China's foreign trade swelled from \$200 billion in 2001 to over \$4.2 trillion in 2018-19. China took the World

Trade Organisation, globalisation and market access to its advantage. Conversely, the democratic political system and corporate lobbying in India left the country behind.

India Becomes the Dumping Ground

In the past two decades, the flood of cheap, mass-produced Chinese goods has wiped out the domestic industry forcing domestic manufacturers to shut down units and gave the workforce a sack. Chinese products are ruling the roost in the electronics, telecom, power, and steel market in India. India does not want this story to be repeated in other sectors like Automobile, which are vital to the country's economy. For instance, Chinese car manufacturers copied European brands and dominated the global automobile market.

India's trade deficit with China rose disproportionately, and placed India's balance of trade under severe pressure. Amid the state of affairs, India did not have any option but to impose anti-dumping duties on Chinese products. Besides China, other member countries of the RCEP are also actively participating in the dumping of cheaper goods into India, which is again a cause for concern. For example, Malaysia is dumping cheaper palm oil into India, thereby putting India's edible oil industry at risk. This, coupled with the unprovoked pronouncements by the Malaysian Prime Minister at the United Nations regarding Kashmir, made the Government to review the trade relations with Malaysia.

India's Trade Deficit with 11 RCEP Countries

In FY 2018-19, India recorded a trade deficit with 25 major countries out of which 11 countries are members of RCEP. India's trade deficit with RCEP countries is about \$105 billion. China (including Hong Kong) alone is \$60.1 billion. The reason behind India's trade deficit is due to the overflow of imports like crude oil, electronic equipment and machinery, iron and steel, chemicals and fertilisers. For this reason, India is very circumspect in its negotiations with RCEP FTA. The deal

may further widen the trade deficit with several RCEP member countries, which would impact domestic industries and producers.

Historically, Free Trade Agreements not only failed to make a positive impact on the Indian foreign trade but also proved to be expensive for India economy. India's foreign trade is self-standing and independent of trade pacts. India is heedful of its intuitions and will enter into any free trade agreements on its terms, without compromising the interest of domestic industry and country's economy. The average tariff applicable to countries with MFN status (most favoured nations) in India is highest among the major Asian economies.

Safeguarding the Interests of Domestic Industries

India felt apprehensive about the dumping and influx of cheaper goods from China. The domestic market and economy could be distressed if flooded with cheaper Chinese goods and merchandise. India's priority, at this juncture, is to safeguard the interests of farmers, dairy sector, small businesses, textiles, automobile and the services industry. India is determined to protect the domestic producers and industry's competitiveness at any cost.

Given the phenomenal growth of India's share of foreign trade with NAFTA member countries, it is not surprising that India shifting focus to NAFTA. At the same time, the US terminated preferential trade status for India under Generalised System of Preferences (GSP) and withdrew incentives to \$6.3 billion of Indian exports under the GSP scheme effective 5 June 2019. India's demand for restoration of the GSP programme for its exports to the American market is under consideration. After a careful assessment and evolution, India tilts towards pursuing the US and European markets rather than opening up its door to dumping from China.

The Doors are Always Open for India

China wants to continue its predominance in the APAC region geoeconomically as well as geopolitically. China's authority is causing

insecurity and jeopardy in the region, especially for India. It could be one of the primary reasons why India put a stop to the mega RCEP deal. India is the third-largest economy in the RCEP bloc, and high winds from India hampered China's efforts to ride the wave. India's withdrawal from the RCEP created chaos and diffidence among member countries which inescapably lead to introspection and anatomization. Inevitably, Japan and Australia are advocating for the deal that includes India.

We cannot completely write off the RCEP as the FTA could bring in some opportunities. However, the doors have been open for India to join RCEP if it changes course and when there is a consensus. On second thought, India may never do, if the terms of the FTA are not amended in India's favour.

Agricultural Reforms and Farmer Welfare Schemes under Modi Government



The rapid development of the industrial and service sector has played a key role in India's growth story. Nevertheless, India is still a major agrarian economy. With almost two-thirds of the population engaged in agriculture and allied activities, the contribution of the agricultural sector to the economy cannot be underestimated.

The successive Indian governments have always tried to improve the agricultural output of the country as well as improve the quality of life of the farmers. Likewise, the agricultural reforms under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi have been an integral part of the NDA government's agenda as well. Various initiatives have been taken to improve productivity, augment farmer's income, safeguard their livelihood, and improve their overall wellbeing. The government has set an ambitious target of doubling the farmer's income by the year 2022 and has undertaken a multi-modal focus to achieve this goal.

Here is a brief glimpse into the several agricultural reforms and farmer welfare schemes undertaken by the Modi Government (1 & 2) to strengthen the Indian agricultural sector:

1. Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY)

Whether it is inclement weather or other man-made reasons, farmers suffered huge losses due to their crops being destroyed. To make up for the losses, the government introduced the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY). It is a government sponsored crop insurance scheme that offers insurance coverage and financial support to farmers in case of failure of a notified crop.

The other objectives of this scheme are to ensure regular flow of credit to the agricultural sector and encourage adoption of modern agricultural practices. Moreover, this scheme envisages helping the farmers continue their work with a stable income.

2. Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana (PMKSY)

Under the leadership of Mr Modi, the Indian government accords top priority to conservation of water and its optimal usage. In order to achieve this goal, the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana (PMKSY) has been envisaged. The scheme aims to ensure “Har khet ko pani” to extend the coverage of irrigation, and “More crop, per drop” to ensure efficient use of water resources. Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana focuses on the creation, distribution, and management of limited freshwater resources.

3. E-NAM

E-NAM or e-National Agricultural Market is an online trading portal connecting various APMC (Agri Produce Marketing Committee) mandis throughout the country. The main focus of this initiative is the creation of a unified nation-wide market for buying and selling of agricultural commodities in a transparent manner. The onus of implanting this initiative lies with the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare of the Government of India. The ministry has appointed Small Farmers Agribusiness Consortium (SFAC) as the premier agency for implementation of eNAM. The benefits that farmers can accrue through this initiative are noteworthy, such as: -

- Removal of information asymmetry between farmers and buyers.
- Real-time price information based on demand and supply.
- Potential of selling commodities across India.
- Prices decided in a transparent manner through an auction process.
- Timely online payment for the products sold by farmers through eNAM.

4. Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY)

In order to realise the potential of organic farming in India, the government introduced the Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (PKVY) in the year 2015. Under this scheme, farmers will be encouraged to form clusters and then adopt organic farming practices over large swathes of agricultural land. The scheme envisages the formation of more than 10,000 clusters to implement organic farming to over 5 lakh acres of agricultural land across the country.

The costs involved in the promotion of organic farming through existing agricultural practices and certification will be covered by the central government. In order to be eligible for this scheme, the cluster must be formed by at least 50 farmers having more than 50 acres of land under cultivation. Every farmer, who is a part of a cluster, will be provided a sum of Rs. 20,000 per acre to be spent over the next 3 years for converting from traditional practices to organic farming practices.

5. Gramin Bhandaran Yojana

One big problem that is faced by farmers is to ensure the safekeeping of the cultivated crop, produce, and farming equipment. To address this problem, the government has come up with the Gramin Bhandaran Yojana. This scheme aims to solve the storage-related problems faced by farmers at multiple levels: -

- Creation of scientific storage capacity along with all essential facilities in rural areas.
- Help the farmers with storage of their processed produce, farm produce, and other vital agricultural inputs.
- Encourage standardisation, grading, and quality control of the product in a scientific manner to encourage its saleability.
- Offering bridge financing and marketing credit to control distress sale due to any contingency post-cultivation.
- Strengthening of the agricultural produce marketing infrastructure across the country.

6. National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture (NMSA)

There is no denying the fact that the future of agriculture lies in sustainable agricultural methods. To encourage and educate the farmers about various sustainable methods of farming, National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture (NMSA) has been formulated. This initiative aims to boost agricultural productivity in areas dependant on rain for irrigation through different integrated approaches like soil health management, water use efficiency, and synergy resource conservation.

This scheme has been devised to address three key dimensions of sustainable agriculture, i.e. Nutrient Management, Livelihood Diversification, and Efficient Water Usage. These goals will be achieved through a multi-pronged approach focussed on conservation of natural resources, eco-friendly technologies, integrated farming, and adoption of energy-efficient equipment. Some of the flagship schemes introduced under the aegis of National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture are: -

- National Rainfed Area Authority (NRAA)
- National Centre of Organic Farming (NCOF)
- Rainfed Area Development (RAD)
- Soil and Land Use Survey of India (SLUSI)
- Mission Organic Value Chain Development in North Eastern Region (MOVCDNER)
- Central Fertilizer Quality Control and Training Institute (CFQC&TI)

7. Micro Irrigation Fund (MIF)

Micro-irrigation is a proven agricultural technique that not only conserves water but also boosts agricultural output. To bring more agricultural land under micro-irrigation, the government has set up a Micro Irrigation Fund with Rs. 5,000 crores. The objective of this initiative is to improve agricultural output and income of the farmers. NABARD is the operating agency for this fund and provides the states with loans on concessional rates for promotion of micro-

irrigation. The current land coverage under micro-irrigation is 10 million hectares while the total potential is of 70 million hectares.

As agriculture is the backbone of the Indian economy, the government should undertake more concerted efforts to improve the state of agriculture as well as the farmers. It will require continued efforts and a focussed approach to achieve desired results.

Rising NPAs in India's Banking— causes, Loopholes & Measures to Curb the Problem



Who can forget about the great financial crisis of 2008, which pushed the world into an economic slowdown? But the Indian economy remained largely unscathed, and the reason behind this was the robustness of the banking sector in India. At that time, both the Indian economy and the Indian banking sector were regarded as a shining beacon during global turmoil. Now, fast-forward 10 years, and the situation of Indian banking system is utterly disappointing. The banking sector in India is plagued by issues like corruption, rising NPAs, lack of supervision, poor accounting practices, and capital inadequacy which have resulted in lowering of the popular sentiments.

Numerous banking frauds and scams have been unearthed in the last few years by the investigation agencies, highlighting the rot at the core of the Indian banking system. Instances like Kingfisher Airlines fraud, Nirav Modi-PNB fraud, PMC Bank fraud are just a tip of the iceberg; the problem runs much deeper. As a matter of fact, in the year 2009, India had the lowest NPA ratio amongst the G-20 economies @ 2.280. But as of 2018, it has amongst the highest NPA ratio amongst the elite G-20 group @ 11.180.

Why Such a Surge in the NPAs?

Well, it would be a folly to think that the sudden surge in the NPAs is a recent phenomenon. The problems run deeper and dates to well before 2009. The investigation has proven that the lowest NPA ratio in 2009 was due to a toxic combination of poor accounting practices

and regulatory laxity. As a result, banks managed to understate their NPAs and hid the true extent of the problem.

Another reason attributed behind this development is that after much prodding from the Reserve Bank of India, the banks finally relented and recognised these bad assets which were otherwise being hidden in the annual reports. When the banks started reporting the true extent of the NPAs, the ratio just skyrocketed from an all-time low of 2.250 in 2011 to 11.180 in 2018.

While NPAs are a common problem plaguing the global banking networks, but the situation looks grim in the Indian context due to the problem of capital inadequacy with Indian banks. Having a healthy capital adequacy ratio is essential for any bank as it signifies its ability to withstand contingent financial losses on account of risky assets. But despite having a conservative loan to deposit ratio, Indian banks fare poorly on this front.

Moreover, the saga of NPAs does not seem to have reached its conclusion yet. New revelations are being made regularly which indicate that all of the NPAs have not yet been accounted for. For instance, in its reports filed in 2018, SBI reported unexpected losses of 2,416 crores due to surge in bad loans. Though the bank says that the worse is over, but it has been saying this since 2010, so one can not be sure if the saga is finally over or there are still some portions left to be unravelled.

Causes of Rising NPAs in India

There are various loopholes in the Indian banking system that has given rise to the problem of NPAs, such as: -

Defective Lending Process

The lending process of every commercial bank should be based on three principles, safety, profitability, and liquidity. But due to vested interests as well as corruption, more often than not decision-makers at banks tend to ignore these principles. Moreover, lack of

transparency in the lending process also makes it difficult to appropriate the responsibility of decision-makers in case of defaults.

High Leverage

When the Indian economy was on an upward trajectory in the mid-2000s, banks offered loans to corporations based only on the recent performance, rather than assessing the historical financial data. As a result, corporations grew highly leveraged. All money for the expansion of business operations was being sourced through banks instead of promoter's equity. When the global financial crisis manifested in 2008, the corporations started facing difficulty in making the repayments. As a result, both the banking sector and corporate sector of the economy came under tremendous stress.

Evergreening

In order to hide the problem of NPAs, banks started offering loans to corporations to allow them to repay their interest liabilities for previous loans. This trend further worsened the problem and was equivalent to "brushing it under the carpet." When the problem of NPAs was finally recognized, the situation had gone from bad to worse.

Frauds

The fact which makes the problem of NPAs even worse is that the bank employees were colluding with the borrowers. Rules were flouted, information was suppressed, and procedures were ignored to offer loans to select corporates. For instance, in the case of the recent PMC Bank fraud, more than 70% of the bank's loans were provided to a single entity, which is a gross violation of RBI's guidelines.

Wilful Defaulters

Due to lax recovery efforts and prolonged legal process, even those borrowers who are in a position to repay their loans are refraining from making the payments.

Lack of Monitoring

Banks do not undertake regular visits to the premises of the borrowers to monitor the progress of the work as well as to press for the recovery of the dues. Most of the times, bank officials are obliged by way of gifts by the borrowers, and they, as a result, do not put pressure for recovery of the dues.

How to reduce the NPAs?

The government and RBI have taken several steps to stem this rot, and they have started showing results as well. These measures can be classified as: -

Regulatory measures:

Policy level decisions like the introduction of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code 2016 provide for a 180-day recovery process for NPAs. As of March 2018, 701 cases have been registered under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, and more than 170 cases have already been resolved.

Remedial measures:

RBI has been recommending remedial measures for banks in the form of guidelines to help with the restructuring of NPAs. Strategic debt restructuring and joint lenders forum are the key initiatives under the remedial measures which have been offering good results.

Apart from these measures taken by the Government and the RBI, certain changes must also be incorporated by the banks on a personal level to stem this rot. Here are some steps that the banks can take to curb the menace of bad loans: -

One time settlement:

Banks need to offer an opportunity to defaulters to settle their outstanding dues through a one-time settlement. Herein, the borrower needs to pay a lump-sum amount in lieu of the outstanding dues. Usually, the banks let go of the accumulated interest and penal charges and settle the account against repayment of outstanding principal.

Transparency:

Banks need to incorporate strict and transparent eligibility criteria to screen the applications of loans. If any borrowers have defaulted in repayments or are facing trouble in making the payments, their applications must be carefully scrutinized.

Automation:

The loan approval process must be automated with the help of tools like artificial intelligence. By removing human involvement from the loan disbursement process, the prejudices can be effectively negated.

Dedicated recovery department:

Banks need to have dedicated recovery departments to follow-up with the defaulting customers and make regular visits to recover the outstanding amounts.

With the potential to wreak havoc on the country's economy, NPAs must be dealt with on a priority basis. There is a need for the banks to wake up to this problem, accept it and then take concrete measures to stop it from spreading.

How far has India been Successful in its Battle Against Black Money?



Indian government has set an ambitious target of becoming a \$5 trillion economy by 2024. With a large population base comprising of an expanding middle class, the long-term outlook for the economy is largely positive despite the short-term upheaval. Though the potential has always been there, and the target of becoming a \$5 trillion economy is achievable but certain roadblocks are acting as an impediment in the journey of Indian growth story. Black Money has been one of the major factors that is impeding the growth of the economy and acts as a drain on national resources. It is one of the burning national issues and has always found a traction with the Indian society.

The Modi Government came to power in 2014 on the plank of identifying the evaders and recovery of black money. With the second Modi government, elected in 2019, putting up a resolute fight against this menace, things have started looking upwards. But the question that beckons is how far has India been successful in its battle against the menace of the black money. Let's have an in-depth analysis of the journey so far and what lies ahead.

What is Black Money, and Why is it Bad for National Economy?

Black money is simply that money on which taxes have not been paid by the receiver or the payer. Every government requires money to implement its policies and development agenda. The biggest source of income for the government is tax revenue, direct and indirect both. Beyond a specified threshold, a certain rate of taxes is applicable to

monetary transactions. These could be income tax, goods and sales tax, or other forms of taxes. But when the seller and the buyer both try to evade their liability to pay taxes on that amount, black money is generated. This black money gives rise to a parallel economy which poses stiff challenges to the formal economy. When the government does not have adequate revenue to implement its policies, it will either borrow from the market, widening current account deficit or would put off the said expenses. Both these situations are extremely detrimental to the economy. This is the reason behind the Indian Government waging war against black money.

Multi-pronged Battle Against Black Money

To ascertain the level of success achieved against the black money, it is important to do an in-depth analysis of various actions initiated by the government.

Income Declaration Scheme, Black Money & Imposition of Tax Act

The Black Money (Undisclosed Foreign Income and Assets) and Imposition of Tax Act were introduced in the year 2015, soon after the Narendra Modi government came to power. This scheme offered a one-time window to individuals with undisclosed foreign assets to come clean. The government was able to detect Rs. 4100 crores worth of undisclosed income in foreign banks from around 650 individuals.

Subsequently, the government opened two more windows in the year 2016, i.e. Income Declaration Scheme and Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana. Under the Income Declaration Scheme, undeclared income of approximately Rs 65,000 crores was declared by around 64,000 individuals. Assets disclosed under Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana were to the tune of Rs. 5,000 crores. With numerous individuals declaring their income and government getting significant tax revenue, these schemes could be touted as successful in unearthing black money hidden abroad as well as within the country.

Demonetisation in 2016

When the demonetisation was announced in the month of November 2016, it came as a shock to the country. The aim of the announcement was to weed out the black money from the economy, but the results are subject to divided opinions. While the detractors say that currency notes of all but Rs. 16,000 crore returned to the banking system while the total expense incurred by RBI on the entire exercise was Rs. 21,000 crore. So, according to them, the exercise was a failure. But there are some sections which believe that demonetisation helped government identify the tax evaders and has since helped widen the tax base bringing more people to the formal economy. Still, the direct benefits expected from demonetisation were nowhere near as expected and it did not wipe out the black money through widening of tax base was a silver lining in the whole exercise.

Pact with Swiss Banks

Swiss Banks have always been notoriously regarded as the safe haven for Indian tax evaders. As a result, to get details of the tax evaders, the Indian government entered into an agreement with the Swiss National Bank in 2016. Under this agreement, the Swiss National Bank would be sharing the details of Indian nationals with Swiss Bank Accounts.

As per latest updates, the first tranche of Swiss account details of Indian nationals has been recently handed over to the Indian Government by the Swiss National Bank on 7th October 2019. This list includes all pertinent details that would allow the government to identify the individuals and their banking details. As a result of this agreement, various Indian account holders closed their Swiss bank accounts due to which the total deposits in Swiss Banks from Indian nationals have a decline from US \$2.2.3 billion in 2014 to US \$527 million in 2017. So, this exercise could be termed as moderate success in addressing the menace of black money.

Widening of the Taxpayer Base

Ever since the Indian government waged war against black money, the number of individual taxpayers has more than doubled in four years. This has translated into almost 50% increase in the tax collections during the same period. By the end of financial year 2017-18, the number of taxpayers in India has increased to 6.84 crores as compared to 3.79 crores in 2013-14.

Introduction of GST

Introduction of GST has been the single biggest tax reform in the history of India. Though the main purpose of GST is to ensure seamless movement of goods across the country but there is another motive of GST which is to identify tax evaders and bringing them into the mainstream economy. With multiple checks while filing GST returns as well as introduction of E-waybills, the chances of illegal movement of goods could be checked. A large number of first-time GST registrations prove that there is a fear of action in the minds of the evaders.

Blocking the Mauritius Investment Route

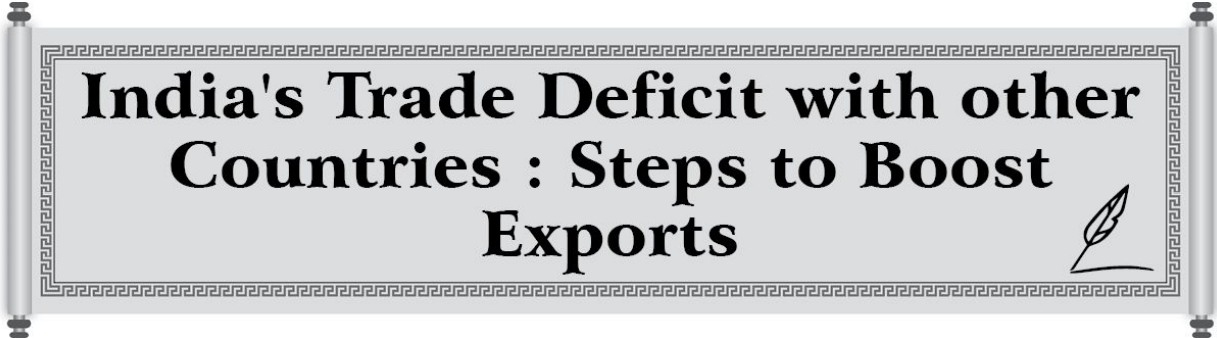
In the month of May 2016, the Indian Government signed a double tax avoidance agreement with the Mauritian government, and on 1st April 2017, General Anti-Avoidance Rules came into force. Both these legislations were aimed at blocking the notorious Mauritian route taken for tax evasion and generation of black money. Shares of an Indian company acquired by a Mauritian Tax Resident have now been made subject to capital gain tax in India, effectively blocking the Mauritian route.

Income Tax Department to be Given More Powers

A government empowered the Income Tax Department with more powers to conduct search and survey operations. The department now need not disclose reason to believe or suspect before conducting a raid. This has helped unearth undisclosed income of more than Rs. 13,000 crore.

The fight against black money is an ongoing battle which requires a steadfast commitment of the Indian Government. Till date, the steps taken have given encouraging results, and it is expected that the intensity of the government's commitment to fighting against the black money will only be strengthened further. It is essential for the economic development of the country that the menace of black money is tackled once and for all.

India's Trade Deficit with other Countries : Steps to Boost Exports



It is essential for every country to maintain a balance in its exports and imports as it is the most significant part of the current account. In a developing country like India, having a trade surplus is even more crucial as it has a significant impact on the overall economic outlook. A trade deficit for India means that the demand for country's exports (goods and services) in other countries is lower while the demand for other country's imports (goods and services) in India is increasing. As a result, the employment levels in the country will take a blow, because reduced demand for Indian goods and services means shutting down of businesses involved in offering those goods and services. This development will then have a huge impact on the GDP figures and can even put the government's plan of making India a \$5 trillion economy on the back burner.

India's trade deficit has widened with more than 25 countries in the last three years. The overall trade deficit for the last three years can be summarised as follows:

Year	Trade Deficit
2016-2017	\$ 40.20 billion
2017-2018	\$ 84.45 billion
2018-2019	\$ 103.63 billion

The trade deficit has widened over the last three years despite positive growth registered in the exports sector. This development can be attributed to increase in the import of products like crude oil, electronic goods, coal, coke, machinery, non-ferrous metals, fertilizers, chemicals, iron and steel-related products, which make up for more than 70% of total imports of the country in the year 2018-19.

The Implications of the Trade Imbalance

As trade imbalance reflects the excess of imports over the exports, it has profound implications for the Indian economy. It is required on the part of the government to undertake measures to restore the trade balance to continue with the excellent growth India has depicted in the past. Here are some of the implications that India might have to face if the widening trade imbalance is not corrected -

Increase in unemployment rates:

As the demand for goods and services from India is lower in other countries for a longer period, there will be significant pressure on the industry. Goods manufactured for exports would lie unsold, exerting tremendous pressure on the financial strength of the organisation. Over a period, the burden would be too great to bear, leading to desperate measures to cut down expenses. This would not only put the expansion activities on hold but would also lead to the closure of businesses. As a result, the unemployment rates would increase creating a multitude of problems.

Overall economic slowdown:

The overall outlook of the economy would be grim as no new investments would take place, and all sections of the industry would try to dig deep, putting all expansion plans on hold. The negative sentiments due to falling exports would affect the average investors who would start looking for safer options for investing their money. The overall economic slowdown would hurt the GDP as well as the overall outlook of the economy.

Decrease in foreign investment:

Foreign investors always look for opportunities where they can enjoy a better return on their money as compared to their own country. As the competitiveness of the Indian economy would reduce, the investors might be wary of investing their money in India. This trend will further slowdown the revival of the economy.

Fall in currency value:

If the Indian exports continue to be lower than Indian imports, the demand for Indian rupee will fall. In the long run the exchange rate of Indian rupee would also fall, depreciating the value of the rupee.

This would, in turn, make buying goods and services from overseas markets even more expensive.

What the Future Holds for Indian Exports?

While for the time being, the trade deficit for India is rising, but the trend is expected to reverse in the coming years. This reversal will be made possible by some recent developments in the international markets. Let's have a look at the factors that will be helping Indian exports in future.

Increased demand from US & European markets:

- After a prolonged period of economic slowdown, conditions are showing improvement in the US and European markets. The confidence of the consumers is returning in these markets with positive job data, leading to the growth of trade. With almost 30% of Indian exports directed to US and Europe, the revival of growth in these economies has started increasing the demand for Indian goods.

Weaker Rupee:

While the weakening rupee does not bode well for the import bill of the country, it promises a lot for Indian exports. Due to depreciation in the value of rupee, Indian exports have become more competitive; consequently demand is returning to the Indian industry.

Adverse conditions in China and Bangladesh:

The rising labour costs in China along with the appreciation in the value of Chinese Yuan have helped improve the competitiveness of Indian exports. Similarly, many orders from Bangladesh have been diverted to India due to wage protests as well as various industrial accidents.

Free trade agreements:

While some sections of the country continue to criticise the FTAs with partner countries, the fact of the matter is that the export sector has

been receiving a boost from these FTAs. For instance, ever since the signing of Indo-ASEAN Trade in Goods Agreement in 2009, exports to ASEAN countries have just doubled.

Government measures:

Various policy level interventions by the Government of India have also been helping in boosting the exports sector of the country. Interest subvention scheme, focused market scheme, focus products scheme, duty drawback schemes are some of the measures undertaken by the government with further measures are in the works.

Steps Required by the Government to Reduce the Trade Deficit

While the steps taken by the government and changes in the international market have helped Indian exports sector revive to some extent, further interventions are required on the part of the government.

Creation of new markets:

There is a need to explore new regions which have not yet been fully explored. Latin America and Africa are two regions where there is immense potential for Indian products and services. Moreover, as the Indian government enjoys friendly relations with most of these countries, it is an opportunity beckoning to be realised.

Balance of trade:

Indian government needs to hold discussions with countries with which India presently has a trade deficit. Policies and agreements need to be formulated wherein these countries open their markets for Indian goods and services. If required, strategic partnerships and trade blocs should be created to allow free access to markets for Indian goods.

Easy availability of credit:

- The government must ensure easy availability of credit for exporters. This will help the export units meet any temporary

shortfalls in their capital requirements and would also encourage them for capacity expansion.

Interest subvention scheme:

- The interest subvention scheme has helped boost the exports in the garment sector and for engineering products. This scheme must be extended to other sectors of the economy as well to encourage industries to focus on exports.

Ease of procedure:

Doing away with bureaucratic hurdles is essential to ensure the smooth flow of goods from one country to another. The government must strive to simplify the export procedures to allow exporters to focus on improving their quality and quantity, instead of being buried under paperwork.

- While the government has taken several measures to boost the exports and restore the balance of trade; still a lot needs to be done. It would require continued intervention from the government to get things back on track and restore the growth rate that India has been enjoying for years now.

India's Draft e-commerce Policy



Data is a national asset that fuels technology but until 2018, data protection, cross-border data flows and encryption weren't coherently functional in the technology policy of India. It was in June 2019, when the government came up with the draft e-commerce policy to lay out a definite plan for the entire pillar of technology.

This policy talks about the local protection of data and falls in line with the personal data protection bill and RBI's directive. With the e-commerce being an incredible opportunity for India to enable 70 million medium and small Indian businesses to become the bedrock of India's digital economy, this policy is seen as one ensuring the security of the domestic data both in letter and spirit.

The policy addresses six broad areas of e-commerce – data, infrastructure development, e-commerce marketplaces, regulatory issues, digital economy and export promotion through e-commerce. The policy also considers the interests of all stakeholders who include investors, manufacturers, MSMEs, traders, retailers, startups and consumers.

The plan of the government seems to envision the transformation of our digital infrastructure through the localization of data. Earlier, the FDI policy on e-commerce that was pronounced through Press Note 2 of 2000, allowed 100% FDI in B2B e-commerce activities. B2B e-commerce, that is the multi-brand retail through inventory based model, has remained prohibited for FDI all along. In 2018, however, the government has only reiterated the policy provisions to ensure

better implementations of the policy in letter and spirit, without making any change in the underlying principle.

The draft policy was issued on 23 February 2019 by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT). In the background of an exciting and rapidly growing e-Commerce industry in India and globally, this policy is seen as a welcome move. Various dimensions of e-Commerce have been covered in this draft policy that includes data, consumer protection, intellectual property and competition. The interest and concerns of the industry have also been considered in this. This ambitious document contains many positives, one of which is that it is the first exclusive e-Commerce policy for India internationally. This makes India one of the few countries in the world to be moving toward advanced e-Commerce legislation.

By favouring the domestically-funded homegrown companies, India will be aided to build its own set of giants that shape the new economy and some of them may eventually turn out to be successful multinationals.

The foreign-funded online commerce companies are only permitted to operate marketplaces and barred from holding inventories. If the draft e-commerce rules are enforced strictly, then it would mean that global companies will have to house their India-specific data in India within three years. This would further imply that companies such as Amazon and Walmart-Flipkart will need to set up data centres in India, if they do not have those here already. It has the potential to lead to additional investments and jobs created within India.

The overall objective of this draft policy is to prepare and enable stakeholders to fully benefit from opportunities that would arise from progressive digitization of the domestic digital economy. While safeguarding the interests of all stakeholders, the policy however fails to set a clear roadmap to enable India to exploit the benefits of the digital economy.

It proposes changes in the areas of data governance, intermediary liability, intellectual property, competition, consumer protection,

investments and cloud infrastructure. Different ministries are required to tackle each of these issues separately and each of these requires separate departments to carry on consultation process instead of clubbing them entirely under one umbrella.

The government's schemes / programs such as Digital India, Skill India, Make in India and Startup India will get a boost through this draft policy as these rely on e-Commerce and its components. For example, there are norms for consumer protection in the policy which has also recognized the importance of data, its protection and storage and has integrated different systems to track imports and introduced anti-counterfeiting and anti-piracy measures.

The cross-border data flows is the most debatable issue that the policy seeks to tackle and since data is the new oil, the policy seeks to treat all the data generated by Indians as a national resource that needs to be protected by stemming cross-border data flows. Sharing of sensitive data is barred with third parties, even with the customer's consent. That is, the data generated by users in India from sources like e-commerce platforms, social media and search engines will not be allowed to leave India.

It is also in sync with the recently updated industrial policy which reflects the underlying brick-and-mortar economy.

But, the stakeholders, including industry, its associations and the independent policy community, point out that in the government's enthusiasm to address all these many aspects of e-Commerce, the draft policy has become ambiguous and raises concerns if it intends to be an internet policy or a specific e-Commerce policy.

Several concerns get reflected in this policy, ranging from the definition of e-Commerce to data ownership, shortcomings in customers protection, excessive liabilities on the platform and lack of clarity on implementation and regulation.

The draft policy includes a too broad definition that includes industries and entities that need not fall under the e-Commerce umbrella. It also

uses the term 'digital economy' synonymously with e-Commerce while on the contrary, e-Commerce is seen as a sub-set of the digital economy and is used nationally and multilaterally by the G20, the Asian Development Bank, the OECD and U.S. and China.

As the draft Personal Data Protection Bill, 2018 is already under consideration by MeitY pursuant to multiple stakeholder consultations, the extensive focus on data by this draft policy has led to confusion.

The policy doesn't define any kind of data-individual data, community data, sensitive data and national data, which depicts a serious drawback that needs immediate focus.

Penal provisioning has been excluded from the purview of this policy while it lays too much emphasis on importance of consumer protection through genuine reviews, anti-counterfeiting measures and e-Courts for grievance redressal.

A liability imposed on consumer to be cognizant of unregistered entities (GST non-compliant entities) and barring the making of payment to them is simple injustice on part of the policy. It is impossible for consumers to carry out this check themselves considering the fast-moving click-and-buy world.

The obligations on the intermediary/platform on issues of trademark seem impractical. Informing by intermediary/platform of a trademark owner each time their trademarked product is again a burden on the platform/intermediary. For it to be constantly proactive, huge human and capital resources are needed.

Multiple legislations on e-commerce are an additional problem of the draft policy. The lack of distinction between an 'intermediary' and an e-Commerce 'platform' complicates the issue further.

India has a large market with large foreign investments in e-Commerce where Alibaba Group has invested approximately \$1.8 billion in e-Commerce companies and Walmart invested \$16 billion in Flipkart recently. This altogether puts India in an advantageous

position of being a key global influencer. And India being one of the few countries having a draft policy requires it to be well drafted and well implemented. Only then can India lead the global e-Commerce debate and be a model of such policies of other developing countries.

How Effective is Insolvency & Bankruptcy code in India?

Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) was enacted in 2016 by Government of India to consolidate all laws related to insolvency and bankruptcy and to tackle Non-Performing Assets (NPA). The bill was based on the recommendations made by the Bankruptcy Law Reform Committee, headed by T K Vishwanathan, constituted in August 2014. Committee had submitted its report in November 2015 and suggested modernizing of present outdated system and framing new structures and institutions.

Before this law there were several laws that dealt with insolvency and bankruptcy of the companies, including Sick Industrial Companies Act, the Recovery of Debt Due to Banks and Financial Institutions Act and Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act (SARFAESI) 2002. During the British era laws dealt with individual debtors such as Presidency Town Insolvency Act 1909 and the Provincial Insolvency Act 1920.

The IBC provides a time-bound process to resolve insolvency. According to World Bank data provided in 2015, India took an average 4.3 years for insolvency resolution, whereas Brazil took 4 years, Pakistan took 2.7 years, South Africa took 2 years and USA took 1 year to resolve insolvency. The 2016 Code applies on both companies and individuals. In case of default in repayment by debtor, creditors gain control over assets and the decisions to resolve insolvency within a 180-day period. In exceptional cases time can be extended by 90 days.

Various Institutions

The process of insolvency is administered by Insolvency Professionals, a specialised cadre of licensed professionals who provide information for creditors to assist them in decision making and also manage the assets of the debtor. These Insolvency Professionals are registered with the Insolvency Professional Agencies. The agencies conduct examination to certify them and enforce a code of conduct for their performance. The records of debts, liabilities and defaults are kept with Information Utilities. For the companies, proceeding of the resolution processes is adjudicated by the National Companies Law Tribunal (NCLT) and for individuals, resolution process is adjudicated by the Debt Recovery Tribunal (DRT). The duties of the authorities include appointment of the insolvency professional, approval to initiate the resolution process and approval of the final decision of creditors. The Insolvency Professionals, Insolvency Professionals Agencies and Information Utilities set up under the Code are regulated by Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI). The board has 10 members, including representatives from the Ministries of Finance, Law and Corporate Affairs, and the Reserve Bank of India.

Objectives

In India it was very difficult to shut the businesses; the whole process of exit was time-consuming and lengthy. The companies which were running in loss and had lot of debt, they left with little options. The IBC makes easy exit for sick companies and provides business-friendly environment and it makes easier for companies to wind up failed businesses. It promotes entrepreneurship, ensures availability of credits and balances the interests of all stakeholders. More importantly, it minimizes the problem of delay as there are strict timelines within which the case has to be disposed off.

The code consolidates various laws which separately deal with different insolvency and bankruptcy cases. The code has helped in minimizing the problem of delay as there are timelines for disposal of cases; quick disposal increases the possibility of good recovery

amount. A database is created under the information utilities which provide easy and quick information on the insolvency status of individuals.

How Effective

India shows significant improvement in World Bank's Ease of Doing Business. Before the enactment of the code India's rank was 130 and massive improvement is seen in India's ranking which now stands at 63rd position. The IBC is not the only criteria for measuring the Ease of Doing but it played very significant role in it. The time taken to dissolve the case dropped. Historically, the entire process of insolvency and liquidation had always been in the hands of the shareholders and debt holders; IBC has paved the way for a major power shift from the hands of debt holders to creditors. The law has cleared very much that promoters and business holders can no longer operate according to their whims and fancies, with simultaneous defaults piling up in their arena.

However, between January 2017 and March 2019, over 1,852 companies have been admitted to the corporate insolvency resolution process, out of which 337 have either withdrawn or accepted the resolution plan, 378 of them have been liquidated and 715 have exited the process. Many of them later moved to appellate authority, the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal or the Supreme Court. The code has provision for time-bound resolution of debt, but resolution of cases takes far longer time. Infrastructure of NCLT is not sufficient for the quantum of cases flooding the system.

Another reason for time-consumption and elaboration of litigation under the IBC is lack of established legal precedents, which will only build up over time. In a case study, a power infrastructure company owes lenders Rs 7,091 crore, this case was sent to NCLT by the RBI in June 2017. The resolution professionals had filed a resolution plan in March 2018, and NCLT approval came in July. However, the issue went to the appellate tribunal and the final approval from the NCLAT came only in March 2019. Because of the year-long delay, the sole

bidder for that power infrastructure company faces necessary fund issue.

Amendment in IBC

Under the new bill, deadline of 330 days has been set for completion of corporate insolvency resolution process, including litigation and other judicial processes. The new bill mandates that votes of all financial creditors shall be cast in accordance with the decision approved by the highest voting share of the financial creditors on present and voting basis.

According to the new bill the resolution plan will be binding on all stakeholders, including the Central government, any state government or local authority. The “resolution plan” mandates an explanation why the insolvency resolution of a corporate debtor is a growing concern and may include provisions for corporate restructuring which include merger, amalgamation or demerger. This enables the market to come up with dynamic resolution plans for value maximisation.

The IBC has played significant role in making business friendly environment in India. The code has very good provisions such as resolving the insolvency and bankruptcy in a time bound manner. It promotes transparency in system and also boosts the efficiency of the economy. It enables banks to take early legal steps against the debtor. The aim of the IBC is to develop proper insolvency process, which focuses on resolution and not become a recovery mechanism.

However, despite having provision for time bound resolution, the insolvency process takes long time to resolve and hardly any case is resolved in given time. The burden of cases is increasing on the NCLT and NCLAT. Lack of proper infrastructure and inadequate professionals are other hurdles for the IBC.

There are also some grey areas in case of foreign creditors. The Foreign Exchange Management ACT (FEMA) 1999 has not been amended and synced with the IBC, as FEMA requires RBI approval

in case of sale of assets. The government should address the issue in speedy manner so that IBC can function smoothly.

India's Economic slowdown: Recession or Downturn?



The recent months have been revolving much around the debate on the sharp loss of economic momentum in India. The current slowdown has lasted for 18 months, making it the longest since 2006, as per the global broking firm, Goldman Sachs. On the other hand, economy is growing and just the rate of growth has slowed down, which is indeed a huge setback for the country as an accelerated growth is necessary to provide employment to millions entering the job market every year.

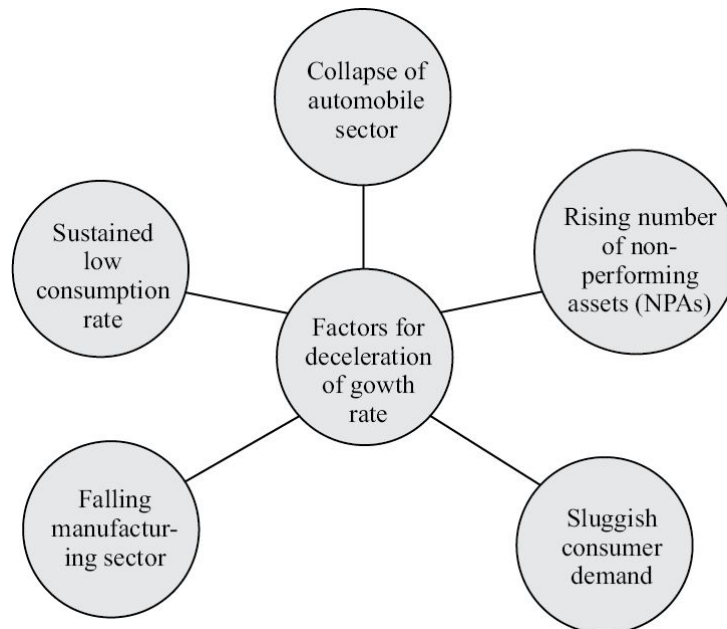
The latest annual report of the RBI for the fiscal year 2018-19 (FY19) confirmed that the Indian economy has indeed hit a rough patch. The GDP growth rate of the economy has slipped to 5 percent in the first quarter of FY20, the lowest in over six years.

The GDP growth rate of India has slipped to 5% in the first quarter of FY20, which is the lowest in over six years and so Rajiv Kumar, the head of the government's think tank Niti Aayog claimed that "the current slowdown was unprecedented in 70 years of independent India" and called for immediate policy interventions in specific industries. On the other hand, the idea of industry-specific incentives has not been agreed upon by the Chief Economic Adviser, K Subramaniam. He argued for structural reforms in land and labour markets.

Decoding the Kind of Slowdown

The present situation can be seen through the prism of a growth recession. Recession is defined by economists as three consecutive quarters of contraction. During a recession, the economic growth slips into negative territory. In a growth recession, the economy

doesn't contract, but continues to expand at a sequentially slower pace.



Since 2008, India has now been in the third growth recession and the economic growth has already slowed sequentially for four consecutive quarters. Weak domestic demand is indicated through the indirect tax collections of the most recent goods and services tax (GST). Probably, the growing slower than nominal GDP growth indicates that the demand shifted to the formal sector after demonetization, is again moving back to the informal sector.

Weak consumer demand and the mess in the shadow banking system indicates that households no longer have the pull option to maintain consumption in the face of slow income growth. The international demand for exports is further pinched due to trade war.

Analysts say that a slowdown in consumption demand, decline in manufacturing, inability of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) to resolve cases in a time-bound manner and rising global trade tension leading to adverse impact on exports are some of the factors affecting India's growth.

Nearly 55-60 percent of India's GDP comprises of private consumption and that has slowed down. Reduced consumption is

also due to the reduced income growth of households. Drought/ near-drought conditions in three of the past five years combined with decline in food prices have hampered rural consumption.

- The private final consumption expenditure (PFCE) has slumped to 3.1 percent in Q1FY20, the weakest level since Q3FY15.
- Analysts suggest it to be a case of structural slowdown as there is a slowdown in the GDP growth for the fourth consecutive year, from 8.2 percent in FY17 to around 6.5 percent in FY20 (E).

Source: Business Standard-economy policy (dated-sept 03, 2019)

As per the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE), the unemployment rate in July 2017 –when GST was rolled out was 3.4. It has been growing since then and was at over 9 percent for week ending August 25. MSMEs along with households comprise 23.6 percent of the total savings in the GDP and households being the only net savers in the economy, their savings are major contributors towards investment. Having reached a level inadequate to fund the government borrowings, these savings are thus contributing to the elevated interest rates. (Source: business standard-economy policy-dated-sept 03, 2019)

The interest rates have already been cut by 110 basis points this year by the Reserve Bank of India. This is the lowest in nine years to boost loans and revive investment. RBI has been pumping in liquidity to tide over a cash crunch in the banking sector.

Measuring the gravity of the slowdown

- The unmanageable debt, slowing growth and alleged harassment by tax authorities has led to the suicide of one of India's most celebrated entrepreneurs, the founder of the largest coffee store chain, Café Coffee Day.
- The decline in vehicle sales has led to the probability of the auto industry shedding close to a million direct and indirect jobs.

- A key barometer of consumption, men's inner wear has suffered negative sales growth.
- Consumption demand accounting for two-thirds of India's GDP is losing energy.
- Private sector investment which is the mainstay of sustainable growth in any economy is at a 15-year low.
- There is almost no investment in new projects by the private sector.
- The US –China trade war that has intensified over time has contracted world trade and, in turn, Indian exports.
- High rates of GST, liquidity crisis in NBFCs and shift in the behavioural pattern of workforce with entry of youth has discouraged savings. With less saving in the economy, there is lesser money for investments.

Way Forward

Corrective measures if taken immediately, can avoid recession. Rise in FDI inflows amidst the news of slowdown, has brought relief for the government. Further, the government revised GST for the automobile sector and opened FDI in contract manufacturing sector besides announcing the recapitalization of the banking sector.

Along with these measures, there is a need to focus on optimum utilization of funds granted by RBI and direct them to boost investment in the economy both in infrastructural and research investment.

In order to achieve structural shifts over the long run, there is a need to tap into the health and education sectors that have been awaiting quality improvements.

Long- lasting structural changes is the only sure way to improve the growth potential of the Indian economy and avoid any occurrence of slowdown.

An immediate solution for the country seems to be the boost in consumption through a stimulus provided directly to the people that should be combined with reforms to boost business morale and confidence.

Indian industry will invest more only when demand for goods and services increase and demand will increase only when wages increase, that means people get money.

It should be noted that the economy is growing at slow rate and the government has set a high target of turning India into a \$5 trillion economy by 2024. Also, the government expenditure comes from the revenue it earns and not from the size of GDP. There are fiscal constraints that imply that the government cannot borrow money beyond a limit. So, very little scope remains for the government to invest. Thus, it is not recession but an expansion yet at a reduced speed.

The latest policy announcements that the government has made include the withdrawal of super-rich surcharge. This is likely to bring back investment and create jobs. This shall push demand for consumption. If so happens as estimated, then Indian economy would surely get a reboot.

India China Trade Imbalance



India has been addressing the issue of trade imbalance in Asia since long. It even led India's Commerce Secretary tell China that the mega free trade agreement RCEP-Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership should address the causes of high trade imbalances among the member countries.

As per the data from India's Ministry of Commerce, the trade deficit with China is over \$53 billion which shows a narrowing by US\$ 10 billion since last year. This is a critical issue and unsustainable in the long-term and more action from the Chinese government is needed. On the other hand, continuous and sustained steps are being taken by the Government of India to control the trade deficit by lowering the trade barriers for Indian exports to China.

The trade ministers of India and China agreed to increase bilateral trade between the two countries in a balanced and more sustainable manner, during the 11th session of India-China Joint Group on Economic Relations (JEG) held in New Delhi.

Various meetings have been held in this regard with the Chinese counterparts as a part of ongoing efforts to seek market access for various Indian agricultural products, animal feeds, oil seeds, milk and milk products, pharmaceutical products and more, considering the potential of these services or products in the Chinese market. In order to facilitate export of Indian rice, rapeseed meal, fishmeal-fish oil and tobacco leaves from India to China, several protocols have also been signed.

The details of the imports from China during 2015-16, 2016-17, 2017-18 & 2018-19 (April-December) are given below: -

Year	Import (Value in USD Million)
2015-16	61707.95
2016-17	61283.03
2017-18	76380.70
2018-19 (up to December, 2018)	53878.06

(source: DGCI&S)

Recent Developments

India and China were engaged in a tense, two-month border stand-off at Doklam two years back, but since then they have been working ties. Even last year, following their meeting in the Chinese city, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping tried to usher in an era of closer cooperation.

Though relations have improved in recent months, their competing interests in South Asia and the Indian Ocean remain potential sticking points. More so, both of them met at the G20 summit in Japan, together with Russian President Vladimir Putin where they pledged to resist protectionism in the face of America's recent policy shifts.

The talks between the two have included too much emphasis on goods so far, where China has an advantage. The talks haven't been enough on investment and services. While India has worked to liberalize trade, it is still a developing country and needs protection in certain sectors such as manufacturing.

India's refusal of signing to the RCEP itself states that further liberalization and opening up on these sectors would not be in its interest at the present moment. India would also prefer to see a phased reduction of market barriers.

India has an elaborate and robust legal framework and institutional set up to protect its environment, life and health of its people, plants and animals. All goods imported into India are subject to domestic laws, rules, orders, regulations, technical specifications, environment and safety norms that are notified from time to time. The Government takes appropriate action in case goods imported from any source are found to violate these regulations and threaten human, animal or plant life or health.

In addition, trade defence measures like anti-dumping duty and countervailing duty, safeguard measures are enforced under the prescribed WTO provisions. Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) initiates anti-dumping investigations on the basis of a duly substantiated application filed by the domestic producer with a prima facie evidence of dumping of goods into the country causing injury to the domestic industry. Such applications submitted by domestic industry are processed as per the procedure and within the time limits specified under the Customs Tariff Act, 1975 and the rules made thereunder. DGTR conducts investigations and recommends imposition of duty, wherever appropriate, to the Department of Revenue by issuing its preliminary/final findings. Acting upon such recommendations of the DGTR, the Department of Revenue may impose the provisional or definitive duties.

As on 28.01.2019, anti-dumping duty is in force on 99 products imported from China. The sector-wise details of these 99 products are given below:

S.No.	Product Category	No. of cases in which duty is in force
1.	Chemical and Petrochemicals	40
2.	Electrical and electronic items and accessories	05
3.	Fibres and Yarn	08
4.	Fibre Boards	01

5.	Glass and Glassware	10
6.	Machinery Items	5
7.	Pharmaceutical	2
8.	Rubber or Plastic products	1
9.	Steel and other metals	11
10.	Other Products	16
	Total	99

(source: Ministry of State of Commerce and Industry website)

China-sized Trade Problem for India

China is the largest trading partner of India while a Business Standard report from April, 2019 claimed that India is China's 7th biggest trading partner. India-China trade since the China joined the WTO in December 2001 has grown from \$1.49 billion to \$84.4 billion in 2017.

India's exports to China in 2016 totalled \$16.5 billion as per the Economic Times. Further, India accounted for less than 1% of Chinese imports in 2018 as per the UNCTAD. While most of India's exports to China are goods and raw materials, it imports intermediate and finished goods.

The main exports to China are petroleum products, cotton, organic chemicals, iron ore and plastic raw materials. The main commodities India imports from China are machines for reception, conversion-transmission, bulk drugs and drug intermediates, consumer electronics, and telecom instruments. Imports of fertilizers from China showed a sharp increase of 233.17% to reach \$512.39 million this year. India remained the largest export destination for Chinese fertilizers.

Remedy

India had been trying to push its agricultural, dairy and pharmaceutical products to China. China has also assured India that it would address the growing concerns over the deficit and has suggested expanded cooperation in industrial production, tourism, border trade to name a few, in order to 'balance' bilateral commercial relations.

On the other hand, the data on recent trade patterns indicate that the US and China have helped India gain a bigger toehold in the Chinese market. According to July's research report of SBI, exports to China have gone up substantially, as compared to exports to US.

In sectors where China imposed retaliatory tariffs on US goods and services, like live animals and animal products, vegetable products, and plastic and rubber, Indian exports to China grew 335%, 134%, and 93.7% respectively in FY19 as compared to FY18.

In sectors where such tariff walls have not been raised - gems, jewellery, footwear etc. - Indian exports either dropped or rose at a relatively slower pace.

The two countries need to tackle their rowing trade deficit before it becomes a 'politically sensitive issue' in India. The two countries need to have a very intense dialogue about trade, particularly market access for Indian agricultural goods.

China has been locked in a year-long trade war with the United States, which has led to its neighbours looking out for opportunities and the past 12 months have seen several protocols signed for Indian exports of chili meal, rice, fish meal, cooking oil and tobacco leaves. In many of these areas, the sourcing is done by state-led agencies. Government should take efforts to encourage sourcing from India in this regard.

Food Security for Sustainable National Development



Food Security is the potential to assure, on a long term basis, that the system provides the total population access to a timely, reliable and nutritionally adequate supply of food. The World Food Summit of 1996 defined food security as “when all people at all times have access to sufficient, safe, nutritious food to maintain a healthy and active life. As the world population is increasing day by day it is necessary to sustainably increase agricultural production, improve the global supply chain, decrease food losses and waste. Food insecurity can lead to lower psychological ability, declined work performance and substantial productivity losses. All of these can hamper the growth and development of national economy. Climate change, government policies of public distribution and marketing of food grains are also some factors contributing to slow down the availability of foods. Those who are suffering from hunger and malnutrition should have access to nutritious food.

Attainment of self sufficiency in food grains at the national level is one of the country’s major achievements in the post-independence period. After remaining a food deficit country for about two decades after independence, India became largely self-sufficient in food grain production at the macro level. There have hardly been any food grain imports after the mid-1970s. Since green revolution in 1970, there has been significant increase in productivity of cereals especially wheat and rice in these regions during 1970s and mid-1980s due to adoption of high-yielding seeds, expansion in irrigation, use of chemical fertilizers and agro-chemicals, and farm mechanization. Food grain production in the country increased from about 50 million tons in 1950-51 to around 277.49 million tons in 2017-18. The

production of cotton, oilseeds, fruits, sugarcane, milk, and vegetables has also increased appreciably.

India was ranked 97 out of 118 on the Global Hunger Index (GHI) in 2016. GHI rates nations nutritional status based on indicators of undernourishment, child wasting, stunting and mortality. Despite ranking above some of the world's poorest nations, India's reduction in malnourishment has been slow as compared to its recent strong economic growth and puts it behind poorer neighboring countries. India has fallen from 80th to 97th since 2000.

Challenges

- A large number of people migrate from rural areas to urban cities. The world's poor and food insecure mostly depend on agricultural and natural resources based livelihoods. Migration of people to urban areas has resulted in a number of slum settlements characterized by inadequate water and sanitation facilities, insufficient housing and increased food insecurity.
- Most of the urban slums have people who are unaware of the government schemes. People from these slums have to buy their food from the common market at the competitive price and are devoid of the subsidized food made available through Public Distribution System (PDS).
- Overpopulation, poverty, lack of education and gender inequality are also responsible for food insecurity. Poverty is a major cause as it limits the amount of food available to children. Overpopulation is linked to competition for food and can lead to malnutrition amongst children, especially in rural areas where access to food is limited. Gender inequality causes female child to suffer more because they are last to eat and considered less important.
- The cost of food items is increasing rapidly, making them unaffordable for most of the people and the short supply of pulses and edible oils, forces the government to import them.

- Climate perturbations in the form of heat, uneven rainfall and drought pattern leads to new disease and pest incidence, pose another challenge to the crop improvement strategy.
- Inadequate distribution of food through public distribution mechanisms (PDS i.e. Public Distribution System) is also a reason for growing food insecurity in the country. The Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS) has disadvantage in the sense that those who are the right candidates to deserve the subsidy are excluded on the basis of non-ownership of below poverty line (BPL) status, as the criterion for identifying a household as BPL is arbitrary and varies from state to state. The often inaccurate classification of above poverty line (APL) and below poverty line (BPL) categories had resulted in a big decline in the offtake of food grains. Besides this, low quality of grains and the poor service at Public Distribution system shops has further added to the problem.
- Multiple layers of middlemen between the farmer and the end consumer, driving up prices and reducing bargaining power and price transparency for the farmers.

Food security in India can be achieved by paying more attention to issues such as climate change, agricultural pricing, integrated water management, capacity, unsuccessful delivery of public services, mismanagement of food products and crop insurance. With over 1.2 billion people to feed, addressing the issue of food wastage is essential for India to combat hunger and improving food security. Limit global warming, including the promotion of climate-friendly agricultural production systems and land-use policies at a scale to help mitigate climate change. All restrictions on food grains regarding inter-state movement, exports, stocking and institutional credit and trade financing should be renounced.

Free trade will help make up the difference between production and consumption needs, reduce supply variability, increase efficiency in resource-use and permit production in regions more suited to it. To reduce illiteracy, the food security need can be productively linked to increased enrolment in schools. With the phasing out of PDS, food

coupons may be issued to poor people depending on their entitlement. The government policy needs to adopt an integrated policy framework to promote the use of irrigation and newer farming techniques. The measures should focus mainly on rationale distribution of cultivable land, improving the size of the farms and providing security to the tenant cultivators apart from providing the farmers with improved technology for cultivation and improved inputs like irrigation facilities, availability of better quality seeds, fertilizers and credits at lower interest rates. Harvesting, handling and storage losses, and top-level crop production are considered to be the key intervention phases for improving food security.

National Policy on Skill Development



The driving forces of social development and economic growth of any country are the skill and knowledge and countries with higher and enhanced levels of skills fine-tune more effectively to the challenges and opportunities of the world of occupation. Skill development is a term that targets those in the labour force and includes those entering in the labour market for the very first time (12.8 million), unorganized workers (433 million) and those employed in the unorganized sector (26.0 million); as per government's report of 2004-05. With a current capacity of the skill development programs at 3.1 million, India is working towards on a set target of skilling 500 million people by 2022.

The National Policy on Skill Development envisages the establishment of initiatives for skill development with an aim of skill development in the country. This shall promote rapid and inclusive growth if supported through improved productivity and living standards of the people. It has set its vision on strengthened competitiveness of the country, high investments in skill development and increased employability of individuals. All these shall fall in place with the adapted ability to changing technologies and labour market demands.

It sets its focus on empowering all individuals through improved skills and knowledge. It also makes the nationally and internationally recognized qualifications accessible to them so that they can efficiently get into decent employment and ensure India's competitiveness in the global market.

All about the NSDP

For the first time in 2009, this policy was formulated to provide a framework for skill development activities in the country. There have been changes in the macro environment since then. Moreover, a lot of experience has also been gained through implementation of various skill development programmes in the country. All these factors have acted as catalysts for change in the policy. Thence, the National Skill Development Policy, 2015 was devised to supplant the Policy of 2009.

The renewed version emphasizes on creation of an ecosystem of empowerment that would be achieved through large scale and speedy skilling. The process would be further enhanced by high standards that would encourage a culture of innovation based entrepreneurship. This would thus engender wealth and employment and would ensure sustainable livelihoods for all citizens of the country as a whole.

To fulfil the vision of a 'Skilled India' the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE) was created with primary focus on human resource. Central Ministries/ Departments, State governments and industry and employers form the key stakeholders.

The Government of India has set up National Skill Development Fund (NSDF) to encourage skill development and it will be a receptacle of all donations, contribution in cash or kind from all contributors including Government, multilateral organizations and corporations. Companies will be encouraged to spend at least 25% of their Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Funds on skill development initiatives directly or through NSDF. To support the initiatives of loan for skilling, a Credit Guarantee Fund for skill development and a 'National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC) has been set up. The fund will be used to leverage credit financing in the skill landscape.

With an aim of providing an umbrella framework to all skilling activities in the country, the policy will also align them to common

standards and link the skilling with the demand centres. Besides laying down the objectives and expected outcomes, efforts will be put into identifying various institutional frameworks as vehicles for reaching the desired outcomes. Not just this, clarity and coherence to align the skill development efforts across the country with the on hand institutional arrangements will also be made available through the policy.

Thus, by linking skills development to improved employability and productivity, the policy will focus on the overall human resource development to take advantage of the demographic profile of India's population.

Objectives of the Policy

The policy focuses on holistic growth of individuals through skill acquisition throughout life. It also emphasizes on skill training of youth, women and disadvantaged groups and ensures that opportunities are created for one and all.

It further looks into promoting commitment by all stakeholders so that they can own skill development initiatives and develop a high-quality skilled workforce that is concurrent to current and emerging employment market demands.

It seeks to enable the establishment of flexible delivery mechanisms which can respond to the distinctiveness of a wide range of stakeholders' needs.

It also endeavours to enable effective coordination between different ministries – the Centre and the States and public and private providers.

What are the Scopes of this Policy?

The National Policy on Skill Development has a wide coverage that encompasses the institution-based skill development including ITIs, ITCs, vocational schools, technical schools, polytechnics, professional colleges to name a few.

It prioritizes the training for self-employment or entrepreneurial development and widens its effectiveness to the initiatives such as adult learning, re-training of retired or retiring employees and lifelong learning as well.

It also takes significant consideration of non-formal training that includes training by civil society organizations. Besides these, formal and informal apprenticeships and other types of training by enterprises have also been paid adequate attention.

Where on one hand, it has accentuated the need of E-learning, web-based learning and distance learning; on the other hand, learning initiatives of sectoral skill development organized by variant ministries and departments have also been kept as a major tool.

Enablers of the Framework

Eleven major paradigms have been outlined to achieve the objectives of skilling India, which include aspiration and advocacy, capacity, quality, synergy, outreach, mobilization and engagement, ICT enablement, inclusivity, global partnerships, trainers and assessors and promotion of skilling among women.

A nine part entrepreneurship strategy has been developed to meet the needs of entire ecosystem through conjuncture of culture, finance, expertise, infrastructure, skills and business-friendly regulation.

It will educate and equip potential candidates to early stage entrepreneurs across India.

Entrepreneurs will be connected to peers, mentors and incubators and they will be supported through Entrepreneurship Hubs (EHubs).

Entrepreneurship will be encouraged among underrepresented groups and women. Access to finance will be improved and social entrepreneurship and grassroots innovations will be fostered.

The official estimates suggest of the need of additional 109 million skilled workers to work in 24 key sectors of India by 2022.

In order to aid the Skill India mission, the World Bank has cleared a USD 250-million loan aid under the Skill India Mission Operation (SIMO) which is a six-year programme in support of the National Policy on Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (2017-23). This programme will focus on increasing the market relevance of short-term skill development programmes that encompass 3-12 months of training or up to 600 hours of skilling.

Irrespective of the employment status, persons of age group of 15-59 will be acquiring skill training under this programme so that 1.2 core youngsters in the age bracket of 15 and 29 years entering the labour market get benefitted.

Around 15000 trainers and 3000 assessors are speculated to be benefitted through this programme.

The reskilling programme will be carried both at the national and state levels to help government of India better equip the young workforce with employable skills.

Placement and entrepreneurship opportunities to women and increasing their exposure to skill training are also the mandate of this programme. This way the government's vision of increasing the women's participation in the labour force and augment greater off-farm employment will be supported through SIMO. Moreover, the skilled labour force will have an enhanced employment prospect to raise their earnings.

Can Contract Farming Revive India's Agriculture?



Contract farming is a model in which agricultural products are produced as per the agreement between buyer and farmers. It is a pre-harvest arrangement. The farmers have to provide the particular agricultural product with promised quality to the buyers. In return, buyers promise to purchase the product and pay the agreed amount to the farmers. To meet the quality and quantity of the products on time, buyers can also provide some support like soil research, farm inputs, transport facility, loans and technical advice to the peasant. Mutual trust and confidence are very important clauses for the contract farming.

Problems Facing Agriculture

In India, majority of the population is engaged with the agriculture and farm related activities, it not only provides employment to the rural households but also works as life support system for most of the rural population. The condition of agriculture is very terrifying in India and the agriculture sector faces many serious problems. Most of the farmers face economic problems, as they do not have that amount of wealth that fulfils the demand of modern farming equipment and technology to support their crops. If somehow, farmers are able to get some loan either from government or from local money lenders, then the farm produce is unable to give good return due to involvement of middlemen. During the season of any particular crop, prices are dropped due to availability of produce in good quantity. In this situation farmers are helpless to sell their crops more below the actual cost price.

To address the problems of peasants, the central government as well as the state governments launched various schemes like fertilizer subsidies, MSP, e-Mandi, diesel subsidy and many other programmes for the welfare of agriculture and the farmers. Despite many steps taken by the government, problems still remain unsolved due to loopholes in the schemes. The second problem other than economic is natural like uneven precipitation to cause monsoon and extreme weather conditions like flood and drought to name a few.

Government's Policies

In India, contract farming is regulated under the Indian Contract Act of 1872. Along with this model, Agricultural Produce Market Committee Act (APMC) 2003 also framed some specific provision for the contract farming; for example, contract farming dispute settlement, farming sponsors and compulsory registration. The general provision like formation of contracts, consequences and obligations of parties are made under the 1872 act.

In May 2018, the department of agriculture & farmers welfare, government of India released the Model Contract Farming Act 2018, which focuses on protecting the interests of farmers of the country considering farmer as the weaker party among two, who is entering into a contract. The announcement for the creation of a Model Contract Farming Act was made in the Budget of 2017-18 by the Union Finance Minister. In a statement from the department said "The final Model Act – State/UT Agricultural Produce and Livestock Contract Farming and Services (Promotion and Facilitation) Act 2018 has been approved by the Competent Authority".

According to the Agriculture Ministry, this act is a promotional and facilitative act and its structure is not regulatory. In this act, along with contract farming services, contracts all along the value chain covering pre-production, during the production and post-production have been covered in the new Act. In addition to promotion of contract farming and services at village and Panchayat level, a Contract Farming Facilitation Group (CFFG) will be provided. The provision of act says

that the contracted produce will be covered under crop and livestock insurance in operation and also APMC act will not cover the contract farming. The act restricts development of any permanent structure on the land and premises of the farmers, the act say that “No right of interest of the land shall vest in the sponsor. Promotion of Farmer Producer Organization (FPOs)/Farmer Producer Companies (FPCs) to mobilise small and marginal farmers has been provided”. It further added “No rights, title ownership or possession to be transferred or alienated or vested in the contract farming sponsor etc”. If farmers can authorise the FPO and FPC, then it can be a contracting party.

For a long time, the crops which were commercial in nature like tobacco, rubber, cotton, coffee, sugarcane cultivation along with dairy had some aspect of informal contract farming. Now, the concept of the contract farming has a very wider significance as it not only includes the bulk purchase and sale but also comprises the export, processing, trading and agro-based industries. This arrangement can better help both the parties of contract as it ensures the supply of agro raw material to the agro industries as per their demand and farmers can get good price for their agricultural produce without market's price risk.

Issues and Limitations

Like every model, contract farming also has some limitations and negative aspects. Most of the crops cultivated under the contract farming are cash crops which generate more profit and at the same time food crops can be neglected because of their little use in the industries. Farmers can face the problem of both market failure and low production at the time of delivery of crops. Farmers cannot get the benefit of market when price is increased for the products. The use of fertilizer and other chemicals can be increased in order to maintain the quantity of the produce but in the long run, it damages the quality of soil and environment. The exploitation of water resources has been seen which resulted in both the contamination and lowering of ground water level.

In case of production exceeding the demand, the farmers will face problems related to the selling of the extra produce as well as storing it. Despite the various provisions, it is very difficult for small farmers to seek any legal protection against any firm or company because the procedure is very time-consuming and involves a lot of money which is not feasible for the farmers in case of violation of contract. In many cases, even farmers are unaware of regulations and laws made by the government and they have no idea as to how to approach the concerned authority to file a complaint against the firm.

Future

As of now, the scenario is changing with steps being taken by the government for the contract farming as the conventional farming has not been so beneficial. The role of information technology cannot be neglected in the development of contract farming as it helps farmers in becoming aware of the government policies and it also provides them with an online platform to register their complaints. Though contract farming has its own limitations, yet with the coming up of FDI, FII in India and the increasing global demand of agro-farming, bio-fuel which are made from agricultural produce, the prospects of contract farming seem promising in near future.

Government is taking a number of progressive steps to introduce latest technologies and provide skill-training programmes to small and marginal farmers to upgrade their skills and help them become on par with the concurrent global practices. Through digital India, the farmers are targeted for direct benefits and also being brought in the mainstream to know their roles and be an effective partner in shaping the agriculture business of the country.

Banking Crisis in India: Failure of Governance and Regulation



Banking is the lifeline of any economy and its functions do not just constrain to depositing money from people and crediting it back or returning it with interest when needed by the depositors. Banking functions include financial inclusion through priority sector lending loans to agriculture, MSMEs, renewable energy, issuing bonds, facilitate foreign exchange to name a few.

The cascading effect of banking is thus huge on other sectors as well and money being a significant need of every activity; banking crisis is sure to bring disruption in the socio-economic infrastructure.

People feel safe by putting money in the banks and it is their saving that is further used in investment leading to business expansion. More business expansion results in more growth of the country which supplements the employment needs of the people.

Failure of banking system in this respect thus remains the main cause of economic crisis and this has been severely experienced in the past. Remembering the Great Depression of 1929 would be apt to cite as an example here. As the worst economic downturn in history of industrialized world, it took the entire business arena by storm.

Over 9000 banks had failed in the 1930s due to which people lost their savings as then the savings were not insured. The banks which survived did not support the creation of new loans as they worried about their own survival and also were unsure about the economic situation. Thus, the situation went on deteriorating and expenditure went on decreasing day by day.

How can the economic crisis of 2008 be forgotten in this regard? It was also a result of the failure of banking system. Taking good lesson from these experiences of the past, India went on to nationalize its banks and make them more inclusive and secure. It though came with certain disadvantages but also helped in improving the financial inclusion through banks.

But at present, many factors have led to the crisis in the banking sector and due to many social obligations that the banking sector holds, it is becoming more and more complex. The rising NPAs (Non-Profit Assets) due to defaulters like Vijaya Mallaya and Nirav Modi has to be counted as a looming issue. The decreasing capital to risk adequacy ratio is another concern. Going to the root cause of these problems, it has been realized that failure of governance and regulation are to be blamed for this.

What Went Wrong

First of all, two immediate big steps like demonetization and GST reforms were taken one after the other. This possibly led to the overburden on banks besides their basic functions of lending and issuing bonds.

Further, many functions as part of financial inclusion like Jan Dhan Yojana gets aligned for banks. These include distribution of pensions, scholarships, selling electoral bonds and many more which increase the pressure and burden on banks.

Other than SBI, the recruitment tests of majority of the banks are not up to the standards and need to be updated. Selected candidates need training with regard to latest frauds.

Compatible interest rates need to be offered by banks in order to get deposits. Rates offered by other small saving schemes and Kisan Vikas Patra are better than offered by banks and so banks are unable to attract large deposits. Government keeps on recapitalizing the banks to meet the Basel norms, but this trend doesn't show a good

sign. Banks' deposit rates should not be less than the postal scheme interest rates.

Problems faced by customers like standing in long waiting queues, cheque bounces, forgetting passwords and failure of net banking are few of the issues that lead to disinterest among people towards banking services. Banks' quick response in such scenario would help retain customers and give them better alternatives of saving rather than investing in estate or gold.

Bank employees lack accountability. They have the notion that the depositors' money is not their money and this leads to collusion with corporate. Corporates on the other hand believe that as the government recapitalizes the banks, so even if they cheat by defaulting, they are not looting people's money. As a result, the tax payers' money is used to fill such scams and this creates trust deficit in tax payers. They will not feel motivated further to pay taxes and this leads to low tax to GDP ratio. Currently, this ratio is 11%.

Salaries in public banking sector at lower level are good but at higher level these need to be increased so as to attract professionals. If not, collusion of public sector employees with corporates as in case of PNB scam may keep happening again and again.

Another major reason for the crisis is the political interference. Government appoints major higher level officials and interference by Finance ministry has also been reported by many former RBI governors. Though Bank Board Bureau was established to appoint high level officials, but it lacked efficiency.

One of the major reasons for NPAs was the lending by banks for infrastructure projects as these projects have long gestation period. Banks should not fund them. Rather, bond market need to take care of it. Other international mechanisms like aid form World Bank, ADB, AIIB can be given more relevance.

One major argument that arises is that the major reason for crisis is the public sector banking. Privatization of banking should be replaced

by reforming the public sector. Examples can be taken from the western countries as well, where they have experienced a good coordination of public and private sector which worked out well.

Banks alone can't resolve the NPAs issue. Governance problems like environment clearance, delay in project approvals, export import policies and some destructive technologies also are major causes. Better solution can be achieved by coordination between the banks and the government. Asset reconstruction companies, SDR, S4DR, Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, Joint Lending Forum, etc. are few good steps in this direction, but more needs to be done.

RBI is the regulatory and monitoring body of banks but each and every transaction can't be checked by it, which further adds to the problem.

In PNB scam, many audits have been bypassed. Normally, there are many audits, multiple checks and balances before making any transaction.

In the case of Punjab and Maharashtra Co-operative Bank (PMC) fraud in September 2019, the Managing Director Joy Thomas has admitted to hoodwinking the auditors, bank's board and the RBI for many years by concealing the default on loans to the tune of Rs. 6,500 crore taken by real estate firm Housing Development and Infrastructure Ltd (HDIL). He said that the bank was "still very optimistic on the repayment plan of the HDIL group". He also presented a "roadmap" for recovering part of its dues and bringing the things back on the track. But that did not happen.

Solution

Some good steps have been taken by the government like amendment in Banking Regulation Act. This will give more power to RBI to take decisions to reduce NPAs. Above 50 crore bad loans are also being monitored by enforcement agencies.

Steps towards establishing big private audit firms must be applied. Independence and autonomy should be given to banks while ensuring compliance. Higher officials should be offered salaries as per market rates.

Clearing the balance sheets would ensure sustainability of banking sector. Laws for confiscation of property of fugitives and extradition treaty with nations like UK and many western countries should be given emphasis. These will help in smooth repatriation of the absconders like Modi and Mallaya.

Indian banking system is not a mere store house of public deposits. It is more like a way of life or a part of life. Though great interest rates are not being offered, yet people feel safe and secure in depositing their savings with banks. It's only due to selfish greed of few individuals, who are using banks as a means to earn big and default willingly, that the banks have come to this point of crisis.

Nobel Prize for Economics 2019 to Abhijit Banerjee: A Proud Moment for India



Abhijit Banerjee, Esther Duflo and Michael Kremer have won the 2019 Nobel Prize for economics for their experimental approach to alleviating global poverty. Their research has considerably improved our ability to fight global poverty.

Their new experiment –based approach has transformed development economics in just two decades and this stream is now a flourishing field of research. Duflo, a French-American, and Banerjee have been married for four years. They teach in Massachusetts Institute of Technology. They are the first couple to win the economics Nobel, and the sixth Nobel-winning couple. Kremer is with Harvard University.

Banerjee is the second India born to get the economics Nobel — the formal award is called the Sveriges Riksbank Prize in Economic Sciences in Memory of Alfred Nobel. Duflo is the second woman to receive the prize. Abhijit Banerjee, along with Nobel laureate Paul Krugman, was part of a panel discussion at the ET Global Business Summit 2015.

Banerjee's social media walls, since the announcement of this award have been flooded with congratulatory messages and tweets from eminent Indian personalities and political leaders including the PM and many more. Amartya Sen, winner of the economics Nobel in 1998, also congratulated Banerjee. Born in Kolkata (erstwhile Calcutta) in 1961, Banerjee's early education was in the city's South Point School and his college was Presidency. After a degree of

Masters in Economics from Jawaharlal Nehru University, Banerjee got his PhD from Harvard.

About Nobel Prize

The Sveriges Riksbank Prize in Economic Sciences in Memory of Alfred Nobel was established in 1968 by the Bank of Sweden, and it was first awarded in 1969, more than 60 years after the distribution of the first Nobel Prizes. Although not technically a [Nobel Prize](#), the Prize in Economic Sciences is identified with the award; its winners are announced with the Nobel Prize recipients, and it is presented at the Nobel Prize Award Ceremony. It is conferred by the [Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences](#) in Stockholm.

The prize was created by Riksbanken, the Swedish central bank, in 1968, and the first winner was selected a year later. So far, 81 Nobel laureates in economic sciences have been awarded.

The prize, officially known as the 'Bank of Sweden Prize in Economic Sciences In Memory Of Alfred Nobel', wasn't created by the prize founder, but it is considered to be part of the Nobel stable of awards. Along with the fame comes a 9-million-kronor (\$918,000) cash award, a gold medal and a diploma.

Last year, six Nobel prizes were awarded, for medicine, physics, chemistry, two literature awards, and the coveted Peace Prize. All awardees but the Peace Prize winner receives their awards on December 10, the anniversary of Nobel's death in 1896 in Stockholm. The winner of the Peace Prize receives the award in Oslo, Norway.

The path towards success

In 2015, Banerjee, along with Nobel laureate Paul Krugman and former Chief Economic Adviser Arvind Subramanian, was part of a panel discussion on the global and Indian economies under the aegis of the ET Global Business Summit. Banerjee has also been a contributor to ET's Edit Page. Banerjee and Duflo's work on poverty first drew global attention with the publication of their 2011 book, *Poor Economics*. In that widely celebrated volume, the two Nobel

Laureates had written: "...we have to abandon the habit of reducing the poor to cartoon characters and take the time to really understand their lives, in all their complexity and richness." The authors' insights included why poor families often invest in the education of only one of several children or why small farmers are often reluctant to use better farming methods. Their central thesis was that small changes, including tweaks in existing structures, often produced lasting and big outcomes in reducing poverty. That book also brought attention to the usefulness of a new field research method for economics: the randomized controlled trial — used in pharmaceutical drug testing.

The randomized controlled trials (RCTs) have been in use in the field of global development, mainly in the field of medicine, to assess efforts to assist the poor. The growing interest in the RCTs has concluded in the awarding of the Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences last year in 2019 to several of its pioneers: Esther Duflo, Abhijit Banerjee and Michael Kremer.

The RCTs promoted by them had been [described](#) by the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences as having come to "entirely dominate development economics."

RCTs have grown from strength to strength, celebrated by the media as a smart idea leading to a revolution in how poverty could be addressed; approved by politicians, who were often instrumental in enabling trials to be implemented; and receiving huge support from private and public funding agencies.

RCTs received very little criticism from within the profession for perhaps a decade and a half. Then around 2010 the change happened, as other economists, both of those working on development and those interested in statistical methods, including some of great eminence within the mainstream of the discipline, began to point to weaknesses in the arguments of the random people.

RCTs cannot reveal very much about causal processes since at their core they are [designed](#) to determine whether something has an effect, not how. The researchers have attempted to deal with this charge by designing studies to interpret whether variations in the treatment have different effects, but this requires a prior conception of what the causal mechanisms are. The lack of understanding of causation can limit the value of any insights derived from RCTs in understanding economic life or in designing further policies and interventions. Ultimately, the researchers tested what they thought was worth testing, and this revealed their own preoccupations and suppositions, contrary to the notion that they spent countless hours listening to and in close contact [with the poor](#).

It is not surprising that economists doing RCTs have therefore been centrally concerned with the effects of incentives on individual behavior—for instance, examining the idea that contract teachers who fear losing their jobs will be more effective than those with a guarantee of employment.

It was suggested by the prize committee that the rise to centrality of this previously marginal idea was evidence of scientific progress and of an advancement that much better enabled us to “improve the lives of the worst-off people around the world.”

In the mid-1990s, Mr. Kremer and his colleagues demonstrated how powerful an experiment-based approach can be by using field experiments to test a range of interventions that could improve school results in western Kenya.

Mr. Banerjee and Ms. Duflo, often with Mr. Kremer, soon performed similar studies of other issues and in other countries, including India. Their experimental research methods now entirely dominate development economics.

The 2019 Economic Sciences Laureates’ research findings have dramatically improved our ability to fight poverty in practice. As a

result of one of their studies, more than five million Indian children have benefitted from programmes of remedial tutoring in schools.

India will be proud of the honour that Abhijit has received - he is largely a product of India's educational system, including Presidency College and Jawaharlal Nehru University (with finishing touches at Harvard). Abhijit Banerjee will continue to do important work on India, including offering policy advice.

Make in India: The Vision, Infrastructure, New Processes & Hurdles



'**M**ake in India' is a flagship campaign launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on 25th September 2014 to encourage companies to manufacture their products in India and also increase their investment. It aims at increasing domestic manufacturing industries and attracting foreign investors to invest into the country. It covers 25 sectors of economy including automobiles, aviation, biotechnology, defence manufacturing, food processing, renewable energy, tourism and hospitality, etc.

India is a developing country and it needs employment as well as manpower which makes it a great initiative. This campaign was launched to ensure job guarantee, skill development and growth of economy.

Vision

The contribution of manufacturing sector in national GDP in the year 2016-2017 was 16.57%. The aim of this initiative is to increase it to 25% by 2025. In the process, the government expected to generate jobs, attract foreign direct investment, and transform India into a manufacturing hub around the globe. The logo for the 'Make in India' campaign is an elegant lion, inspired by the Ashoka Chakra and designed to represent India's success in all spheres. The campaign was dedicated by the Prime Minister to the eminent patriot, philosopher and political personality, Pandit Deen Dayal Upadhyaya who was born on the same date in 1916.

Vision: Zero Defects and Zero Effect

We should manufacture goods in such a way that they carry zero defects that our exported goods are never returned to us. We should manufacture goods with zero effect that they should not have a negative impact on the environment.

The initiative 'Make in India' is built on four pillars which are as follows:

- **New Processes:** The government is introducing several reforms to create possibilities for getting Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) and foster business partnerships. Some initiatives have already been undertaken to diminish the business environment from outdated policies and regulations. This reform is also aligned with parameters of World Bank's 'Ease of Doing Business' index to improve India's ranking on it.
- **New Infrastructure:** Infrastructure is integral to the growth of any industry. The government intends to develop industrial corridors and build smart cities with state-of-the-art technology and high-speed communication. Innovation and research activities are supported by a fast-paced registration system and improved infrastructure for Intellectual Property Rights (IPR) registrations. Along with the development of infrastructure, the training for the skilled workforce for the sectors is also being addressed.
- **New Sectors:** 'Make in India' has identified 25 sectors to promote with the detailed information being shared through an interactive web-portal. The Government has allowed 100% FDI in Railways and removed restrictions in construction. It has also recently increased the cap of FDI to 100% in defence and pharmaceutical.
- **New Mindset:** This initiative intends to change the mindset by bringing a paradigm shift in the way Government interacts with various industries. It will focus on acting as a partner in the economic development of the country alongside the corporate sector.

Infrastructure

Industrial corridors and 21 new nodal industrial cities are to be developed which will be having advantages like large land parcels, planned communities, ICT enabled infrastructure, sustainable living, excellent connectivity – road, rail, etc. Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor is a mega infrastructure project of USD 100 billion with financial and technical aids from Japan, covering an overall length of 1,483 km. Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) of 1504 km as the backbone, DMIC will intersect 7 states namely Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Maharashtra.

Railway projects such as setting up of new railway stations, modernization of rolling stock, high speed railways, port mine connectivity, etc. have been initiated for modernizing and better connectivity of Indian railways. Aviation industry has been targeted to become 3rd largest by 2030 and to cater international and domestic traffic.

New Processes

Improved business processes and procedures open up new avenues of opportunities and create confidence among entrepreneurs which resulted in India moving up 12 places in the World Bank's Doing Business ranking 2016 released in October 2015. Goods and Services Tax – single tax framework was introduced in July 2017.

Incorporation of a company is reduced from 10 days to 1 day. Number of documents for exports and imports reduced from 11 to 3. Power connection is provided within a mandated time frame of 15 days instead of 180 days. Validity of industrial license is extended to 7 years from 3 years.

Hurdles

- Trading or imports of goods for mass consumption especially in a food, consumer goods, electrical products and light engineering goods needs to be controlled. Strong regulations need to be set up for quality clearances of foods in markets. Chinese products, chocolates and candies flood Indian markets since the importers

presently do not have to take FDA (Food and Drug Administration) permission.

- One issue that affects both current and new manufacturing units is land. The land is so expensive that it cannot be acquired for manufacturing. The only places where land is available are those that are without inhabitants or barren, and this does not make manufacturing attractive for labourers. Cities dependent on manufacturing are no longer attracting the best employees as the manufacturing units are located in places where it is difficult to live.
- China has become the manufacturing hub for world, especially for the electronics industry. With Modi government aiming to make India the next manufacturing powerhouse, it will require an ecosystem that will foster the growth of the manufacturing sector. This will not only be in form of sops like duty reduction etc., but would require a larger policy framework that makes the process of doing business in India easier. With simplified taxation and labour laws, better transport infrastructure, and addressing the frequent power outages issues, will positively impact India's manufacturing industry; both for the growth and bringing foreign investment.
- India ranks low on the "ease of doing business index". Labour laws in the country are still not conducive to the 'Make in India' campaign. This is one of the universally noted disadvantages of manufacturing and investing in India.
- India is often termed as an agricultural economy whose mainstay is agriculture. However, the contribution of agriculture to the GDP is fast coming down from its above 50% levels at one point. Industry and services together rose over 11% in their contribution to the GDP, but employment figures rose only by 6%. This implies that we continue to employ more and more people in agriculture while income growth is happening in the industry.

This national program is designed to transform the country into a global business hub as it contains attractive proposals for top local

and foreign companies. This campaign focuses on creating number of valuable and honoured jobs as well as skill enhancement in almost 25 sectors for improving the status of youths of the country.

The Modi government has sought to address most of concerns, with India under his watch climbing from languishing around 140th place in the World Bank's ease of doing business rankings to 63rd this year. The government also cut corporate taxes for new manufacturing companies to an effective rate of 17 per cent, putting India on a par with rivals such as Singapore.

However, a lot of other areas remain unaddressed, such as labour and land acquisition laws that make establishing and expanding factories prohibitive.

RBI Ban on India's Crypto Currency Exchanges



Everyone wants some good return against his investment and for this people are also ready to take risks. Earlier, people invested their money in real estate, gold, bonds and equities. But this trend has been changed since last many decades. Now people have new option for making money in very short time. This new option is 'Cryptocurrency', but it has no legal source and it also involves very high risk in investment.

Cryptocurrency is nothing but a digital or virtual currency. It has become very demanding after the introduction of Bitcoin. There are lot of traders who accept the payment in these Cryptocurrencies both in online and offline mode. There are many Cryptocurrencies available through online markets are Ethereum, Monero, Dash, Ripple to name a few. Bitcoin is the most well-known, acceptable and demanding among all of the cryptocurrencies. No virtual currency is comparable to Bitcoin in demand, acceptance and even in their value. Majority of the portion of cryptocurrency is in the form of Bitcoin only; most of the trades and businesses are done in Bitcoin in the world of virtual currency.

People buy Bitcoin for many purposes like for investment and for making payment of various services and goods such as flights, jewellery, hotels, giving loans against virtual tokens, settling, accepting them as collateral and even for the payment of academic fees. These digital currencies can be mined through data mining, purchased via peer to peer and can be invested through various cryptocurrencies exchanges. But the main issue surrounding the

usage of Bitcoin is that it has no legal source, it stays unregulated and it can be easily used in black markets.

On 5th July 2018, Central Bank put a ban on the cryptocurrency exchanges; RBI had issued a circulation regarding the ban. Central Bank also gave the order to freeze the accounts of crypto currency exchanges. Thus, a three months deadline was given for settlement of accounts operated for the trade of virtual currencies. RBI has frequently warned users, holders and merchants regarding the various risks involved in these virtual currencies. RBI said that “technological innovations, including those underlying virtual currencies; have the potential to improve the efficiency and inclusiveness of the financial system. However, virtual currencies also variously referred to as cryptocurrencies and assets, raise concerns of consumer protection, market integrity and money laundering among others.”

To address the related risks, RBI decided to take some immediate steps. Entities regulated by RBI will not provide any service and assistance to any entities or individuals who are dealing in cryptocurrencies. This is a big blow to cryptocurrency holders and its trading platform which work for circulation of virtual currencies in India. Earlier, RBI repeatedly warned holders and traders of cryptocurrencies regarding the risk involved in the business with these currencies, through its public notice on December 2013, February 2017 and December 2017.

In the absence of any specific regulation and norms for the use of cryptocurrency, the exchanges have been tried to be self-regulated with the verification of e-KYC to the users. This regulation was guided by the Blockchain and Cryptocurrency Committee, which was constituted under the auspices of the Internet and Mobile Association of India. But, if there had been any consideration on the exchanges, then there was no law and legal system to protect the interest of investors. Government had also not given licence to any of the cryptocurrency exchanges and had not authorised them as medium

of exchange. A statement released in December last year by Finance Ministry said “These virtual currencies are also being described as ‘Coins’. There is however no physical attribute to these coins. Therefore, virtual currencies are neither currencies nor coins”.

Against the ban circular, there were several petitions filed in the Supreme Court. A bench consisting of CJI Dipak Misra, Justice A.M. Khanwilkar and Justice D.Y. Chandrachud refused to stay on the RBI circular. That petition was filed by the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI). The lawyer of IMAI said that the association did not oppose any regulation, but the three months time period seemed very less to close the bank accounts dealing with cryptocurrencies and it is likely to create demonetization like situation for businesses. Against the argument of IAMAL, RBI argued that cryptocurrency was never a legal tender and that the RBI was examining the depiction made by the parties.

However, the cryptocurrency is banned, but the transaction can be continued through peer to peer method where people can buy and sell cryptocurrency directly without any restrictions with the help of exchanges without using normal banking channels. The entities which are involved in the business of virtual currencies start working on alternative model for entry and exit from virtual currencies. It is very difficult to put complete ban on cryptocurrencies because of its core technology which is Blockchain. In this Blockchain technology there is no central regulatory authority and at the same time it is equally controlled by its users.

In India, dealing in cryptocurrency is a breach of foreign exchange regulations and thousands of people have already received notices from Income Tax department. These notices were sent following a nationwide survey which showed that in a period of 17 months, there were more than \$3.5 billion worth of transactions that have taken place. From the last year, the cryptocurrency exchanges came under the notice of Income tax department and since then raids have been conducted in nine exchanges across the five cities. According to a

report it was estimated that about 1 million traders were in India, out of which half a million were active traders. The total revenue of top 10 cryptocurrency exchanges in India was estimated to be Rs 400000 million.

In the Union Budget 2018, the Finance Minister clearly said that cryptocurrencies are not a valid tender, but the government will explore its key technology Blockchain. Government has always been opposing the virtual currency because it can be a mode of tax evasion, money laundering, terrorist funding and other illegal activities. Even social media platform like Facebook announced to put ban on ads related to these virtual currencies and said that “financial products and services that are frequently associated with misleading or deceptive promotional practices, such as binary options, initial coin offerings and cryptocurrency are blocked from being displayed on Facebook”.

In the fast changing world where most part of our lives is associated with smartphone, artificial intelligence and internet of things, it seems very difficult not accepting the virtual currency. Cryptocurrency is seen as the future of currencies of all the nations. In fact, some of the countries allow the payment in the cryptocurrency and some are monitoring and even thinking to allow it in their country. Yet, big economies like United States of America and People Republic of China did not take any step. China is reportedly set to launch its own digital currency by 2021. Countries such as France, Singapore and Malaysia are also testing similar virtual currencies.

In India, the RBI put ban on cryptocurrency and this step must be welcomed in the present situation where dealing in the cryptocurrency involves risk for both the individual and nation. Again in December 2019, the Reserve Bank of India reiterated its opposition to private digital currencies. Nevertheless, the RBI has begun consultations with other central banks on India's own digital currency. For this, the RBI must have some regulations and the central

government needs to draft preparatory mechanism by enacting laws and rules for the regulation and control of cryptocurrency.

The Problems and Solutions of Unemployment in India



Unemployment simply means a person willing to work is unable to find a qualified job for him. Unemployment is one of the major indicators of the Indian economy. Currently, India is facing a very serious issue of unemployment. Steadily rising population but stagnating economic growth is posing a serious challenge in the form of an unemployment crisis. Human resource is one of the most important resources of a country. However, these resources are being wasted which is shown by the fact that many doctors, engineers, graduates and even scientists are currently unable to find jobs and are unemployed. It is not uncommon to read reports that MBAs and B Tech qualified individuals applying for the job of a bus conductor or peon in a government office.

A recent report by the National Sample Survey Office's periodic labour force survey shows that the current state of unemployment is that it is at a four-decade high and stands at 6.1% for the year 2018-2019. Recent research by Pew Research Centre shows that the current state of unemployment is considered 'a very big problem' by most of the Indians. The condition is such that over 16.8 million Indians are jobless and another 393.7 million are currently working in very poor quality jobs. According to the International Labour Organisation, the unemployment rate in India is rising and will be much higher than the projected rate for the year 2018-2019.

Reasons behind rising unemployment in India

There is not one reason for the rising rate of unemployment in India. Multiple factors contribute to poor employment rates in the country.

Some of the major ones are: -

- Rising population is one of the biggest culprits and is the main cause of the highest unemployment rate in over four decades. The country's economic growth is unable to keep up with the population growth leading to situations where more than a thousand people are applying for jobs with only ten vacancies.
- The slow rate of industrial growth has also hit employment. While there is growth in industrialization, the rate of growth has slowed down, leading to more unemployed Indians looking for jobs. The industrial growth has been unable to meet the demands of the rising population.
- Loss of small scale and cottage industries has also contributed to rising unemployment rates. Goods that are handcrafted require very specific skills but the demand for high production industrialized goods has decreased the demand from such small scale industries, thus making the workers of such industries unemployed.
- India has always been facing ineffective economic planning which has resulted in a wide gap between supply and demand where demand is less, but supply is much more.

Effects of the rising rate of unemployment

The reasons for the rising unemployment rate can be numerous with each contributing its percentage share in the problem. And so are the problems created by the rising unemployment rate. Unemployment creates a lot of problems for society. Some of the major issues faced due to rising unemployment are:

- Unemployment leads to less availability of cash with an individual and thus decreases their purchasing power. With the unavailability of money, the unemployed turn poorer, giving rise to another big problem of Indian society i.e., poverty.

- High unemployment rate causes slower economic growth which in turn leads to lower employment rates. This can continue to form a cycle unless something is done by the government to take care of the issue before it turns into a big problem.
- An empty mind is a devil's workshop. Unemployment leads to loads of problems; unemployment youth generally tend to get attracted towards crimes, drugs, alcohol abuse, robbery and other societal evils. This creates another big issue of law and order in society.
- If there is sustained unemployment in the society and someone willing to work is unable to find the right kind of job for himself, he will ultimately turn towards the wrong direction to earn money and to be able to feed himself.

How to tackle the menace of unemployment

The rising unemployment rate in India is a very big issue that has to be handled maturely. This does not affect the unemployed mentally but takes a toll physically as well. Someone who is willing to work in order to earn money will definitely turn in the wrong direction to earn his/her share of the money. Government has undertaken steps to control the rising rate of unemployment but those steps are not sufficient and will never be sufficient if they are not implemented properly. Some solutions that have been put forward to control or reduce the problems caused by unemployment are:

- The population growth rate in India has to be controlled at all costs if India wants to emerge as the leader among the developing nations of the world. The huge population is one thing that has continuously been bogging India down. The current state is such that India will overtake China in terms of population in a few

years. This simply cannot be allowed to happen if India needs to feed all its citizens and provide jobs to its citizens.

- Another major reason for high unemployment rates is poor skills of the Indian students looking for jobs. Everyone wants a job, but no one is ready to do the hard work to learn the skills that are required for that job. Absence of proper training institutes and students graduating from poor quality colleges and institutes contribute further to this problem. People should be allowed what they want to do, but in order to do what they want to do, they should be skilled enough to work in that field where they want a job.
- A majority of rural India has to travel to urban parts for studies, medical treatments or even jobs. The government has not done enough for the rural people to train them in setting up at least small scale industries which can employ scores of people. Moreover, people from rural areas travel to the cities to find jobs. The government should take steps so that people from rural areas are able to find jobs at places in their villages only and they do not need to travel to cities to get employed.
- A large number of people in India are involved in agriculture. Due to climatic factors or other man-made factors, the crops get damaged, leaving people facing huge losses and resorting to other alternatives which include moving to cities for jobs. The government needs to offer the farmers better facilities and remuneration that encourages them to stick with farming and be meaningfully employed.

There are numerous causes of unemployment and numerous problems due to unemployment, but there are also ways to mend these problems and improve the employment rates in the country. The government has been taking steps to bring down unemployment rates, but they have not been enough. Better efforts need to be put forward to curb this problem which if left to grow will be a serious issue for the government as well as for the youth of this country.

The Goods & Services Tax - Achievements & Implementation Challenges

The Goods and Services Tax (GST) is an indirect tax reform scheme that is implemented and appreciated in many countries. In India, it will be a value added tax that will comprehensively replace multiple Central and State tax schemes. The GST will replace the Octroi Duty, the Excise Duty, the Central Sales Tax, the Value-Added-Tax, Entry Tax, Stamp Duty, etc. Some of these taxes were charged by the State Governments and some by the Centre. Because of this, it gives the State Governments to fix the tax bracket according to their requirements, thereby resulting in multiple tax schemes with different tax bundles that cause the businessmen heaps of paperwork trouble. There is a much needed tax unification scheme that will ease the problems faced by the indigenous manufacturers, distributors and retailers.

The basic premise behind GST is that this is tax deducted on each point of sale or purchase. This is different from the prevalent tax scheme, under which the product is taxed once at the manufacturers' and once at the retailer's outlet. GST is a betterment of the current VAT system and will be introduced once there is a proper system in place: the GSTN (the IT network that will enable the collection of the tax) is being put in place and the government has instituted a Special Purpose Vehicle for this purpose. The SPV will be a private entity with the government's strategic control.

Implementation

In India, GST has been talked about for quite a long time now. Under the Atal Bihari Vajpayee government, an empowered committee was

set up to create a GST model for the nation and to oversee the development of an IT network that would enable the implementation of the scheme. Even the UPA government wanted to roll out the scheme and hence announced the formation of an empowered committee of the finance ministers of the states. This committee then formed a JWG (Joint Working Group) which submitted a report in 2007. After due discussion with the government and considering the report, it was decided that a committee of Principal Secretaries of the states would be formed to take the process forward. Lengthy discussions have been done on GST and it is time now that this scheme be implemented. Even the business community has welcomed the GST because of its known benefits as evidenced in other countries.

The recommendations of the empowered committee have broken GST into two parts: Central GST and State GST

The rates for these taxes have not been decided and will be left at the discretion of the governments considering the revenue requirements of the state. The rationale behind this bifurcation is that this will encourage more harmonious tax sharing between the two governments. On the other hand, it is stated that this kind of a structure is nothing more than a new name for the old tax schemes. Truly, if the determination of the SGST is left at the will of the state governments, then there will be confusion and the actual intent of GST will be lost.

The second important recommendation is of using a two-rate scheme. In this, essential goods and services like certain food items, etc. are taxed at a lower rate, while all other products and services are taxed at the same rate. This move is supposed to lower the impact of the tax on the BPL families.

Also, GST will be levied on the imported goods and services, because as already made clear, although the scheme works on collecting the tax from the different stages of value addition in the product, but the actual brunt is borne by the end customer.

UBS AG (formerly Union Bank of Switzerland), the global financial giant, claimed in a report that in the coming years, three policy implementations would be crucial:

- -Aadhar Card
- -Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC)
- -Goods and Services Tax Reforms

It was claimed that in the coming three years, the impact of each of these would be of the order of 1% of the GDP. Thus it is important for India to now push for the GST.

GST will streamline the taxation and thus help reduce tax evasion and tax frauds. This in turn would mean that the government would be able to earn a lot more taxes than usual because of the expansion of the tax base, and that tax compliance would increase. In order to pass this benefit down to the people, the governments normally price the GST at lower rates than the combined rates of the previously existing taxes. Over all, it will help the businesses as a lower rate would decrease the tax burden and increase export opportunities.

GST will also democratise the burden of tax on services and goods alike. Currently, services are exempted from taxation at the state level. GST would thus help increase the tax base. Also, it will solve the problem of tax cascading to a certain extent. The manufacturing sector would take a big sigh of relief because it currently faces one of the most complex tax structures in the developing or developed world.

One of the more resounding criticisms of GST is that it is a regressive tax scheme, in a sense that it benefits the rich more and makes the poor pay more as a percentage of their income. GST will be a flat tax scheme and hence common logic indicates that rich and poor will have to pay the same tax on a particular commodity. In India, and other countries sensitive to this issue, there have been different rates of taxes for different types of commodities. The zero-rating of some commodities will help keep the regression in check.

The all-new Cenvat Credit Rules, 2014 do little to clarify eligibility for input credits by using general terms such as “any goods which have no relationship whatsoever with the manufacture of a final product” and “ services used primarily for personal use or consumption of any employee”. Before penning the GST Act and Rules, the Empowered Committee would do well to take a hard look at all the present laws that GST subsumes and their complexities. It could tempt them to rethink on the necessity to draft even the preamble.

There has to be a clear communication from the Government’s side about the benefits of the GST and its likely implications on the general public and the businesses. Normally, with the negative connotation that goes with the word tax, any new tax scheme puts the people on a back foot and creates an unwelcome environment. With GST and its likely benefits, if the government can communicate the importance of this scheme, through public messages and proper communication channels, then the negative impacts can be lowered.

The popularity of GST has been increasing is evident from the fact that around 38 lakh new taxpayers have registered under GST regime and the total count has crossed one crore if we include the 64 lakh earlier ones. Total number of taxpayers was above 1.14 crore in October 2018.

From the government’s point of view, the gross GST revenue collection for December 2019 has crossed Rs 1-lakh crore mark, showing a 16 per cent rise in revenue Year-over-year (YoY). It is for the ninth time since the inception of GST in July 2017 that monthly collection has crossed the mark of Rs 1 lakh crore.

Young India's Preference - from Job Search to Job Creation

India's recognition as a country of talented youth with extraordinary intellect has opened platform with plethora of opportunities for Indian young minds. Some of the big Indian names doing extremely well on global platform are Google CEO Sunder Pichai, Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella, Global Foundries CEO- Sanjay Kumar Jha, SoftBank Internet and Media Inc CEO - Nikesch Arora. These leaders are idealized models for many young Indians. Their success motivates Indian youth to aim for such positions in corporate sectors.

On the other hand, there is another segment of leaders. They are founders of startups like Rahul Bahl and Rohit Bansal (Snapdeal), Sachin Bansal and Binny Bansal (Flipkart founders), Nitin Saluja and Raghav Verma (Chaayos founders), and Ritesh Aggarwal (OYO rooms founder). These names belong to different league altogether. They once decided to work on their entrepreneurship ideas and that resulted in huge success for them. These leaders are doing wonders in entrepreneurship and driving young minds to choose job creation over job search. Apart from inspiration factor, there are many other things contributing to flaring the passion for entrepreneurship among young Indians.

According to 2014 report for the G20 Young Entrepreneurs' Alliance, it was estimated that digital entrepreneurs could create 10 million jobs in span of next five years. In 2011, IIM Ahmedabad graduates, Radhakrishna and Raghunandan G, launched Taxiforsure as an online platform through which consumers can rent taxis. BITS Pilani batchmates, Phanindra Sama, Charan Padmaraju and Sudhakar Pasupunuri founded the pioneering venture RedBus together. In June

2013, they sold RedBus to the Ibibo Group for an estimated amount of Rs 600-700 crore, the biggest overseas strategic acquisition of an Indian internet asset.

Another example of successful ventures is that of TravelTriangle, an online travel services company launched by IITians Sankalp Agrawal and Sanchit Garg that is clocking revenues in crores.

In India, problems like draught conditions lead to agriculture failure in many parts of the country. In such circumstances, employability looks like a distant dream. Issues like snail paced industrial growth and global slowdown have an adverse effect on employment opportunities. An overview of these problems is further escalated by tough competition to first find admission in reputed colleges than in desirable companies. Due to neck to neck competition, desirable jobs unlatch window for very few candidates, leaving others to work with alternate options of employability, just for the sake of it. In such cases, element of passion goes missing and halfhearted efforts result in low performance. Above all, mechanization of labour in industries shrinks job opportunities for labour based workforce.

Apart from these factors affecting the workforce, youth suffers from dissatisfaction in jobs too. Lack of good quality environment and contributing issues like underutilization of calibre, lack of appreciation, unexplored skills, knowledge, and presence of quirky boss takes away zeal to work in a company. They feel it is more important to make efforts towards the goal associated to their passion. They are motivated to bring life to their own professional ideas rather than working for others. Other contributing factors like insecurity in jobs, working under dull and mundane job profile, conflicting attitudes at workplace contribute to the decision of choosing entrepreneurship as a career choice.

Government of India is also playing a motivating role to encourage this preference among youth. At the launch of 'Startup India', Prime minister encouraged the young minds saying, "Youth of India must turn from job-seekers to job-creators". 'Startup India' is a government

scheme that comes with an action plan entirely focused on promoting bank financing for start-up ventures. Ultimate aim lies in encouraging job creation through Startups. Policy comes with benefit to the young Indians with advantages like: Start-up fund of Rs. 10,000 crore for funding of Start-ups, Start-ups to be exempted from paying income tax on their profit for the first 3 years, fast-tracking of Start-up patent applications and other freebies.

According to Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, a total of 24,940 startups has been recognised by the department for the promotion of industry and internal trade (DPIIT). The data has been last updated on November 21, 2019. So far the IT services sector witnessed the most number of registration with 3443 new startups.

WhatsApp on November 25 announced an investment of \$250,000 in the Indian startup ecosystem to help the Indian entrepreneurial community connect with their customers and grow their businesses.

A Small Seed is Tomorrow's Big Tree

Start ups are progressive to the interest of nation. Even big companies like Infosys, Oberoi Hotels, Reliance, etc. were small in the beginning. It is a well accepted fact that SMEs (Small and medium enterprises) play a vital role in growth and development of country. The estimated contribution of SMEs to the country's GDP was 37.54 per cent during 2012-13 and the share of SMEs in India's total export was 44.70 per cent for the year 2014-15. Considering the credibility of Start-ups in India, institutes like IIMs and IITs have introduced the concept of incubation where new companies are promoted in their campus. Such initiatives speak loud of the importance that start-ups concept hold for every segment of Indians. It taps the creative utilities of their minds. Young people who possess the qualities like crystal clear vision, risk taking abilities, thrust to market their ideas and reach to masses despite obstacles, have the ability to make it big tomorrow. In April 2015, Olacabs, Quikr, Freshdesk and Policy Bazaar received major funding. Companies like Delhivery (\$85 million), Fintellix (\$15 million), and Swiggy (\$15

million) received funding in May. In June 2015, companies like Ecomm Express (\$137 million), Flipkart (\$50 million), Applied Solar Technologies (\$40 million), and Saama (\$35 million) received funding.

Entrepreneurship Goes Beyond Self Employment

In India, many ventures which started from home shelves ended up providing employment to hundreds. The start-up concept clicks well with the youth. They only need to have a brilliant workable idea that coincides well with the need of the hour. Youth in India are considered to be dreamers, makers, visionaries and leaders who have the potential to march to their own drums to bring life to their ideas.

India may be third after the United States and China in the global start-up ecosystem ranking. India may have much to learn from Hong Kong, which successfully hosted RISE 2018 - Asia's biggest tech event in July, 2018, bringing together start-up entrepreneurs from across the globe under one roof to discuss the road ahead.

As many as 200 start-ups from India participated in the event and many of the newbie tech entrepreneurs from the country were of the view that India had it in to become a serious contender for investment in start-up ventures.

The never-ending demand for jobs can only be met by promoting entrepreneurial activities. This can be made possible by providing right platform to young entrepreneurs. It is evident that Indians have launched ventures in the past and they still possess the passion. Opportunities are in abundance and the country is plush with resources. The challenge for young India lies in optimizing resources and overcoming the barriers to enter the league of developed nations and inspire every other developing nation. Entrepreneurship is past, present and promising future of India and every young Indian holds right to stand up and add value to any action that materializes dream of our country.

Feminisation of Agriculture Sector



In India, majority of the workforce is dependent on agriculture as a source of revenue. However, due to consistent crisis in agriculture, rural men migrate to cities. They adopt other work choices as construction labourers, rickshaw pullers, domestic servants and street vendors to make both ends meet. This male migration leaves family behind in the village to be raised by de facto female-headed families. With this, rural women become responsible for the integrated management and use of diverse natural resources to meet the daily household needs. This leads to increase in number of women in multiple roles such as entrepreneurs, cultivators and labourers. The Economic Survey 2017-18 points out that growing rural-to-urban migration by men is causing “feminization” of agriculture sector with increasing number of women in multiple roles as cultivators, entrepreneurs, and labourers. This ever increasing participation of women in the agricultural labour is driven by economic factors operating in tandem.

Economic Factors

The state of poverty forces the women members to work in the agricultural fields to meet the financial needs of the family. There are many economic reasons instrumental to the growth of feminisation of agriculture. One of the major reasons is a huge gap in the male and female wages. With the existence of gender wage differentials, men are paid more than women. Men move out for better perspectives elsewhere, and a low-income pursuit is left for women. The differences in educational attainments and work skills between women and men are reflected in wage differentials. Lower

educational attainment than men makes women more likely to be crowded in low paid jobs. Due to domestic responsibilities, their lower mobility restricts them to opt for the profession of their choice. Male migration forces women to fill in for them in the agricultural fields. They are forced to take up the role to fill the void left behind by male members of the family. Traditional way of agriculture is labour intensive. Hence, high demand for labourers in the agricultural sector further intensifies feminization of agriculture

Women's Contribution

As per Census 2011, out of the total number of female main workers, 55% were agricultural labourers and 24% cultivators. The figures show that for sustainable development of agriculture and rural economy, the contribution of women to agriculture and food production cannot be ignored. However, in agriculture, ownership of only 12.8% of the operational holdings by women reflected the gender disparity. The Survey highlighted that with women being predominant at all levels ranging from production, pre-harvest, packaging, post-harvest processing, and marketing of the agricultural value chain, it is imperative to adopt gender specific interventions. Though women farmers have been contributing immensely to the agricultural production but their work arena has been subjected to the justification of its significance.

Blind Eye to Women's Contribution

Women are most active in work arena such as cultivation of crops and vegetables, wasteland development, watershed development and regeneration of degraded forests. Insufficient attention to the work section has shown that women's contributions remain invisible in planning and thus, are ignored. Interestingly, women account for 93 percent of employment in dairy production in India. But 75 percent of dairy cooperative membership belongs to male. Women's livestock activities have been traditionally perceived as an extension of domestic work around the house. It is observed that among the rural men who migrate in search of work, only less than one-third are able

to secure a regular position in cities. The remaining migrants return to their villages, most often, at the times of harvesting and sowing. Meanwhile, only agricultural activities including fertilizing, weeding, raising animals and watering are left to the women.

Society and Feminization of Agriculture

Women's land ownership is still one of the major issues that remain intact in India. Economic security is worsened by policies and institutions which do not understand that promoting women's control over their incomes and assets would help boost growth and development. This is one of the main forms of gender inequality that is systematically neglected in social policy and income statistics. In Asia, a large proportion of women are not able to retain their earned income over 40 percent in Bangladesh, over 40 percent in Gujarat and over 70 percent in Indonesia. Discriminatory barriers and socio-cultural rigidities remain the major reasons which block women from obtaining effective control of property, assets and resources. The deep-rooted social inequalities go against women having an effective voice in community management. There is factual evidence that rural women are responsible for the integrated management and use of diverse natural resources to meet the daily household needs. This reflects that the entitlements of women farmers will be the key to improve agriculture productivity. Therefore, government is taking significant measures in this direction.

Govt. Schemes to Improve Entitlements for Women Farmers

The impending condition of agriculture industry needs women farmers to have enhanced access to resources like land, water, technology and training. Towards this, government has been implementing schemes which help improve the entitlements of women farmers. To ensure progress of women in the agriculture sector, the government is attributing at least 30% of the budget allocation for women beneficiaries in all development activities. Focussing on women, self-help groups (SHGs) to connect them to

micro-credit, government is taking measures to provide information and ensure their representation in different decision-making processes.

The government has come to terms with the fact that women's predominance at various levels like production, pre-harvest, post-harvest processing, packaging, marketing, it is imperative to adopt gender specific interventions. Along with government Intervention, another aspect that coincides with growth of female farmers in India is education and technology.

Women in Agricultural Education and Technology

An army of rootless men in cities, along with an equal-sized army of women left behind in villages, does not provide the basis of a secure and stable future for the country. Building better amenities in rural regions is the necessity to make shining India a real picture of the lives of its people in rural villages. This requires that women farmers should have enhanced access to technology and training. A current program in India on the lines of technological empowerment of women in agriculture has to be backed up with enhanced agricultural management skills and knowledge. Gender sensitization in rural areas through information and communication technologies helps develop a social understanding of women as farmers and economic contributors. Women farmers have a great deal of experience as farmers coupled with tremendous knowledge and expertise on indigenous crop varieties and the special environmental requirements for cultivation. This experience can be empowered to enhance agricultural productivity with trained and equipped female farmers.

Certainly, feminization of agriculture is a step forward to reduce discrimination. It is a chance to translate social desirability into social practice. Agriculture has traditionally been an acceptable avenue of work for women in rural areas, otherwise infamous for many a stigma when it comes to women's employability in workplaces. It is important to reverse this trend. Food sufficiency can only be guaranteed by continued gender involvement in agriculture. It is, therefore, required

for agricultural policy to aim at gender-specific interventions that integrate women as active agents in rural transformation, and involve men and women in extension services with gender expertise. Government should invest more on women education, since development in all spheres of life including agriculture hinges on education of the people particularly women.

How far have the Farmers Benefited from the New Agricultural Schemes?



Agriculture is the backbone of Indian economy. Agriculture is also the largest source of livelihood in India. India is the largest producer (25% of global production), consumer (27% of world consumption) and importer (14%) of pulses in the world. It is the second largest producer of rice, sugarcane, wheat, cotton and groundnuts, as well as the second largest fruits and vegetable producer, accounting for 10.9% and 8.6% of the world fruit and vegetable production. In 2017-18, annual milk production of India was 165 million tons. India is the largest producer of milk, jute and pulses. Agriculture contributes to 23% of GDP, and employed 59% of the country's total workforce in 2016.

The government of India has implemented several farmer welfare schemes to stimulate agriculture sector and to improve their economic conditions.

Some of the important initiatives by the government are:

Krishonnati Yojana

It is an umbrella scheme which includes:

National Food Security Mission (NFSM): This scheme aims to increase the production of wheat, rice and pulses.

National Food Security Mission-Commercial Crops: for crop development programme on cotton, jute and sugarcane for enhancing productivity.

Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture (MIDH): It covers wide horticulture base, which includes fruits, vegetables, tuber crops,

mushrooms, spices and aromatic plants, flowers and foliage and plantation crops like coconut, areca nut, cashew nut, cocoa and bamboo.

National Mission on Oilseeds and Oil Palm: It aims to increase in production of vegetable oils sourced from oilseeds, oil palm and tree borne oilseeds.

National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture: It aims at making agriculture more productive, sustainable and remunerative and climate resilient.

National Mission on Agricultural Extension and Technology: Its aim is to revamp and strengthen agricultural extension to enable delivery of appropriate technology and improved agronomic practices.

Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojna

This scheme was launched by the Prime Minister, Narendra Modi on 18th February 2016. It envisages a uniform premium of only 2 per cent to be paid by farmers for Kharif crops, and 1.5 per cent for Rabi crops. The premium for annual commercial and horticultural crops will be 5 per cent.

Soil Health Card Scheme

It is a scheme launched by government of India in February 2015. Soil cards are issued to farmers which will carry crop-wise recommendation of nutrients and fertilizers required for the individual farms to improve productivity through judicious use of inputs. All the soil samples are to be tested in various soil testing labs across the country to analyze its strengths and weaknesses and suggest possible measures.

Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (PMKSY)

This scheme was launched on 1st July 2015 with the motto of 'Har Khet Ko Paani'. It is being implemented to expand cultivated area with assured irrigation, reduce wastage of water and improve efficiency of water use. It also focuses on creating protective irrigation

by harnessing rain water at micro level through 'Jal sanchay' and Jal Sinchan'.

Krishi Kalyan Cess

Union Budget for 2016-17 (April-March) introduced Krishi Kalyan Cess – a new cess on services at the rate of 0.5%. The effective rate of the Krishi Kalyan Cess, however, will be lower than 0.5% as the government will provide input tax credit for the cess, as against no input tax credit for Swachh Bharat Cess.

Deen Dayal Upadhaya Grameen kaushalya Yojana

This scheme was launched on 25th September 2014 by Union Minister Nitin Gadkarii and Venkaiah Naidu on the occasion of 98th birth anniversary of Pandit Deen dayal Upadhyaya. A corpus of Rs. 1,500 crore is aimed at enhancing the employability of rural youth. Under this programme, disbursements would be made through a digital voucher directly into the students' bank accounts as part of the government's skill development initiative.

Benefits from Agricultural Schemes

Under the Krishonnati Yojna, the Union Cabinet has approved a subsidy of Rs 5.5 per quintal for sugarcane farmers to help cash-starved millers. The government has also increased the minimum support price (MSP) of raw jute by Rs 200 per quintal to Rs 3,700 per quintal for the 2018-19 crop seasons. This scheme plans to double farmers' income by 2022. The government has also increased the minimum support price for wheat to Rs 1735 per quintal, for gram to Rs 1450 per quintal, for mustard Rs 3900 per quintal etc. Minimum support price is the price at which the government purchases crops from the farmers.

The other scheme Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojna aims to achieve convergence to investments in irrigation at the field level, expand cultivable area, reduce the wastage of water and enhance adoption of precision-irrigation. The PMKSY also explores a number of methods to treat and reuse municipal water for irrigation projects.

Soil Health Cards have been distributed to the farmers by the government in some states including Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Orissa. In order to make this scheme more successful and make it reach large number of people, the government of India and the agricultural department of India has launched soil health card portal which includes Fertilizer Quality Control System and Participatory Guarantee System Portal.

Bhagat Puran Singh Sehat Bima Yojna was launched by the Punjab government. Under this scheme, farmers and their families will receive health cover of up to Rs. 50,000 for their treatment. In case of the death of the head of the family or accident causing 100 per cent disability to that person, the family of the farmer will get a compensation of Rs. 5 lakhs.

The subsidies given by the government for solar powered motors help the farmers to buy solar panels. Many farmers in Coimbatore have been benefitted under the scheme. The money spent amounted to Rs. 178.16 lakhs.

Over 90 lakhs farmers have benefitted from the crop insurance scheme during Kharif season and Rabi season in 2016-2017. Farmers have also been provided assistance for owning agricultural machinery including tractors.

The government is also trying to educate the farmers. Agriculture colleges and universities have been set up. They give all types of knowledge regarding agricultural science. These colleges and universities organize orientation courses for the farmers. These courses train the people in modern techniques and methods of farming. The Doordarshan and Aakashvani are also educating the farmers regarding the new techniques in farming. They have started special programmers like Krishi Darshan and Kheti Ki Baten exclusively for the farmers. The government is trying to help the farmers in many ways. A number of efforts have been made to develop agriculture and boost the agriculture production.

Apart from all these schemes, arrangements have been made to enable farmers to sell their produce at any e-mandi across the

country through the e-NAM network. There are facilities for cold storage as well. An immunisation programme for the cattle has been put in place to ensure farmers do not have to spend a lot of money. The govt has also started PM KUSUM (Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evem Utthan) scheme so that the farmers can also become energy-producers and sell it to the grid.

The government is working at three levels to strengthen fisheries - promoting fisheries in villages with financial assistance, modernisation of boats under blue revolution scheme and construction of modern fishing infrastructure. People in the fishing trade have been connected to Kisan Credit Cards.

However, despite the government launching so many schemes to help the farmers, the farmers are committing suicides. Government has reported around 12000 farmer suicides every year since 2013. The main causes for suicides are high costs of fertilizers, crop protection chemicals and even the seeds for cultivation. Costs of agricultural equipments like tractors, submersible pumps, etc. add to already surging costs. Another reason is unpaid loans from local banks. NCRB data points out that in 2474 suicides out of the studied 3000 farmer suicides in 2015 the victims had unpaid loans from local banks.

The schemes and initiatives taken by the government have not been able to bring down the cases of farmers suicides. This means the strategies being followed need to be re-evaluated and implemented in their true sense. To fulfil the Prime Minister Modi's dream of doubling of farmers' income by 2022 into reality, Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) has constituted state-wise coordination committees. The main task of this committee is to prepare extensive strategic documents for making the income of the farmers double. During the last 3 years, ICAR has developed 571 new crop species giving better yield in adverse natural intolerant conditions. Apart from this, the council has developed 11 new bovine species along with better agriculture methods.

Public-Private Partnerships in Preparing the Curriculum for Market- Relevant Skills Development

Youth population comprises nearly half of the global unemployed people and represents the largest ratio in the world history in both absolute and relative numbers. The World Bank reports that 1.3 billion 15-30 year old people live in the developing world and as these young people start stepping into the job market, making them equipped with the needed skills by the marketplace gets imperative.

Shortage of skilled, productive workers and a disparity between the types of skills training offered and the skills needed by industry are among the universally identified constraints that limit investment and economic growth. Retraining to meet new employment opportunities is decisive as well in developing countries, as the emerging markets across the globe necessitate on skilful workers for new jobs generated by these growing economies. Thus, for initial skills development and reskilling, technical and vocational education and training are quintessential.

Bringing the world of education and training to the world of work is what it takes to give the relevant skills training. Training is significant to the needs of businesses and labour markets and by bringing together enterprises, labour, government and trainers at the local, industry and national levels, training can be ensured to be accessible to young people and workers throughout their careers. This partnership enables innovation and technology adaptation and also helps in promoting investment and creating more and better jobs further ensuring that skills drive change.

An overview of India's Position

Being the youngest populations globally, 47.8% of India's population is below 29 years as per statistics which is going to increase to 49.9% in 2021. With the prospect of 365 million people being eligible to join the workforce over the next 15 years, many skill development initiatives were taken traditionally by the government and the establishment of Industrial Training Institutes and Centres were also instigated.

It was in 2009 that the National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) was inaugurated with the mandate of skilling 150 million people by 2022 in 20 focus sectors identified by the government. The informal segment also came to the fore to adopt a three-pronged approach that would revolve around creating, funding and enabling sustainable skills training initiatives in the private space. Around 49 private sector training providers got approval till May 2012 by the NSDC. These sectors emphasized on skill training 67 million people in 21 high growth areas by 2022.

India is speculated to be the third largest economy in the world by 2035 after US and China. As a rapidly growing nation full of opportunities, India has already got the eyes of many global companies set upon it. A dynamic change is experienced in Indian labour market. In spite of growing labour pool, India's major concern lies in employability which points towards the missing link between the formal education system and vocational training. It becomes more challenging with the high school dropout rates and low turnout at the vocational training institutes. Merely 2 % of the Indian workers are formally trained and only 15% of the workers in the manufacturing sector have received in-service training. As per Government of India's report 2007, about 93% of the labour force works in unorganized sector without any formal training.

Changing Path

The Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) in the early years of post-independence India were set up by the government to offer skilled

manpower for fulfilling the needs of country's emerging industrial sector. Besides, the government-run ITIs, private-sector run Industrial Training Centres (ITCs) have also been set up. The growing numbers of both the ITC and ITI have been targeting numerous vocational courses in order to cater to the changing industrial needs.

PPP – Public-Private Partnership – Bringing a Transformation

For the overhaul of the ITIs, in early 2000s the government took to embrace the concept of public-private partnership in the ITIs. The plan was laid out to upgrade 100 ITIs through domestic resources, 400 ITIs with World Bank assistance and the rest of the 1, 396 through PPP modes.

Public- private partnership is envisioned in form of active partaking of industry/ private sector at every stage of design and execution of the scheme. The NSDC was set up as a no-profit-no-loss company through the public-private partnership route to catalyze private sector contribution in the skills area.

Many big corporate groups and educational institutions have realized the significance of setting up skilling ventures of their own and many have also aligned with the NSDC to start skill development ventures.

The project proposals of skill development submitted by these groups to the NSDC orient towards engineering and manufacturing skills majorly. They are thoroughly evaluated on several parameters that encompass the assessment of market demand for trained manpower of targeted sector, comprehensive evaluation of course curriculum with emphasis on practical training to meet industry norms and study model for sourcing trainers and collaborations with various corporates for placement to guarantee the holistic approach of the business model.

Reaching the masses with quality training at reduced costs still remains the biggest challenge and diversity of the states and different

sectors pose another challenge for scaling up of sustainable models.

The Communication Campaign of the NSDC aims at glorifying the pursuit of skills and explaining to all stakeholders how a skilled workforce is extremely important for India to grow and prosper. For the same, many stakeholders will need to be aligned and training organizations will have to build connections with the heart and soul of many young people in the country to tailor their offerings so that their aspirations are met and needs of the employers also get fulfilled simultaneously.

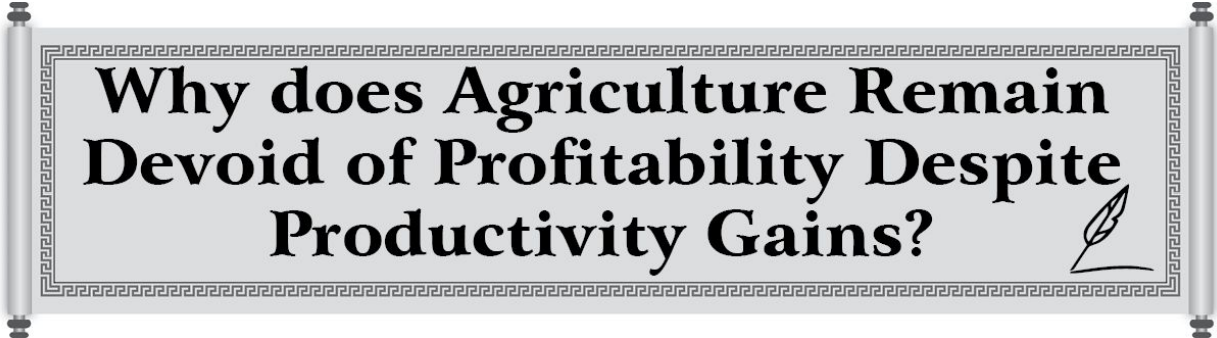
With a proper model in place, the public-private approach can succeed as already the NSDC partners have demonstrated that skill development can become a sustainable business with the prospective of it becoming the largest social enterprise sector. Skill development still needs a strong foothold in India through coordinated approach that involves different areas of government action on workforce participation, social inclusion and innovation. Only through this, the policies on skills can unite with the wider economic, employment and social strategies.

On one hand, an enabling environment needs to be provided by central and state governments and on the other hand, employers and industry have to take the leadership for identifying the competencies and development of competency standards. Then, can they carry out an analysis of skill demand and development of curriculum to further facilitate training of trainers and help in the delivery of training, monitoring and evaluation, participation in affiliation and accreditation process.

All stakeholders must have financial stake in the skills process and industries have to realize that collaborative partnerships involve everyone's benefit. Rather than individual company-related efforts, it is the sectoral model that plans for the workforce development of a sector that fairs well in succeeding.

Leveraging technology by organizations will considerably increase scale, reduce cost and improve learning. A forward looking and outcome based workforce planning will be fruitful and the next best practice should probably be outsourcing to increase return on investment in training and development. Most importantly, rather than being limited to HR/ CSR cells of organizations, the skill development needs to become a CEO-level agenda and should be seen as a serious issue.

Why does Agriculture Remain Devoid of Profitability Despite Productivity Gains?



At the time of independence the condition of Indian agriculture was very dismal, due to the colonial rule. Agriculture sector was totally ignored by the British government; even they didn't have any good policy for the primary sector. The British left India in such a worse condition that the country was unable to feed its own population despite the availability of large cultivable land in India. Initially India was dependent on other countries, especially on United States to fulfil the food requirement of the country. Now, six decades have passed and Indian agriculture sector has achieved milestone in the food production. Today, India has become net food exporter and has successfully stepped out from the tag of food dependent nation.

The first Green Revolution in the 1960s gave thrust to the production of food grains. The major beneficiaries of the first Green Revolution were Punjab, Haryana and Western Uttar Pradesh where the production of wheat increased. Modern technology, methods and equipments were adopted by the farmers in their fields, such as high-yielding varieties of seeds, fertilizers, pesticides and tractors. Irrigation system was developed by the help of the central and state governments. The first Green Revolution in India was led by the agricultural scientist M.S. Swaminathan. Without his efforts, it was difficult to bring such revolution. After the first agricultural revolution, there was a sequence of revolutions in the allied sectors like Yellow Revolution for oilseeds production (during the early 90s). The sudden increase in the production of edible oil was recorded due to the use of hybrid oilseeds like mustard. Further, Grey Revolution helped in

increasing the production of fertilizers, due to which the import of fertilizers was reduced. It also gave a boost to the Green Revolution.

In the later period, government policies supported the farmers and encouraged them to improve their agricultural production. Land reforms were introduced by the government to transfer the land to the actual tillers of the soil. The reforms included:

1. Abolition of intermediaries
2. Tenancy reforms to :-
 - (a) regulate rents paid by tenants to landlords
 - (b) provide security of tenure to tenants
 - (c) confer ownership rights on tenants
3. Imposition of ceilings on holding in a bid to procure land for distribution among landless labourers and marginal farmers.

Rural employment programmes were run to increase the purchasing power of the poor villagers. It also initiated the poverty alleviation programme to enhance the living conditions of the farmers. Fourth Five-Year Plan onwards, programmes like Small Farmer Development Agency, National Rural Employment Programme, Integrated Rural Development Programme and Employment Insurance Scheme were introduced by the government for enhancing the livelihoods of the poor rural people.

National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) was set up for providing institutional credit to the farmers. Further, nationalization of various banks helped in eliminating the role of local moneylenders. The announcement of Procurement and Minimum Support Price (MSP) was done to ensure the fair return to the agricultural products and to provide incentives to the farmers to further expand their production. Farmers could thus not be 'penalized' for their surplus production.

In 1965, Food Corporation of India (FCI) was established under the Food Corporation Act, 1964 in order to fulfil three major requirements.

- (1) effective price support operation for safeguarding the interests of the farmers.
- (2) distribution of food grains throughout the country for public distribution.
- (3) maintaining satisfactory level of operational and buffer stock of food grains to ensure national food security.

In the past six decades, the government took major steps at policy level and also farmers changed their traditional methods of farming. Even, many farmers started practising organic farming, yet lots of problems are still present in the agricultural sector and lot of work is to be done by the government. If a farmer grows surplus agricultural product, but is not able to gain the fair price of his produce then at times this situation leads to loss to the farmers. For example, in off-season, prices of tomato go up to even Rs.100 per kg but in the season of tomato, it is available at Rs.20 per kg and so and if the production is at record level, then the prices may decrease to Rs. 2 or 3 per kg. In this situation, the farmers who have cultivated tomatoes face huge loss and they cannot even earn their minimum production cost.

Under the Minimum Support Price, very few crops are included such as rice, wheat, pulses to name a few. Even under this scheme, small farmers are unable to take the advantage. Red-tapeism and the role of middleman lead to corrupt practices and the farmers do not get the real value of their crops. In the remote areas, there is lack of basic amenities, infrastructure, cold storage facility and warehouse facility.

The cold storage even if available, are out of reach of the small and marginal farmers. Due to lack of storage facilities, the farmers are thus forced to sell their produce at very minimal rates. If they do not do so, their produce is at a risk of getting spoilt due to rain or unhygienic open conditions. The godowns of FCI are already

overloaded and there is additional burden of food storage which leads to spillage and deterioration of food crops if stacked haphazardly.

People involved in black marketing buy huge stock at very low prices from the farmers to store them and create an artificial shortage in the market. Thus, when the demand increases leading to the rise in price, then these black marketers release these stocks at their self-determined prices and earn huge profits.

Moreover, farmers are in the habit of overusing the fertilizers assuming that it will yield them huge crops. But, this has led to the decline in competitiveness of such crops in international market, especially in Europe and America as these countries are more inclined towards organic food. For example, few years back Alfonso mango was banned by some European countries.

Government is still working to solve the structural issues related to agricultural sector. For example, e-NAM trading platform or National Agriculture Market has been launched to eliminate the role of intermediaries and help farmers in better price discovery. It also provides facilities for smooth marketing of their produce and facilitates online trading. Further, Soil Health Card introduced by the centre has helped to keep a check on the soil quality and incentivize the farmers based on their soil productivity. Doubling of farmers' income by 2020 and minimum income support scheme for the poor and marginal farmers by providing Rs 6000 annually to those having less than 2 hectares of land, are progressive steps.

Much needs to be done to create awareness to treat agriculture as a profession and not merely a substitute. Contract farming has so far benefitted the farmers and so it should be promoted further to bring better results. A 24/7 helpline must be launched in regional languages so that farmers can get the information of the market anytime. Farmers and rural youth should be given training to use modern equipments and technology such as smart phones so that they can get benefits of different apps related to agriculture.

Waste Management in India



While the rapid pace of urbanisation in India bodes well for the individuals looking to move to cities from villages, it presents significant challenges for the environment. As more and more individuals are moving to the cities, the infrastructure is struggling to keep up with this rapid influx. Thus, a serious environmental challenge comes up due to lag in infrastructure development, and that is huge mountains of open and untreated waste/garbage. Across all major cities of India, it is a common sight to see huge mountains of solid waste at the dumping grounds as well as at the beaches. India is generating more than 1.50 lakh MT solid waste every day, out of which almost 90% is the collected waste. Even though it is not desirable for India to stop its giant strides towards becoming a \$5 trillion economy but is essential to strike a balance between economic goals as well as environmental responsibilities. Achieving this goal is not possible without a well-planned waste management strategy in place.

Waste Management: Magnitude of the Problem

With a steady rise in population, the waste generation rates in India are rising. Here are some important facts that highlight the magnitude of the problem: -

- As per the report published by the Ministry of Environment, Forests, and Climate Change in the year 2016-17, a total of out of the 5.4 crore MT solid waste generated in India every year, almost 90% goes unprocessed and keeps rotting in the landfill sites.

- Another report published by United Nations in 2016, India produced 20 lakh MT of e-waste. Out of which only 0.7% was processed.
- Out of the 7.17 million MT hazardous wastes generated, only 49.4% was recycled.
- A report published by the government also mentioned that at times, the total unprocessed waste at dumping sites reaches over 3 crore MT, most of which is highly polluting in nature.
- Out of the total waste collected only 20% is being processed whereas the remaining 80% is being dumped at landfill sites.
- As per government figures, India generates 94 lakh tonnes of plastic trash every year which is a major cause of pollution.

As India is taking giant strides towards achieving the status of a developed economy, the pace of annual waste generation is expected to rapidly increase. Without a concrete waste management plan in place, the environmental costs of this development are going to be monumental.

The developed countries like US, UK, Germany, France, etc. have excellent waste collection coverage. But when it comes to cities in India, especially with a significant low-income group population, the situation is alarming. As per a report by WHO, over 90% of waste is dumped in unregulated dumping grounds or even worse, is burned in the open. These practices are leading to various health, environment, and safety-related issues.

The Necessity of Waste Management

Unregulated dumping grounds and open burning of waste is causing various problems that if not addressed, will become severe in future. Here are the major challenges presented by poor waste management planning: -

- When waste is dumped in open grounds and in the shape of mounds, it leads to generation of methane gas. Not only can

methane gas cause serious health issues if inhaled, it also causes a greenhouse effect leading to global warming.

- Poor waste management and open dumping grounds are breeding grounds for disease vectors like mosquitoes and flies during the monsoon season in India. These vectors then roam around freely carrying along with major health risks.
- Ineffective waste collection and waste disposal is causing various environmental problems such as water pollution and soil pollution. In many cities and rural areas in India, many people still rely on groundwater for their daily needs. Using such contaminated water can cause serious health issues.
- Open burning of waste is one of the biggest contributors to rising levels of air pollution in Indian cities. When people breathe such air, they have a higher chance of falling sick. With access to quality medical care still difficult for a large section of the population, it can turn into a serious problem.
- Working with industrial waste, healthcare waste, and metallic waste poses various types of health and safety-related hazards for individuals who work near them.

The social and financial cost of unplanned waste management is too high to ignore. Therefore, the need of the hour is the creation of a well-planned waste management strategy to stop the situation from aggravating.

Essential Components of a Waste Management Strategy

It is imperative for the central as well as state governments to have a waste management plan in place to control the spread of this menace. There are some useful strategies that can help with the management of waste in urban centres. Here are the essential components of a sound waste management plan: -

- Reducing waste generation: - The essential component is reducing the levels of waste generation. Government agencies at various

levels, central as well as municipal, must prepare plans to reduce the quantity of waste generated in a particular region. For instance, in India, the central government has banned the use of single-use plastic in the country since October 2019. This step has helped substantially reduce the use of single-use plastic products and has encouraged people to look for more eco-friendly options.

- Improved collection and disposal: - It is imperative for governments as well as people themselves to ensure proper collection and disposal of waste. Having separate bins for dry waste and wet waste or bio-degradable or non-biodegradable waste can help the municipal agencies with proper disposal of the waste. Recyclable products can be recycled and reused while non-recyclable products can be disposed of in a safe manner. For instance, in cities like Chandigarh and Panchkula, municipal authorities have made it compulsory for residents as well as commercial enterprises to have separate bins for wet and dry waste. Non-compliance would lead to fines which act as a deterrent.
- Use of biodegradable materials: - It is important to encourage the use of bio-degradable materials instead of non-biodegradable ones. This goal can be achieved by educating people about the hazards of non-biodegradable materials and at the same time restricting their production and distribution.
- Creation of bio-fuel: - Fuel imports are a big expense for an energy-hungry country like India. Instead of spending billions of dollars on using fossil fuels, which have negative effects on the environment, the government entities, as well as private entities, should contemplate using bio-fuel. With the help of anaerobic biosolid digestion systems, methane gas can be captured from land-fill solid waste and then can be used for cooking, heating, as well as power generation. This strategy will also reduce the quantity of methane released in the environment and reduce the greenhouse effect.

- Citizen engagement: - No strategy for waste management can be successful with the active engagement of the citizens of the country. The government must launch mass campaigns to make people aware of the benefits of proper waste management and how they can contribute to this cause. Relating waste management with national welfare is bound to induce co-operation from the people. Swachh Bharat Campaign launched by the Prime Minister is an excellent example. Now that cities are given a “Swachh Rank” according to their waste management performance, there is a rise in awareness amongst people pertaining to the management of the waste.
- Legal Checks: - Legal checks must be put in place against open burning of waste or improper dumping of the waste. Proper overseeing mechanisms must be put in place to ensure management of landfill sites. If required, industries could be fined for not having waste management systems in place.

The environmental and social problems caused due to the absence of waste management planning are a cause of serious concern. There is a need for collective efforts between the central and state authorities to address this problem and handle the challenges posed by it.

Water Scarcity in India



With almost 75% of earth covered with water, one might assume that humans are never going to face scarcity of water. But, all the water in the oceans is saline and non-potable. Neither can it be used for drinking nor for agriculture. Humans require freshwater for all these tasks, which are incredibly rare. Hence, only 3% of the total water available on Earth is potable. Out of this 3%, almost 66% is stored in the form of glaciers or is otherwise not available for use. With the steadily rising population, rampant abuse of groundwater sources, incessant pollution of rivers, and rapidly depleting sources of freshwater, India is looking at a crisis. A crisis which can manifest itself over the next decade and could escalate tensions for rights over water sources with neighbouring countries. Yes, water crisis in India is a reality and is already knocking on our doors. If necessary actions are not taken right now, the situation is only going to aggravate.

Water Stress & Water Scarcity: Two Sides of the Same Coin

Water stress is a broader term and is a more inclusive concept; it signifies an imbalance between available water resources and the rate of usage. It is the ability or the lack of freshwater required to meet human and ecological demands. As more wastewater is being generated and dispersed in the present times, the environmental impacts of the same are profound.

- The major reason behind the water scarcity being faced by India is the fact that three consecutive years of weak monsoons have

pushed almost 25% of the population or 33 crore people towards drought.

- As per latest reports by Niti Aayog in 2018, 21 major cities of India, including Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Chennai, etc. might face the situation of zero groundwater levels by as early as 2020.
- Excessive pumping of ground water and inefficient recycling systems have already pushed 12% population towards 'Day Zero' crisis.
- By 2030, the demand for water in India will be twice the available supply, which might result in GDP loss of up to 6%.
- Lack of proper infrastructure results in 40% loss of piped water in major cities.
- With India's population expected to increase to 1.6 billion by 2050, the demand for potable water is going to increase substantially. Moreover, rapid progress in terms of industrialisation and urbanisation will also put unprecedented pressure on water resources and lead to environmental issues.

Water Scarcity: Impact on Health

To put things in perspective, it is important to look at the impact of the water crisis on human health in numerical terms: -

- Children in more than 100 million homes in India lack access to fresh water and as a result suffer from malnutrition.
- Due to lack of proper water treatment facilities in India, ground water resources are contaminated with chemicals and biological pollutants.
- Only 33% of the total population of India has presently access to hygienic sanitation facilities.
- More than 21% of diseases affecting Indian citizens are water-borne diseases.
- It is estimated that by 2030, almost 40% of the population will have no access to drinking water.

- Diarrhoea killed more people (60%) in India as compared to any other water borne diseases. As per reports, India lost 73 million working days due to water-related health issues.

Impact of Water Crisis

The water crisis in its present form has been responsible for various problems affecting India. Apart from health-related implications of water scarcity, the other issues that are being caused by the prevailing water crisis are:

- **Agricultural crisis:** - Out of the available freshwater, almost 66% is used for agricultural requirements, 10% is being used by households, 20% is used by industries and 4% is lost in transit. Due to increase in population as well as per capita consumption of freshwater, the menace of water scarcity has become even more potent in India. When this combines with seasonal variations in availability of water, the freshwater required for agricultural as well as industrial processes is becoming scarce.
- **Environmental crisis:** - The increase in per capita as well as overall usage of water by Indians, has a profound impact on industrial as well as agricultural development. Moreover, excessive usage or wastage of water by humans is having a disastrous effect on aquatic ecosystems and species residing in them. When the ecological balances are disturbed, the essential role they play in regulating the aquatic ecosystems cannot be performed, possibly leading to a bigger environmental disaster.
- **Geopolitical crisis:** - With various river basins being shared by India with its neighbouring countries, the scarcity of water can lead to flaring of tensions which might develop into a war-like situation. In most cases, there are no proper agreements or institutions in place governing the distribution of water. As a result, in case of any one-sided action, tensions can escalate between the neighbouring countries. This is detrimental not only to world peace but to the much needed regional collaboration also to fight this crisis.

Water Scarcity: What is the Answer?

It is important that corrective measures are taken before the situation worsens. Thankfully, the Jal Shakti Ministry is creating awareness regarding the limited freshwater resources being available and how to tackle the problems at hand. Some of the steps which can be taken to improve the situation are: -

- Optimum utilisation of water: - Whether it is households, industry or agriculture, it is possible to save water across all users. There is a need to change the tendency of wasting water amongst people living in areas with plentiful water. Changes in lifestyle and food habits can also go a long way in ensuring optimum utilisation of water. For instance, while in order to produce 1 kg of rice, almost 3500 litres water is required, the water required to produce 1kg of potatoes is only 100 litres.
- Waste-water recycling: - It is important to ensure that industrial units do not contaminate freshwater sources with the disposal of their waste-water. In fact, local authorities should put systems in place to make it mandatory for commercial users to recycle water and install ETPs (Effluent Treatment Plants) to process industrial waste before disposing of it.
- Rainwater harvesting: - Regions facing scarcity of drinking water should undertake rainwater harvesting by building community ponds and reservoirs. As most of the rainwater otherwise goes into the sea and oceans, harvesting it and saving it for future use can solve a lot of problems.
- Improved transboundary cooperation: - Transboundary issues should be transformed into transboundary cooperation to ensure optimum utilisation of water resources. India and the neighbouring countries should undertake initiatives towards joint water management.

While the challenges posed by water scarcity are huge, but it is still possible to manage the crisis. All it requires is strong determination and concerted efforts by all stakeholders.

Urban Pollution in India : A National Crisis



Pollution has always been regarded as a silent killer for its effects take time to show but by the time they become visible, much damage has been done. India is amongst the fastest growing economies in the world. The benefits of this rapid economic growth have started to trickle down, and people at grassroots are now also seeing its benefits. This economic growth has also led to expansion of urban areas with more people being added to urban areas every year. Better infrastructure, career opportunities, healthcare facilities, and overall better standards of living are a big draw for rural population to move to urban centres.

This demographic shift has brought along with it a major challenge, i.e. Urban Pollution. Over the past few years, a series of air pollution-related episodes have unravelled the true extent of this menace. Air quality levels in the country have touched severe+ levels in northern cities. Such dangerous has been the level of $PM_{2.5}$ in the air that it led to closure of schools, intensive media coverage, Suo-moto cognizance by the Supreme Court of India, and declaration of public health emergency in various cities.

Urban Pollution in India: The Real Picture

The gravity of the matter can be understood by the simple fact that extreme air pollution in India has become a new season on its own. Events unravel in the same manner every year, and the apathy of multiple state governments has only led to a worsening of the situation. The peak air pollution season starts just before the festive season in October and continues till February. Here are some

startling facts about the situation that has now become a national crisis: -

- The $PM_{2.5}$ levels in the NCR region are so high that experts estimate that between the time kids leave their home and come back, i.e. approximately 7 hours, they are exposed to pollutions levels that are equivalent to smoking 60 cigarettes. Worse is the fate of people from underprivileged sections of the society who are exposed to the pollutants for their entire day.
- As per a recent report published by the Health Effects Institute, that if no serious measures are taken, the annual deaths from air pollution in India will rise from 11 lakhs in 2015 to 17 Lakhs in 2030 and 36 Lakhs by the year 2050. Such a scenario will also spell doom for the economy and pull down India's GDP by almost 1%.
- As per a report published by Bloomberg, out of the 30 most polluted cities in the world, 14 cities are in India. While China has improved drastically and has now only 5 cities in the list of 30 most polluted cities.
- When one considers only the levels of $PM_{2.5}$, the performance of Indian cities worsens as there are 14 Indian cities in the list of top 20 polluted cities. When it comes to PM_{10} particles, the situation is equally bad. A higher concentration of PM_{10} particles is attributed to a major cause for climate change. Out of 30 worst cities for PM_{10} levels, India has 8 entries in the list.
- Air pollution in India kills far more people than the number of people dying from accidents or terrorism. The situation is worsened by the indifference of government agencies at multiple levels. But the brunt has to be borne by the common public.

Reasons for Rising Urban Pollution

Various reasons can be attributed to this consistent rise in the levels of pollution in the urban centres of India, such as: -

- Unregulated construction activities: - Due to the rising population in the Indian cities, the construction activity is in full swing. It is a

common sight to see an old building being demolished and new buildings being constructed. But what might miss the eye is the heaps of rubble and uncovered dust, which when blown away by the winds mixes with the air and leads to higher density of particulate matter.

- **Dirty fuels:** - To keep up with the rising demands of the urban population, industries are running overtime. Lack of knowledge and proper infrastructure leads to fumes and smoke being released in the air without proper treatment. The soot and carbon particles in the industrial smoke are responsible for various lung-related ailments.
- **Vehicle Pollution:** - While the government has mandated PUC (Pollution under Control) check for every vehicle, most people do not follow the guidelines. As a result, there are many vehicles on city roads that release toxic fumes in the air worsening the already bad situation.
- **Farm fires:** - Farm fires are a common occurrence in north Indian states of Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh. When the stubbles are burnt to prepare the land for the upcoming sowing season, it releases huge amounts of smoke in the air. The slow wind speed does not allow the smoke to dissipate and traps the pollutants. It ultimately leads to increase in the concentration of pollutants in the air.
- **Geographical factors:** - The problem of urban pollution is not entirely man-made; there are some geographical forces also behind the scenes.

The slow speed of the wind in winter season does not allow dissipation of pollutants. The inversion of temperature layer traps the pollutants, pushing up their concentration to dangerous levels.

As the Indo-Gangetic plain is landlocked, the Himalayas stop the polluted air from leaving the region and also leading to convergence of wind that traps pollutants.

Loose unconsolidated particles of alluvium in northern regions of the country contribute to the increased concentration of dust particles in the air.

What should be done?

There is a need for a well-planned strategy to tackle this ever-worsening menace of air pollution in India. Cosmetic measures like odd-even or blame-game between the states are not going to help matters. There is a need to see some collective action on the ground where different agencies get together and fight this menace. The action needs to be taken not only in cities but in villages as well. Some of the ways in which the menace of urban pollution can be controlled are: -

- Usage of clean cooking stoves: - Majority of rural households still use traditional wood-fired stoves. These stoves generate a lot of smoke, adding up to a significant amount of air pollution. Replacing these cooking stoves with cleaner options will help in reducing the level of air pollution and also improve the health of the villagers.
- Reuse of farm stubble: - Farmers burn leftover crop stubbles as the cost of removal is higher than reusing it. The government needs to incentivise the farmers and encourage them to not burn the crop residue but instead either mix it in the soil or sell it in the open market.
- Regulating construction activities: - There is a need to regulate construction activity in urban centres. Proper guidelines are required regarding disposal and management of the rubble to prevent dust from mixing in the air.
- Ban on burning of waste: - There should be proper recycling facilities to manage the increasing levels of waste in urban centres. It will help in controlling the instances of open burning of waste which is a major cause of urban pollution.

- Promoting cleaner fuels: - Bio-diesel and other cleaner fuels should be promoted, and the usage of diesel as a vehicle fuel should be regulated.

There is a need for government agencies at various levels to work together to fight this menace. While efforts are being taken but more efforts are required. There is no scope for delay as the situation will only get worse with time.

Why the International Solar Alliance is Geopolitically Significant to India



With the steadily rising population, the rapid pace of industrialisation in developing countries, wide fluctuations in prices of crude oil, the need for harnessing the alternative sources of energy has become imperative. Presently the entire world is going through a “tectonic shift” in the patterns of energy consumption. Countries are now exploring the scope of using “clean and affordable” sources of energy which are essential to maintain sustainable security. This united move towards embracing renewable energy has various geopolitical consequences, and solar energy has emerged as the most important cog in the wheel of move towards renewable and sustainable sources of energy. It is getting attention from subject-matter experts as well as policymakers for its easy availability and excellent affordability. This very realisation and its global acceptance laid the groundwork for establishment of the International Solar Alliance (ISA).

International Solar Alliance and India

Being one of the biggest consumers for energy sources, India has always been looking for more affordable and sustainable sources of energy. Price and availability of energy sources have always been a pivotal political and social matter. As a result, India took the initiative of establishing the International Solar Alliance in partnership with France. These two friendly countries are major economic powers as well as leading energy consumers in the world. Both India and France initiated the development of framework for International Solar Alliance during the Paris Climate Convention. As two major economies laid the foundation for the ISA, the entire world took notice. This

development reflected the urgent need for establishing a robust global body that can satisfy the dual goals of integration and adaptation of energy resources to battle the menace of climate change.

The then general secretary of the United Nations, Mr Ban Ki Moon praised the initiative taken by India in partnership with France. He described this development as an event that has the potential to save lives, improve human well-being, and promote global peace. When India led this initiative with France, some detractors cast aspersions over the potential of this initiative. But since then 122 countries have joined the International Solar Alliance with smaller countries like Sudan and Fiji getting equal representation on the matter along with advanced economies in France and Australia. This is a big step towards global partnership in addressing the problem of global warming and climate change.

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the first meeting of the ISA partner nations in the month of October 2018, he hailed ISA as a giant step towards ensuring “One World, One Sun, and One Grid.” The Indian Prime Minister further elaborated that he is optimistic that the International Solar Alliance will become the “Alternative OPEC.” The views expressed by Mr Narendra Modi can be substantiated from the very fact that even Saudi Arabia, the world’s leading energy supplier, has also joined the ISA. It reaffirms the importance of ISA and how it is fast becoming the global platform for equitable distribution and production of energy sources. All these developments reaffirmed India’s rising status in global matters and presented a great opportunity to lead the biggest global energy revolution in history.

India, ISA and Geopolitics

While the recognition and wide acceptance that International Solar Alliance has received globally is a noteworthy development in itself but the way it has given India a chance to lead the world into a shift

towards renewable energy has several geopolitical ramifications for the country.

- Energy security: - Along with China, India is one of the fastest-growing economies in the world. In order to sustain this pace of development, it is important for India to ensure steady availability of energy sources. But there are various challenges being posed by traditional sources of energy which have necessitated it for India to move gradually towards renewable energy sources like solar energy.
- The middle-east region is the biggest supplier of non-renewable energy resources for India. But the regional conflicts between key supplier nations have been putting India's energy supplies in jeopardy. Take conflict between Iran and Saudi Arabia for instance. When a drone, believed to be originated from Iran, bombed an ARAMCO facility in Saudi Arabia, global tensions flared up. While the Saudi Government ensured India that the supplies wouldn't be affected, the markets went crashing due to panic.
- The sanctions imposed by the US on India's major oil suppliers like Iran and Venezuela have led to an increase in the cost of purchase, pushing prices upwards. This increase in the cost of energy resources can derail the Indian growth story.
- The US is also mulling actions against Russia, another key energy partner for India.
- Any delay in the supplies or increase in the global energy prices has serious political ramifications for the country.

By shifting to renewable sources of energy like solar energy, India can significantly reduce its dependence on non-renewable sources. As the situation in the global oil market is very precarious, India cannot afford to delay the move. This will not only offer greater energy security to the country but will also help in achieving climate change targets.

- Global peace and security: - Being one of the G 20 member nations, India has a great responsibility to ensure global peace and security. Various reports have been published attributing most global conflicts to the quest to establish control over oil and gas reserves. Whether it be World War I, World War II, Cold War or Iran-Iraq war, the root cause behind the conflict has been attributed to the demand for energy. Presently, many radical organisations like Boko Haram in Nigeria, ISIS in Iraq and Syria, and religious extremists in the North Caucasus region fund their operations through oil. As a matter of fact, even many countries offered support to these organisations to further their ulterior motives or protect themselves from the organisations. India being home to various minorities living peacefully cannot afford to be seen as a perpetrator of global conflicts or atrocities being inflicted on people from a particular religion. Inaction on India's part can create problems at home. If the ISA, led by India and France, is able to promote usage of solar energy, it would significantly reduce the global dependence on energy from the disturbed regions., helping in reducing the threat posed by religious extremism and radicalisation.
- Economic benefits: - By moving towards solar energy, India can reduce its dependence on imports from West Asian countries. This will help India save a lot of foreign exchange, thereby giving a boost to the value of the Indian rupee and also expand the economy further. India is helping volatile countries like Afghanistan and Uzbekistan to tap the solar energy for their development. During the recent visit of Indian President Mr Ram Nath Kovind to Bolivia, Bolivia expressed to join the ISA and engage further with India for jointly developing Lithium batteries.

These developments demonstrate that solar energy co-operation is indeed the way forward for establishing an equal and just energy order in the world. Moreover, it is a big step towards "Global South" where countries in the southern hemisphere like India, will lead the world towards a better future.

Renewable Energy for a Greener Future: Development & Challenges



Fossil fuel sources such as oil, gas and coal produce greenhouse gases which are responsible for climate change and global warming. Climate change and global warming causes negative impacts and has devastating consequences on the biodiversity and ecosystems, existence and survival of human beings.

More importantly, the growing demand for electricity, heating, cooling, and transportation is leading to the inexorable rise in the emission of greenhouse gases which represent a significant challenge worldwide. Therefore, the reduction of greenhouse gases emissions to mitigate climate change has turned out to be an essential concern for the entire world, almost for every citizen and nation. On the other hand, reserves of oil, gas, coal and other fossil fuels are diminishing. Consequently, the constant and uninterrupted supply of oil, gas other fossil fuels at an affordable price remains a serious global concern.

Renewable energy has turned out to be an essential part of every economy and nation. Energy generated from solar, wind, biomass, thermal, hydro and other sources are considered as renewable energy.

Globally, numerous International organizations have advocated, proposed and adopted various policy initiatives to shift to renewable energy such as solar, geothermal, biomass, wind, hydro-power and others. Comparatively these renewable energy sources are reported to be more sustainable, cleaner, and less pollutant.

Renewable Energy Advocates

United Nations (UN) Stockholm Declaration on the Human Environment 1972 became the forum for the first and formal discussions about Renewable energy in the world. The world leaders have expressed their concerns about the depletion of fossil fuel reserves and emphasized on renewable energy. There onwards, several international bodies, forums, non-governmental organizations have been established to focus and promote renewable energy in the context of global warming. Subsequently, several initiatives were undertaken by the United Nations, the United Nations Environment Program, the World Meteorological Organization and other international organizations.

Since late 1970s, a number of initiatives and conventions that focussed and stressed on renewable energy are: World Commission on Environment and Development Report 1987, Nairobi Program of Action for the Development and Utilization of New and Renewable Sources of Energy 1981, Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change 1988, United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (Rio Earth Summit) 1992, the Conference of the Parties (COP), Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement, etc.

In December 2012, the United Nations General Assembly unanimously declared year '2012' as the "International Year of Sustainable Energy for All". Furthermore, designated the decade '2014-2024' as the "Decade of Sustainable Energy for All", underscoring the importance of renewable energy for sustainable development agenda. Renewable energy is essential for achieving the United Nation's millennium development goals and for opening up new opportunities for growth and prosperity worldwide.

The million-dollar question

"How do we develop and adapt to alternative, clean, affordable and renewable energy predominantly to arrest the climate change and to substitute fossil fuels?" still remains a million-dollar question.

Despite extensive research over the decades, not a single energy source that is powerful enough to replace oil and gas is produced.

Scientists now turned emphasis on integrating a wide range of renewable energy sources known as "renewable energy hybrid" that can be powerful enough, work in tandem to accelerate the transition towards more sustainable energy. Renewable energy hybrid solutions will be increasingly used provided the alternative energy is efficient, low-cost and possible to switch smoothly between different renewable energy sources. The most prosperous countries of the future will also be the ones that adapt to the most sustainable energies. Despite the positive outlook, the worldwide demand for renewable energy has been very slow.

India's Renewable Energy Capacity and Ambitions

Nearly 90 percent of the power in India is generated through conventional energy sources using fossil fuels, which contribute heavily to global warming. However, the good news is that the Indian power sector is witnessing a revolution about generating electricity from various renewable energy sources and registered commendable progress. India's installed capacity has grown six times in the last decade. Solar power has seen its capacity grow around 12 times. The present government had set a target of 175 gigawatts of the installed renewable energy capacity of which 100 gigawatts in solar energy, 60 gigawatts in wind energy and 25 gigawatts in biomass and hydel energy. However, the country's installed capacity of renewable energy is 22 percent of the country's total installed capacity for power generation. At this pace, the central government's ambitious target of having 175 gigawatts of installed capacity by March 2022 may not be achieved. India's renewable energy capacity is expected to reach 150 gigawatts by 2024.

Renewable energy is vital to India's commitment under the Paris Agreement on climate change. Along with world countries, India has committed to reducing its carbon emissions from 2005 levels, relative to the GDP by 2030. India is the world's third-largest emitter of

greenhouse gases, set a higher target; 40 percent of its total installed power capacity to be in renewable energy by 2030.

Various Governments have extended support, schemes, incentives, tax rebates and sops favouring renewable energy sector. Various schemes were introduced by governments in the last decade, like Jawaharlal Nehru National Solar Mission, Modified Special Incentive Package Scheme, National Manufacturing Policy, Make in India, etc.

Key Challenges

The wind energy in India has been experiencing low demand over the last two years, though it has grown at a steady pace in the past decade. Hence, the manufacturing capacity for wind energy has remained underutilized. Solar photovoltaic also falls short of targets set by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy.

In the case of solar power, distance is a major constraint for the planned long-range transmission due to the power purchase agreements under the auctions of solar power. And at present, India lacks affordable storage facilities for renewable energy.

There is some incompatibility with respect to the number of demand centres and the available corridors, due to the lack of an effective plan and dedicated infrastructure for renewable energy evacuation.

There are a few challenges that affect the grid integration of wind and solar energy in India. Grid operators and generation owners face major technical issues, such as uncontrolled variability. There are insufficient flexible base-load options that can balance the non-firm nature of renewable power. The problem with solar energy and wind farms is, they do not deliver the same amount of continuous electricity compared with traditional power plants. The grid operators must be able to predict how strong the wind will blow exactly or the sun will shine in order to match traditional energy sources.

Renewable energy storage technology is still not affordable and will take another five years for it to be viable. If power storage becomes

easily available at affordable cost, power generation from renewable sources will pick up and make it win the race over fossil fuels, albeit rather slowly.

E-waste: The Dark Side of the Tech Revolution



As mobile phones become smarter and computers and other devices become even more advanced and efficient, the disadvantage of technological revolution will continue to throw up problems and challenges. Electronic waste is one of the issues that has a global impact. India is generating mountains of electronic waste from discarded computer equipment, mobile phones to other electronic goods. India is ranked fourth in the world among top e-waste producing countries. Our country accumulates nearly two million tonnes of hazardous e-waste annually which poses severe consequences for public health and environment. There was a sharp rise in manufacturing and consumption of electronic products in India in the past decade and continue to rise with a threefold increase in the next decade. So, has electronic waste as India's e-waste grown five-fold in a decade?

The lion's share of India's e-waste comes from the unorganised sector and small units which do not have the logistics and state-of-the-art facilities to handle and recycle the e-waste. They have been dumping the waste into the rivers and water streams, causing irreparable damage to the surrounding environment. This will only serve to make matters worse.

India contributes five percent of the world's e-waste annually. Computer equipment and mobile telephones are the leading electronic waste generators in India. Computer equipment consists of three fourth of the total electronic waste generated in India, while mobile phones and telecommunication equipment accounts for 15 percent and e-waste from discarded televisions, refrigerators account

for remaining 10 percent. Among metro cities, Mumbai ranked first as it produces more than 1.5 lakh tonnes of e-waste annually. Delhi and Bengaluru are second and third most electronic waste generating cities.

Global Problem

India is not alone in facing the severe challenge concerning electronic waste. The world as a whole is experiencing environmental damage and health problems. Electronic waste has become another global issue. Worldwide, 50 million tonnes of e-waste is generated annually. The United States stood first in e-waste generation, and China became the second most e-waste generating country.

Only about a quarter of the world's electronic waste is collected and recycled. Computers, printers, mobile phones, consumer electronics and other electronic gadgets are spreading rapidly across the globe. More than 5 billion people in the world own mobile devices, and mobile phone users worldwide will increase to 7.5 billion by 2024. In India, usage of electronic devices has registered a stupendous growth in the last five years. Unlike the Radios and Transistors of the 80s, the electronic devices come with short self-life. They do not last very long because users tend to upgrade and replace with advanced products, and here comes the problem. The discarded devices are being swept into huge piles of electronic waste which poses a grave threat to the environment and humans alike. Electronic waste causes toxic emissions and poses several health hazards. Notably, electronic waste from old computer equipment increased by 200 to 400 percent from 2007 levels. Globally, 70 percent of heavy metals found in landfills are accounted for by electronic waste.

There is an urgency for overhauling the process and establishing regulated and standardised procedures for collecting and managing electronic waste across the world.

Greed Outstrips Need

The majority of electronic waste from developed countries is exported to third world countries in Africa and Asia. The e-waste recipient countries lack sophisticated technology and skills. As a result, they are indulging in crude and manual manner of disposal of the e-waste, which is causing damage to the environment and human health.

Moreover, most electronic waste in India, China and other developing countries is improperly handled due to various reasons. Electronic waste recycling in most developing nations is left to the vagaries of the informal sector and backyard recyclers. The majority of electronic waste is incinerated by rag pickers and unprofessional recyclers to recover valuable metals. However, during the process, e-waste releases far-reaching toxic gases and pollution. They manage to extract a meagre quantity of metal compared to state-of-the-art recycling plants. The Basel Convention, an international treaty introduced to prevent global dumping of hazardous e-waste. The convention brought in stringent procedures to protect the environment as well as labour.

Goldmines or Landfills?

The modern mobile phones and laptops, computer equipment, are made of using 60 wide ranges of elements comprising both precious metals and hazardous elements like lead and mercury. For example, the manufacturing of personal computers and mobile phones alone consumes ten percent of gold and silver, 30 percent cobalt and palladium mined worldwide. These 60 different elements are closely interlinked in electronic parts, and this requires specialised, cost-effective metallurgical processes with extensive treatment to recover gold and other metals. Unfortunately, precious metals like gold, silver, copper, indium, and palladium reaching the landfills as the backyard recyclers lack the skill and facilities to recover the entire quantity of metals from e-waste. Currently, only a small portion of e-waste is collected and directed into state-of-the-art recycling plants. Significant improvements are needed here to fully utilise this secondary metal resource.

Finding an Opportunity within a Problem

The good news is that dozens of e-waste recycling companies have emerged to boost the e-waste recycling industry and to help corporates and business enterprises to manage discarded devices and other electronic waste. The governments must invest in creating awareness of e-waste and its repercussions and also introduce various sops to encourage the e-waste recycling companies and firms which are actively getting their discarded equipment recycled. Electronic equipment companies can choose to extend the life of a device while manufacturing to produce devices that last longer. However, technology is a lifecycle issue. No matter how highly durable is an electronic device, the temptation to possess the latest model in the end-users is increasing day by day.

Electronic equipment manufacturing companies must use the discarded devices and refurbish as per the latest technology. Individual customers and corporates can choose to buy the refurbished computer equipment and mobile phones that look brand new, latest and at the same time inexpensive, too. Corporate companies can donate the discarded computers, printers and other equipment to not for profit organisations, schools and to the less privileged. This way, the life of a device can be prolonged by a few years, which in turn protects the environment. To encourage such practices, The Basel Action Network has introduced a global certification programme known by 'e-Stewards' to ensure that used electronic equipments are being refurbished or disposed of in the most responsible, eco-friendly and secure manner.

India's Environment Agencies, Pollution Control Boards

In March 2018, the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change amended the E-Waste Management Rules 2016. As per the act, collection, storage, transportation, segregation, refurbishment, dismantling, recycling and disposal of e-waste shall be in accordance with the guidelines published by the Central Pollution Control Board. Under rule 21 (2) of the act, the manufacturer, importer, transporter,

refurbisher, dismantler and recycler shall be liable to pay financial penalties as levied under the provisions of the Environment (Protection) Act 1986 by the State Pollution Control Boards. As per the amended act, the Central Pollution Control Board continuously conduct random sampling of electrical and electronic equipment placed in the market to monitor and verify the compliance of toxic substances.

The unprofessional handling of e-waste not only damages our environment and creates health problems but also becomes a hurdle in employment generation. The governments and environment agencies, pollution control boards, must step in and employ various strategies, pass stringent laws and implement uniform guidelines in the e-waste handling and recycling. The central and state governments must consider including the e-waste handling and recycling to the Skill India scheme. Given the specialised skills and technology, infrastructure and investment, the governments across states required to create proper facilities for efficient and environmentally-friendly recycling of e-waste.

Stubble Burning & Air Pollution in North India



The World Health Organisation's slogan for the World No Tobacco Day 2019 is "Tobacco and Lung health" The irony is that breathing the air in most Indian cities is like smoking 40 cigarettes a day. The hazardous air pollutants effect is known to impact northern India, due to a weave of atmospheric seasonal factors and human factors like crop fires, burning of stubble, etc.

WHO Air Quality Guidelines

More than 75% of the urban population and 85% of the world population is exposed to air pollution levels that exceed the thresholds limits of WHO Air Quality Guidelines.

The prescribed WHO Air Quality Guideline, the values should be:

Ozone (O_3)-100 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ 8-hour mean

Nitrogen dioxide (NO_2) - 200 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ 1-hour mean

Sulfur dioxide (SO_2)- 20 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ 24-hour mean

Coarse Particulate Matter (PM_{10}) - 50 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ 24-hour mean

Fine Particulate Matter ($\text{PM}_{2.5}$) - 25 $\mu\text{g}/\text{m}^3$ 24-hour mean

The Annual Ritual of Burning of Crop Residue

Every year, the onset of autumn is automatically associated with a higher level of air toxins in most of India. The annual ritual of burning of crop residue kickstarts the Dussehra-Deepawali festive season during October-November. Traditionally, the farmers, especially in a few north Indian states, are in the practice of burning the straws and

paddy stubble after the rice harvest so that they can sow the next crop, mostly wheat.

The exposure to outdoor particulate matter (PM)_{2.5} is the fifth leading risk factor for death worldwide. Toxic air caused 1.2 million deaths in India in 2017. The poisonous particulate matter known as PM_{2.5} is a mixture of solid particles and liquid droplets in the air. Admittedly, burning of crop residue or rice-paddy straw and stubble, waste burning and other such factors are deteriorating air quality across the nation.

Primarily, the primary source of the air toxics is arising from the crop stubble burning in northern states of Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Punjab province of eastern Pakistan. Rs 200,000 crore is the estimated annual economic loss due to air pollution from crop residue burning in Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Rajasthan.

Although air pollution is a global issue, it poses a significant threat to Indians. Rare is the day when people happily breathe good quality air, as toxic air is a fact of life in most cities of India, throughout the year. It is no exaggeration to say that New Delhi is the world's most polluted capital city. Gurgaon, the most polluted city in the world in 2018, has the world's most toxic air. Twenty-two of the world's thirty worst polluted cities are in India. Agra, Bhiwadi, Faridabad, Gurgaon, Ghaziabad, Jaipur, Kanpur, Lucknow, Noida and Patiala are nearby and adjacent suburbs to New Delhi.

The Ill-effects of Crop Residue Burning

The crop residue burning has been robbing children of their right to healthy living. Air pollution from crop residue burning is a leading risk factor for acute respiratory infection in children and adults. If left unchecked, the growing menace of crop stubble burning levels will lead to a host of problems.

Air pollution causes Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD), pneumonia, ischaemic heart disease, lung cancer, laryngeal cancers, nasopharyngeal carcinoma, stroke, and tuberculosis. Some studies show that Air pollution causes even cataract and Low birth weight.

Government's Role in Minimising the Crop Residue Burning

In India, several policies came into effect during the past years. Crop residue burning is an offence under various acts including the Air Act of 1981, and the Code of Criminal Procedure 1973. An amount of Rs. 2,500 per acre is the penalty that a Pollution Control Board can impose as 'Environmental compensation cess' on framers caught burning the stubble.

While residue burning reduced by 25% in Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, the majority of farmers in Punjab prefer to pay the environmental compensation or the paltry sum of fine and continue to burn stubble. Hence, we need an urgent solution and alternatives. Unless these problems are addressed, any penalty imposed on crop residue burning will not work.

Moreover, most of the Indian State Governments have not yet explicitly addressed crop residue burning in their governing frameworks or having poor emissions controls. The state governments must enforce stricter laws, make the officials concerned responsible and impose a hefty penalty for non-compliance. The National Green Tribunal (NGT) issued a show-cause notice and slapped a penalty on Delhi, Haryana, Punjab and Uttar Pradesh governments for not having an action plan providing alternative methods, infrastructure, technology and assistance to farmers. State Governments are bringing various incentive plans to encourage farmers from stopping from the practice of burning crop residue.

Contribution from Researchers, Scientists and Start-ups

Soil researchers and scientists have been researching and exploring various options that would allow farmers to sow their next crop. On the other hand, Niti Aayog and several startups are coming to farmers' rescue to conduct a study on mass production of fertiliser from crop residue, which farmers continue to burn in the fields. Some startup companies and technology firms have developed sowing machines which are capable of seeding for the new crops without removing the stubble and straw residues from the farm's soil surface.

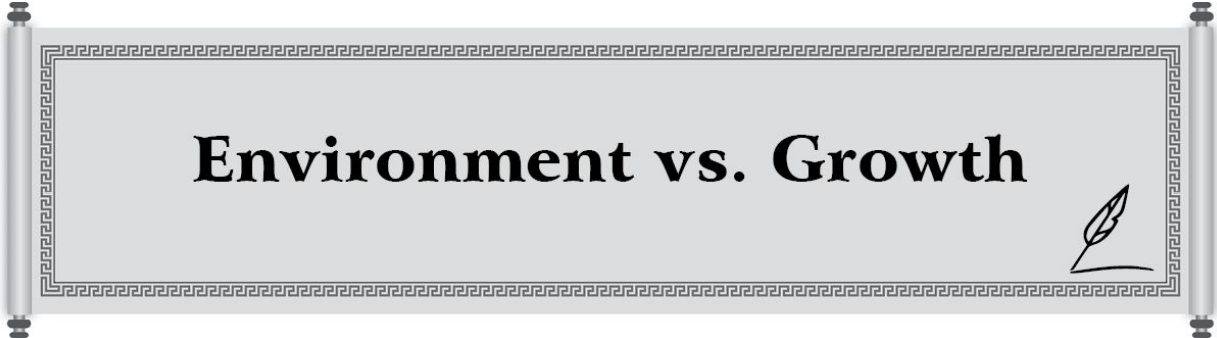
Educate Farmers to Elevate

The practice of burning straw and stubble is favourable for farmers as it is faster, easier and cost-effective. Multiple cropping and shortened intervals between crops leave shorter duration during which the field needs to be prepared for the next crop. The ill-informed farmers' attitude towards environment epitomises 'who cares?' or a lackadaisical attitude becomes a bit sensitive to environmental concerns. Volunteers and civil society emphasize the importance and inculcate a better sense of responsibility in farmers.

The farmers are also ignorant of other consequences. They will have to shell out more money on fertilisers, as stubble burning makes the soil less fertile and lessen the yield. Burning crop straw and stubble in one year alone results in the loss of 1.4 million tonnes of nutrients from the topsoil layer.

The governments, NGOs, Village co-operatives and other bodies must highlight and create impactful awareness about the repercussions and financial losses to the farmers. The farmers must be told how their counterparts in the South, East and West India manage the handling of crop stubble. They should be educated about the cost and benefits and encouraged to adopt the concept of no-till farming.

Environment vs. Growth



“We cannot deforest our way to prosperity and we cannot pollute our way to prosperity”. This was an emphatic declaration made by the finance minister of India Manmohan Singh in his 1991 budget speech. His words were visionary.

One out of every six people on the planet lives in India and the country accounts for 17% of the world population. India and China combined constitute the home to humongous 35% of global populace and both are on a high-growth trajectory. But as the population grows, a vital question needs to be addressed about the hidden environmental cost that is incurred for this growth.

So, with the rising population, it is requisite to find a balance between the economic development and consumption of natural resources.

Beginning of an Era of Growth

Soon after Independence, the nation prioritized on providing two square meals and water for drinking and irrigation to its starving millions. In order to obtain affordable power and irrigation for the masses, ambitious schemes of hydroelectric power and irrigation dams were launched. The mountains and forest regions endured colossal cataclysm in the process, to give way to huge water reservoirs, long roads and underground tunnels. The irrigation, drinking water and electricity benefitted a large number of people on one hand and on the other, displaced a substantial population of the hill and tribal regions, whose means of sustenance was the immediate hilly and forest environment. They had to endure

considerable hardship and the arrangements made for their rehabilitation failed utterly due to bureaucratic apathy and red tapism.

Moreover, the dams built in ecologically fragile areas led to an extensive damage to the soil and also resulted in salinity and ravines. The pitiable plight of the hilly and tribal people moved many activists and people from the common mass to take up their cause and they launched movements for protecting the forests of these vulnerable groups. In this process, two much renowned movements emerged - 'Chipko Andolan' for preventing forest cutting and 'Narmada Bachao Andolan' for saving people living in the Narmada river valley from displacement due to massive dam construction.

The unrelenting demand for expansion of irrigation facilities, water supply, chemical fertilizers and electricity for developing agriculture, industry and general living standards of the mass during the first three decades of Independence could not be ignored.

Environment is Over-burdened

The last two decades have witnessed a rise of strident tone from environmentalists and activists for the sake of ecologically fragile habitations and forested regions. In the post-reform India, the 'environment vs. growth' debate has become much more relevant which has led to the environmental issues gaining popularity.

The natural systems around us are breaking apart and for our unswerving needs to have more electricity, steel, aluminium and other minerals, we are heading towards making more dams and indulge in extensive mining activities which continue to eat the grasslands and hills.

Not just this, things are going wrong in our food system as well. Pollinators are an ecosystem service we derive from natural capital and they play a crucial role in growing our crops. But, the modern genetically modified crops intensively managed by agribusinesses cannot support bees and so they are dying out across the developed

world. The extent is that bees are now artificially reared and imported from other countries and released over the crops to pollinate it. But in lack of suitable habitat, they are all dying out.

With the increasing pressure on environment with development, environmentalism has shifted from being an 'elite' issue conversed in conferences and seminars to becoming a real issue disturbing people's daily lives, health and livelihoods.

Be it the water table declines and extensive droughts in Vidarbha and Bundelkhand or water logging in the Malwa region of Punjab that has affected more than 2 lakh farmers' livelihoods, the problems remain unsolved yet discussions continue. The pollution caused by unrestrained mining and thermal power generation through poor quality coal in Chandrapur in Maharashtra causing respiratory sickness of 10,000 people annually is another issue.

Yet the effluent and sewage treatment capacity are not capable of treating even half of the pollutants pumped into the river Ganga every year. Delhi's air pollution every winter narrates another story and dimension where uproar is witnessed through elites coming on roads to raise their voices. The impact of environmental pollution is surfacing starkly and now everyone is being affected directly—be it rich or poor.

Innovative Strategy for Greener Growth

The unbounded and blind greed of the human business has often led to negligence towards environment or public safety. By following a two-pronged approach, India and other developing countries can become greener and reduce their environment footprint while continuing to grow and deliver goods and services, simultaneously, for vital economic development.

The first hand strategy should be that the enterprises should decouple production systems from consumption of materials and energy in order to be sustainable. Through switching to renewable sources of energy and materials intended towards cleaner

production, sustainable growth can be possible. Enterprises should maximise recycling and reuse of wastes and environmentally sound product design.

A key player in this is the government that needs to simplify the policies to create an ecosystem for new sustainable businesses to flourish. Introduction and adoption of Green Accounting standards would enhance the speed of transition among businesses.

The new buzzword besides these developments is “balancing” growth with environmental protection. For this, smarter regulation for leveraging technology and markets should be the priority. For better regulation, technology-based tools and market approaches are other requisites.

In 2011, Ministry of Environment & Forests and Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL) envisaged the Emissions Trading Scheme, through which real-time emissions monitoring and trading was launched in select industrial clusters. This was modelled on the renowned “Acid Rain” program of the US. More such innovative advances for monitoring pollution are the need of the hour.

Global Solution Needs Global Effort

The largest contributor to the environmental pollution, the rich countries like US have not been able to reduce the consumption of fossil fuels. On the part of these rich countries of Northern Hemisphere, it's quite unrealistic to expect the poor and highly populated countries of the Third World to adopt the high cost alternative sources of energy such as solar and wind.

The cost of renewable sources of energy for entire world needs to be shared by the North, for a pragmatic development towards curbing pollution in the near future. They must realize that the atmosphere and environment are not divided as stated by national boundaries. They are common to the entire global community and it is only through international and united efforts that the global warming and ozone layer depletion would be combated. Countries contributing

more to the environmental degradation need to make greater efforts and exercise larger renunciation in their consumption patterns in order to cut down the rate of pollution.

Lastly, more serious institutional strengthening has to be looked at as it is the demand of the changing time to have an independent, professional environmental regulator for India.

The way our 1919 reforms resulted from the economic crisis through finding an innovative path for India's economic destiny, the same way, we need to plan an innovative path for the purpose of India's ecological destiny to pull it out from the environmental crisis.

The Importance of Environmental Protection and Sustainable Development

A common preoccupation of all the states of the world that is also seen as a world-wide objective is the problem of environmental protection and sustainable development of material resources. A series of international provisions with universal vocation have been adopted by means of collaboration and cooperation among states. The international measures regarding environmental protection are recognized at the level of international general or conventional law.

The society has turned conscientious by the concept of sustainable development and it has started to recognize the role and significance of environmental factors as well as of the functions and services the environment provides.

In establishing the line of action at the level of communitarian process, the sustainable development has to be taken into consideration. It is only through durable development or durable way of life that the harm to the biophysical context is controlled. The human activities along with the biosphere in their own dynamic form have to allow the continuity of human life so that satisfaction of each individual's own needs and development of a variety of cultures is met.

The actual realization right now is that for sustainable development, protection of environment is a requisite. Right from the industrial pollution and degradation of forests to depletion of ozone layer, green house gases and ocean level rising, almost every change happening on this planet is resulting in global warming and climate alteration that will adversely affect environment and human health. In such a

scenario, conservation of biodiversity, protection of wetlands and prevention of environmental pollution along with promotion of ecological balance enable sustainable development.

In the post-independence period there was no environment specific legislation to address the problems of environmental degradation and the growth of Indian environmental jurisprudence can be traced to the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment held at Stockholm in 1972. India participated in this conference which underlined the need of India and other states to adopt the environmental measures essential to deal with environmental hazards.

In light of the international obligations of India that arose from the Stockholm conference, the 42nd Amendment to the Indian Constitution was introduced in 1976 that emphasized the explicit principles of environmental protection. These environmental measures were enshrined in the Articles 48A and 51 A (g) of the Constitution.

As part of the Directive Principles of State Policy, Article 48A obligated the state to improve and protect the environment. Citizens were obligated by Article 51A (g) to undertake the same responsibilities. The judiciary as well can play a vital role in protection of environment through judicial activism. Supreme Court under Article 32 of Indian Constitution can issue writ directions.

On global front, the United Nation Organisation passed several UN conventions like Ramsar Convention on protection of wetlands and UN Convention on Biodiversity. Every year on June 5th World Environment Day is celebrated across the globe.

Global Warming, Forest Conservation and Protection of Wetlands

The earth is gradually warming and this is believed to bring a permanent change in its climate. With the average global temperatures being higher than ever in past millennium, the levels of

carbon monoxide also crossed all earlier records. This has led to deteriorating chances of the ecosystems to adapt naturally. Increased frequency and severity of extreme events besides the changing climate patterns are adding to vulnerabilities of natural disasters.

The National Policy of India 1988 emphasized the role of forests in national economy and ecology and also ensured environmental stability and restoration of ecological balance by preserving the remaining forests.

The policy was not just meant to deliver to the needs of the rural and tribal population through fuel wood, timber and fodder but also recognized the involvement of local population in forest resource management.

Stricter conservation measures were facilitated through amendment of the Forest Conservation Act of 1980 in 1988.

Wetlands being the most productive life support and immense socio-economic and ecological significance attached to them make them crucial to the survival of natural biodiversity. Endangered and rare species of birds and animals, endemic plants, insects and migratory birds get their suitable habits in wetlands. Being signatory to the Ramsar Convention on Wetlands and Convention of Biological Diversity, India needs better monitoring methods to increase the knowledge of physical and biological characteristic of each wetland resource, develop better understanding of wetland dynamics and their controlling processes. The Ramsar Convention on wetlands is a step towards calling international attention to the rate at which wetland habitats are disappearing.

Biodiversity Conservation

The Parliament of India enacted the Biological Diversity Act, 2002 as a federal legislation to preserve biological diversity in India. It also provides mechanism for equitable sharing of benefits that come from the use of traditional biological resources and knowledge.

At global level, Convention on Biodiversity Authority (CBD) works for the conservation of biological flora and fauna and India being a party to this convention is committed to preserve the same and so it enacted the above act. It also implemented the National Biodiversity Authority (NBA) in 2003 to implement the act. Through this, the practice of protecting endangered plant and animal species and their habits is encouraged.

Ozone Depletion, Water Pollution and Environmental Impact Assessment

The photo dissociation of man-made halocarbon refrigerants like CFCs, freons, halons reach the stratosphere after being emitted from the surface and lead to ozone depletion.

Article 21 of our Constitution defines our right to live and it is not restricted to mere animal existence, but it also constitutes the right to get pollution free water and air. Article 48 of Constitution of India, Directive Principles of our State Policy (DPSP) directs that the State should take steps to organize agriculture and animal husbandry on modern and scientific lines. The State is further required under Article 48-A to take steps to protect and improve environment and safeguard the forests and wildlife of the country. Every citizen of the country is required to protect and improve the natural environment including forests, lakes, rivers and wildlife under Article 51-A.

Leakage of hazardous gases like chlorine from industries and throwing of waste material of alcohol plants into the adjoining areas result in spreading of obnoxious cells that get released apart from mosquito breeding. Discharge of highly toxic effluent by the tanneries is another issue prevalent in areas where major leather factories are located, such as Kanpur. This carelessness has not just resulted in pollution of rivers like Ganga but also leads to suffering of people from respiratory and other skin diseases. All of these remind the enforcement agencies to do the job.

Environmental pollution is not confined to any particular country or region but is widening and crossing over the state and political boundaries, which further affect land, water, air, space perversely. It is this realisation of degraded consequences of the environmental pollution and its future impact on living being that the legal, political and scientific battle has started in all forums of international, regional and national organizations.

Due to the gap between the intent of the policy and the actual achievement, the environment quality has deteriorated during the past two decades. Protection of the environment poses a fundamental challenge to the nations which desire to industrialize faster. Though various efforts are being made to control India's environmental problems and the government has also recognized the need for planned land and water resource management and protection of environmental resources, yet much needs to be done on actual grass roots level.

Through sustained, concerted actions of policy makers and communities that promote the standard of living and social health of a specific region, the actual economic development can be realized.

How Important is Energy Conservation for Our Planet?



Energy is the engine for the social and economic development in the past, present and future. It is the basis for progress and prosperity of nations and societies. Future economic growth crucially depends on the long term availability of sources that are affordable, accessible and environment-friendly.

Energy may be defined as the capacity to do work. Energy can be transformed from one form to another form. The sources of energy may be (i) renewable or (ii) non-renewable. Non-renewable energy resources are those sources of energy that once used cannot be regenerating again, renewable source is inexhaustible which cannot be finished. However, energy can neither be created nor destroyed and cannot be recycled. Energy is found on our planet in a variety of forms, some of which are immediately useful to do work, while others require a process of transformation.

Energy conservation means energy deterrence from being wasted more than its purpose of use. Energy conservation is not about making limited resources last longer, but it is a process of doing nothing more than delaying a crisis until we finally run out of all our energy resources. Energy conservation is accomplished when growth of energy consumption is reduced, measured in physical terms. Energy conservation is any behaviour that results in the use of less energy.

Today, energy impacts have now widened to cover regional and global issues such as acid rain and the “greenhouse effect”. Thus, the impact of energy use on the environment has been two-fold: pollution

of environment from emission of greenhouse gases from burning of fossil fuels and depletion of energy resources.

In the category of fossil fuel, we include crude oil (petroleum) and natural gas also. We consider this to be primary source of energy but are non-renewable and exhaustible because they are found in finite quantities cannot be renewed. This means although coal, oil and natural gas are biotic in origin as they were produced from plants and plankton that lived millions of years ago, they cannot be renewed in practical terms; at least it cannot be reproduced in our times. It may be mentioned that although the world is not yet running out of oil but like all other non-renewable resources, oil supplies are found to decline.

At the end of the 20th century, coal was the fundamental energy source feeding the industrial revolution in the nineteenth century, oil accounted for 39% of the world's commercial energy consumption followed by natural gas (24%) and coal (24%), while nuclear (7%) and hydro/renewable (6%) accounted for the rest. Among the commercial energy sources used in India, coal is a predominant source accounting for 55% of energy consumption estimated in 2001, followed by oil (31%), natural gas (8%), hydro (5%) and nuclear (1%).

In India, biomass (mainly wood and dung) accounts for almost 40% of primary energy supply. While coal continues to remain the dominant fuel for electricity generation, nuclear power has been increasingly used since the 1970s and 1980s and the use of natural gas has increased rapidly in the 80s and 90s.

Energy conservation is important on a global level. There are three main reasons for energy conservation.

Consumption of Fossil Fuels

At the moment, more than 80 per cent of our global energy comes from fossil fuel (Oil, Gas and Coal). The way we produce and use energy today is not sustainable. Our main fossil fuel sources – oil, coal and gas – are finite natural resources, and we are depleting

them at a rapid rate. Fossil fuels are a nonrenewable resource, meaning that at some point the very last chunk of coal will be dug from the earth and the last drop of oil will be pumped from the Earth. When this happens, fossil fuel won't be available anymore since mankind can't create these resources.

The process of converting fossil fuels to energy results in many harmful outcomes. The combustion of fossil fuels produces emissions, including carbon dioxide (CO₂), carbon monoxide (CO), sulfur dioxide (SO₂), nitrogen oxides (NO_x), and particulate matter (PM). Nearly all of these have negative impacts on the environment and our health. Furthermore, they are the main contributors to the climate change, and the race to the last 'cheap' fossils resources evokes disaster for the natural environment.

In the developing world, regional and local desertification is caused by the depletion of fuel wood and other biomass sources that are often used very inefficiently causing substantive in-door pollution and millions of deaths annually.

Environmental Protection

Different energy sources have different effects on our environment, such as emissions, waste, and the impacts of land and water use. In order to understand how to reduce the adverse impacts of growing use of energy on the environment, we need to know its extent of impact on environment.

More than 2.7 million people are dependent on traditional bio energy (mainly from wood, crops residues and animal dung) as their main source of cooking and heating fuel. This is often harvested unsustainably, causing soil erosion and increasing the risk of flooding, as well as threatening biodiversity and adding to greenhouse gases emissions.

The other reason for conserving energy is the health and well-being of every life form on the entire planet. Using fossil fuels and some

other energy forms typically pollute the environment in a number of ways. When energy is produced from non-renewable fuels, to heat our homes or power our cars for example, pollutants are released into the air contaminating the air we breathe and water, too. The more energy we use or miles we drive in our cars, the more energy power plants must produce or gasoline our cars burn, releasing more pollutants into the air.

Socio-economic Impact

Energy conservation is important even with regard to socio-economic impact on countries and communities. It is certain that countries and communities which have better economic standards are the ones which tend to utilize more energy than others. So, being conscious and wise in the use of energy proves helpful to other countries and communities for accessing the same.

Due to rising population, economic growth and a quest for improved quality of life global demand for energy is rapidly increasing. There is a growing demand for energy due to industrialization, population boom, vehicles on roads and automation in office, home, and farms. Most of the power generated in the world today comes from fossil fuels. Even though increasing numbers are shifting to 'green electricity', the production of electricity remains one of the most polluting activities of humankind.

Energy Conservation is undeniably of immense concern to all of us, since we depend on energy for everything we do every single day. At present, excessive energy use and growing exploitation of natural resources have adversely affected our environment and hence environmental issues in energy have become the focus of today's debates. It is being considered important to improve energy use efficiency and switch to environment-friendly energy sources since improved energy efficiency and better energy management will not only help in preventing environmental damage but also in saving on financial fronts.

As energy-related activities have significant environmental impacts, it is indispensable to provide an energy system which covers the needs of the economies and preserves the environment. Even though energy conservation reduces energy services, it can result in increased financial capital, environmental quality, national security, and personal financial security. Individuals and organizations that are direct consumers of energy may choose to conserve energy to reduce energy costs, promote economic security, or maximize profit. However, this can lead to unintended rebound effects, which can negate environmental benefits of conservation unless backstops are instituted to prevent overall consumption increases.

The Depletion of the Ozone Layer



In the 1970s, when scientific evidence was published showing that man-made emissions of commonly used chemicals, originally thought to be harmless, were destroying the ozone layer - the natural shield that protects life on Earth from the dangerous UV radiation of the sun - a fundamental concern was raised: human activities have environmental consequences that are not always predictable but that can affect everyone's life on the planet. These increased levels of UV radiation due to the depletion of the ozone layer threaten human health. This striking reality should influence all of our actions: when we harm the environment, we harm ourselves. The discovery in 1985 of a large ozone "hole" over Antarctica during springtime, growing larger and deeper each year, has revealed the scale of the problem. Since then, action has been taken by the international community through the adoption of the Montreal Protocol on Substances that Deplete the Ozone Layer (1987), an agreement aimed at severely restricting the use of ozone depleting chemicals.

Ozone is a colourless and natural gas made up of oxygen (O_3) which is very active. Near the earth's surface ozone is harmful to humans, plants and animals (tropospheric ozone). But ozone also forms a gaseous layer, mostly in the stratosphere (the upper atmosphere) 15-30 km above the surface of the earth, and protects life on earth by absorbing biologically harmful ultraviolet (UV) radiation from the sun.

In the stratosphere, the ozone layer protects the earth's surface from excessive ultraviolet (UV) radiation from the Sun but it is being depleted. In the 1970s, scientists became concerned when they discovered that chemicals called Chlorofluorocarbons or CFCs long

used as refrigerants and as aerosol spray propellants—posed a possible threat to the ozone layer. Released into the atmosphere, these chlorine-containing chemicals rise into the upper stratosphere and are broken down by sunlight, whereupon the chlorine reacts with atmosphere and destroys ozone molecules up to 100,000 per CFC molecule. The use of CFCs in aerosols has been banned in the United States and elsewhere. Other chemicals, such as bromine halocarbons, as well as nitrous oxides from fertilisers, may also attack the ozone layer.

The ozone hole created at the pole permits passage of UV radiation on earth's atmosphere which causes sunburn, cataract in eyes leading to blindness, skin cancer, reduced productivity of forests, etc., therefore, the "Montreal Protocol" amended in 1990 called to completely phase out CFCs to prevent damage of ozone layer any further. It has been observed that atmospheric gases like carbon dioxide, methane, nitrous oxide, water vapour, and chlorofluorocarbons are capable of trapping the outgoing infrared radiation from the earth. Infra-red radiations trapped by the earth's surface cannot pass through these gases and increase thermal energy or heat in the atmosphere. As a result, the temperature of the global atmosphere is increased.

Why is Ozone Important?

In the stratosphere, ozone absorbs virtually all of the solar ultraviolet (UV) radiation with wavelengths of less than 290 nanometers (nm) and most of it in the biologically harmful wavelength region of 290 to 320 nm (which is called UVB). This prevents the radiation from reaching the surface of the Earth in quantities which could adversely affect the lives of human beings, plants, and animals. The UV radiation that is not absorbed is the same rays of the sun that cause us to sunburn and otherwise damage our skin. This UV absorption is mostly responsible for the temperature inversion (temperature increase with increasing altitude) that characterizes the upper stratosphere and produces its quiescent nature. Ozone also absorbs

strongly in the infrared part of the spectrum, and this absorption plays a part in maintaining the heat balance of the globe.

Ozone is destroyed naturally by the absorption of ultraviolet radiation, and by the collision of ozone with other atmospheric atoms and molecules. This can break down or deplete the ozone layer. A severe decrease in the concentration of ozone in the ozone layer could lead to the following harmful effects:

- Climatic effect
- An increase in the incidences of skin cancer; a large increase in cataracts and sun-burning
- Suppression of immune systems in organisms
- Reduction in the growth of phytoplankton found in the Earth's Oceans cooling of the Earth's stratosphere and possibly some surface
- Adverse impact on crops and animals

Main Ozone Depleting Substances (ODS)

Ozone (O_3) is a highly reactive molecule containing three oxygen atoms. Ozone layer is a thin layer of ozone in the stratosphere, the upper part of the earth's atmosphere (between 10 and 50 km above the earth surface). The importance of this ozone layer lies in the fact that it serves as a natural filter for blocking deadly incoming UV radiation from the sun.

It has observed that ozone layer can be destroyed both by natural and man-made causes.

- Natural causes include a number of naturally occurring substances which destroy stratospheric ozone. These include Hydrogen oxide (HOx), Methane (CH_4), Hydrogen gas (H_2), Nitrogen oxides (NOx) and Chlorine monoxide (ClO). It has been seen that during volcanic eruptions, significant amount of chlorine may be released in the stratosphere. Similarly, tiny particulate matter in the

stratosphere, known as stratospheric aerosols, may also lead to ozone destruction.

- Human activity which releases chlorine atoms into the atmosphere can cause severe ozone destruction, because chlorine atoms in the stratosphere can destroy ozone, e.g. most damaging among such agents are human made chlorofluorocarbons (CFCs).

Ozone Hole and Global Warming

Ozone (O₃) high in the atmosphere absorbs ultraviolet radiation from the sun, thereby protecting living organisms below from this dangerous radiation. The term 'ozone hole' refers to recent depletion of this protective layer over Earth's polar regions. People, plants, and animals living under the ozone hole are harmed by the solar radiation now reaching the Earth's surface – where it causes health problems from eye damage to skin cancer.

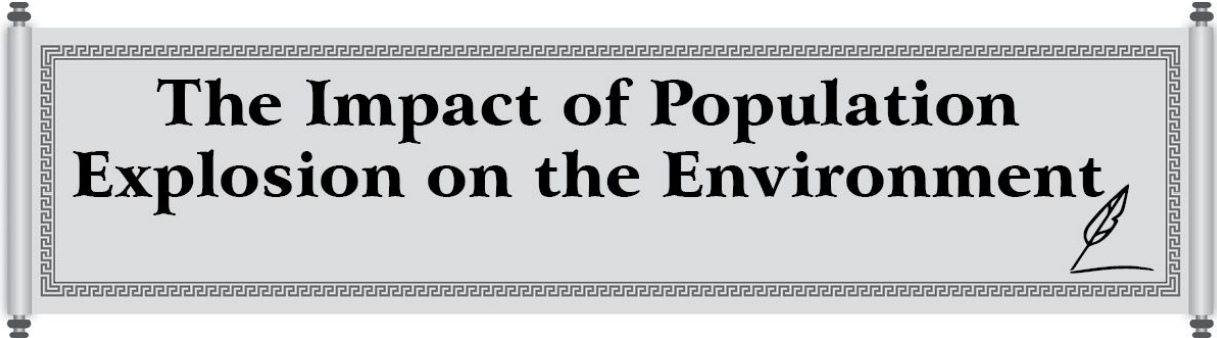
The ozone hole, however, is not the mechanism of global warming. Ultraviolet radiation represents less than one percent of the energy from the sun – not enough to be the cause of the excess heat from human activities. Global warming is caused primarily from putting too much carbon into the atmosphere when coal, gas, and oil are burned to generate electricity or to run our cars. These gases spread around the planet like a blanket, capturing the solar heat that would otherwise be radiated out into space.

Both of these environmental problems do, however, have a common cause — human activities that release gases into and alter the atmosphere. Ozone depletion occurs when chlorofluorocarbons (CFCs) — formerly found in aerosol spray cans and refrigerants — are released into the atmosphere. These gases, through several chemical reactions, cause the ozone molecules to break down reducing ozone's ultraviolet (UV) radiation-absorbing capacity.

The only practical approach to stopping the destruction of the ozone layer is reducing human-created pollutants that contribute to its depletion. Efforts to protect the ozone layer now involve many

different nations and industries. An international agreement, called the Montreal Protocol, was established in 1987 requiring countries to cut CFC use in half by 1999. In addition, manufacturers of ozone-destroying chemicals have made major advances in CFC alternative technologies. But even if all CFC use was halted today, the CFCs already released will continue to break down in the stratosphere and destroy ozone for decades. While government legislation, supported by industry involvement, are major factors in preventing further damage to the ozone layer, individuals also have an important role to play.

The Impact of Population Explosion on the Environment



At the beginning of human evolution more than two million years ago, the natural resources were overabundant as compared to human needs. However, when human population increased, more and more food and resources for shelter were required and these were drawn at an increasing rate from the environment. Thus, increasing use of natural resources by rapidly increasing human population has resulted in over-exploitation of natural resources. As a result of such exploitation, we see soil erosion, loss of biodiversity and pollution of land, air and water bodies. Finally, we can say that the degradation of the environment from over-exploitation has reached a level which is threatening well-being and survival of human beings.

The increasing population and economic activity has resulted in excessive material consumption which is putting heavy burden on natural resources and is damaging the environment severely.

The environment has reacted to the over-exploitation by the human beings. Its backlash can be seen in the form of floods, drought, acid rain, oil spills which are of common occurrence and they are largely due to the carelessness and callousness of humans towards the environment.

Population growth and environmental degradation are two of the great concerns of our age, as both are seen to be problems of local and global importance. The links between them are generally not clearly understood, though population growth is usually regarded as an underlying factor of environmental change, associated with the

huge scientific and technological advances which have transformed societies, economies and politics over the last two centuries.

At the global level, the problem of 'global warming' and 'ozone layer depletion' poses serious threat to human health and wellbeing. At the local level, we can observe salination of irrigated soils making it unfit for cultivation and infertile. Eutrophication of a water body occurs when plant nutrients such as nitrates and phosphates are released by the action of aerobic bacteria on organic wastes entering a water body. These nutrients promote growth of algae (algal bloom). Algae consume all the oxygen and aquatic organism die due to lack of oxygen. Moreover, the Minamata disease is caused as plastic, caustic soda, fungicide and pesticide manufacturing factories release mercury along with other effluents in the water body nearby. Mercury enters food chain through bacteria – algae-fish and finally the humans. Extinction of wild life species is another environmental loss.

At the regional level also we can observe environmental backlash in the form of floods, drought, acid rain and oil spill. Floods are a natural disaster and India is a flood-prone country. The habitations close to the river get flooded resulting in loss of human life and property. This means heavy economic losses and outbreak of epidemic diseases.

At the global level, the environmental backlash can be observed in the form of biodiversity loss, global warming and greenhouse effect, collapse of marine fisheries and Ozone layer depletion. With the dwindling forests, the natural habitat of various plants and animals has vanished. Also, many valuable trees and animals have vanished forever. Industrialization and urbanization have led to emission of large quantities of carbon dioxide into atmosphere from burning of fossil fuels. This increased CO₂ concentration does not allow heat radiations given out by earth, to escape into the outer space and has raised the average global temperature causing global warming.

Threatening the Future of Mankind

The explosive rise in human population is threatening the future of mankind. Among the several factors that have contributed to the enormous rise in human population, the important ones are improved agricultural practices, progress in medicine prevented deaths and average longevity of humans has increased as many deadly diseases can be treated through modern medical technology.

Enormous Pressure on the Environment

With growing population, requirement for space, shelter, and commodities have exerted enormous pressure on the environment. Forests and natural grasslands have been converted to farmlands. Wetlands have been drained and arid lands have been irrigated. Thus, the natural resources have been depleted and the landscapes have undergone drastic changes.

Water withdrawal has exceeded beyond the rate of replenishment of the ground water table and has resulted in drying out of wells. In many areas excessive withdrawal has depleted ground water resources causing acute water scarcity. Similarly, to make houses for so many, stones and other building materials have to be quarried, more rocks have to be blown off and more water to be used.

Growing Quantities of Fossil Fuels

Various modes of transports have been developed which consume growing quantities of fossil fuels such as coal, gas and petroleum, polluting the atmosphere. The raw materials and fossil fuels and water needed to run industries for manufacturing articles of everyday use lead to their depletion. Rapid industrialization has also led to pollution from dumping of industrial effluents into rivers and other water bodies. Mining activities have depleted stock of mineral resources particularly fossil fuels.

Lack of Basic Amenities

It has been found that overpopulated areas result in congested roads and slum formation which lack basic amenities like drinking water, drainage, waste disposal, lack of hygienic conditions creating

potential conditions for public health problems including spread of epidemic diseases in the area. The rivers Ganges, Yamuna and others are suffering from pollution due to discharge of effluents from industries, human settlements, bathing, washing of clothes and throwing of garbage into the river.

Deforestation

Humans have cut down trees and cleared forests to obtain firewood and timber and to get land for agriculture and human settlements. Deforestation has resulted in serious loss of biodiversity. Moreover, industrialization has also impacted the environment. To meet the growing requirement of the increasing human population, large scale manufacture of essential goods is necessary. There is an equilibrium in nature because of the fine-tuning in the interaction between abiotic and biotic components. Human activities have interfered with this equilibrium. Uncontrolled human activities caused damage to the environment. For instance, forests have been cut down for use by humans for converting them into the cultivable fields, for building houses and for taking away logs for making shelters and furniture or fuel. Cutting of trees and clearing of forest reduced rainfall in the area. Also removal of plants and trees leads to soil erosion. Moreover, extinction of wild life species is on the rise because their natural habitats are being destroyed due to deforestation.

Rapid Depletion of Natural Resources

Industrialization that disregards environmental concerns led to environmental degradation in the form of rapid depletion of natural resources, generation of a lot of toxic gases, and liquid effluents, and large amount of waste. Disposal of waste not only needs land but also pollutes the environment and poses hazards to human health. Apart from this, accelerated consumption of fossil fuels by industries is depleting their stock as they are limited and non-renewable. Moreover, burning of fossil fuels releases CO₂ in the atmosphere leading to global warming.

Further, non-renewable energy resources such as coal, natural gas and petroleum are being used up speedily, leading to their depletion. Apart from all this, excessive burning of coal, wood, kerosene, petrol etc. release toxic gases such as SO_2 , NO_x , CO and hydrocarbons in the air. The toxic gases pollute air which adversely affects human health and plants. Similarly, acid water from mines, toxic waste of industries, chemical fertilizers and pesticides from agricultural fields have polluted rivers and other water bodies. Finally, the problem of soil pollution is increasing day by day due to faulty disposal of solid and liquid wastes generated from households and industries. Thus, humans have spoilt the environment by (i) depleting natural resources to a critical level and (ii) causing pollution to the nature.

To sum up, we can say that population explosion coupled with human greed for progressive prosperity and comfort has exploited and degraded the environment mercilessly to such a large extent that human survival itself is now threatened. Similarly, contaminated food, water and air are taking its toll on human health. Toxic chemicals and harmful radiations have the potential of causing serious problems of human health. Air pollution causes asthma, pulmonary fibrosis, pneumoconiosis and long exposure to pollutants in the working place such as mines, textile mills, poultry, crackers, sand blasting and chemical industries cause respiratory diseases. Similarly, carcinogenic chemicals and ionizing radiations in the environment have been responsible for cancer. Other problems due to large population are reduced job opportunities, unemployment and related stress. Degraded quality of life and continuous health problems lead to mental problems. Thus, human survival itself is threatened due to the damage done to the environment by humans themselves.

The Scarcity of Resources: How the Resources are becoming Scarce and What can be Done to Prevent This?

The Earth is home to more than 7 billion people. All these people need air to breathe, food to eat and water to drink. We also need materials to build our homes, make clothes and energy to perform all these activities. The earth provides us with all these things and with combination of all these, they are termed Natural Resources (NR). A scarce resource is one which when offered to people at no cost, more would be wanted (demanded) than is available (supplied). Notice that the opposite of a scarce resource is a free resource. At no price, the quantity supplied of a free good for instance exceeds the quantity demanded leading to a surplus.

We can define resource as anything useful or can be made useful to humans. It fulfils their requirements. Air, water from rainfall in lakes, rivers and wells, soil, land, forest, biodiversity, minerals, fossil fuels, etc. are the resources that are directly available for use from nature and are hence called natural resources. However, the increasing population and economic activity has resulted in excessive material consumption which is putting heavy burden on natural resources and is damaging the environment severely.

Today, we see deforestation, draining of wetlands and reclamation of coastal areas to build their homes, farms and factories. At the same time huge amounts of fossil fuels are being used in industries and for transportation. It has been found that destruction of forests causes loss of biodiversity. Therefore, the need of the hour is to prevent further degradation of natural resources and to ensure their sustainable utilization for making them available to future generations also.

Every country strives to progress ahead; one aspect of progress is economic development manufacturing and trading.

Every country builds industries which provide employment, serve the consumers' needs and help to generate revenue. Development projects in the past were undertaken without any consideration to their environmental consequences. As a result, rivers and lakes got polluted; air pollution reached at threatening level and piling of industrial wastes resulted in land degradation. Industrialization and economic growth provided material comforts and luxuries of life but at the same time deteriorated the quality of life. In view of the colossal damage to environment by developmental activities, people are now concerned about the environmental impact of developmental projects.

Natural resources are derived from the environment. Some of them are essential for our survival while most are used for satisfying our wants. Natural resources are materials and components (something that can be used) that can be found within the environment. Every man-made product is composed of natural resources (at its fundamental level). A natural resource may exist as a separate entity such as fresh water, air as well as a living organism such as a fish, or it may exist in an alternate form which must be processed to obtain the resource such as metal ores, oil, and most forms of energy. While resource scarcity is a global challenge, as no single country is self-sufficient in resources needed to power one's economy, its effects are not equal across countries/ regions. This is attributed to the uneven distribution and variations in demand for resources by countries/regions.

How the Resources are Becoming Scarce?

Natural resources occur naturally within environment that exists relatively undisturbed by mankind, in a natural form. A natural resource is often characterized by amounts of biodiversity and geodiversity existent in various ecosystems. Some Natural resources can be found everywhere such as sunlight and air, when this is so the

resource is known as a ubiquitous (existing or being everywhere) resource. However, most resources are not ubiquitous. They only occur in small sporadic areas; these resources are referred to as localized resources. There are very few resources that are considered inexhaustible (will not run out in foreseeable future) – these are solar radiation, geothermal energy, and air (though access to clean air may not be).

The vast majority of resources are, however, exhaustible, which means they have a finite quantity, and can be depleted if managed improperly. The natural resources are materials which living organisms can take from nature for sustaining their life or any components of the natural environment that can be utilized by man to promote his welfare is considered as natural resources.

The exploitation of resources for years has led to destruction of environment and irreplaceable damage to the earth. The growing population has more mouths to feed and to be provided with facilities. Thus, forests were wiped out from large areas of forest. Similarly, trees were felled for wood, for making shelters, carts for transportation, etc. and also as a source of fuel. Further, the discovery of fire increased the use of wood for cooking. Thus, humans began to mine not only coal for fuel but also ores of metals to make wheels and ornaments, etc. It has been found that in the beginning, the damage was not so enormous but after the industrial revolution or in the last 400 years, forests have dwindled at an alarming rate. Moreover, wild life has been threatened to extinction. Some wild animals have vanished. Pollution from industries has made the air impure and water bodies full of filth. With the innovation, the treasured natural resources such as the soil, the forest, the minerals, metals, the air, the water, plants and animals were increasingly overexploited. Thus, Environmental resources are limited

and fast getting depleted due to over exploitation by the human population.

What can be Done to Prevent This?

Our resources like forests, wild life, water, coal and petroleum need to be used in a sustainable manner. We can reduce pressure on the environment by sincerely applying the maxim of 'Reduce, Reuse and Recycle' in our lives. Five choices are recycle or reuse existing supplies, waste less, use less, find a substitute or do without. Management of forest resources has to take into account the interests of various stakeholders. The harnessing of water resources by building dams has social, economic and environmental implications. Alternatives to large dams exist. These are locale-specific and may be developed so as to give local people control over their local resources. The fossil fuels, coal and petroleum, will ultimately be exhausted. Because of this and because their combustion pollutes our environment, we need to use these resources judiciously.

All the things we use or consume – food, clothes, books, toys, furniture, tools and vehicles – are obtained from resources on this earth. The only thing we get from outside is energy which we receive from the Sun. Even this energy is processed by living organisms and various physical and chemical processes on the earth before we make use of it. There is much debate worldwide over natural resource allocations; this is partly due to increasing scarcity (depletion of resources) but also because the exportation of natural resources is the basis for many economies.

Air, water, soil, vegetation and animals were renewable primary resources. This is so because they naturally recycle and reproduce themselves and can hence last forever. It has been observed that solar, winds and tidal energy are virtually inexhaustible resources on human time scale. Thus, these are called unconditionally renewable resources.

Land and soil are conditionally renewable resources because they degrade and take a very long time in their renewal. For instance, formation of an inch of soil layer generally takes 200 to 1000 years. Similarly, soil erosion occurs much faster as compared to the rate of soil formation, so it can become non-renewable resource as the top soil may be lost forever. We must check land and soil degradation to prevent soil erosion and landslides, to maintain soil fertility, for increasing biodiversity and for maintaining economic growth in the world.

Apart from land and soil, fresh water is also conditionally renewable and its fast depletion must be checked by prevention of water wastage, increasing water use efficiency, recycling of water, capturing and storing more flood run-off, harvesting rain water, and desalinating seawater. In addition, biodiversity is also conditionally renewable because over exploitation of plants and animals may lead to extinction; hence, a renewable resource may be lost forever. Therefore, the over exploitation of living resources must be prevented.

Global Warming is Warning us through Rising Sea Level and Melting Icecaps



If we ask to ourselves are the effects of global warming that bad, we would be able to answer it ourselves that yes, they are. They are bad to such an extent that even a superficially average temperature rise is enough to cause a dramatic transformation of our planet.

A natural consequence of the warming of our planet is the rise in sea level. When water heats up, it expands and so the sea level rises when ocean water warms. Ice melts when exposed to heat and the resultant water then runs into the ocean which leads to the rise in the sea water. The sea level has remained constant or relatively stable since thousands of years and various human civilisations and communities have been discovered to have settled along the coastlines of rivers and water bodies. But at present, sea level rise has reached about eight inches since the beginning of the 20th century and more than two inches in the merely last 20 years.

All such signs report the accelerating speed of the rise in the sea level. NASA and other agencies have been actively monitoring the ocean warming and the changes in the mass of the planet, but the biggest concern that we face at present is that we seem to be having no option as well as being helpless when we hear of the ancient ice sheets covering Greenland and Antarctica sending out continuous alerts that a warming planet is affecting their stability.

Paleo climatic record has shown the possibility of sea level rise of as much as 10 feet in a century or two as an after effect of ice sheets falling apart rapidly. The regional differences in sea level rise are affected by ocean currents and natural cycles such as El Nino

phenomenon of Pacific Ocean and Pacific Decadal Oscillation. With the continuous melting of ice sheets, scientists suggest the likelihood of overtaking of the natural causes by the melt water. These natural causes are also the most significant source of regional variations and the most significant contributor to overall sea level rise.

It was not long ago, when determining of polar land ice was tricky for scientists. They in the early 1990s were not able to determine if the polar ice was growing, shrinking or in balance. But thanks to the satellites and airborne missions, we can avail the information regarding the mechanisms which determine the contributors to the growth and shrinkage of polar ice.

These estimates have also helped us to correctly observe the world's frozen regions and the annual ice losses from Greenland and Antarctica in last decade. This has helped us with updates on how much sea level has been changing –as measured by satellite for the past 23 years and also in determining how much sea level rise is caused by the loss of land ice.

Humans are the Cause

The number one cause of global warming are the human influences and this has been reported by the National Climate Assessment. The carbon pollution caused by burning fossil fuels remains the prime concern and the destruction of forests on mass scale has deteriorated the pollution-capturing capacity of the environment. The gases releases into the pollutants such as carbon dioxide, methane, soot and other pollutants behave like a blanket that traps the sun's heat and cause the planet to warm rapidly. As per the studies and the evidences, in the last 1300 years; the years 2000 to 2009 were hotter than any other decade and this warming is shifting the climate system that includes its land, atmosphere, oceans and ice in far-reaching ways.

According to the American Meteorological Society's State of the Climate in 2017, the year brought an end to the three-year streak of

new record temperatures that were set each year from 2014–2016. Depending on the data set used, 2017 came in second or third warmest, after 2016 (warmest) and 2015 (second or third warmest). The near-record temperatures occurred in the absence of E1 Niño, which is usually a factor in extreme global warmth. For much of 2017, E1 Niño-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) conditions were neutral, and October 2017 readings were 0.38–4.48° Celsius (0.68–0.86° Fahrenheit) above the 1981–2010 average, depending on the dataset. It was the warmest non-E1 Niño year in the instrumental record.

By 2020, models project that global surface temperature will be more than 05°C (0.9° F) warmer than the 1986-2005 average, regardless of which carbon dioxide emissions pathway the world follows. This similarity in temperatures regardless of total emissions is a short-term phenomenon; it reflects the tremendous inertia of increased heat being trapped by greenhouse gases. By 2030, however, the heating imbalance caused by greenhouse gases begins to overcome the oceans' thermal inertia, and projected temperature pathways begin to diverge, with unchecked carbon dioxide emissions likely leading to several additional degrees of warming by the end of the century.

With the rise in temperature, the disasters like storms, heat waves, floods and droughts have also worsened. These result in an atmosphere that can collect, retain and drop more water further leading to changing weather patterns in such a way that wet areas become wetter and dry ones become drier. Due to the warming atmosphere, there have been an increasing number of droughts, intense storms and floods which has dumped more moisture further posing risk to public safety and health. Drought conditions endanger the access to clean drinking water, fuel out-of-control wildfires and result into dust storms, extreme heat events and flash flooding. Lack of water around the world has led to serious diseases and death. On the opposite end, heavier rains causes the rivers, streams and lakes to overflow which further damage life and property, contaminate drinking water, lead to hazardous-material spills and promotes mold

infestation and unhealthy air. Warmer and wetter the air, more likely it is for food-borne and waterborne illnesses and disease-carrying insects like mosquitoes, fleas and ticks to brood and grow.

Not just this, climate change has also become the biggest global health threat of the 21st century and is a threat that impacts us all—especially children, elderly and low-income communities and minorities directly or indirectly. With spiking temperature, there is a sudden spear in incidence of illness, emergency room visits and death as well.

So, we witness more hot days in places where once people experienced normal temperature conditions. A number of heat-related deaths have been reported each year due to direct impacts and indirect effects of heat-exacerbated, life-threatening illnesses which entail a long list such as heat exhaustion, heatstroke and cardiovascular and kidney diseases. It is no more surprising to know that extreme heat kills more people around the planet each year on average, than hurricanes, tornadoes, lightning and floods combined.

Moreover, increase in ground level ozone; which is the main component of smog; is another factor that's gifted by rising temperature and that worsens air pollution. This pollution from cars, factories and other sources react to sunlight and heat. With the undergoing rapid changes in sea and land, animals inhabiting them are also doomed to disappear if they aren't able to adapt quickly to the changing conditions. While many face seasonal behaviours and traditional migration patterns, others experience increased extinction risk due to climate change. Oceans become more acidic due to absorption of our excess emissions by a large part of the seas; further posing threat to underwater life.

Climate change overall is promising a frightening future and it's growing alarmingly; with no back door escape or exit for us. With the pumping of a century's worth of pollution into the air in nearly unchecked fashion; we are inviting the end of this beautiful planet day by day. It's high time that we came forward together to combat the

consequences of climate change not just at a global level but from very basic units such as community and locality as well.

Coral Reef: Challenges and Opportunities for Sustainable Management



The ocean conceals billions of creatures interacting in ways that we never understand completely. In the darkest and deepest parts of the oceans are ecosystems with more diversity than a tropical rainforest. Corals are one of the most diverse and splendid habitats of marine ecosystems. Appearing as solitary forms in the fossil record more than 400 million years ago, Corals are extremely ancient animals that evolved into modern reef-building forms over the last 25 million years. The coral community is a unique and complex ecosystem which includes a vast collection of several biological communities, representing one of the most extraordinary and diverse ecosystems of the world. That is why they are often referred to as the “Rainforests of the oceans.”

Coral reefs are an erosion-resistant marine ridge or mound consisting chiefly of compacted coral together with algae material and biochemically deposited magnesium and calcium carbonates. They are made of tiny animals called ‘polyps’ that stay fixed at one place and are the main structure of a reef. They have a hard outer skeleton made of calcium which provides habitat for a large variety of organisms that rely on corals as a source of food and shelter. Consisting of plants, fishes and many other creatures, coral reefs are home to about 25% of all marine life. There are shrimp, starfish, jellyfish, sponges, sea slugs, oysters, clams, sea water, sea urchins; several types of fungi, sea turtles and many other species of fish.

Coral reefs are fragile ecosystem as they cannot survive beyond 26-27 degree water temperature in water. Less than 0.1% of the world’s

ocean floor is covered by coral reefs. Their growth rate is very slow. They grow anywhere from 0.3 c.m. to 10 c.m. per year. The Great Barrier Reef is the largest coral reef which is made up of over 2900 individual reefs and 900 islands stretching for over 2600 km off the north east coast of Australia.

The significance of coral reefs cannot be underestimated. While most people never venture far beyond the coast, the coral reefs, deep inside the dark ocean provide a great range of precious gifts of nature which are integral part of our health and economics. By one estimate, the total net benefit per year of the world's coral reefs is \$29.8 billion. Tourism and recreation account for \$9.6 billion of this amount, coastal protection for \$9.0 billion, fisheries for \$5.7 billion and biodiversity for \$5.5 billion (Cesar, Burke and Pet-Soede, 2003). A great range of medication including some anti-cancer drugs and painkillers come from reefs. They protect shorelines from big waves by absorbing wave energy and also help carbon cycle. They are mine of information as coral reefs and their associated communities of sea grasses, mangroves and mudflats are sensitive indicators of water quality and the ecological integrity of the ecosystems. They endure relatively narrow ranges of temperature, salinity, water clarity, other chemicals and water quality characteristics which can further help local resource managers in developing sound management plans for coral reefs and other coastal and marine resources.

The existence of coral reefs is in peril. They are disappearing for a number of reasons. The precious natural heritage is bearing the burns of two kinds of stresses associated with reef systems: natural and human induced. Fertilizers drained out into oceans promote algae growth which covers the coral and it dies. More CO₂ absorption into the oceans makes the water acidic which makes it harder for coral to make their shells. Corals can't live beyond 26-27 degree water temperature; greenhouse gas emissions pose a threat to them. Apart from all these things, dangerous fishing methods like cyanide or blast fishing have a detrimental effect and kill corals.

Although the coral reefs are on the verge of decay; yet it's not a tough row to hoe. We can still mull over the current situation and come up with the solution of the problem. By adopting some preventive measures we can save coral reefs. We should eat sustainably seafood to protect them. We can decrease marine litter and protect coral reefs by adopting the three "Rs - Reduce, Reuse, Recycle". We can come together and support marine national park. We can inform others about the vitality of coral reefs and the threat they are facing. Though we cannot deny the negative impact of mentioned stress on coral reefs yet every cloud has a silver lining. We should do our bit for this cause and make a difference.

Climate Change is Farce



Over the years, climate change has been a cause of worry for the scientists across the globe. Several studies have been done to estimate the reasons behind changes in climate, global warming, melting of glaciers and warming of ocean waters, etc. But there hasn't been any defined theory that justifies and authenticates the reasons put forth by various climate scientists and experts in regard to this change in climate.

Globalisation, urbanisation and industrialisation are often considered the main cause behind the climatic change which is affecting the society as a whole. It is believed that carbon dioxide gas released in the air through various sources viz. industries, burning, car emissions, etc. is raising the temperature of the planet and if this is continued the same way, the Earth will soon become a hot planet without any habitation. The links between the rise in temperature and carbon emission cannot be denied. We have been listening to these predictions over the years. But the question which arises remains the same over the years- "Is the rate of climate change really this fast?" and "Will Earth really become inhabitable?"

It is high time that the layman as well as the experts understand that the change is marginal and the various assertions which are coming in news lately like climate change leads to child marriages or linking global warming to malaria is completely baseless. The focus should be shifted to real problems. All this tends to resonate that climate change is a farce.

Each country has defined set of climate policies which undermine the efforts made by the people of the nation to avoid exploiting the environment. Environmentalists and climate scientists are studying day and night about various climate phenomena. While majority of scientists studying the climate change have agreed that human activity is responsible for changing the climate, there are still some who deny that climate change is for real and even exists or that humans are responsible for its occurrence.

These deniers are usually not climate scientists nor do they come face to face with the scientists who claim any change. These deniers usually focus their attention on the media, the general public and policy makers with the aim of delaying any action on climate change. They are often backed upon by various coal and oil companies who fund them to publish and stand against the reality of climate change.

Over the years, there have been several arguments employed by the deniers, some of which are even contradictory to each other. They have claimed that climate change is not occurring at all. Some say that climate globally is actually getting colder thereby declining the fact that temperature is actually rising. Some of their claims agree with increase in global temperature, but deny any connection with human activities.

Some claim that human activities are causing the rise in temperature but the subsequent impacts are not sufficient for the need of any policy. After attesting the reality and importance of global climate change for almost two decades, their tactics have shifted their focus on arguing over the fact that though climate change is occurring but the cost incurred to take any action is too high or it's too late to take any action.

However, all such fake claims have been rejected by the global climate community on the whole. To understand the scientific consensus on climate change, there have been studies of various published journals over the years. As a conclusion, it has been found

that half of the published articles gave equal heed to the claims of deniers in opposition to the scientific credited views.

Media is also to blame for the same to some extent. This discrepancy is a result of the media's drive to provide equal weight to both sides with equal attention. As a result, the reality of climate change still remains an unfolded story. Scientists across the globe are still debating over the issue whether climate change is for real or is it any absurd comedy whose truth is not known.

Merely not going by the claims of the deniers, it is high time that people start believing on the factual study conducted by climate scientists using high-end technology incorporating satellites to estimate the real cause of the problem and also find out solution to the same as a team because climate change is what is affecting not only these scientists but everyone occupying a space in this universe.

Not working and acknowledging this problem is equivalent to letting a fire burn down the whole building just because the temperature of the flames is not known, or not addressing the fact that smoking causes lung cancer because few doctors still claim its authenticity. According to United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), one cannot delay working upon the climate change over uncertainty over some of its aspects.

Now, it is time that the world stops ignoring the climate change and takes up responsibility as a citizen of the planet to counter this problem. Sidelining the claims of any deniers, one should stick to the facts and also maintain a sense of perspective by avoiding any insubstantial theory and baseless and ineffective solutions which basically diverts one from fixing the real problem. Though it may seem, but climate change is not a farce. It is high time that we deal with this real and serious issue diligently.

Groundwater Conservation and Management for Agricultural Purpose in India



Owing to the relative ease and flexibility with which it can be tapped, groundwater is becoming a progressively more popular resource. By developing groundwater resource, promise of poverty alleviation in many areas sees a hope; yet, its sustainable use and management in regions where it is under threat poses a major challenge.

Groundwater forms a vital natural resource for sustenance of India's agricultural economy and also meeting the goals of country's social, economic and environmental needs. This unique resource is widely available and is a security against droughts. Its linkage with surface water resources and the hydrological cycle, yet directs towards the urgent need of harnessing the surface water and soil. The conditions requisite for its availability constitute the geo-hydrology, aquifers characteristics ranging from deep to alluvium, sediment crystalline rocks to basalt formations and agro climate ranging from humid to sub-humid and semi-arid to arid.

The features which make it more attractive as compared to other resources are its low cost of development, minimum evaporation losses, relative turbidity, uniform quality and temperature, reliable supply and pollution-safe. It serves as a major source of drinking water to rural population and almost 80% of domestic water usage in rural India is supplied from groundwater and major part of it is supplied to farms, villages and small towns.

Water Stress Index 2019 ranks India as the 46th highest risk country in the world; 11 of India's 20 largest cities in the country are facing

extreme risk, notably Delhi, Chennai, Agra, Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Indore, Kanpur, Nashik, Lucknow, Hyderabad, Bengaluru. Water Stress Index measures water use by households, industry and agriculture compared with available supplies from rivers, streams and lakes.

The 'groundwater drought' that India faces at present is a consequence of the rapid and unmanaged groundwater withdrawal. With less than 3% of terrestrial land mass supporting about 19% of the global populace, India covers more than 30% of the global irrigated land and consumes the largest volume of global groundwater.

The burgeoning population of India demands rapid urbanization and change in anthropogenic water use, further affecting cropping pattern and lifestyle that lead to unsuitable absorption of available groundwater. This has led to withdrawal of more than 80% of the available groundwater in most parts of the country. Global groundwater depletion (GWD) linked with food production and trade amounts to 33.9% and India has been placed in the top of the list of groundwater depletion.

Causes of Groundwater Depletion

The diversity in hydro-geologic set-up and climatic conditions of the country has led to heterogeneous recharge of the natural available groundwater. Inefficient water use practices, low prices of power for electricity-driven well pumps and supplied water and wasteful irrigation systems with poor maintenance have led to its depletion.

On one hand, the northern India presents highly groundwater-enriched, porous aquifers of the India-Ganges-Brahmaputra (IGB) river basins and, on the other hand, peninsular India constitutes low-yielding, crystalline aquifers. The climate of the country varies from extremely arid to some of the wettest places on Earth.

Unregulated extraction of water for enhanced irrigation of water intensive cultivation that comprises boro rice including Basmati has

led to one of the most rapid and drastic groundwater depletions in human history.

Steps Taken by Government

A paradigm shift has been seen through the recent central and state government management strategies on groundwater withdrawal and stress on management strategies through schemes like Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana.

Policies that restrict subsidized electricity distribution for agriculture purpose like Gram Jyoti Yojana are also seen as promising for the future.

Construction of large-scale, regional enhanced recharge systems in water-stressed crystalline aquifers allocated to Tapti river mega recharge project is one of the major steps undertaken by the government.

Interlinking of river catchments, for example, Narmada-Sabarmati interlinking project is a credible step towards replenishment of aquifers through increasing of groundwater storage in near future.

Strategies for Regions with Over-exploitation of Groundwater

Much of northern, southern, central and western India have one thing in common - they lie in arid and semi-arid climatic zones featuring low to medium rain and low natural recharge rates. The aquifers range from hard rock in southern, western and central part to deep alluvial in northern part. So, for water lifting devices, electric tube wells form the main source of energy here.

Farmers should be discouraged to dig new wells and tube wells and any further investment in creating new groundwater asset is not required in these parts. Rather, efficient usage of existing groundwater structures by investing in water efficiency measures will reap benefits for farmers.

While separation of agricultural feeders from rural domestic feeders and investments in high voltage distribution systems for rationing of high quality power to agriculture is already underway in states like Punjab and Karnataka, what needs to be done is the combining of reduced pumping activity with more efficient water use in order to enhance crop per drop of groundwater.

Innovations in groundwater sector are a prerequisite to revitalization of surface water irrigation sector. Public canal systems need to respond to farmers' expectations of timely and reliable water supply. Innovations such as on-farm water storage will help increase reliability and flexibility of canal water supplies. This is called diggies in Rajasthan.

Schemes such as diesel subsidy scheme, pump subsidy scheme and solar power scheme already launched in state of Bihar need to be applied to other states that aim to reduce cost of groundwater irrigation. A major share of India's groundwater resources is owned by small and marginal farmers and adopting such pro-poor strategies can pave the way for second green revolution in the country.

Ways to Conserve Groundwater

Protecting and conserving water is everyone's duty and so before relying upon the government to come and fix it, everyone at individual level must be aware of following some basic ways to conserve this resource.

Fixing leaks wherever seen, such as in pipes, toilets and faucets is much larger problem than imagined and water can be conserved by changing high discharge outlets with low discharge ones.

Using water wisely and only when required can reduce water usage. Small alterations in our habits like replacing our flush toilet with a low-flow unit, running laundry and dish washing machines at full load and taking shorter showers can bring good results.

Right from using toothpaste and shampoo to toilet cleaners and detergents, everything drains down our bathrooms and kitchens to end up in water bodies or seep into the ground to mix with the groundwater which is similar to effluents discharged from industries. Treatment of wastewater before release is the prime need. By switching to natural substances for domestic needs like lemon juice, baking soda and vinegar will help discharge of less chemical waste.

Wet waste should be separated from dry ones and biodegradable waste can be turned into manure and used to grow plants.

Farmers should be educated to use natural manures and stay away from excessive usage of pesticides that end up mixing and polluting the groundwater.

Septic tanks should be set up far away from source of fresh water and villagers including farmers should be made aware of maintaining septic tanks such that they never make contact with groundwater. An excellent way to conserve groundwater is to preserve rainwater as it reduces our reliance on groundwater.

Urbanization and Its Hazards



Urbanization refers to large scale migration of people from rural areas to cities in search of better opportunities like well-paying jobs, better schools, colleges and better lifestyle. Some reasons why people migrate to urban areas are poor health and hygiene facilities, extremely bad condition of roads, no proper schools and colleges, limited job opportunities, etc. The urban areas are equipped with infrastructure, public facilities as well as employment opportunities compared to the rural areas. Therefore, inhabitants are more attracted to migrate in cities to avail hi-tech facilities, enhance their lifestyles and ultimately these activities raise numerous urbanization problems. The U.N. World Urbanization Prospects 2018 report has said that about 34% of India's population now lives in urban areas.

Causes of Urbanization

Industrialization

Industrialization is the process by which an economy is transformed from primarily old agricultural economy to non agricultural economy that is one based on the manufacturing of goods. It is one of the causes of urbanization. Urban cities have better economic growth and job opportunities that attract people towards cities. Multiple factories are established in urban cities, which lead to a demand of factory labour. Industrialization has increased employment opportunities by giving people a chance to work in modern sectors in job categories that also helps in economic development.

Employment Opportunities

In cities and towns, there are plentiful job opportunities in all sectors such as public, health, education, transport, sports and recreation, industries, and business enterprises that continually attract people from the rural areas to seek better livelihood.

Education

Urban cities have better education facilities. There are highly upgraded universities, colleges for every course while rural areas do not have schools for higher education and universities for professional courses. The teachers and professors in urban areas are more skilled, educated and have better understanding of their respective subjects.

Modernization

Urban areas have better facilities with sophisticated infrastructure, medical facilities, communication, dress code, liberalization and other social availabilities. People believe they can lead a happy and comfortable life in urban areas.

Social Causes

Many social factors such as attraction towards cities, better standard of living, better educational and employment facilities, need for status also induce people to migrate to cities.

Commercialization

The distribution of goods and services and commercial transactions in the modern era has developed modern marketing institutions and exchange methods that have tremendously given rise to the growth of towns and cities. Commercialization and trade comes with the general perception that the towns and cities offer better commercial opportunities and returns compared to the rural areas.

Hazards of Urbanization

Pollution

Industrialization in urban areas has led to more pollution due to the release of greenhouse gases and other chemicals by industries. Vehicular pollution has also increased due to more and more number of people migrating to cities.

Overcrowding

Overcrowding is a situation in which a large number of people live in too little space. Urbanization leads to congestion of huge number of people into a small area. As more and more people migrate to cities in search of better facilities, it causes overcrowding.

Unemployment

Unemployment is the highest in urban areas. As people are migrating in huge numbers, the number of job opportunities has become considerably low as compared to the population. Income is high in urban areas but the cost of living makes the income horribly low.

Poor Sanitation and Health Issues

Due to overpopulation and rapid population increase in most of the urban cities, there are inadequate sewage facilities which lead to poor sanitation. Sewages are drained into neighbouring rivers, lakes, seas which results in spreading of communicable diseases such as typhoid, dysentery, plague, and diarrhoea leading to suffering and even deaths.

Increase in Crime

Many crimes such as murder, robbery, theft, rape, kidnapping and riots are reported in urban cities. Some reasons why these crimes take place include unemployment, poverty, illiteracy and lack of resources. These acts of urban crime upset the peace and tranquillity of cities/towns.

Traffic Congestion

As more and more people move to cities and towns, transport system is highly affected. The number of vehicles on roads increases which leads to traffic and vehicular pollution.

Housing Problems

Overpopulation in urban cities has caused scarcity of houses. This is due to poverty, unemployment, and costly building materials which can only be afforded by few.

Expansion of Slums

Due to poverty and lack of access to formal housing, slums are developed in urban cities. Another reason for expansion of slums in urban cities is lack of developed land for housing and the elevated prices of land which is beyond the reach of the urban poor.

Possible Measures

More Job Opportunities

More jobs should be created for people. Government should provide funds to encourage entrepreneurship. Subsidies and grants may as well be provided to foreign and private investment in environmentally friendly development projects that encourage job creation.

Environment-friendly Cities

Sustainable cities should be built that embrace improved environmental conditions and safe habitats for all urban population. Campaigns should be made to create awareness among people to keep their city green and clean. Pollution should be controlled by taking appropriate measures like encouraging people to use public transport, dispose industrial waste properly, etc.

Easing Traffic Congestion

Traffic congestion must be controlled in urban regions and people must be encouraged to use public transports. Traffic control system should be improved to avoid accidents.

Improve Condition of Rural Areas

The condition of schools and colleges must be improved. High schools and universities must be established in rural areas with more skilled teachers and better teaching facilities. Better health and medical facilities must be provided in rural areas so that people do not need to move to cities because of minor inconveniences.

Speedy urbanization has many unconstructive implications especially towards social and environmental aspects. While the process of urbanization occurs at global scale, it is more visible in developing countries. This growth has led to concerns about the sustainability of these urban centres. Huge growth in the world population and migration of people to urban cities is causing major concern about the quality of life in these urban cities.

The Country's Need for a Better Disaster Management System



Disaster is extreme disturbance in the functioning of a habitat that causes widespread human, environment or material losses that overreach the ability of the affected population to cope with its own resources. About 59% of the landmass is prone to earthquakes of various intensities, over 40 million hectares is prone to floods, about 8% of the total area is prone to cyclones and 69% of the area is susceptible to drought. Some of the examples of disasters are landslides, earthquakes, tsunamis, cyclones, droughts, floods, etc.

India is a highly disaster prone country because of its geographical locations and geological formations. India has long coastline, snow-clad high peaks, high mountain ranges, the perennial rivers in the north that are responsible for this problem. India, which has only two per cent of the total geographical area, has to support 16 per cent of total world population. Naturally, there is a tremendous pressure on the natural resources, which directly or indirectly lead to the occurrence of disasters.

The year 2019 has been one of the worst years in the history for India when it comes to natural disasters. As many as 13 Indian states (Kerala, Gujarat, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Odisha) have been affected due to floods. Government reports state that the year witnessed the heaviest monsoon rains to wreck havoc in India in the last 25 years. More than 1,600 people were killed with millions of people losing their homes and their livelihood

Example of life threatening natural disasters that caused a great loss to mankind was Tsunami that took place in 2004. With the magnitude of 9.1– 9.3, it was the third largest earthquake of the world recorded

ever. Almost 227,898 people died. The earthquake had the longest duration of faulting ever observed, between 8.3 and 10 minutes.

Another major disaster was Uttarakhand floods in 2013. The huge and life threatening cloudburst caused flash floods and landslides that struck Uttarakhand from 14 to 17 June, 2013. More than 5,700 people were assumed dead and more than 1 lakh pilgrims were trapped in the valleys leading to Kedarnath shrine and there are many more such examples.

Disaster management is a well-planned strategy for making efforts to reduce the hazards caused by the disasters. Disaster management does not remove or eliminate the threats. It focuses on formulating plans to decrease the effect of disasters. A well coordinated disaster management helps the country to know about the potential hazards of the disasters and provides the answer to the many questions like how, when, where the disasters can occur. National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) has been set to coordinate responses to natural or man-made disasters across the country. It lays down policies on disaster management, takes measures for the prevention of disaster, mitigation and prepares for dealing with threatening disaster situations. It coordinates the enforcement and implementation of the policy and plans for disaster management.

Steps that Can Be Taken to Make a Better Disaster Management System

The National Policy on disaster management reflecting the universal approach involving prevention, mitigation and preparedness in pre-disaster phase should be restructured with appropriate additional funding, along with the so far existent policy of the post-disaster relief and rehabilitation under crisis management.

Awareness, sensitivity and preparedness to respond to such situations should be increased among the decision makers, administrators, policy makers, professionals (engineers, architects), financial institutions (banks, house financing institutions) and common people.

The authorities should have detailed sets of data and information on phenomenon that lead to disasters. Scientifically collated and analyzed time series data on climate, geological, hydrological and environmental aspects can enhance our understanding of natural events, their likely impact on life and property and development of effective warning systems.

The State administration managing the impact of a disaster should be able to coordinate and regulate the works of various NGOs. Many such agencies coming with relief from farther areas do not have a good knowledge of the geography and socio-economic environment of affected regions. Under such circumstances, channelizing such relief from specific centralized points to different zones as per feedback received from a continuously monitored assessment system can yield better results.

Disaster management policies must incorporate programs to protect the most vulnerable segments of society—the poor, marginalized, women, children, disabled, and elderly.

Given that natural disasters do not always follow national boundaries, cross-boundary issues of its management should be addressed through enhanced regional cooperation. Furthermore, an effective regional response system should be developed to pool capacity for mutual benefit.

Effectively use the expertise of domestic as well as international agencies specializing in the rescue of life and engage army and Para-military in rescue operations.

Each and every person must take an active part at the time of disasters to reduce the risk of human life by donating money and things of basic necessity or by being a part of rescue team. A proper disaster management team capable of taking charge as soon as possible when the disaster strikes should be established. To handle the situation efficiently, we need to be well-equipped with latest technologies. Rehabilitation is an integral part of disaster management. When disasters occur administrative measures are terribly inadequate and perhaps this is the most difficult period for a

victim. The role of administration does not end with the end of disasters. In fact, its efforts and commitment get more complex. It requires proper coordination among various agencies. In this context it is very important to note that disasters are non-routine events that require non-routine response. Government cannot rely on normal procedures to implement appropriate responses — the rescue teams require learning special skills, technologies and attitudes in dealing with disasters.

Effective disaster management, therefore, needs to ensure that the different interests and priorities of communal life are integrated into planning and response, especially those of vulnerable people and groups. The natural disasters are inevitable, even if we have measures to predict/ forecast them, we cannot stop them from happening. The best which can be done is to avoid the practices which are hazardous for the environment and are leading towards environmental degradation, while preparing plans for our disaster management.

Injustice of Capital Punishment



Death penalty or capital punishment has been a controversial subject and many people oppose it in general even if they are convinced in the guilt of the accused. Others feel that it is the proper punishment for the crimes committed. Capital punishment or death penalty is a legal process whereby a person is put to death by the state as a punishment for a crime. The judicial decree that someone be punished in this manner is a death sentence, while the actual process of killing the person is an execution.

The Amnesty International in its latest report has found that the global executions have fallen by almost one-third in 2018 and that makes it the lowest rate in at least a decade. This dramatic global fall in executions shows that even the countries which are most unlikely to abandon the practice are now beginning to change their ways and have realized that death penalty is not the answer.

This indicates hope about this cruel punishment being consigned to history in only a matter of time.

According to the Amnesty International, there were 2,531 death sentences globally in 2018 as compared to 2,591 reported in 2017. Of all the known executions, around 78 percent were carried out in just four countries: Iran, Saudi Arabia, Vietnam and Iraq. Also, in Iran where the death penalty is too common form of punishment, the executions have fallen down by a huge 50 percent.

But, even after the positive news, capital punishment has been in use continuously and that violates basic human rights including the right to a fair trial and the importance of ensuring dignity and respect.

Seeking for the state of the satisfaction for the public in the ploy of capital punishment simply does not form a part of justice or serving justice. In a civilized society it does not deserve a place. Countries such as Saudi Arabia, Iran, China and Pakistan continue to execute people at an alarming rate and convictions often follow legal proceedings that violate every standard of fairness and human decency.

History talks of many different types of execution that included death through beheading, lethal injection, poison, electrification, guillotine, shooting (death by firing squad), death by stoning and hanging.

The state punishes the criminals for vengeance, retribution, deterrence and incapacitation and most importantly recidivism. The most known of all the capital punishments happened in history are the assassination of political personalities like Socrates, the Prime Minister of Pakistan Zulfikar Ali Bhutto and President of Iraq Saddam Hussain. And more recently, a court in Pakistan had sentenced Pervez Musharraf to death in November 2019 after finding him guilty of high treason for subverting the constitution in 2007.

Evolution of Capital Punishment in India

After independence in 1947, India retained the 1861 Penal Code which provided for the death penalty for murder. During the drafting of the Indian Constitution between 1947 and 1949, several members of the Constituent Assembly expressed the ideal of abolishing the death penalty, but no such provision was incorporated in the Constitution.

Private members' bills to abolish the death penalty were introduced in both houses of Parliament over the next two decades, but none of them was adopted. It has been estimated that 3000 to 4000 executions occurred between 1950 and 1980.

Information on the numbers of persons sentenced to death and executed from 1980 to the mid- 1990s is harder to measure. It is estimated that two or three persons were hanged per year. In the Bachan Singh judgment of 1980, the Supreme Court ruled that the death penalty should be used only in the “rarest of rare” cases, but what defines rarest of the rare is not clear.

The Ratio Decidendi of Bacchan Singh case is that the death sentence is constitutional if it is prescribed as an alternative for the offence of murder and if the normal sentence prescribed by law for murder is imprisonment for life. This means that death penalty can only be imposed on “rarest of rare cases” where an alternative option is excluded.

Later, in the case of Macchi Singh v. State of Punjab, the court tried to lay down criteria for assessing whether a crime fell into the category of “rarest of rare.” In the case of Santosh Kumar Bariyar v. State of Maharashtra, the Supreme Court ruled that, “The rarest of rare dictum serves as a guideline in enforcing Section 354(3) and establishes the policy that life imprisonment is the rule and death punishment is an exception.”

Section 303 of the Indian Penal Code mandated death penalty for all offenders serving a life sentence. This section was struck down as being held unconstitutional. The year 2008 accounted for the case of Prajeet Kumar Singh v. State of Bihar, wherein the court ruled exactly on what would constitute a “rarest of rare case.” The Court held that a death sentence would be awarded only, “when a murder is committed in an extremely brutal, grotesque, diabolical, revolting or dastardly manner so as to arouse intense and extreme indignation of the community.

In India it is legal but rarely voted for and it has been used only four times since 1995 on Auto Shankar in 1995, Dhananjay Chatterjee in 2004, Ajmal Kasab in 2012 and Afzal Guru in 2013. Though there are numerous countries that forbid death sentences, there is an international consensus till date regarding its legality. A Delhi Court in January 2020 issued death warrant against four convicts in the 2012 Nirbhaya gang-rape and murder case. For now, the hanging has been deferred by the Apex court due to mercy pleas by the convicts.

The court wants it to be established as an example and the most frequent argument for capital punishment is that of deterrence and the prevailing thought is that imposition of the death penalty will act to discourage other criminals from committing violent acts.

More so, earlier the penalty for rape cases was life imprisonment that was supported by both states and central government; but now capital punishment has been imposed for rape as well as murder. In that case, the rapists are more prone to commit the dual crime of raping as well as murdering the victim thinking of the punishment to be of same kind in both the cases. This has to some extent led to increase in crimes against women although it was introduced for checking and limiting such crimes in the first place.

It also happens in many cases that convicts are wrongly charged for the crimes which haven't been proved against them and even some people might be wrongly accused and punished in place of the actual convicts. In such cases, no compensation from the government's end may be useful for the family of the innocent person wrongly punished.

So, in order to regulate and mitigate such circumstances, standardized guidelines should be laid down. This will help dilute the confusion in the mind of various jurists regarding which cases can be identified as rarest of rare.

The decision should be taken with due care and reasonableness and it should be kept in mind that although the accused has committed a

brutal act, if there is any chance that proves that the accused shall not inflict further harm to society; on this ground, he/she must not be given capital punishment. It shouldn't be rendered in haste and the punishment should be reasonable in comparison with the act.

Should India have a Uniform Civil Code?



The topic of uniform civil code has been one of the most burning issues in the country. After the government delivered on its electoral promises of abrogation of Article 375 and abolishing the evil practice of triple talaq, the demand for implementation of a uniform civil code in the country started gaining more traction. Many people are of the opinion that as the government has the required mandate and implementation of uniform civil code was a poll promise, then what is the need for waiting and the uniform civil code must be implemented as soon as possible. But the issue is not as simple as it may seem on the face of it. India is a religiously and culturally diverse country and there are various groups who have their reservations on this matter. So, this beckons the question as to whether India should have a uniform civil code.

What does Uniform Civil Code Mean?

Uniform Civil Code means that all the citizens of a country to be governed by the same set of laws formulated by the democratically elected government of India. Implementation of the Uniform Civil Code would lead to discontinuation of various personal laws that have been used in India for many years. There is a popular belief that when all the citizens of the country are subjected to the same set of laws, it will bring them all at parity and help the country progress further.

History of the Uniform Civil Code in India

The concept of uniform civil code was brought up by Dr B R Ambedkar during the constitutional debates. He was inspired by the

idea of uniformity in the western world where the same set of laws and principles are applicable to all citizens irrespective of their religion, creed, or colour. He believed that a uniform civil code would bring about uniformity in the Indian society and will act as a uniting force for the country.

But his idea was met with stiff opposition from the other members of the constituent assembly. Their objection was based on the grounds that India is home to a wide variety of religions and cultures and the uniform civil code will destroy that diversity. Moreover, arguments were given that uniform civil code will infringe on the right to religious freedom under article 25 and article 26 of the constitution of India. Consequently, the matter was left to be implemented by the government in the future and was included in the article 44 of the constitution which read that “The state shall endeavour to secure for the citizens a Uniform Civil Code throughout the territory of India.”

The Present-day Scenario in India

In modern-day India, Goa is the only state in the country where a Common Family Code is applicable for matters pertaining to marriage, succession, and adoption. The issue of Uniform Civil Code has been touched upon by the courts in various judgements including the famous case of Shah Bano where the Supreme Court's Constitution Bench noted that the government should bring in a uniform civil code as its absence is leading to degradation in the position of women in the society. But instead of thinking about the Uniform Civil Code, due to opposition from groups with vested interests, the Central Government enacted another separate law for Muslim women i.e. Muslim Women (Protection of Rights on Divorce) Act, 1986. Ever since, no government has shown any serious intent to implement the Uniform Civil Code; a decision which can be attributed to political interests instead of preserving the diversity of the country.

Why India should have a Uniform Civil Code?

The basic premise behind the idea of the Uniform Civil Code is to bring an end to all forms of religious discrimination prevalent in the country. It is not a hidden fact that personal laws of all religions have been used to oppress women. In the name of tradition and faith, women are subject to inhumane treatments and have to face suppression in various forms due to the enshrined gender discrimination in the personal laws and their interpretations. Only those groups have been opposing the Uniform Civil Code that have abused the personal laws for their benefits. Here are some essential factors that have been necessitating the formulation of a uniform civil code:

- Against the secular credentials: - India has always taken pride in its secular credentials, but with various personal laws in practice, the notion of secularism seems hollow. When certain communities are being allowed to run their religion-based parallel courts to determine the disputes related to personal matters, how can the country be truly secular? Only a Uniform Civil Code can ensure unity in diversity in the country and enforce the secular credentials of the country.
- Equality for women: - Banning of triple talaq came as a respite for Muslim women who always lived under the threat of being given instant divorce by their husbands. Now, that the entire Indian society is becoming conscious about the rights of the women and is working towards equal representation to women, there is no place for oppressive and regressive personal laws.
- Unity of the nation: - There is an underlying dissatisfaction amongst a large section of the society against certain communities who are being given preferential treatment through personal laws. It is acting as an impediment in the nation coming together and become united in the true sense. Only with the help of a Uniform Civil Code can these differences be addressed, and the country is united in reality.
- Global parity: - India is being touted to become the next superpower in the world, along with China. In such a situation when the eyes of the entire world are on India, having various sets of personal laws bring the credentials of the country into

disrepute. By doing away with different personal laws and bringing in a Uniform Civil Code, India can emerge as a much stronger, secular, and united country that is ready to have its say on the matters of global significance.

The need for having a Uniform Civil Code in India cannot be overlooked and is an issue that demands urgent attention from the government and other decision-making bodies. Efforts should be made to build a consensus around the Uniform Civil Code, and it should be implemented and adopted in the true sense.

‘Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao Yojana’ – has it Changed People’s Mindset



“**W**hen you educate a man, you educate a man but when you educate a woman, you educate a generation”. The social awareness campaign of the Indian Government, “Beti Bachao, Beti Padaho” shares the same notion and is thereby taking a forward step in generating interests amongst parents of baby girl to celebrate her presence rather than treating her as burden.

Over the past one century, girl child in Indian families has been treated as a burden which would one day go away to another family with huge dowry. This mindset prevails not just in rural India but also amongst well educated families of urban background.

Moreover, practices such as female foeticide or abandoning the girl child have been common among orthodox families. Even many families go on throwing away the born girl child in garbage. Girls have been prevented by society as well as families from going to schools or opting for higher studies.

Many laws and campaigns took place but were of little or no use. People lacked awareness and continued with inhuman practices. But, the new government led by Narendra Modi in 2014, brought up an effective initiative with new campaign named “Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao”(BBBP). This social campaign aims at generating awareness and improving the efficiency of welfare services which intend for protecting the girl child.

Story so Far

A significant declining trend in child sex ratio (CSR) has been witnessed in the census 2011. It stated 918 girls per 1000 boys in the age group of 0-6 years. This CSR in 1961 was 976. It has declined in 429 out of 640 districts; that is two-thirds of the country. 244 districts remained below the national average of 918.

The decline has been presenting a grave picture of Indian women who have been facing such low status in the society. This disempowerment continues over a life-cycle. Gender-based sex selection and pre-birth discrimination continued to be followed. If people were not happy by this, they continued with post birth discrimination against girls in terms of health care, nutrition and educational opportunities.

To address this declining Child Sex Ratio and related issues, the government launched the BBBP in Panipat, Haryana on 22nd January 2015. This tri-ministerial effort is convergent of Ministries of Women and Child Development, Health and Family Welfare and Human Resource Development.

The focus lies on awareness and advocacy campaign for changing mindsets. It also aims at multi-sectoral action in select 161 districts which are low on CSR. This is to ensure that girls' education is enabled and the Pre-Conception & Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques Act (PC&PNDT) is enforced.

The initial funding for this scheme was Rs. 100 crore and not just CSR but rising crimes against women have also been targeted under this campaign. Under this "Selfie with Daughter," a motivating campaign promoted on social media in June 2015, initiated by Sunil Jaglan - the Sarpanch of village Bibipur, Haryana, was able to gain world-wide fame. He himself posted the selfie with his daughter Nandini on Facebook. Further, Olympics 2016 bronze medallist Sakshi Malik was appointed the brand ambassador of BBBP in 2016.

However, here's a bad news. Human Development (2019) Report says that out of 189 countries, India has been ranked 129th in gender

equality. World Economic Forum has also come up with a startling news that India has slipped to 112th rank in Gender Gap Index. India's ranking is lower than China's (106th), Sri Lanka (102nd), Nepal, (101st) and Bangladesh (50th). One wonders why we are so far behind our smaller neighbours.

So Far the Progress

The scheme was initiated in Phase 1: (2014-15, January, 2015) with 100 districts and got expanded to 61 additional districts in Phase-II (2015-16, February 2016).

The scheme has been received well and has gained success in establishing the improvement in Child Sex Ratio as a National Agenda. The results have been witnessed in form of growing awareness, sensitization and conscious building around the issue in public arena.

The Nodal agency for the implementation of the scheme is the Ministry of Women and Child Development. The State Social Welfare/ WCD departments have been supporting the ministry in the same. Departments of Health and Education have also coordinated well.

The scheme is driven on ground by the enthusiasm and motivation of the District Collector/ Deputy Magistrate (DCs/DMs) of selected districts.

Favourable trends have been visible in many districts and as per the latest report of the Health and Management Information System (HMIS) and Family Welfare (MoHFW) for 161 BBBP districts indicate that the progress on intermediary targets has been credible between April-March, 2016-17 and 2017-18.

Progress Status of 161 Districts

Sex ratio at birth (SRB)

In 104 BBBP districts out of 161 targeted ones, improving trend is visible in SRB. One district is only showing stable trend.

Status of First Trimester ANC Registration

Against the reported ANC registrations, 119 districts have reported progress in this status. 13 districts showed stable status.

Status of Institutional Deliveries

Against the total reported deliveries, institutional deliveries in 146 districts have improved as compared to previous year. Stable trend has been noticed in 60 districts.

Many initiatives have been undertaken by the District Administration in coordination with the WCD and Health and Education Departments.

1. Gudda Guddi Boards – Display of Birth Statistics in public places: This displays the number of girls born vis-à-vis number of boys. Entry point has been created discussion and debate on this issue. This has generated wakefulness amongst the passersby and locals. Jalgaon district in Maharashtra is one live example.

2. Brand Visibility of BBBP logo – BBBP logo is being used by all government buildings, public offices, official/public vehicles, public transport, school buses and more.

3. Local Champions – Local champions on BBBP are chosen from varied fields like sports, academics, writing, law and student to name a few. They were selected as role models excelling in their fields by the District Administration. They were entrusted to work in each block in order to sensitize the community about the significance of gender equality and women empowerment. Youth from gram panchayats and villages were mobilized by these local champions as community volunteers under BBBP.

4. Breaking gender stereotypes and challenging son-centric rituals
Dedicating special day on value of girl child through celebrations, linking of Sukanya Samriddhi accounts with birth of girl child and felicitating parents were some encouraging steps. Prevention of child marriages was also targeted.

5. Rewards and Recognition

Best Panchayats were felicitated. Parents who valued their daughters were recognized and community members and local champions were also rewarded for their exemplary work. Awarding meritorious girls also helped change people's mindset.

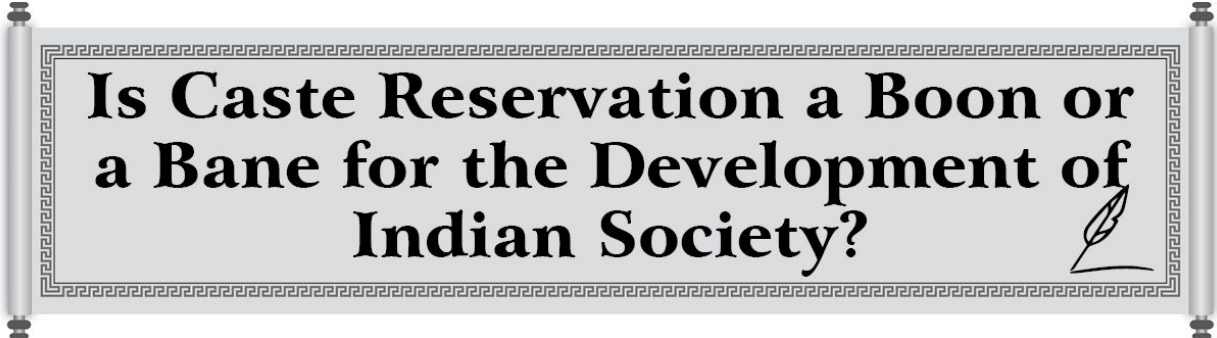
10 good performing districts were felicitated for their commendable work towards BBBP. These districts were Sikar, Raigarh, Tarantaran, North Sikkim, Bijapur (Vijaypur), Hyderabad, Sonapat, Ahmedabad, Jhunjhunu, Udhampur.

The sex ratio has crossed up to 950 females per 1000 males. The ratio of women police officers has also increased to 8.5% from the previous 6 per cent.

A large number of women are now joining the Armed Forces and becoming fighter pilots, scientists and doing research. Gita Gopinath, Dipa Karmakar, PV Sindhu, Karishma Shah, Sakshi Malik are few of the great achievers of contemporary India.

Government's focus on giving priority to quality education to girls is encouraging parents to send their girl child to school. Still, more needs to be done. The scheme requires great Civic body support to achieve its objectives pan India. The dowry system in varying forms is still prevalent in the society and needs to be tackled wisely. Police force needs to be more vigilant and dutiful towards registering the complaints from women victims of rapes and sex abuse.

Is Caste Reservation a Boon or a Bane for the Development of Indian Society?



The caste system initially marked people on the basis of their occupation like teaching and preaching (Brahmins), kingship and war (Kshatriya), business (vaish) etc. The caste system was meant to be an occupational division but soon it started dividing different sections of the society. Intermingling of castes was restricted as it led to untouchability and other social evils and built a harsh environment of animosity. Foreign rulers and colonial powers misused the caste based division in the society to further their own ends. The framers of the constitution of independent India included several provisions to eliminate inequality and discrimination prevalent in the Indian society. As per the government policy, 15% of the government jobs and 15% of the students admitted to universities must be from Scheduled castes and 7.5% must be from Scheduled tribes. Other than this, the state governments also follow their own reservation policies respectively based upon the population constitution of each state. So, nearly 50% seats are reserved.

Article 15 of the Constitution provides that no citizen shall be subjected to discrimination in matters of rights, privileges and immunities pertaining to him. Article 16 (1) of the Constitution provides: "There shall be equality of opportunity for all citizens in matters relating to employment or appointment to any office under the State". The two most contentious issues in the application of Article 15(4) as well as Article 16(4) have been: (i) determination of backward classes and (ii) extent or quantum of reservation. Although Article 16(4) does not qualify 'backward class of citizens', as does

Article 15(4), by the words 'socially and educationally', the problem of determining such classes is similar under both the provisions.

In 1979, the Mandal Commission headed by Indian parliamentarian Bindheshwari Prasad Mandal was constituted to consider the question of seat reservations and quotas for people to rectify caste discrimination. In 1980 the Commission's report recommended that members of Other Backward Classes (OBC) be granted reservations to 27 per cent of jobs under the Central government and public sector undertakings, thus making the total number of reservations for SC, ST and OBC to 49%.

The main objective of reservation system was to provide increased opportunities, enhanced social and economical status, and well being of the underprivileged class popularly known as Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST) and Other Backward classes (OBC). However, as India developed as an independent democratic nation, various factions of the society gradually grew dissatisfied with their conditions and sought more freedom and privileges. They felt the provision of reservation for certain classes was unfair on the society. Lately every profession in India is jolted by reservation, from teachers to politicians, students to employees.

Even in election process, parliament on December 12, 2019 passed a Constitution amendment bill to extend quota to SCs and STs in Lok Sabha and state assemblies by another 10 years with Law Minister Ravi Shankar Prasad asserting that the Modi government will never stop the reservation system.

Arguments Against Reservation

Meritorious candidates are sidelined to make way for the reserved communities. Reserved category people qualify despite having very low marks which hampers the growth of meritorious upward caste candidates. For example, under the current NEET system, over 500 students with marks either in single digit or zero and negative in

physics and chemistry were able to get admission into MBBS colleges in 2017 alone.

National Survey showed that “In India, only 0.7% of scholarships are provided on the basis of merit. Most of the scholarships or aid is available only for OBC, SC, ST, Women, Minorities and Muslims.” This restricts the growth of aspiring students from upward caste of the society who are financially weaker.

Caste reservation takes away the right to equality as it is stated in our constitution that there should be no discrimination based on caste, colour, creed, etc.

Politicians use reservation as an agenda to do vote bank politics and get votes of people from reserved categories. 70% of the population of India belongs to reserved categories that are SC, ST and OBC.

Lately, more and more caste groups have been demanding reservation for their communities rather than working hard in their respective fields; for example, Jats in Haryana, Patidars in Gujarat, Marathas in Maharashtra, etc.

Reservation policy promotes caste over intelligence and hard work. This leads to creation of substandard engineers, doctors, bureaucrats and other professionals under the present reservation policy.

Arguments in Favour of Reservation

Caste based reservation system in India has helped to remove social evils like untouchability, caste-based discrimination and has improved social, economic and educational status of lower caste people.

It has brought many marginalized oppressed caste groups into the mainstream as now they get representation in various aspects of society and are involved in decision making, something that has been denied to them for a long time.

Reservation allows the backward classes to improve their lives and status in society and helps them to get meaningful employment.

It also removes the social and economic disparities in the country and helps to take a step forward on the path of a balanced society.

There is no denying that social discrimination based on caste, creed, and religion continues to be one of the most inhuman and evil practices in human society. Reservation is no doubt good, but when it tends to harm the society and ensures privileges for some at the cost of others, as it is in the present form, it should be ended. Reservation is definitely required but not for the people of lower castes but for the poor people, handicaps, soldiers' families, senior citizens, Kashmir migrants, and people with very low or no income. It should not be enforced based on caste/ religion, minority/ majority as it is happening now. It is better if reservation is based on economic conditions instead of castes. Progress and development cannot take place without changes. It's time our government brought in a big change in the reservation system ensuring India's progress and the citizens of India should understand that reservation is not a right, it's just a privilege. This way we would be successful in removing caste discrimination and unite the economically rich together in helping the economically poor, irrespective of their castes.

Gender Equality in India



Gender is a socio-cultural term referring to socially defined roles to males and females. The concept of treating men and women equal is termed as gender equality. Gender equality is a burning social issue today. Patriarchy became the order of the society. In the patriarchy system, the patriarch or male was considered the head of the household and had natural authority to make family decisions. It has been the root of discrimination between genders. Women have always been dominated by men in the patriarchal society where men are the rule makers. Men are the supreme authority and women are the followers. People are taught male patriarchy through education, male dominance is enforced and a masculine view of the world is presented to children. Women are considered to be physically weaker than men.

At a very early age, girls are expected to help out in household duties which are highly unpaid and unrecognized and they are expected to do that throughout their lives. The unequal distribution of opportunities and resources continue into adulthood and also women face significant wage gaps and indiscriminate sexism in everyday affairs. Similarly, boys who grow up seeing their mothers unquestionably handle all the housework, expect their wives and daughters to follow the same.

Gender roles were biased by custom, tradition and sexist culture that downgraded women on the basis of their biological weakness. Women are often looked down upon by the society or entitled to areas less significant or dedicated by men. Nature does not discriminate men from women. But women worldwide have been the victim of inequality not only in terms of social and political rights but

also on grounds of employment opportunities. Without effective gender equality, getting rid of social evils like female feticide and discrepancy of education between men and women is not possible.

Gender Equality Issues in India

Women have been subjected to household or domestic expression from ages. They are dominated by male psychologically which creates a lack of self confidence in them to face the society.

Women are not well aware of their rights and legal provisions which favour and protect them.

Women have fewer opportunities and less access to basic and higher education, have greater health and safety risks and less political representation.

Families with limited means cannot afford the cost of education and don't allow girl child to study.

Female feticide and female infanticide is common scenario where sex-selective operations are done to kill the girl child even before she is born.

The average sex ratio in India has declined from 906 female births per 1,000 male births in 2012-14 to 898 in 2014-16. Recently the World Economic Forum has also come up with a startling news that India has slipped to 112th rank in Gender Gap Index. India's ranking is lower than China's (106th), Sri Lanka (102nd), Nepal, (101st) and Bangladesh (50th).

Crimes against women show an upward trend, in particular brutal crimes such as rapes, dowry deaths, and honour killings.

The dowry system, involving a cash or in-kind payment from the bride's family to the groom's at the time of marriage, is another institution that disempowers women.

Patriarchy is so deeply entrenched both in our mindset and our laws, Indians have long since accepted the current social situation as the default one.

Gender equality is required for equal participation of females in all the sectors including agriculture, manufacturing industries etc., and more awareness among men to share household and domestic responsibilities, better access of women to resources like land, property and education. Such resources strengthen the chances that future generations would suffer from fewer instances of gender discrimination.

The constitution of India grants equality to women and also empowers the state to adopt measures of positive discrimination in favour of women for neutralizing the cumulative education, political and socio economic disadvantages faced by them. The state has enacted various legislative measures intended to ensure equal rights to encounter social discrimination and atrocities. Some of the acts are molestation (sec .354 IPC), torture both mental and physical (sec. 498-A IPC), sexual harassment (sec. 509 IPC) etc. Constitutional privileges provided are, article 15 which states not to discriminate against any citizen on the grounds of race, sex, caste, sex, place of birth or any of them. Article 39A, which states to promote justice on the basis of equal opportunity and to provide legal aid by suitable legislation or scheme or in any other way to ensure that opportunities for securing justice are not denied to any citizen by reason of economic or other disabilities. There are many more laws and acts to protect the rights of women and to ensure gender equality.

Government of India has launched many schemes in order to uplift women in the society. 'Beti bachao beti padhao' initiative for empowering women in the field of education was launched. Another scheme called 'one stop centre scheme' meant to offer easy access for women suffering from domestic abuse or violence and needing support was introduced.

Gender inequality can only be removed when the mentality of men will change, when the male species of human beings would start treating women as equal and not subordinate or weaker to them. Also women need to change their mindset as they are playing a supportive role in furthering men's agenda of dominating women.

The movement for women's empowerment is needed where women can become economically independent and self-reliant, where they can fight their own fears and they get their rights and they don't have to ask for them. Women should have good education, good career, ownership of property and most importantly freedom to make their own decisions.

Empowering A Woman Empowers Next Generations



“There is no tool for development more effective than the empowerment of women” – Kofi Annan

Everyday women across the world are performing diverse responsibilities right from doting daughters, caring mothers, affectionate wives, expert colleagues and many more. Not only are they doing this flawlessly but with great compassion and grace. Certainly, they are the backbone of any society.

Though in many parts of the world, they are the ignored gender and are at the receiving end of discrimination, oppression, abuse, financial dependability and such other social atrocities. Since generations, they have been living under bondage, restricting them from achieving any social or economic freedom. A lot of barriers for women empowerment and equality are deep-rooted in the cultural norms of any community. Several women suffer this brunt whereas others have become habitual to being considered inferior to the menfolk.

The world is ever evolving and there is no contradiction about the fact that women across the globe have achieved significant progress, yet majority of them are still struggling to achieve an equal position in the male dominated society. Women population constitutes around 50% population of the world, yet a large number of women are still unemployed. The world economy is suffering a lot due to the unequal opportunities for women at workplace. Though there has been amelioration in the status of women in the 20th century, but their rightful empowerment is yet to be attained.

The true meaning of women empowerment refers to creation of an environment for women where they are self-reliant, have positive self-esteem and are independent to make their own decisions for their personal benefit as well as for society. It is not only to restore their rightful and dignified status but also escalating and improving their social, economic, political and legal strength. The key advantage of women empowerment is that there will be holistic progress of the society.

Women today are playing bigger and bigger roles in almost every field - architecture, judiciary, financial services, engineering, medical and IT jobs. They are also making their mark in conventional male-dominated roles such as army, police, commandos, pilots, etc. Despite the fact of increased number in every field, women are still the world's most underutilised resources.

True women empowerment is correspondent with comprehensive development of the society. A well educated woman with sound knowledge about health, hygiene and cleanliness is adept for providing a disease free environment for her family. A self-employed woman is not only financially sound and contributes to the family's income but also to the country's GDP. A woman conscious about her legal rights is unlikely to be a victim of domestic violence or any other form of exploitation or abuse. Their innate gift towards organisation and versatile upkeep of home makes them distinctively suited for both political and social leadership roles.

Thus, the best way to empower women is to educate them and make them knowledgeable so that they are capable of making their own decisions and are not dependent on men for the same. This is evident from the fact that for the past three years, women have made an impeccable mark by securing top position in the leading examinations across India. Nandini KR from Karnataka is the third woman in a row who has secured first rank in the prestigious UPSC Civil Services examination 2016 after Ira Singhal who cleared UPSC Civil Services 2014 followed by Tina Dabi in 2015. Not only this, CBSE Class 12th topper 17 year old Raksha Gopal scored 100 in

three subjects — English core, Political science and Economics. Nishita Purohit, a national-level basketball player, from Surat (Gujarat) led the list of toppers in the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) MBBS entrance examination 2017. Women are shining bright and letting the world know there is no stopping them.

Time and again it has been said that the status and position of women in society are the best way to discern a civilisation, its strengths and its shortcomings. In the last few decades, Indian women have come a long way where women enjoy a status of equality with the men as per constitutional and legal provisions. But with headlines about rape, honour killing, female foeticides and domestic violence still making the newspapers, put a silent question mark.

If we turn the pages of Indian history, the birth of a girl child was not unwelcome. However, slowly and steadily, the preference for a male child resulted in unreceptive attitude towards a girl child. A woman's child bearing potential was valuable, but it became significantly higher when a woman became mother of a son. Marked preference for sons led to the neglect of female children. This led to severe discrimination in nutrition, health care and education.

Over a century, women struggled really hard before the law to get equality in civil rights, property rights, voting rights, marriage and employment to name a few. Legislative measures such as abolishment of purdah system, sati system (self-immolation by the women with their husbands), female infanticide, pre natal determination of sex of child, etc. have contributed substantially in raising the status of women in India.

Government Laws and its subsequent amendments, along with various Government schemes have seen larger inclusion of women with respect to their standing in the society. Numerous councils and bodies have been set up with an aim for the well-being of women such as the National Commission for Women, Department of Women and Child Development and the Parliamentary Committee on Empowerment of Women. Along with, the recent campaigns of 'Beti

Bachao, Beti Padhao' are being aimed at reducing female infanticide and promoting the importance of educating the girl child. The popular slogan educate a man and you educate an individual; educate a woman and you educate a family is the most appropriate in today's scenario.

The World's 100 Most Powerful Women 2019 announced by Forbes in its annual list include the first full-time Finance minister of India, Nirmala Sitharaman, appointed in May 2019 makes her debut and is ranked 34th on the list. Roshni Nadar Malhotra, CEO and Executive Director, HCL Enterprise is ranked 54th on the list. First generation entrepreneur Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw is ranked 65th on the list.

History has stood witness to the brilliance of women in politics, time and again. India has also seen such influential female political figures from time to time. Their schemes and political traits have been appreciated by many and criticised by many more. However, their contribution to the development of the country can never be overlooked. Vijayalakshmi Pandit, the first woman president of U.N. General Assembly in 1953, Pratibha Devisingh Patil , the first president of India from 2007 to 2012, Indira Gandhi, the first woman Prime Minister of India, Sushma Swaraj, the BJP leader and former Union Minister of External Affairs of India, Vasundhara Raje, former CM of Rajasthan, Mamta Banerjee, CM of West Bengal, the current Finance Minister of India Nirmala Sitharaman, etc. have proved their indomitability. Even the former speaker Sumitra Mahajan has presided over the 16th Lok Sabha and was the second woman to hold the office, after her immediate predecessor Meira Kumar.

The list of the leading women of modern India does not end here. Several other women from different domains of life are constantly inspiring and influencing youth of India. Be it sports persons like badminton player Saina Nehwal, wrestler Geeta Phogat; actresses like Priyanka Chopra or Aishwaraya Rai, writer Arundhati Roy, filmmaker Gauri Shinde, etc., they are all making a contribution to make the nation a better place. India is the nation of some

phenomenal women such as Indra Nooyi, former Chairperson and CEO of PepsiCo; Tessy Thomas, former Project Director for Agni-VI missile, who have proved their mettle against all odds.

Though the government is taking requisite steps for women, it is important that women too empower themselves by being strong from heart and think from mind. They need to learn how to embrace their life with all challenges every day. They also need to change their outlook that they are weak, anybody can cheat them or use them; instead they need to think that they have the same power as men and can do anything better than men.

Nonetheless, women have come a long way, yet, we live in a strong patriarchal society with its deep-rooted mindset of socio-cultural values and the road to true women empowerment is still a long way to go. We need an egalitarian approach with no place of discrimination of any sorts on the basis of gender. The government should identify and ensure complete eradication of any factors that are trying to hinder the development of women by practising the custom of male domination.

They should guarantee the rights of women and provide them prospects to accomplish their full potential. This will result not only in attaining gender equality but also achieve a great deal of international development goals and economic growth. When we empower a woman or girl, it creates a ripple effect which in turn contributes to the well-being and productivity of her family, community or country at large.

Is an Egalitarian Society Possible by Educating the Masses?



Indian society is concoction of several cultures, castes, religions, customs and beliefs. A society that is mix of so many diversions is bound to have discriminations, biases, conflicts of thoughts and opinions. It is understandable but along with that, it is required to accept that we need to bring a lot of change in the existing system to make it more harmonious and prosperous.

What is an Egalitarian Society?

An egalitarian society is based on the belief system which exclaims that all are equal and should have equal rights and opportunities. Equality in opportunities implies absence of partiality, privilege, bias and exploitation.

With the start of Varna system in Indian society, the inequality began to take place. It is since then that we are struggling with the problem of social evils based on class, caste, creed, religion and race. In Indian society, concept of education too has survived through the time where it faced injustice at the hands of society. There was a time when only Brahmanas were eligible for gaining knowledge; Kshatriya were disqualified to get education and Shudras were surviving with the tag of marginalised with pathetic circumstances.

Feudalistic society was based on the features like dominance of priests, marginalisation of people on the ground of caste, creed, religion and untouchability. Presently, Indian society consists of Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, and Sudra, but they don't have to adopt caste based professions. Indian society is gradually emerging above all disparities on the basis of caste, religion, linguistic bonds, in

spite of being trapped in these labyrinths. Reaching this level of liberation has been possible only because education has played a splendid role as an emancipator for underprivileged. There are certain practices like gender discrimination, female infanticide, early marriage, honour killing which still continue in certain sections and regions of the country.

Denial of Equality Means Denial of Rights

In a country like India, denial of adequate share in distribution of wealth, opportunity, material and prosperity means denial of rights. Education provides awareness which enables the individual to use his rights and have access to justice. The apathetic continuation of poverty and ignorance gives rise to absence of social justice and denial of democratic spirit.

Indian society has risen above many disparities on the basis of caste, colour, race, religion and linguistic bonds in many urban areas. The leaders of social reforms in India, like Ram Mohan Roy, Swami Vivekanand, Mahatma Gandhi, Rabindranath Tagore and others emphasised values of egalitarianism, liberty, secularism, humanism, and gender equality. They worked for the removal of caste restrictions, untouchability, dowry, sati and purdah system. This has been possible because of the role played by education. Although a lot has been done in the past, much is being done in the present. Still, there is need to introduce solutions to the existing problems. One such problem is gender inequality. India is still struggling with the problem of gender inequality to a great extent.

Today, girls are outshining boys in academic exams, games, work but still our society is witnessing issues like commodification of women, rape, marital rape, domestic violence, sexual harassment, female trafficking and dowry. These issues are predominantly seeking attention on the social grounds. In the world of equal gender, there is still need of a great deal of efforts to educate parents and children about gender sensitisation. Women need to be aware of their rights

and that can only be done through education. To make India an egalitarian society, education is a must prerequisite.

Education: An Instrument of Social Change

Education can create a new outlook. It is a powerful means to change human nature in a desirable way. It is education which prepares them to be responsible members of the society. Changes brought about by education are perpetual and boundless in nature. Education as an instrument of social change means how education helps people to bring a social change. Education changes the outlook and develops ability to go beyond the traditional approach towards solving social and economic problems.

Nelson Mandela said “Education is the most powerful weapon you can use to change the world”.

Education also motivates the children to adopt new pattern in order to remain dynamic and forward looking. Education fulfils the needs of the society and propagates such ideas which promote social changes in all fields of life.

Education Surpasses Irrational Restrictions and Promotes Equality

Education empowers with the knowledge of rights and ability to fight injustice and inequality in political, cultural, economic, religious and social aspects of unequal society. Government needs to imply educational reforms in such a way that it brings in children self-learning agency and inculcate habit to question and try to find solution of the existing problem. Education endows upon individuals, the wisdom to gain confidence in the sections like women, lower caste people which are otherwise considered weak in the system of society.

Common education for all can create a rational and uniform impact. Uniformity in the society is the lifeline of an egalitarian society. Egalitarianism can only be realised when people are educated.

Why do We Need Educational Reforms?

Presently, education is being imparted in schools, colleges and universities. In formal education system, apart from any knowledge and skill development, there is a need to focus on the qualitative aspects too. This aspect is missing in underprivileged sections of the society. Our society is evolving every moment. Our education system has to change, update and reform accordingly, in schools, colleges and universities. Government needs to imply educational reforms in practical form. Aim of the reforms is to develop in students a self-learning agency to answer their curiosity. The objective should be to question the wrong and bring solution to the existing problems in the society.

Equality in Education

In India, literacy is still hovering around 74% on an average reaching above 90% in Kerala and below 75% in Bihar and Jharkhand. These figures are worrisome for nation. Along with serious efforts on free and compulsory education, there is a need to prioritise on other policies too. Government's efforts in bringing equality in educational facilities across the country need to be escalated. It is a common scene in India to see poor children walking to their one-room schools, while middle class children are taken to school in private buses. This inequality among two sections of society widens the gauge between rich and poor. Poor students 'experience with bad schools, inefficient staff and insufficient resources thus follows them throughout their lives. The difference is so wide that it never let them catch up with private school students. There is an ardent need to work on this aspect and work on the upliftment of education set up for the poor.

“Until we get equality in education, we won't have an equal society.”

—Sonia Sotomayor

Education – A way and means to Egalitarian Society

To conclude, it can be said that in complex countries like India, only education has the potential to bind all in single thread. A pragmatic state of different languages, cultures, scripts, religions and customs can get united on the pretext of education. Unequals like rich and poor, rural and urban, gender divide and Hindu and Muslim can meet at one point, if education is imparted to one and all. Though it is a long and continuous process but gradually educated mass can bring a revolutionary change with their attitudes guided with ethics. Essence of education is to lay foundation of classless society where dignitary identities of all humans are protected. It aims at bringing change in the thought process and hence promises an egalitarian society.

Racial Discrimination and Struggle for Equality



There have been numerous practices in our society that have created differences on the basis of caste, creed, race, sex and religious beliefs. One of such practices which evolved and was practiced systematically during the colonial period of history was racism. The discrimination in the society on the basis of racial differences is known as racism and it is a significant social issue which relates to the era of colonialism that has its root back to 1500s.

Basically the racial differences in spite of being naturally occurring became the basis for systems of exploitation and discrimination.

India as a nation is divided on the basis of colour, caste, religion and gender. The advent of globalization has led to the concentration of money in the hands of few which has created a new line for dividing us that is wealth. Discrimination by colour and social standing are the most prominent ones in the prevailing Indian society. We are becoming xenophobic day by day. This has been an accepted norm since years that those with loads of money and fair skin are better than others. We feel cultural self-discrimination ingrained inside us while we are abroad and then we also blame foreigners for being racist to Indians living in their country. On the other side, we are racist towards people from our own country.

There have been incidences where North Eastern people have faced discrimination against themselves from North Indians. Even their

dwelling places are attacked. A guy from Bihar is being hated by a guy from Mumbai for no valid reason. South Indians while travelling to North Indian states are teased with various names. These are the worst kind of squalor of human decency.

We don't even spare the foreigners visiting our country from teasing by calling names like "Hapshees" and "Negroes". The word "Chinkee" has been given to those who are with slightly oriental features. A nation cannot command respect with these types of filthy behaviour.

This is a blatant truth that India is featured as a "racist and sexist" country amongst foreign tourists who come with advises from their respective embassies about taking cautions for their safety, life and dignity while their stay in India. It is almost like racial attack and is a matter of extreme shame. We can't say we are proud of being in such a state. Racism is a prevalent issue in our country to such an extent that we don't feel ashamed to even being racist towards our own selves. In our desperation to change the perception of the world about Indians, we are running blindly to prove that we are modern, educated and rich so that we are not called the land of snake charmers anymore. We deny accepting our roots, origin and in this blind rat race, we even leave behind our values, traditions and culture.

Refugees from Bangladesh and Nepal live in a squalor and filthy conditions. To discriminate them for their poverty is a completely made-up idea without any logic.

The proud lines of unity in diversity are boosted now and then, but cases of racial discrimination on such a massive extent make the authenticity of such lines questionable. Thus, we all Indians are divided into different citizenries. Every state of India and every other

province portrays different styles, skin colours, cultures and characters. Even Indian capital New Delhi has turned into the breeding ground of racial discrimination. It's surprising and shameful to know that the students from North eastern states experience most of the discrimination in Delhi. The recent cases of misbehaviours towards many students from North eastern states have once again portrayed the real hollow condition of India where we just fake about being one but in true sense are deeply full of hatred, indifferences and malice towards each other.

Some newspapers reports suggest that racism is being faced by women and girls from North Eastern states of India. Quite often we ourselves spot Manipuri or Assamese women being abused or teased by men in Delhi. But we hardly care about interfering as somewhere within ourselves we also have an indifferent feeling towards them. We also make fun of these people from North East by calling them names like "Chinese" or "Chinkees". This is not just shameful but also a very disheartening situation that calls for awakening of our sleeping souls.

Some time ago, an incident of a North Eastern boy being beaten up to death in a Lajpat Nagar locality of New Delhi has outraged the whole youth community and students from North East India, has also raised questions of India's sincerity towards the ideology - "Unity in Diversity". It is sorrowful and very disturbing to hear to such mishaps every now and then. We must question ourselves "where are we leading to?" Are we actually developing as a nation that stands united in times of troubles? Are we in real sense a nation with varied cultural beliefs yet bonded by the thread of nationality? Are we actually Indians seeking the path of brotherhood and peace or are these mere show-offs for remaining part of the world?

Even one of the oldest democracies like the US is not free from this malady. A regular tussle between the whites and blacks is a shame to such a developed nation. This is the result of mass immigration of people of different countries to the United States.

There has been a UN Global Conference on racism in 2001 in which all nations were good at being critical but when it came to them, they were uncomfortable talking about the same. For example, Israel and US were not in view of discussing the possibility that Zionism is racist against Palestinians and this debate led to both of them stepping out of the conference. It was also discussed that the demands for less skilled workers particularly in North America and Europe do not lead to increase attacking foreign workers. India refused to include any discussions based on caste discrimination. India is never comfortable talking about such issues. But then, when are we comfortable or bothered about talking sincerely about such topics in public? We just care about raising voices when certain movie's name appears hurting to our religious sentiments. We are good at following others blindly but not sincere and genuine enough to think what needs to be thought. Then what will happen to the people held in bondage?

Today, racism is not that blatant but it has not even gone completely too. It has become more common though and yet subtler than earlier. It will surely take a long before this scourge gets completely eroded from our society but for that much more powerful and superhuman means are required. Until and unless we realize the gruesomeness of such incidences ourselves, we can never change for real and better.

The Dark Disparity - Gap between Rich and Poor



The rich are getting richer day by day and the poor are getting poorer. This disparity between the rich and poor is growing at a very fast pace. The two ends are at wide extremes and there is no common point where they stand equal. This inequality is basically a difference in the economic state which includes the income, wealth and assets. But the underlining problem is the income difference. This difference is prevalent since ages - one has always been a king and the other the pauper. This economic inequality varies considerably between historical period, societies, countries and population. However, with growing industrialisation and globalisation, this gap is increasing at a fast pace and has become quite substantial. One does not need to be a complete egalitarian, since some degree of inequality is good for an economy, which creates incentives to work hard and take risks. There are many reasons for this economic inequality - increasing inequality in wages, gender discrimination, ethnic discrimination, globalisation, technology changes, taxes, education, culture policy reforms, nepotism, etc.

Economic inequality can be measured using various numerical indices, but the most commonly used is Gini coefficient. It is a statistical measure of wealth dispersion. It is a number valued between 0 and 1, wherein the value of 0 means perfect equality and the value of 1 corresponds to absolute inequality. It is a scale that defines whether everyone has the same income or only one person has all the wealth, and every other person has zero income. The 0 and 1 of this index is two extremes of the poles that show the truth prevailing in the countries. Using this coefficient, it has been found

that though Africa and Latin America have some of the greatest inequality in the world, the much developed countries like China and US also have significant inequality. This concludes that national prosperity and individual prosperity are two different aspects that are not related to each other directly. The internal wealth distribution within any country is what that matters. Most of the countries of the world fall between the range of 0 and 1 of the Gini coefficient. Where Iceland is the most egalitarian country, Finland, Germany and Sweden have low coefficient. Israel and USA have relatively high Gini coefficients.

The gap varies significantly between the rich and poor in the developed and the developing countries. The economic interdependence that is growing at a fast rate is very asymmetrical. The benefits and costs of linking and de-linking are unequally distributed. Industrialised nations like Japan, USA, Europe are very interdependent in their relations with each other. On the other side, the developing countries are highly dependent on industrialised nations but independent from one another with respect to economic relations. Thus, the globalisation creates two segments of winners and losers, and also inevitable includes both risks and opportunities. A January 2014 report by Oxfam claims that the 85 wealthiest individuals in the world have a combined wealth equal to that of the bottom 50% of the world's population, or about 3.5 billion people. According to a Los Angeles Times analysis of the report, the wealthiest 1% owns 46% of the world's wealth; the 85 richest people, a small part of the wealthiest 1% own about 0.7% of the human population's wealth, which is the same as the bottom half of the population. More recently, Oxfam's 2017 report says the top eight billionaires have as much wealth as the bottom half of the global population, and that rising inequality is suppressing wages, as businesses are focused on delivering higher returns to wealthy owners and executives. This data clearly speaks for the dark disparity between the rich and the poor. Some also feel that education and inequality goes hand in hand, but the relationship between them is

not clearly defined. While the countries with low wealth inequality have educated workforce, the opposite is not always true. This can be seen from the fact that the largest spenders on education as a percent of GDP were the two most unequal nations - Israel and US in 2011.

This evil of inequality has been here for centuries and will persist for years because its roots are still very deep rooted and not all countries and people are acceptable to change. With the growing technology, industrialisation and globalisation, soon the population across the globe will be divided into two groups - technology friendly and technologically replaced. Those who are able to cope with the technology will persist while the others will get replaced by it.

The governments also play an important role in the presence or absence of this disparity. The interventions from both the government and the capitalist market can increase or decrease the inequality in the society.

How has Globalization Affected Indian Society?



According to authors Dr Nayer R.F. and Gerard Stoudmann, Globalisation refers to the processes that encompass causes, courses and consequences that increasingly make the transnational and transcultural integration and interdependency of human and non-human activities.

In layman's words, globalisation refers to the integration of markets across the economies, leading to the increased internationalisation of markets for financial systems, knowledge transfer, goods and services, production and competition with the advancement in communication, transportation and technology.

Three Phases of Globalisation

Globalisation can be divided into three phases: Globalisation 1.0, Globalisation 2.0, and Globalisation 3.0. Globalisation 1.0, dates to Industrial Revolution era when transportation involved wind power by sea and animal power by land. Globalisation 2.0 began after World War II when steam power moved the goods internationally at affordable prices. During this period, the entire world was fond of the "Made in the USA, Made in Japan and Made in Germany" labels on almost every product.

Globalisation 3.0, the current stage, embarked on around the early 1990s when information and communication technology revolution radically lowered the cost of moving ideas. Globalisation 3.0 is entirely different from the previous version 1.0 and 2.0. In

Globalisation 3.0, not only the world become flat but also it squeezed itself went from being small to tiny. Globalisation 3.0 helped the emerging economies to open up to the world and boosted rapid growth of exports, industry and GDP. Whereas the previous phases of globalisation favoured the developed economies such as Britain, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, and the US. With the emergence of the third phase of globalisation, the playing field was levelled. India and China are competing with each other to cater to the entire globe.

The current phase of globalisation eliminated barriers with regard to geography, distance, time zones and language to make the world a tiny sphere to form a world language to allow everyone to communicate and share technology and transfer knowledge. As a result, diverse technological, market and political forces have converged, and that has produced a global playing field that allowed communication, collaboration, participation and created competition.

Globalisation 2.0, introduced Indians to multinational companies, while Globalisation 3.0 provided the means to Indian companies to become multinational companies and set shop across the world. Small firms to Fortune 500 companies, every foreign entity brought business functions to India and created employment for Indians. The emergence of wireless technologies pumped up collaboration, to make mobile and internet available to every ordinary Indian.

India had tasted the current phase of globalisation when economic liberalisation in India was initiated in 1991 by late Prime Minister P. V. Narasimha Rao. India's economic reforms in 1991 helped the country to integrate with the world economies through the process of cross-national flows of investment, technology, production and goods.

Globalisation brought a plethora of problems, along with abundant opportunities, advantages and profits for Indian society. Thus, globalisation can be termed as a double-edged sword. At this juncture, Indian society's challenge is to maximise the benefits of globalisation and to minimise the negative impacts of globalisation.

Positive Side of Globalisation

Indian citizens and companies gained the freedom and ability to initiate economic transactions with counterparts of other countries. Globalisation had a substantial positive impact on Indian society. Globalisation acted as the engine of India's growth. Globalisation brought technological advancement into India and gave access to global resources. It raised demand, created employment and increased productivity, which in turn fuelled the growth of cross-border trade of commodities and services; the flow of international capital and the extensive and rapid spread of technologies. The intense competition forced firms to produce quality goods and services at affordable prices.

Indian society is greatly benefited due to Globalisation. People could quickly expand their businesses, services to foreign countries, allowing them to a broader market, which contributes to higher income and sustainable economic development. Business houses have been enjoying the economies of scale due to the wide range of their footprint. The phenomenon led to improving the standard of living along with modernisation. On the other hand, it played a vital role in poverty reduction and upliftment of millions from the below poverty line. Globalisation has created access to higher education and reduced the knowledge gap.

Before globalisation, people used to spend hours at Banks, Railway reservation counters and even at the ticket windows of movie halls. Now, we can do banking, ticketing, and purchasing and investing at the stroke of a key. There is greater access to news, entertainment and infotainment from around the world. Globalisation has dramatically revolutionized many different fields and has changed everyday life.

The boom of the manufacturing and services sectors due to globalisation increased employment creation in cities and towns. This led to rural to urban migration, increased population in cities and infrastructure development in towns.

Globalisation highlighted various social issues and focussed on social awareness and community development. Subsequently, more awareness was created among the society concerning gender equality, human rights, animal rights, and woman empowerment. Correspondingly, Indian women were allowed to get rid of orthodox obstacles and abandon social taboos and emotional aversion. Overall, the values of Indian society and its self-awareness have changed multifold.

The flip side of globalisation

Consumerism has spread across and changed the behaviour of Indian society. Indian society especially the rich and affluent, have developed a penchant for western style of eating habits and products which gradually increased the patterns of behaviour of society and eventually led to embracing the western culture and tradition. Resultantly, western culture and customs have become a symbol of globalisation.

On the positive side, foreign nationals are increasingly embracing Indian culture, customs and cuisine and even classical music. Globalisation facilitated employment, income and affordable housing that led to an increase in nuclear families. Thus, the joint family system of our society has become a thing of past. Teenagers are left alone at homes; toddlers and children being raised by babysitters and crèches. Many changes took place in the upbringing of children between now and before globalisation. Deprivation and neglect in childhood can have a lasting psychological impact in early adulthood. Moreover, gadgets and social media are widening relationships. Because of which, humanity and humility are disappearing and society is becoming more inhuman. Globalisation also aggravates the physiological and behavioural factors of stress.

Globalisation facilitated sweatshop factories and exploitation of labour. Globalisation has also widened the gap by growing inequality between the rich and the poor in their abilities to take advantage of education, employment and investment opportunities. Reduction of

labour absorption in the public sector after the globalisation led to an adverse effect on the labour employment situation in India.

Globalisation works both ways; it brought the internet, devices and social media into the hands of ordinary people. Instantaneous news and communication brought by the devices are enabling both mass movements and fake news. How does globalisation affect the environment has been a primary global concern. Globalisation led to an increase in consumption, demand and eventually, production. Therefore, indirectly globalisation is responsible for the exploitation of the labour, the depletion of natural resources and the decay of the environment. Globalisation may translate into increased emissions of greenhouse gases and causing to global warming.

Why We Should Support Girls' Education?



From the Medieval period of Indian history to the Colonial period, the Indian society has failed to understand the importance of education of girl child. Educating the girl child is seen as a waste of resources and time by many of Indian community. This problem not only is continuing but also taking the lead in some states and parts of rural India without realising the impact and consequences. Even now, the priority and attention is given to boys in education compared to girls.

In spite of the country's economic growth, development, progress and introduction of various schemes by the Central and State Governments, millions of girls still face multiple obstacles and are subjected to discrimination. Everyday life is dire for the majority of girl children. As of 2019, female infant mortality rates are higher than male infant in 25 Indian states. Nearly three lakh girl children under the age of five, die every year due to a variety of reasons ranging from female foeticide to infanticide. The practice of female foeticide in the womb and homicide of the female child after her birth has been prevalent in India.

Illiteracy and Female Foeticide

Until the 90s, girl children from the economically and socially backward classes were made to drop out of schools and were married off in their teens, as the families could not afford education of girl-child. When a girl-child is forced to marry in her teens, she not only drops out of school but also becomes pregnant and bears a child in adolescence. To make matters worse, the adolescent girl will be

forced by the family to abort (foeticide), if the foetus in her womb is a female.

These negative series of events build on and reinforce each other due to illiterate women. The grandmothers and mothers of girl-children force them to bunk school and help them in household work, fetching water and even marry them off at an early age. They also forcefully make the adolescent girls abort the female foeticide or infanticide. This is how a lack of education is robbing women across the country. In the past few decades, millions of girl children dropped out of school due to economic conditions, inadequate access to water, sanitation, healthy nutrition and basic healthcare. School drop-out of the girl-child is common, and many girls found in these places will never step their foot into a classroom to receive a formal education.

Education is Power

The gender gap in education in various states in India is exceptionally problematic. As a result, women cannot be as productive as they could be and are not only harming themselves, but also the country as a whole. Education is power, and due to lack of education, women are becoming powerless, and entirely dependent on fathers, husbands, and sons. They are deprived of economic and social independence; this is why they get suppressed by the family and society. Indeed, not educating girl children renders them particularly vulnerable.

Education can help the girl-child realise their potential and empower them to change their own fate and destiny of their families for the better. Education can only boost their confidence and make them feel more empowered to stand up for themselves. Educating girl children is a critical component to earning, economic freedom and vital to women empowerment. If educated, they can get rid of poverty; gender inequality decreases as poverty declines and the overall condition improves. They attain economic and social empowerment

and stand to gain from all fronts. Thus, women's empowerment is intimately connected to educating girl children.

Girls who complete their secondary education will know the importance of family planning and their physical health and will eventually bear fewer children. They can safeguard their infant children's health, administer timely vaccination and provide nutritional food. Therefore, children born to mothers who have at least completed secondary education are twice as likely to live past the age of five. Girls who complete even just primary education can reduce their chances of contracting HIV and STDs threefold.

Education Leads to Political and Legal Change

Illiterate women in both rural and urban India are still not even legally allowed to spend money, pursue employment, exercise the vote, travel alone, make their own decisions without spousal permission. Literate women will become familiar with the electoral process and can exercise their right to vote without assistance, they can make informed decisions and choose the contestant based on development and merit rather than depending on family members to exercise their franchise. Letting them achieve greater social construct enables them to lobby for social reforms, from which flows political and legal change.

However, the situation is gradually improving. 8.8 percent of women were literate as per census 1951. 64.6 percent of women are literate as per census 2011, although India's illiterate female population still remains the highest in the world. Decades of government and non-government efforts have yielded some positive results. Various State Governments and Central Governments have introduced many schemes to encourage Girl-child education.

Governments' Schemes

Beti Bachao Beti Padhao was launched in 2015 by the Central Government, which is aimed at improving the sex-ratio and educating

the girl child. Under the “Beti Bachao Beti Padhao”, village panchayats will be held accountable if girls are married before turning 18.

In 1998, The Mahila Samakhya Programme was initiated to work towards including women in the education system. It functions through Sanghas - village-level women’s collectives.

Kishori Shakti Yojana aimed at girls in the age group of 11-18 year for their overall development including awareness about their health, personal hygiene, nutrition, family welfare and management. The scheme uses Anganwadi Centres to equip girls to grow and upgrade their home-based and vocational skills.

Sabla Scheme which is implemented through Anganwadi Centres is aimed at Adolescent Girls for their all-round development who are not enrolled in schools. The scheme aims at improving the health and nutritional status of girls in the age group of 11-14 years attending AWCs and all girls in the age group of 14-18 years.

Under the Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana, small affordable deposits can be made in the bank accounts of girls. It provides one of the highest rates of interest.

The National Vidyalakshmi Portal is a single window electronic platform for educational loans. Anybody can get information regarding various loans and schemes offered by banks and apply for education loans.

Scheme for Strengthening Education Among Scheduled Tribe Girls in low literacy districts takes a holistic approach to promote education among ST girls. It provides for cash incentives to students, periodic awards such as cycles, watches, construction of hostels, educational primers in tribal languages, and so on. The scheme is implemented through NGOs.

Ashram schools in tribal sub-plan areas for tribal girls were set up by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, through States/UTs. State Governments

are eligible for 100% funding for the establishment of Ashram Schools for girls in these areas.

The Ministry of Women & Child Development and Ministry of Human Resource Development have initiated "Gender Champions" scheme. Through the scheme, they strengthen the potential of young girls and advocate for gender equality and monitor progress towards gender justice. Universities and their affiliated colleges under the direction of the University Grants Commission, implement the "Gender Champions" scheme.

To conclude, educating girl-child will lower child marriages, female foeticides, atrocities against women, etc. On the other hand, it will lead to the overall development of girls, help them attain economic and social independence, participate in elections, earn them a livelihood which will ultimately lead to their empowerment as well as advancement of the country.

How Effective are Social Security & Social Welfare Schemes in India?



India is a developing nation that has witnessed steady development over the last two decades in many aspects. But with development, come new challenges. The biggest challenge is to ensure social development along with economic development. India has been under the rule of British for several centuries and has been independent only 72 years ago. While during these 72 years, the country has achieved a lot of success on various fronts, but there are a lot of social issues which need to be addressed and resolved to ensure all-inclusive growth. These problems include lack of education, depriving girl child of their rights, underage labour, lack of employment, lack of nutrition, dowry system and many more.

The governments over the years have accepted the social issues plaguing the nation and have initiated various drives to resolve them. The main aim of the drives is to bring in awareness amongst the people and educate them about the issues and how they can be resolved for real growth.

This is the reason why social security and social welfare schemes are launched periodically along with various initiatives to help the nation become a better country. In order to make these schemes successful, active participation by the government authorities as well as citizens and private entities is paramount.

Social Security Schemes Launched by Modi Government

The government under PM Modi has launched various social schemes with the motive of strengthening the social fabric of the nation. Some of the flagship schemes are: -

- **Women-centric schemes:** Government has launched various schemes like ***Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao*** or ***Ujjawala Yojana*** that aim to strengthen the status of the women in Indian society. These schemes focus on the specific needs of the female section of the society, i.e. better access to education, healthcare and essential facilities. Then, there are further small savings schemes, for empowering women financially, such as “***Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana***” that aims to encourage savings for the girl child’s education and marriage.
- **Pension schemes:** These schemes have been designed to offer financial independence to senior citizens or individuals who desperately need financial support in their old age. Schemes like “***Atal Pension Yojana***” require one to contribute a certain sum of money every month towards the pension fund and then after their retirement, they will receive regular monthly pension allowing them to lead their lives comfortably. Then there are some social security pension schemes like “Pradhan Mantri Kisan Maan Dhan Yojana” which aims to offer financial security to farmers.
- **Schemes for the economically weaker sections:** Lack of money is a serious issue for the under-privileged sections of the society in present times. A large population in India lives below the poverty line, and such schemes focus on uplifting the strata of society. To resolve this issue, various schemes have been developed that are targeted towards the economically weaker sections of society. These schemes provide them with monetary benefits that help them go through with their daily lives.
- **Schemes for self employed people:** Government also provides sources for self employed people to save for their retirement to meet their retirement needs. Government institutions have provisions for the government-employed people, but the self-employed people do not have any provisions like that. For such

self-employed people, the government has opened up the option to invest in the “National Pension Scheme or NPS.” Now, self employed people can invest in NPS to receive a regular pension upon their retirement.

- Tax saving schemes: Various tax deductions and rebates are offered by the government for honest individual tax-payers. These schemes help individuals reduce their tax liability and save additional money for their future requirements.
- Insurance schemes: Government has floated plenty of insurance schemes such as Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana which offers monetary compensation in case of an unwanted event. The insurance secures the future of the family in case something happens to the sole breadwinner of the family. The premium invested is very low and serves as a great benefit for the survivors in the family.

How Effective are These Social Security Schemes

The truth is that the actual effectiveness of these social security schemes is very low. There are a lot of provisions available for the common people to avail the benefits of social security provided by the government. Social security schemes are aimed at common people, but the fact is that many of them actually fail to reach the masses.

Some schemes are left unused due to lack of communication from the government's side. The announcement of such schemes does not reach the common public, and as a result, people are deprived of the benefits of these welfare schemes.

On the other hand, some middlemen and bureaucrats misuse the schemes for their own selfish needs. Also, these schemes are lacking protective measures due to which undeserving individuals benefit from the schemes whereas deserving section is left out from the whole picture. Extreme measures need to be taken so that the schemes reach the deserving individuals properly in time.

Way Ahead

The question that needs answer is that if the government is doing enough from its own side? The truth is an absolute no! India spends only a small percentage of its GDP on such social welfare schemes and welfares. People do not get enough chances to get benefits from such schemes as very few effective schemes are actually available in the first place.

India spends a mere 1.4% of its GDP on social security schemes which is extremely less than other nations like China, USA, Russia, etc. Even some developing and underdeveloped nations like Nepal spend a better section of GDP on social welfare of its citizens as compared to India.

Though, India does have some good schemes that can be very beneficial if the benefits actually reach the masses, the country needs better communication between the citizens and the government so that the socially under-privileged sections of the society get seamless access to various social welfare and social security schemes.

The government should spend more on the publicity of these schemes and find new techniques to ensure that the benefits of the schemes reach the rural and underprivileged areas of the society. The nation will only develop as a whole when the rightfully deserving gets access to the development schemes made available by the government.

Some of the most popular social security and welfare schemes initiated by the government are Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojna, From Jan Dhan to Jan Suraksha, Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojna, Atal Pension Yojna, Ujjawala Yojana and several others.

Active participation from the individuals is also required to make sure that the schemes made available by the government reach the deserving sections of the society. Only then will the nation progress in a true sense.

Women Empowerment is the key Factor for Achieving Sustainable Development



“There is no tool more effective for development than the empowerment of women.”

Kofi Annan

The world has agreed to 17 Sustainable Development Goals but only 1 goal, namely Goal 5 seems to be dedicated to the empowerment of women. The SDG 5 goal is to “Achieve gender equality and empower all women and girls”. Yet, the interconnection between women’s empowerment and environmental sustainability has not been undertaken practically, and in terms of the environmental movement as well as empowering women, all of this has been overlooked.

What is Sustainable Development Goal 5?

World Commission on Environment and Development has defined sustainable developments “development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs”. Some goals of SDG 5, which are essential in the Indian context are: -

- Reforms are required to give women equality in terms of rights to economic resources. These reforms should also focus on the ownership and control over land and other different types of property and natural resources.
- Eliminating child, early and forced marriages of women.
- Putting an end to all types of discrimination against women and girls.

- Incorporating necessary policies and legislation to promote gender equality. This will help in ensuring women empowerment at all levels of society.

Why Women Empowerment for Sustainable Development?

When viewing everything in a broad spectrum, it is observed that women have played a vital role in the global environmental movement. The World Commission on Environment and Development has linked the modern-day crisis in terms of the environment with unsustainable financial and developmental practices that were worsening the North-South gap between the economically richer countries and the economically poorer countries such as India, where the majority of women are poor and illiterate. Women have benefitted more than men from the progress in economic and social development in India in the last decades. Still, they represent the group that is the most vulnerable due to the sole reason that these resources and power remain highly skewed towards men.

If India aspires to achieve sustainable levels of economic growth along with social development and environmental sustainability, equal opportunities must be offered to both men and women pertaining to all decision-making activities. Gender Equality is an extremely crucial aspect for ensuring a wholesome development of the economy.

Gender bias is still deeply embedded in the Indian culture which shows its effects in economic, political as well as social institutions all around the country. According to Barbara Stocking, ex-chief Executive of Oxfam Gb, “Leadership from the top is essential, but the values of gender equality have to permeate the whole organization.”

In several developing countries, women have always played a crucial role as farmers, animal tenders, water and fuel collectors along with several other duties. They require adequate representation in the

process of decision-making which relates to the issues of environment and development all levels.

Women play a crucial role as the managers of natural resources. Women are the primary managers as well as active users of land, forest, water and various other natural resources. In the Indian rural regions, it is the responsibility of the women to take care of the food production and consequently, they spend most of their time tending to livestock, taking care of fields, performing cooking duties, and fetching water. Especially tribal and indigenous women have a unique relationship with natural resources and consider them as a blessing from Mother Nature.

Despite such attitude towards nature and following a balanced approach for respectful usage and preservation of the natural resources, women are not considered a part of various development and environmental management schemes.

Indigenous women have time and again shown concern for the quality of life for the present as well as future generations, but discrimination has stopped them from showing their true potential, and they are unable to exercise their full potential for natural resources and environmental management.

What has been Done and what more should be Done?

India has been trying many things to improve the status of women in India such as: -

- Programs such as the Sarva Siksha Abhiyaan as well as initiatives like Right to Education have played an important part in enhancing the Gross Enrolment Rate for girls from 55.5% in 2008 to 78.9% in 2014-15 at the Secondary level and from 31.6% in 2008 to 53.8% in 2014-15 at the Higher Secondary level.
- 50% of the workers in the Mahatama National Rural Employment Guarantee Act are women.

- With landmark legislation in 2016, women were granted 26 weeks of paid maternity leave to encourage them to remain in the workforce.
- From 1994 to 2012, India lifted nearly 144 million people out of abject poverty.

BUT still, this has not been enough. India needs to do more.

India has 5% of its population of 1.3 billion still living in extremely poor conditions and 21.9% of the population living below the poverty line as of 2011. Women accrue less income than men for the same amount of work during their lifetime due to a number of reasons. Besides, the social stigma and unfounded biases have also contributed to preventing women's participation in the workforce which has led to a decrease in India's total female workforce.

According to data by Oxfam India, around 20 million Indian women dropped from the workforce between 2005 and 2012. The Government can solve these issues by taking steps to eradicate poverty levels and improve the living conditions of women in rural regions. Government of India needs to establish new forms of economic accounting to include a large amount of unpaid work done by women and also promote policies that will reduce the disproportionate amount of time women spend working compared to men.

Women have a different perspective to achieve sustainable development goals, and they have many different concerns and ideas for change. They need to be taken on board for all decision-making steps for the protection of the environment and unless done so, a sustainable environment will remain an unachieved distant goal.

The Road Ahead for India

India is still looking in the right direction in terms of the correct steps taken with the formation of new policies, but still, this has not been enough, and more efforts have to be put in. While the global contribution of women towards GDP is around 35%, the contribution

of Indian women towards GDP of India is way less at only 17%, which is not even half of the global average.

More efforts are required for enhancing and empowering the women's voice in environmental decision-making thereby enabling them to avail the abundant opportunities offered by India's economy.

"We need women at all levels, including the top, to change the dynamic, reshape the conversation, to make sure women's voices are heard and heeded, not overlooked and ignored."

Sheryl Sandberg

India's Fight Against Diseases



India is a vast country known for its diverse culture, rich history and also high population and along with this high population comes the challenge of dealing and coping with the high burden of infectious diseases. India faces the problem of a range of infectious diseases and deaths from Noncommunicable Diseases (NCDs) has become increasingly prevalent over the years despite the efforts put in by the government in the healthcare field.

In the past, India has faced numerous epidemics of emerging as well as re-emerging infectious diseases such as the smallpox epidemic of 1974, the cholera outbreak of 1992, the plague outbreak of 1994, the dengue epidemic of 2006, the flu pandemic of 2009 and many others. India fought such epidemics very strongly, and the government was successful in controlling the conditions before they could cause more damage than they already had, but the emergence of new multidrug-resistant bacteria has made the situation alarming. Such bacteria can cause infectious diseases like tuberculosis and malaria and they are a challenge not only for India but also for the global community and require concentrated efforts to eradicate these diseases entirely.

Essential Aspects of India's Fight against Diseases

According to a data survey from 2016, with around 2.79 million people diagnosed with Tuberculosis in India, TB is one of the most widespread infections within the country. The Indian Government in 2018 set a deadline of eliminating Tuberculosis in India by 2025 and going by the global deadline of 2030; this is a very ambitious deadline

to achieve. But going by the current data and statistics, this goal is very far from being attained, given that India is home to the highest number of Tuberculosis patients and is followed by Indonesia and China. Multidrug-resistant tuberculosis (MDR-TB) is a severe health concern, and according to the World Health Organization, India was home to almost half of the 600,000 new cases of MDR-TB in 2016.

India has set up multiple contemporary national strategies and policies which have been designed to tackle and solve the problems and challenges due to the spread of infectious diseases in the country. There are five critical national strategies for infectious diseases in India which are: -

- Strategic plan for malaria control in India - This plan was set up with the aim of scaling up interventions for malaria control and reduce the burden of the disease on health and economic development of the people affected with this disease.
- National biotechnology development strategy - It was announced in 2007 with the aim to support research in the fields of the human genome, vaccines, and infectious diseases as an integral part of biotechnology. Along with this, the Department of Biotechnology also provides support to understand the basic biology of infection as well as translational research.
- National action plan on antimicrobial resistance(AMR) - AMR is one of the top 10 priorities for collaborative work with the WHO, and the goal of this plan is to tackle AMR in India and contribute towards global efforts to effectively combat its public health threat.
- National strategic plan for tuberculosis elimination - With TB killing almost one person every minute in India, this plan was started with the goal to achieve a TB-free India with zero deaths and morbidity and mortality from TB by 2025.
- Swachh Bharat Mission - One of the primary aims of this project was to make India open defecation free by 2019 by constructing over 12 million toilets in the rural parts of the country.

Along with these strategies and policies to research on infectious diseases and to prevent them from spreading, there are also institutes and organizations set up by the government which are entirely dedicated to working on controlling infectious diseases in the country. The Indian Council of Medical Research is one such organization which works to control the spread of infectious diseases in India and also research on emerging infectious diseases which may take the shape of an epidemic or a pandemic if not taken care of beforehand.

Strategies Undertaken against the Diseases

The Government of India also started the Integrated Disease Surveillance Project in 1998 to research on emerging infectious diseases and keep them under check. The Institute of Epidemiology was started by the Indian Government in Chennai which started the training program in the fields related to epidemiology and public health. Not only this, a new Department of Health Research was set up under the regulation of the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare with the sole task of researching on health development and act as a leader in providing adequate health research response.

The Center for Infectious Disease Research (CIDR) set up at the Indian Institute of Science (IISc) is one of the most prominent institutes of the country, and it has a Biosafety Level 3 facility dedicated to research work on highly pathogenic microorganisms.

Apart from this, India also started various Centers for Disease Control and Prevention with the initial aim of fighting HIV/AIDS infection. The CDC works closely with many local as well as national institutions to address HIV, TB, AMR, influenza, as well as to strengthen laboratory, surveillance and workforce capacity to respond to disease outbreaks in the country.

More than a decade after Leprosy was declared eliminated from India, many new cases of Leprosy were reported in 2017, bringing

the disease back in the country. The disease was reported with more than 1 lakh cases by the Central Leprosy Division of the Union Health Ministry which makes it far from eliminated and its status may be changed from eliminated to resurged if more cases are found in the future.

Along with the above-mentioned cases, dengue is one disease that affects India gravely and there are a high number of cases every year. India has to still fight dengue before completely eliminating the virus from the country. Recently, live type-2 polio strains were found in circulation which spread the scare of polio returning to India. Though Polio has been entirely eradicated from India, it can still come to the country through the neighbouring country of Pakistan which has still not eliminated the disease.

The Road Ahead for India

The various strategies and policies set up by the Government of India against infectious diseases have a solid basis as well as a detailed structure which will help in effectively tackling such conditions and eliminating them from their roots in the long run. More and more national plans, strategies and policies are being set up by the Government to fight against such infectious diseases with bolder efforts and effective implementation.

India has been showing considerable progress towards disease reduction in the previous years, but the general trend showing progress towards eliminating the disease from the country is slowing and this will limit the actual success of the Indian medical system as a whole. More efforts need to be put in and all the strategies and plans already put forward by the government need to be followed and implemented effectively to see proper results.

Illiteracy in India: A Curse to the Society



According to the United Nations, Illiteracy is defined as the 'inability to read and write a message in any simple language'. People with this inability lack knowledge in any particular field or subject and are simply termed as Illiterates. An illiterate person is no different from a handicapped person lacking one of the most important elements for social interaction. Illiteracy in India has always been a major issue leading to some of the major problems of Indian society like poverty, unemployment, child labour, female foeticide, and population explosion. None of these problems is individual problems. Each of these is linked to one another and the root cause is Illiteracy.

The Magnitude of the Problem

Government has started numerous initiatives to reduce the illiteracy rate in the country, especially among the children, but the situation is far from satisfactory, and the goal is still unachieved after years of hard work. Not only among the children of the nation, but there is also a very wide disparity in literacy in India in terms of gender. People post messages on social media platforms to support gender equality, child education, girl education and even the government has started various schemes like 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' but the ground reality is very different from what is shown on television because no one is actually bothered to curb the issues.

In terms of numbers, India has the largest population of illiterate adults in the world, with 287 million illiterate adults. Out of these 287 million, 68% of the adults are women. Not only this, there is a very wide gender disparity in terms of literacy rate in India. While adult males have the literacy rate of 83%, adult females are in a very bad

state in terms of literacy with the current standing at just 57%. It is a very sorry state for a nation that had the first university of the world to be counted among the most illiterate countries in the world.

India has a lot of social issues due to a large diversity in terms of location, topography, culture as well as resources but at the end, all of these issues are connected to each other like a chain with each issue being connected to the other, either directly or indirectly. Illiteracy is the strongest (and most notorious) link which has resulted in numerous other issues. It is therefore right to say that illiteracy is the mother of all evils like poverty, unemployment, child labour, and several others.

Reasons for Illiteracy in India

Illiteracy is not an individual problem. It brings numerous other problems along with it. The World Bank has done multiple studies which have established the fact that there is a direct and functional relationship between literacy and productivity as well as literacy and the overall quality of human life. India is currently home to around half of the world's illiterates and if nothing is done to improve literacy, this issue is going to bog down the future of the country. Some major reasons that have labelled India the country with most illiterate people are mentioned here: -

- **Population and poverty** – Population is the main reason of the high illiteracy rate in India. The exponential increase in population has led to an increase in poverty which has led to high illiteracy rates in the nation as a whole. For a country still in its developing stage, it is very difficult to meet the growing demands of the population at such a fast pace. The condition is such that in rural areas, the children and even adults do not get access to even primary level of education.
- **Gender and social discrimination** - The backward classes of the society are almost always denied the benefits of education due to the rampant social discrimination spread across Indian society. Education is denied to not only the backward classes but in the rural areas, gender discrimination is also there due to which

females are not able to get an education. This has led to a large gap in literacy rate between females and males.

- Low-quality education - Even if a source of education is available, the quality available is very poor. The teachers teaching the students are themselves not educated enough and this has led to the degradation of the knowledge that children are acquiring from the teachers. The poor quality of teachers and professors is one of the main causes of low-quality education and hence low literacy rate.
- Unhygienic and unhealthy environment - Illiteracy is a direct result of the irresponsible handling of the educational institutions and the sorry state of such institutions, especially in rural areas. The unavailability of hygienic washrooms, proper seating arrangements in classrooms, unhealthy food items affect the overall education of the children studying there. Under these conditions, it is nearly impossible to improve the illiteracy rate in the country.
- General apathy: - Apart from all these reasons, another big reason for high illiteracy rate in India is people lacking interest in getting literate. They feel that if they have lived so far happily without getting literate, they can continue to do so. They are not bothered to learn new things or learn new technologies or use something new. They are content with being illiterate and put no efforts towards education.

What can be done to curb Illiteracy in India?

Much has been done in the past decade about education in the country, but the goal is still unachieved, and if the current stage of events continues, it will become very hard for the country to improve the literacy rate of the people. Government has done much and there have been numerous schemes oriented towards educating the young and the adult alike but ultimately the effort needs to be made by the people only.

- The constitution of India guarantees free and compulsory education for all. Under the Directive Principles of State Policy, equal educational opportunities have to be provided to all the citizens of the country. These laws were put in the Constitution by the lawmaker's years in advance while thinking about the literacy of Indians.
- For the people living in rural areas, especially the ones belonging to Below Poverty Line families, the Government of India has started free education programs to increase the enrolment of students from such areas in educational institutions.
- The Sarv Shiksha Abhiyan, started by the Government in 2001 with a vision to educate the children of the country and bring down the illiteracy rate in the country drastically had found popularity in both rural as well as urban areas. Under this scheme, uniform and books were provided to children free of cost so that the families do not have to spend anything, and they do not have a second thought on sending their children to school.

The Indian government has been working to improve the state of higher educational institutions in the nation. It has been planned to open various new institutes of national importance in many different fields so that more children are able to get higher education.

The Road Ahead

No matter how much efforts are undertaken in the field of education, they are never enough. There is always a scope of more. While many efforts have been effective and they have also started showing results, there is still a long way to go. India is still among the topmost region in terms of high illiteracy rates and rural people are still not able to access high quality education. When rural people have to face problems of food, water and shelter, education automatically takes a backseat in the minds of the people. But ultimately people also need to understand that all these problems of food, shelter and water can be solved if they can get quality education. Active participation from

the society itself is essential to address the problem of illiteracy in India.

Negative & Positive Impacts of Advertising on Society



Whether one is a business owner or a writer or a common man, advertisements have become a part of one's day-to-day life. Advertising is a paid mediated form of communication from an identifiable source and designed to persuade the consumer to take an action. A persuasive communication employs persuasive techniques to catch consumer's interests. People react to the same advertisement differently and make decisions on how to spend their available resources on consumption related items. To decide on a particular product, the prospective consumer is forced to choose that product due to the persuasive language behind the advertisement.

Hence, advertising is any paid form of non-personal presentation and promotion of ideas or products by an identifiable sponsor. Advertisements just have a basic ambition, i.e. to help a business grow and flourish. Advertisements can also be social aimed at society and trying to change the ill-effects present in society. Here is a quick look at the positive impacts that an advertisement casts on society:

Social Advertisements

Social advertisements have a history of casting a huge positive impact on society. In India, there are certain advertisements that have educated people about things that were necessary. Be it a regular warning about smoking with the caption 'Smoking is injurious to health' which is embedded with every movie that you watch or a specialized advertisement directed by a commercial company itself.

Recently, an advertisement based on the suppressed rights of transgenders in India was released by the medicine company Vicks.

The advertisement has moved people to tears, making them realize how the society has wronged them.

There are other many advertisements aimed at girl child education, child labour, dowry system, oppression of women, etc. treating these issues as the evil monsters of the Indian society and trying to move a step ahead to eradicate these issues. When such a scenario comes up, advertisements establish their credentials as a positive motivator for society.

Commercial Advertisements

The commercial advertisements, although are focused on the company's benefit yet work for the benefit of consumers in a way or other. They benefit in various ways: -

- Commercial advertisements can make companies competitive. This makes them provide better services to consumers.
- Companies tend to take care of the health matters of the public.
- They are a good way to connect with the audience.

The Information-based Advertisements

Some advertisements are released by the government with an aim to educate the masses and are used as a method of mass communication. Suppose that the government intends to let people know about their policies or some new changes in the authorities, it can simply do so using the advertisements. There are a lot of social welfare schemes going on, and the best way to let masses know about them is through advertisements.

Benefit for the Company Generating the Advertisement

The commercial advertisements help businesses a lot! Through those advertisements, they are able to reach out to masses and make them aware of their products and policies. These advertisements help them create a class and value image for themselves, along with generating interest for their products amongst potential customers.

These advertisements have very different ways through which they can cast an impact on the consumers, and it is usually a positive one for them. They either get a greater consumer base or are successful in building up a great personal image for themselves.

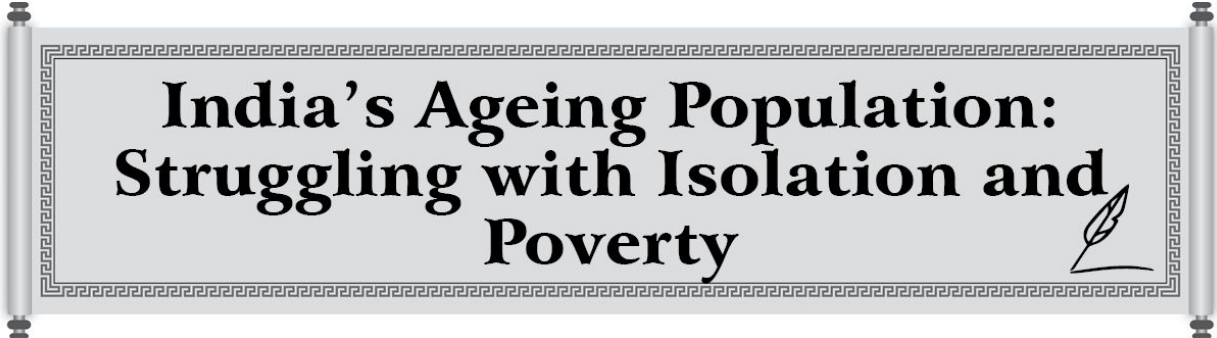
The Negative Impact of Advertising on Society

- Advertisements are a huge source of misrepresentation. No company would let the consumers know about the ill-effects of the products they are selling. That is when things start going wrong. In the rush of presenting their stuff as best, they often tend to cross the boundary between reality and imagination, and this is when the false interpretation of the product starts. This is an act of fooling the society into believing false facts and characteristics of the product and trusting them on the basis of the company's advertisement. This is just fooling people into buying their products which turn out to be exactly opposite of what it was portrayed as.
- Advertisements tend to create an unrealistic expectation for society. The beautiful images represented in the advertisement lead people to think that the scenario created is possible with the help of the product that they are displaying. For example, fairness creams. First of all, these fairness creams create a sense of dissatisfaction and loss of self-confidence in one. This makes them think that their complexion is not good enough. The second part is where deceiving comes into the picture. They portray as if their fairness creams are capable of changing a dark complexion into a fair one within a few days and make one confident and successful. People are fooled by such companies, and their reputation takes a hit.
- The youth is getting corrupted by the advertisements. The youth of the modern days is getting exploited by these advertisements constantly. The advertisements can range from fashion, food to electronics. The advertisements develop a sense of inferiority in the individuals that make them think that they are lagging behind due to not possessing the mentioned stuff. They would then go anywhere and do anything just to get their hands on the product.

This has also been a cause for parents and kids arguing a lot. The youth get dazzled by the glamorous life portrayed in the advertisements and it makes them compelled to have the stuff even if they are not in a position to afford them.

Advertising is a form of marketing communication through which a business or an organization informs the target audience about its products and services. Yes, it has the potential to sway political elections and create financial monopolies when implemented in a right manner. It has the ability to reshape different cultures and influence civil action.

India's Ageing Population: Struggling with Isolation and Poverty



The focus of the entire Indian administrative system is on reaping the benefits of the demographic dividend. As per the official statistics, the availability of demographic dividend started in 2005-06, will peak around 2036, and would last till 2055-56. The government agencies are buoyant regarding the future prospects of the country based on the benefits expected from this trend. But there is a massive challenge facing the country which has long been overlooked, i.e. the senior citizens and their problems. A report from the United Nations Population Fund states that on a global level, the elderly population i.e. individuals above the age of 60, presently constitutes about 12% of the global population and would reach 22% by 2050. When looked at from an Indian perspective, the situation is even more alarming. The percentage and size of elderly individuals are consistently increasing. The total population of the elderly in India increased from 77 million in 2001 to 104 million in 2011 and is estimated to reach 300 million by 2050 i.e. approximately around 20% of the national population.

Challenges Faced by India's Ageing Population and How to Tackle Them

Due to improved healthcare facilities and a decline in fertility rates, population ageing is an inevitable reality. Though an increase in average lifespan is actually a reason for celebration, it is also true that various problems that old age brings with it are actually a reason for concern. Two of the major issues that are beckoning India's ageing

population are poverty and isolation, which in turn lead to various other problems affecting the overall quality of life in the old age.

1. Isolation and Loneliness

Despite having a total population of nearly 1.3 billion, loneliness has become a harsh reality of the urban settlements in the country especially for the senior citizens. As per research conducted by Agewell Foundation, every second senior citizen of India is suffering from loneliness. Moreover, the study reveals that every fifth senior citizen of the country is in urgent need for psychological counselling. As per the census data released in 2011, more than 15 million senior citizens of India live by themselves with 75% of them being females. Additionally, almost 15% of elderly individuals live in a household with all members above the age of 60 years.

-Reasons behind isolation and loneliness

Various reasons have been attributed by experts to the rising problem of loneliness and isolation amongst elderly citizens of the country, such as: -

- Death of the spouse and change in living arrangements
- Poor Health
- Less interaction with family members due to their busy schedules
- A gradual decline in the joint family living system
- Work-related migration
- Non-availability of social interaction, especially in urban areas

This feeling of loneliness is attributed by experts to not living by oneself but in fact, due to lack of activities to keep oneself busy. An elderly individual might not feel lonely if he/she has a set of activities to remain occupied such as going to the bank, shopping, social clubs, etc. But one might feel lonely and isolated despite living with an extended family due to lack of time to interact with one another and no set of activities to keep oneself busy.

How can This Problem be Addressed?

There is very little that the government can do in this regards. Different legislations have been passed wherein children are required to take care of older parents and support them financially. But various studies have established that elderly citizens feel isolated even while living with the extended family. Thus, the problem is actually social in nature and requires a multi-pronged approach to be tackled. Some of the steps that can be taken for addressing the problem of isolation being faced by senior individuals are: -

- Get busy: - Elderly people need to keep themselves occupied through the day by engaging in some productive work. This could include working with an NGO or local groups to address various social problems. Having a busy routine will actually help avoid the feeling of being alone.
- Being part of social groups: - There are various social groups which one can join. These groups meet on a regular basis and comprise of individuals of the same age group. This allows one to share experiences and inputs regarding various aspects of their lives and avoid social isolation.
- Seek medical help: - Seeking timely medical and psychological help is also essential to avoid the feeling of isolation. Most of the times, the reasons behind one feeling isolated are psychological in nature and by getting timely medical help, one can address the problem effectively.
- Lead an active lifestyle: - One should not remain confined to the home during old age. Leading an active lifestyle that includes going out, meeting people, and having new experiences will significantly help resolve the issue.

Poverty or Income Insecurity

Poverty or income insecurity is another critical challenge faced by the elderly population of India. Usually, the family members are supposed to take care of the financial needs of the older members of the family. But due to rapid changes in the socio-economic scenario, the levels of financial insecurity amongst the elderly have rapidly increased

leading to financial insecurity. As per a survey conducted by the Government of India, almost 60% of elderly women and 26% of elderly men do not have any personal income. A major source of income for elderly individuals is primarily the wages and salaries paid by employers. This indicates that even during old age, elderly citizens of India have to work to sustain themselves. The report also revealed that elderly work participation is higher amongst less educated and poor individuals.

Poverty or income insecurity increases with age. The survey revealed that though 50% of elderly individuals have some type of income that is insufficient to support a decent standard of living. As a result, they are unable to take care of their needs and are dependent on others. The reasons behind the increase in the number of elderly individuals facing poverty or income insecurity are: -

- Lack of financial planning during working years
- Working in sectors or jobs with no post-retirement planning
- No effective social welfare or pension schemes in place
- A decline in the joint family system and changing living arrangements
- Dependency on family members for basic requirements

How can this Problem be Addressed?

While the government has launched various social security schemes over the years, the results have been far from impressive. The implementation of these schemes is still not efficient, leaving the elderly to take some proactive steps on their own. Some of the steps that can be taken to address the problem of poverty and income insecurity in older years are: -

- Participation in voluntary pension schemes like Atal Pension Yojana which offer assured pension during post-retirement life.
- Better financial planning and investment decisions during working years with guidance from experts.
- Investment in assets that offer assured income with lesser risk.

- Becoming members of self-help groups in rural areas that offer financial assistance to members.

Though, both the problems of isolation and poverty facing the elderly individuals of India are ominous in nature, but they can be addressed by the individuals themselves. With better planning and execution, avoiding the negative effects of these problems is perfectly possible.

Diplomacy in War Against Terrorism



Terrorism is a global problem. In this day and age, almost every country is affected by this menace either directly or indirectly. Some nations support it; some condone it while some completely ignore it. Each country has its own way to deal with this global problem. From small countries like Israel and Ireland to bigger ones like US and Russia, terrorism is a challenge faced by the governments of all countries.

Today, war is not confined to any powerful nation. Each and every country today is fighting a war against terrorism which is turning to be a menace for the mankind. The growing terrorism calls for a diplomatic answer from the world. Doing war is easy, but countering terrorism in non-violent and peaceful manner is required. It is time to conduct a diplomacy war against terrorism instead of going berserk about fighting back terrorists with the same tactics as employed by them. The key to success in the global war on terrorism today is diplomacy. Terrorists across the globe conduct acts of terror to get their voices heard. Sometimes terrorism is a pursuance of politics through other means. Terrorism thus can be considered as an instrument in the hands of weaker people in the war against the stronger systems like governments.

The 9/11 terrorists attacks shook the foundation of USA. It was an act conducted by Al-Qaida to tame down the strongest nation. The day questioned the security measures of not only America, but all the nations. Using the means of technology, Al- Qaida proselytised its message to the people of the world. However, USA took it to its stride and played tactfully and created an intersection between terrorism

and diplomacy. USA today stands strong with all the nations that are weak but willing to uproot the underlying conditions that allow terrorism to flourish.

Each country today has different set of regulations to fight terrorism. But diplomacy is the most fundamental instrument to ensure convergence between these regulations. It can only be done if a common understanding prevails to fight terrorism. Commitment and sustained efforts are required to fight back this evil. India being a democratic nation holds its head high to fight back terrorism with diplomacy. The hostile relation between India and Pakistan over the issue of Kashmir is a known fact globally. And the hatred has certainly grown over the years. Pakistan has now and then, directly or indirectly supported terrorist activities against India. But the Uri terror attack by Jaish-e-Mohammad in September 2016 and Pulwama attack in February 2019 which killed 18 and 40 Indian soldiers respectively have been strongly condemned worldwide. The Modi government took these despicable attacks very seriously. Post these attacks, India had garnered global support to expose the 'terror state' of Pakistan.

At the UN General Assembly, India openly called Pakistan a 'terrorist state'. It has also accused Pakistan of conducting 'war crimes' against India through its 'long standing policy'. In retaliation, the Indian army conducted many surgical strikes against suspected militants in Pakistani-administered Kashmir. The Indian action was meant to pre-empt their infiltration. Modi and his government are now open about their public policy of diplomatic isolation in regard to Pakistan at the international level. Pakistan is giving shelter to many India focussed militants. With the facts also in hand, Pakistan has not made any effort to control these terrorists groups or has ever tried to maintain cordial ties with its eastern border neighbour. Isolating Pakistan with diplomacy has been in stride of India with various developed countries and neighbouring countries coming in its support. The cancellation of 19th SAARC summit which was to be held in Islamabad was a diplomatic slap on Pakistan's face. India's

decision to pull out of the Summit was supported and endorsed by other member nations with Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Sri Lanka and Maldives following suit. This isolation of one nation in any regional organisation is uncommon and unprecedented. India has further exposed Pakistan in different forums, but has been vocal about expressing its disappointments about the muted response of organisations like European Union about the Uri and Pulwama attacks.

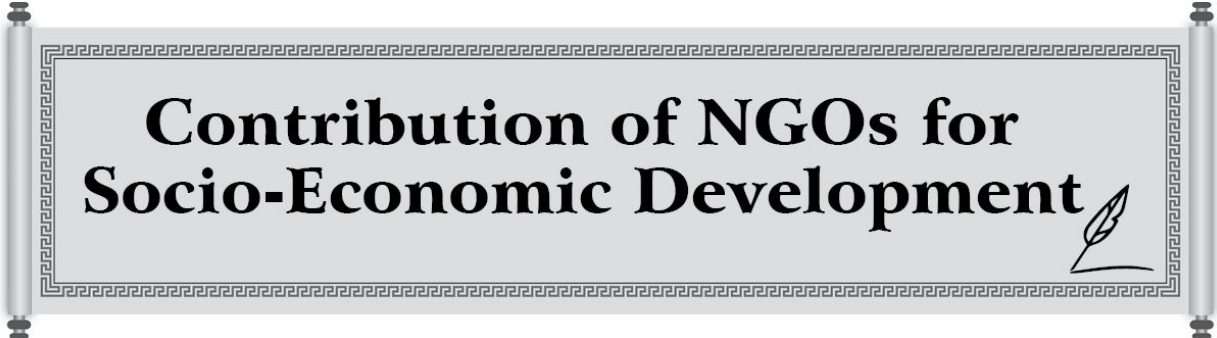
India has also been a key influencer in getting Pakistan isolated from other countries. It has been the first time that the Pakistan based terror groups like LeT and JeM have been named openly during the 2017 BRICS declaration held in China. Modi raised the issue of terrorism and the BRICS leaders joined him in expressing their will to fight terrorism. This is a big win for India in terms of diplomatically isolating Pakistan.

Recently, China, at Pakistan's behest, brought up abrogation of article 370 in Kashmir as well as Army chief General Manoj Mukund Naravane's recent remarks on Pakistan-occupied Kashmir at the UN Security Council to build a case that India was preparing a military action against its western neighbour. But the member countries were least amused. Now, under the new dispensation headed by Imran Khan, a lot of emphasis is being put on jobs, on the Pakistani economy, on development. Hence, if the focus shifts to the economy, maybe there is a chance of hostilities towards India taking a back seat. PM Modi has taken various international platforms to express the need to weed out terrorism and also share crucial details regarding the terror groups operating out of Pakistan and his efforts have certainly paid off. Recently, US refused to give \$ 350 million military aid to Pakistan citing insufficient action taken against the dreaded Haqqani terror network.

Be it India, USA or any other country, only sustained efforts will result in long term benefits. It is high time that nations understand that diplomacy and police work can tackle and thwart terrorist attacks

more effectively than precision air attack. Terrorism is a weed which needs continuous and sustained efforts by countries of the world. Diplomatic isolation is the right path to bring in a terror-free nation. Zero tolerance towards terrorism and organisations and nations supporting it shall be condemned in all aspects to have a sustainable and safe future.

Contribution of NGOs for Socio-Economic Development



There is an old saying “the real India resides in villages,” it holds true in the present times as well. While the pace of urbanisation has reached new heights in the last few decades but still almost two-thirds of the Indian population resides in villages. That is the major reason behind most of the government policies in India being focused on rural development. But the reach and efficiency of the administrative setup in India are quite limited, leaving a lot to be desired. For individuals living in the cities, it is still easier to avail the benefits of government schemes, for Indian citizens residing in villages and rural areas, it is not that easy. The lack of knowledge about the available government schemes and their rights acts as an impediment for the progress of individuals residing in rural areas. This is where the role of NGOs came to the fore. Over the years, NGOs have been playing an increasingly important role in the socio-economic development of India especially the rural region.

NGOs and Their Economics

NGOs or Non-Government Organisations are not-for-profit entities that are engaged in serving humanitarian and cultural interests instead of commercial objectives. They are value-based organisations which fund their operations through grants from the government as well as grants for non-government and private entities, local as well as international. While NGOs receive funding even from the government agencies, they ensure their non-government status by excluding any representatives from the governments from their membership. Moreover, NGOs need not

report to the government or any of its agencies and conduct their operations independently. There are no specific criteria that one must fulfil in order to become a member of an NGO but having humanitarian approach, drive for human welfare, and willingness to work for the cause of others are desirable.

Role of NGOs in Socio-Economic Development

NGOs are active in the field of socio-economic development, but their efforts are not to replace the efforts of the government but rather support them. Any organisation that is active in the field of socio-economic development of the masses is responsible for ushering in qualitative changes and is assessed on the basis of its performance on the following four objectives: -

- Encouraging participation of the people for implementation of the programmes launched by the government and meant for the greater benefit of the community.
- Playing a supplementary role in implementing welfare initiatives of the state.
- Engaging local community members in planning and raising resources for welfare schemes. Thereafter, implementing the activities and sharing the fruits of development.
- Organising the people and instilling their conscience for raising demand for development programmes and then implementing them.

Importance of NGOs in India

After the independence of the country in 1947, NGOs have undertaken various initiatives for upliftment and welfare of the poorer and weaker sections of the society. Here are some facts about the NGOs in India: -

- There are more than 3.30 Lakhs registered NGOs in India.
- 56% of registered NGOs in India are working in the field of women and child welfare.

- 17% of the NGOs are active in the field of education and are also working for mentally challenged and disabled people.
- 85% of the self-help groups formed by NGOs are exclusively meant for women and have loan recovery levels of over 88%.

Following are the various areas of socio-economic importance in which NGOs are active in India and have been playing a pivotal role:

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- Implementation of social welfare programs for the weaker sections of the society.
- Creating awareness regarding environmental protection and education.
- Envisaging health for all programs and ensuring their proper implementation.
- Optimal utilisation of natural resources and renewable sources of energy, including forests.
- Ensuring proper management of water and soil conservation.
- Promotion of ecological awareness and ensuring tribal development.
- Implementation of programs based on fulfilling the minimum needs of the people.
- Creating and implementing education, health, nutrition, and family welfare programs.
- Disaster management and preparedness.

Way Ahead for NGOs

There is no doubt that the NGOs have been playing an extremely crucial role in the progress and welfare of the weaker sections of the society. Going ahead, there are certain areas where more concerted effort is desirable from the NGOs, such as: -

- Improving the state of agriculture: - Agriculture forms the backbone of Indian economy. The government formulates various schemes periodically, but they are not being implemented properly, and the

benefits are not reaching the farmers. NGOs can play a more proactive role in educating the farmers about these schemes and help them avail the facilities being offered by the government.

- Better health facilities: - NGOs also have to play an important role in ensuring better health facilities for individuals residing in rural areas. Lack of proper health facilities results in numerous untimely deaths every year, acting as a roadblock in the progress of the economy. By educating people about various health schemes, safe health practices, organising health camps and by creating awareness, NGOs can ensure a better future for the residents of rural areas.
- Conduct community development programs: - NGOs need to conduct various community-level programs to ensure the welfare of the society. Water conservation, using renewable sources of energy, building toilets, skill development workshops, training programs for females are some initiatives that require more efforts from NGOs.
- Trade development programs: - NGOs have to come forward and take steps towards eliminating middlemen from the transactions between the farmers and the marketplace. By acting as a channel partner, NGOs can offer rural enterprises a better chance to progress and ensure economic upliftment of the society.
- Transparency: - In the last few years, various NGOs have been found to be flouting the established rules and regulations. The country cannot afford the NGOs being blacklisted for not complying with the law of the land. Therefore, NGOs must usher in better transparency in their operations to make sure that people do not have to suffer due to the absence of NGOs.

NGOs act as an important link between the government and the people. However, there is a need for the NGOs to be more

transparent in their operations and be accountable for their actions for the welfare of the country.

Increasing Population Biggest Threat to India's Development



The World Population Prospects 2019 released by the Population division of the UN department of economic and social affairs has stated that India, Nigeria, Pakistan, the USA, Ethiopia, Indonesia, Egypt, the Democratic Republic of Congo and the United Republic of Tanzania would experience the largest increases in population between 2019 and 2050.

Prof. PR. Brahmananda stated, "A stationary economy with an open ended population expansion angle will be the greatest permanent disaster for the country. All hopes of improvement in living standard even at the meagre levels of vast masses will have been forever dashed to pieces. Such an atmosphere cannot be conducive for economic progress. The prospect of more bread being ruled out, the flow of freedom may not flutter for long."

Around 2027, India is projected to overtake China as the world's most populous country. The reasons underlined by the report include the higher fertility rates, growing older population and migration. Population explosion is also contributed majorly to poverty and the growth rate of population is a function of migration, birth rate and death rate in the country.

While high birth rate and fast declining death rates contribute to the high population growth, better sanitation and health facilities have led to the declining death rates. It is the difference between the birth rate and the death rate that measures the growth rate of population.

The Ministry of Health and family welfare has admitted that among the various reasons for most problems related with providing healthcare and unemployment, social security and so on, population

growth is also one of the major factors in India. Further, a high population with no jobs may become a threat to the economy and the current challenges will become harder as we will have more young people as well as older people.

Impact on Economic Growth

Development of an economy is centered on economic development that includes not just the increase in national income (GNP) or per capita income, but also reduction in unemployment as a result of the growth of employment opportunities and reduction in poverty and inequalities of income.

The rapid population growth in India is creating problem of utilization of manpower, over-strained infrastructure, pressure on land and other renewable natural resources, increased cost of population and inequitable distribution of income. All these problems combined together hinder the development of the country.

It is debated that population growth leads to the increase in labour force which is an essential productive resource. By increasing the amount of labour force, population growth will help in producing more output. More so, the increase in population leads to the increase in demand for goods. Thus, population expansion also means enlarging of the growing market for goods and further adding to the economies of large-scale production. However, such situation can be true for western countries and depends on number of other factors.

Impact on Resources and Environment

In India, economic resources are relatively scarce and lack of capital resources result in the unemployment of the increasing population or labour force. Unemployed people do not add to the national output. This decreases the purchasing power of the people which means the demand for goods will also decrease and shrinking of the market economy as a result.

There are adverse effects of the rapidly growing population and poverty on environment as well. Growing number of people and rising

levels of consumption per capita are depleting the natural resources and degrading the environment. The greatest concern is that the number of population rise will increase to such an extent in future that it will cause overall scarcity for resources.

India supports 16.9 percent of the world's population on 2.4 percent of its land area, which means that it has great deal of pressure on its all natural resources.

Impact on Savings and Investments

With the increase in population, there is also an increase in the number of people whose requirements of 'feeding and clothing' have to be met. That means that consumption increases which in turn lowers both saving and investment- two vital elements needed to accelerate the capital formation for economic growth. Thus, overall development gets hampered.

Impact on Employment and Skill Labour Force

It's not just unemployment that is borne out of the explosive growth of population, but underemployment too is increased. The demographic pressure on economy results in increase in backlog of unemployment and under-employment. In the process of absorbing the growing labour force in productive employment, the ability to raise productivity of labour gets severely constrained.

While self-employment is predominant in agriculture, absence of employment opportunities outside agriculture creates an additional labour force that is forced to remain in agriculture and allied activities. As agriculture performs the role of residual absorber, so there are cases of work sharing with family members in spite of the low productivity per person. This leads to fall in net sown area per person and further disguised unemployment emerges in agriculture.

Impact on Demographic Changes

As India is passing through a phase of unique demographic changes and the Census projection report states that the proportion of working

age population between 15 and 59 years is likely to increase from approximately 58 percent in 2001 to more than 64 per cent by 2021. The bulk of this increase is likely to take place in the relatively younger age group of 20-35 years. Such trend makes India one of the youngest nations in the world but at the same time, there is a need to give high priority to the generation of employment opportunities along with providing them proper education and imparting right and requisite skills.

Limited Healthcare Facilities

Basic facilities required in the hospitals, like medicine, furniture and equipment are not adequate to serve the population. Besides this, inadequate doctors in Government hospitals are also a concern for health authorities. Also, government's spending on healthcare services is not up to the World Health Organization (WHO) norms of GDP.

Hampered Infrastructure, Basic Necessities

The rapidly increasing population will lead to the over-exploitation and degradation of land and depletion of fisheries which will threaten the achievement of food security.

Lack of infrastructure facilities will further lead to lack of clean water to drink. The rise in urban slums due to migration of rural population to urban areas for job opportunities creates situation of poor sanitation. This has added to the vulnerability of the people to several diseases.

The Health Ministry had launched Mission Parivar Vikas in 2017 to increase access to contraceptives and family planning services in 146 high fertility districts. There has also been enhancement of sterilization compensation scheme in 11 high focus states (8 Empowered Action Group, Assam, Gujarat and Haryana) and the government has also been looking for private sector to help in the cause.

There is need of more support from the private sector and the investments in CSR should also be enhanced in the area of reproductive health and family planning.

Along with these, there is an urgent need of implementing various policies on family planning, promotion of education, social and economic development, especially of the poor sections of the society.

If You Want a Good Mother, Sister and Wife, then Start Educating a Girl Child



A mother is the most genuine and loving being in a person's life. She has the purest of souls and kindest of hearts. She nurtures and supports not just her kid but the entire family. She enlightens the household with her wisdom and makes it a liveable heaven by garnering it with love, care, generosity, insight, tenderness, availability and sincerity. She is the single soul that anyone can reach out to without fear and worry. To a mother, her kids are the foremost to be taken care of, to be heard and to be grown with everything they need for development.

Give a mother the right amount of resources and she will make her kids the best of all, for she will keep herself empty stomach and feed her kid with the limited food available and keep herself aware to make her kid grow in an intelligent, admirable and wise being. Adding to her attributes the right proportion of education, makes a sensible progress not just in lives of her family members but also in her neighbourhood and the society to which she belongs.

A wife on the other hand is the beautiful incarnation of deity who leaves her patriarchal family to serve her husband. She dedicates her entire life in beautifying the household of her in-laws and in making her husband's life better and progressed. Besides her cordial and benevolent nature, a good wife requires to be educated to understand things in orderly manner and use her acumen in times of need and emergency. She can prove to be a humble support to her husband and provide him confidence and help when he falls back. A woman, who is encouraged with education, is self-reliant and confident. She is empowered to take her own stand and fight for herself and her family.

If she is educated, she knows its power and will never let her family suffer in lack of anything. With her knowledge, she will ignite the darkness and fill the void from the lives of her loved ones.

Modern world owes much to the famous inventor and American businessman, Thomas Edison. Whatever he achieved in life would not have been possible without his mother taking a backseat and supporting him at the most crucial moments of life. He grew up to become the most influential figure of the millennium but his childhood narrates a different story. He was sent back to home with a letter by his teacher proclaiming him to be a dull child deeming him a victim of ADHD (attention deficit hyperactivity disorder). But, his mother Nancy Edison believed in him and was always sure of him. She withdrew him from school and began teaching him at home. Had she been uneducated, the world would not have witnessed a great personality like Thomas. Due to the efforts of an educated mother, the world was blessed with the electric bulb and thousands of other inventions to which Thomas Edison single-handedly held patent record in his name.

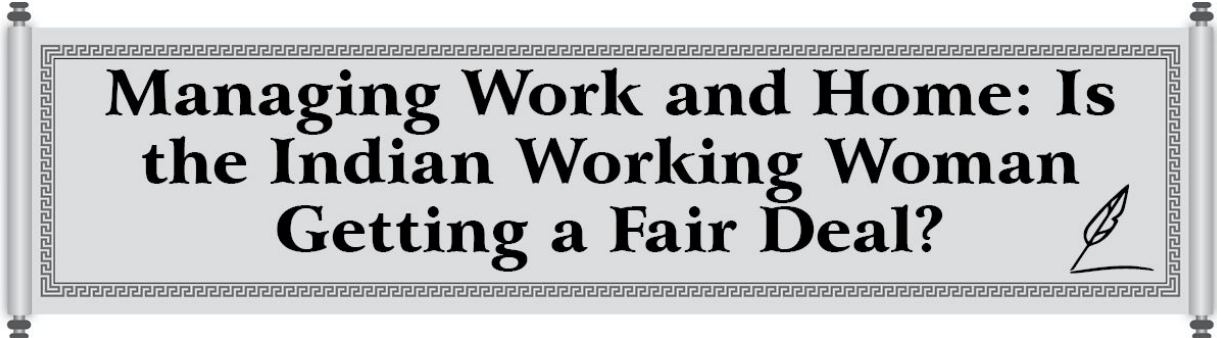
The nightingale of India, the veteran singer Lata Mangeshkar is the eldest amongst her 5 siblings and she devoted her life to music and her siblings. Her parents passed away at a very early stage when she was merely 13 and the burden of entire family shifted on to her shoulders. A close friend of his family helped her get started in a career as a singer and actress. In order to bring up her younger siblings, she did not marry herself but ensured that her siblings get proper education and flourish along with their families. It was her dedication and truthfulness in nurturing the relations that gifted the Indian music industry with a cluster of musical gems in form of famous singers from her family such as Asha Bhosle, Hridaynath Mangeshkar, Usha Mangeshkar and Meena Mangeshkar. Besides a great voice that she is gifted with, it was her education that remained a shield and significant weapon that helped her and her family achieve what they wanted.

A woman can be a good mother, wife and sister once she gets education and knows how to use her rights. She can be bold and beautiful at the same time. It's rather surprising but exhilarating to note that amongst the social activists who fought for the rights of women and their education, Mahatma Jyotirao Phule, being a male himself is the pioneer of girls' education in India. He and his wife, Savitribai Phule noticed the plight of women and organised a strike against the barbers in order to persuade them to stop shaving the heads of widow. Not just this, Savitribai Phule noticed the plight of women who fell prey to sexual exploitation and became pregnant and committed suicide or killed the newborn due to fear of banishment by the society. She opened a care centre for pregnant rape victims and helped deliver their children. She proved that a woman when enlightened with the flame of education can spread its brightness throughout the world and can nurture not just her family but also her fellow compatriots.

We can go on noting endless names and giving in numerous examples on how educated women can be resourceful for their family, fellow beings and the society in totality. They can be powerful and ingenious in letting their loved ones follow the right path and use their conscious and experience in progressing through stages of life.

Educating a woman should not be seen in singularity as a woman when educated, leads to the education of an entire nation. She is going to be an educated sister, wife and mother who will benefit everyone around with her quick-wittiness, boldness, creativity and knowledge. She will never let her family, her husband her siblings and her child suffer in ignorance and witlessness. She will always be their guiding soul and will positively contribute in laying the foundation of a progressive nation building. So, it's not just about me and you, it's about imparting education to every girl child in similar fashion as a boy is being educated. It's about giving every girl child in our locality, society, town, city, village, district, state, country and world her basic right – the right to education, so that she progresses in order to let us all progress simultaneously.

Managing Work and Home: Is the Indian Working Woman Getting a Fair Deal?



The 21st century has seen greater strides in achieving equality status in the work sphere between the sexes. India is undergoing a transition of sorts in the workplace atmosphere. From being a society in which economic work outside the home was conducted solely by men, steady strides have been taken forward to bring evermore greater women participation in various occupations through the spread of literacy, educational opportunities and improved health indicators.

But with the increase in women participation at work, the frequency of hassles which the modern Indian woman juggling work and home face has also increased. Indian working woman faces multiple problems in the social, economic, political, domestic, psychological sphere.

Majority of Indian women are involved in economic activities or productive work. This work is done in addition to domestic work or household which is considered as a woman's responsibility. Generally the male individuals are unwilling to contribute their part in finishing the household work. As a result, women are committed with double burden of doing household work, taking care of children and husband and their official work of employment outside home.

Women need work life balance because in today's career women are continually challenged by the demands of full time work and when the day is done at office, they carry more responsibilities and commitments at home. Women's lives are juggling act that includes multiple responsibilities and commitments at work as well as at home.

Women are the progenitors of the institution of the family, having granted by God the power to produce offspring. For this reason, the position of mother figure in the Indian culture sphere is very strong and obtains a lot of respect and responsibility. Traditionally, women have been seen as a group of individuals responsible for taking care of children and maintaining household while men are responsible to go out to work and earn money. A woman primarily plays two roles in the society, one as the mother to her children and second being a wife to her husband. We live in a patriarchic society which is male dominated. Often women have to subjugate her interests for her family.

Home is always considered as the first place for women to work and office always comes second or becomes a secondary responsibility. Therefore, balancing between work and home is a difficult task for working women. It is common to see a working woman gets up early to work in kitchen and prepares food, getting the children ready for school and then getting herself ready to reach office on time.

The Indian working woman thus does not seem to be getting a fair deal in managing her relationships at home and her work commitments.

The double burden is not only limited to urban areas. In rural areas women are found working at home as well as contributing in fields also throughout the day. In rural areas the women are involved in allied activities such as animal husbandry, agriculture, sericulture, labourers and farmers.

A woman faces many difficulties managing work and household at the same time. It is the responsibility of the society to appreciate her contribution and encourage her in her efforts. Greater understanding of the problems faced by the working women is required. Double burden can be reduced by changing the mindset of the Indian women as well as the patriarchal society that looks down upon women.

Another setback that is constantly faced by working mothers is that their work is often considered to be optional; it is also viewed as less

important than that of their partners. When these attitudes are confronted, it makes the transition for the working mother all the more difficult. The constant backlash from the public makes these mothers feel so guilty that some may even quit their jobs. To make working mothers feel needed, and to have their work mean something, others need to look upon their work as something substantial, something important, not simply an option. When workplaces provide flexible scheduling and childcare services, these are the first steps in getting working mothers into the workforce and alleviate their feelings of guilt.

Men should realize their responsibility in helping towards household chores. In-laws and relatives should have empathy towards working women's psychological, social and physical needs. Community people should be more appreciative and supportive. Companies should provide a safer environment for women to work.

When a working woman is present in the family the responsibilities need to be divided evenly so as to reduce the stress due to uneven balance between work and home. Understanding is the most important factor; women need to feel that their work is important and necessary. Women should not feel guilty about not giving time to their children and family. Working women need a support system in order to survive the roller coaster involved when they go back and forth.

It is the responsibility of the policy makers and the planners to acknowledge women's double burden and find the possibilities to minimize it. Home and child care responsibilities should be reduced to make them more compatible with their economic role. Participation in every field should be increased and encouraged. Day care centres for children, crèches at workplace can be a good initiative. Most importantly, the next generation of children must be made sensitive about hardships faced by the women in the society and should be taught to contribute in the domestic work from the very beginning of childhood. Successfully achieving work life balance will ultimately create a more satisfied workforce that contributes to productivity and success in the workplace.

The Power of Social Media



The American author of Socialnomics Erik Qualman said that “the power of social media is that it forces necessary change” and if we observe closely, it indeed does through its impactful means. Not denying the fact that it has not just remained a source of entertainment for us but also helped us form opinions on major social issues time and again.

Negating the significance of social media in an age of information would simply mean being deported to a barren island with no one to talk or communicate. Communication seems so vital today that sharing ideas seems more like a habit next to eating and sleeping. And the sharing of ideas can’t be possible without social media.

But, in this chaos of talking and sharing every moment of our lives, are we really thinking aloud or even asking ourselves about the smallest decisions we make in our day to day lives! Right from switching between television channels to unconsciously watching those tele-ads or even creating our viewpoint on some current issue that has been viral on social media, almost everything seems like being superimposed. In short, what we think is not our thought but the one that is created by the media and our opinion is not our own but what the media wants us to have.

Media Encompassing Television Ads

Media being highly commercialized and sophisticated in its mode knows very well to play with the human psyche. They are good at creating a halo around them even while we are in the comforts of our

room watching a film or series and thence pop up umpteen advertisements with products to lure us into buying them soon.

Their spell over us makes us buy items which we do not really need, by using youth icons like cricket stars and actors. Many ad agencies go on targeting kids in order to influence their parents and force them into changing their buying behaviour towards specific brands. Advertisements are just a small drop in the sea of media but at the same time, media can't survive without the former.

How it Helps Us

What is that one single magnetic force that keeps us inclined towards the media? It is its power to create awareness about the happenings around us. While being a resourceful medium of conveying the updates, it has also become an affordable means to gain knowledge and skills.

Looking behind to the colonial era, when print media was the powerful way to spread one's voice against the British and helped the nationalists in mobilizing the masses, we can sense its relevance even after seven decades of independence.

Watsapp and YouTube are the most revolutionary innovations of this century. It provides not just platform to learn and teach but have become a convenient mode of earning some extra money through getting specified subscribers and likes as well. Learning for students has become so smooth, hassle-free and engaging in this era and YouTube is sure to be applauded for the same.

Facebook has wide reach and connects people across globe so effortlessly. With millions of apps to our service and tons of websites in our reach, we have a plethora of choices to transform our world meaningfully and efficiently.

How it Harms

In this dazzling world of internet and social media, we have become immune to finding relevant information and unconsciously gulp down whatever comes our way.

The recent episodes of mob lynching in some regions of North East and Northern states of India depict the lack of sensibility in people who blindly follow Facebook and Whatsapp trolled messages that spread rumours regarding visitors or strangers in some state being cattle smugglers and children lifters. Social media here has been a distraction for the mass and also a misleader.

Agitation and unrest over the Citizenship Amendment Act continues into the year 2020. Protests were witnessed in various parts of India including Delhi and a lot of public property was destroyed by anti-CAA protestors. Even educational institutions like Jamia Milia Islamia, Jawahar Lal University, Aligarh Muslim University were not spared with students coming out on roads in large numbers. As soon as some news was viral on Facebook and Whatsapp and it had its consequences in no time.

With the internet providing so much of freedom to its users, the incidents of hate speech, hate videos, fake news and abusive content have flooded the social media platforms so much so that it has ended up creating disappointment and disillusion amongst the youth.

Online games such as 'Blue Whale Challenge' and 'Salt and Ice Challenge' to name a few which have the potential to cause fatalities or serious damage to the life and psyche of youth have been trolling on the internet. They have been reported to instil suicidal tendencies in kids or youth involved in the game and many kids already lost their lives due to these.

How Media can Enhance its Power

Media has the smartest weapon—communication! Through this weapon, it can control and curb many evils but at the same time can exploit emotions of people and misguide them. Being a responsible messenger of the society, media needs to disseminate only the needful and evade off the unnecessary things.

It should call for action when it sees fake news or hate speech going viral on its platforms. It should rather teach people about how their posts on social media remain global and so they have to be more aware of what they are saying or commenting.

It has to be a motivator which spreads good cause and also avoids spreading rumours. It has to act more responsibly in the backdrop and understand that it has the power to shape its audience's imagination. So, it should act more sensitively and use its power astutely.

Is Growing Level of Competition Good for Youth?



The development of any country is highly dependent on its youth. Youth are in the stage when they learn new things, acquire experience, conceive new ideas and bring in new vision of new generation. India has a population of over 1.32 billion. More than 50% of its population is below the age of 25 and more than 65% below the age of 35. Due to the large number of its people and far less opportunities, competition in India is growing day by day in all spheres of the society. But the most vulnerable section which falls prey to its implications is the Youth. Competition, in fact, has become a necessary evil for the young generation.

Life of the young is not at all easy. The spirit of competition is instilled in them right from their nursery admissions and keeps them busy for their entire lives. There is a stiff competition to obtain outstanding percentage of marks to secure admission into a good and reputed college or university. Similarly, there are competitive exams and interviews when it comes to government jobs and even higher studies. For instance, in UPSC civil services examination, more than 10 lakh candidates participate out of which only 1200 get selected. Students face competition not only in academics but also in every other field like sports, music, art, politics, etc. which can be a viable career option for them.

Competition among youth has positive as well as negative impacts.

Positive Implications of Competition Among Youth

High level of competition encourages young aspirants to work hard and brings out the best in them. As opportunities are few, only the conscientious can win and the deserving achieve success. Competition helps in learning to deal with success and failure. It tests the dedication and perseverance of a person and helps them to push their limits. It motivates the youth to enhance their skills and expand the frontiers of learning and innovation. It instils in them a sense of achievement and contentment. Competition inspires young entrepreneurs to compete globally with their counterparts in other nations. Competition in sports plays a vital role in bringing out the invincible spirit of the players and instils harmony and teamwork among team members. Every day, new records are made in almost every sport only due to the competition to excel. Competition enables constant improvement in products and interminable update of technology. It helps to foster the best talent among the youth especially in performing arts. Contests held at district to national level, by reality shows on television, allows performers to showcase their talent and gain instant fame. Competition is the only path of social mobility, and the best means of realising their dreams, for the underprivileged youth.

Negative Impacts of Competition among Youth

But not all the people face competition in a positive way. Some find it really difficult to survive in this competitive world. Students who find themselves trapped in this world full of competition become vulnerable to vices like crime and substance abuse. Unable to accept failure, they seek solace in alcohol, smoking and drugs. Unemployment forces job aspirants to look to make money through unfair means like robbery, theft, conning, etc. The growing level of competition may create unusual pressure which exposes the youth to mental problems such as stress, anxiety and depression. This isolates them as they don't like interacting with people and withdraw into a shell. Some find it so difficult to cope with the intense pressure in this competitive world that they even end their lives.

Excessive cramming to secure a rank in a competitive exam has hampered the thinking power of the youth. By promoting extensive practice and rote learning of prepared modules, coaching institutes have shifted the focus from understanding and learning. Unfortunately, the knowledge acquired through this mechanism is short-lived. It is seldom retained, once the exams are over.

The opportunities available are limited as compared to the huge number of candidates. Often children lose their childhood running after a dream of getting into a prestigious college or of cracking a competitive examination just because their parents want them to. They are devastated to realize they didn't enjoy the best years of their lives for a dream they could not achieve.

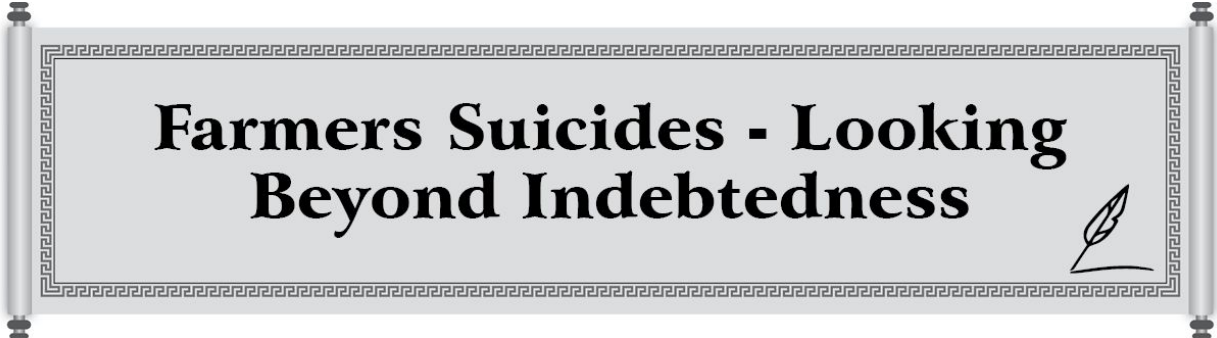
Apropos of Charles Darwin's theory of 'The survival of the fittest', only those people will be able to survive who adapt to the growing competition; for competition is inevitable in today's world. However, only because competition puts some children under duress, it is not right to put brakes on competition amongst youth. Hence, competition is necessary despite its negative impacts. Parents and teachers should inculcate healthy competition in their children to work hard to earn a coveted seat. But at the same time, children should be taught that success in a particular field or exam is not the ultimate goal; one needs to become a good human being first. In order to overcome depression and anxiety, youth should adopt practices like meditation and yoga. Meditation is a powerful practice to increase concentration, harness stray thoughts, and eliminate stress. Experiencing inner peace is essential for a healthy body and mind. We should develop positive thinking as our minds shape our lives — what we think, we become.

Children are like soft wet clay that can be moulded into any shape. So, if we inculcate strength, confidence, perseverance and power in them to face life situations in youth, then instead of succumbing to failure, they will bounce back to face the fierce competition. One should take failure as a stepping stone to success and learn to take hardships in one's stride. Examples of great people who became

successful after multiple failures abound, and today the whole world admires them.

Unhealthy competition comes into play when winning at any cost becomes the sole motive. It leads to undesirable events like people slipping into depression or students committing suicide. Competition is good if taken in the right spirit .It gives enormous opportunities to test ourselves on a number of skills, inculcates confidence in us and makes us realize that anything can be achieved through sheer hard work and determination. The youth should also learn to remain positive and face all circumstances in life without losing faith and conviction. Once this happens, we will witness a better and higher level of positive competition where both the winner and the loser win.

Farmers Suicides - Looking Beyond Indebtedness



'A farmer commits suicide every half-an-hour in India since 2001.'

According to the data by the National Crime Records Bureau of India in 2014, 5,650 cases of farmer suicides reported. The highest number of farmer suicides was recorded in 2004 when 18,241 farmers committed suicide. The farmers' suicide rate in India has ranged between 1.4 and 1.8 per 100,000 total population over a 10-year period through 2005. As of 2018, the Indian government has not published data on farmer suicides since 2015.

As we are a fast developing nation with speedily growing urban population, it is often overlooked that 70 percent of our population is still part of rural India and for them agriculture and related activities are the main source of income. Demographically speaking, we are still an agrarian economy. And it appears that while our country is on an urban developmental roll, our farmers have faced dire neglect, significantly underlined now by the shocking suicide statistics.

Farmer suicides account for 11.2% of all suicides in India. As of 2017, farmer suicides have occurred in large numbers in Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Telengana, Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Orissa and Jharkhand. In its 2012 annual report, the National Crime Records Bureau of India reported that 135,445 people committed suicide in India, of which 13,755 were farmers (11.2%). Of these, 5 out of 29 states accounted for 10,486 farmer suicides (76%) – Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh and Kerala. Moreover, one can always expect a higher real suicide-rate than reported since the data provided by states is often skewed with some claiming zero farmer suicide.

Studies and speculation within the county and abroad have tried to pin down the cause which leads to the utter hopelessness in farmers inciting them to such a step. While our county is long past the feudal system, many farmers own a very small strip of land or operate as tenant farmers to other big farmers and are bound in a vicious borrowing cycle to the modern day 'lords', the moneylenders. Farmers are deprived of the benefits of the government subsidy in slashed interest rates, for most cannot meet the documentation demand of the banks and so prefer loans from local wealthy moneylenders even though at much higher rates. While for most farmers the loaning-sowing process is also really only a gamble since most remain at the mercy of the weather conditions. Many rely on the seasonal rains for irrigation while untimely rains can undo, in an instant, all the back-bending, rigorous toil that is a farmer's life. Nature's fickleness spells disaster for them as they are looking up to the crop to pay back loans and to scrape a living for the family. At times, it stretches them just enough to push them off the brink into hopelessness and a death wish.

Interesting correlations are being drawn to determine the situation of the places worst hit by the suicide menace. Some have pointed out that cash-crop - like coffee and cotton-growing farmers are the most at risk. However, the spread of cash-crop area as a predicator of suicide rate does not prove a reliable measure as many well-to-do farmers with the means to tackle weather fluctuation too have a hold on this sector, like in Gujarat. But in other areas with small cash-crop growing farmers, the suicide numbers are dismal, understandably, since a failure means loss of sustenance unlike for the grain growing farmers.

One line of argument tracing the cause behind the suicide trend is that the liberalisation policy adopted by the government in 1990s has taken down the farmers. Since liberal trade spans nations and prices are subject to international price fluctuations, the farmers do not have enough security to cope with them. Another issue which has called for much attention, with rising protests, is of Genetically Modified seeds. The GM seeds claim better product and productivity and are

pest resistance and thereby high-benefits for the farmers. However, it has been observed that these expensive seeds also require extra irrigation and fertilization, pushing up the cost of production higher. Moreover, it has been observed that insects and pests have become resistant to the repelling technology in GM crops, which now demand intensive levels of fertilization, toxic for the environment. Also, a major drawback is that these crops are sterile and the farmers are required to purchase new seeds for every season. Seed companies which have acquired a patent on the GM seeds have quite managed to take over the agricultural market in this manner.

The rising costs and thereby dipping economic viability of farming and the urban trend has seen a gradual shift away from farming. Yet a substantial portion of the population remains engaged with agriculture and what cannot be discounted is a rise in overall production and productivity.

However, the country envisions a nation self-sufficient in meeting its food demands and for that there is a need for a major focus shift by the government onto bettering the agricultural field and helping the downtrodden farmers. In July 2018, the government approved a steep rise in the minimum support price of crops, giving farmers the promised 50% return on input costs, a politically astute move that can ease farm distress and boost rural demand if implemented effectively. The biggest increase in MSP, about 40-50%, is for coarse grains that are planted by the poorest farmers, mostly in unirrigated areas. About a quarter of India's area under such crops is in Rajasthan, with the rest split between several states including Maharashtra, Karnataka, Uttar Pradesh, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh. The historic Rs 15,000-crore move fulfilled the promise made in this year's budget that MSPs would be determined on the principle that the harvest should get the farmers 150% of the cost of planting and tending to the crop. The rift between our farmers and the urban country seems to be simply expanding rapidly and the farmers are finding it impossible to grapple with the difficult scenario and succumbing to easier death. Sinister death, sardonically met by

drinking the very pesticide bought to help them, leaves in its wake a greater desolation for the living family.

A poignant point in case is also that male suicide is much greater than female suicide since, as can be understood, the responsibility of providing for the family in our country, especially in rural areas, rests on males. Some steps like exempting farmers of loans up to one lakh have been suggested to provide some relief to the farmers. But not just allowances of monetary relief but structural improvement are now necessary which understand and address the problem at its core.

Should Educational Qualification be Made Mandatory for Politicians?

“Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world.”

—Nelson Mandela

Since the advent of India's independent era, the country has seen both extremely educated as well as uneducated leaders. This has stirred a huge debate as to whether education should be deemed as a necessary precondition for politicians in this day and age. In India, there is no minimum educational qualification required to become a minister; but, there is a minimum educational requirement to become a peon. However, a string of past events prove that even the well educated politicians use their education to satisfy their selfish desires. There have been a number of politicians involved in scams and corruption. The high amount of funds with the government has always been meddled with. Therefore, superior educational skills do not guarantee the presence of moral and ethical values in politicians; it is just a statement of how literate they are as they can use the same expertise to carry out illegal activities.

There is a thin line between literacy and education but these terms are often used interchangeably. More often than not, we get swayed by how “literate” a person is. Literacy is about acquiring skills and learning whereas, education is about the application of these skills, knowledge, values, beliefs and habits that the individual has acquired over the years, for the betterment of self and others. Literacy can be seen as a means to education but not education in itself. “By education, I mean an all-around drawing of the best in child and man

in body, mind and spirit” was a statement made by Gandhi and is the main driving force behind the Gandhian Philosophy of Education.

The emphasis on the importance of education is often contradicted when the educated leaders and politicians get involved in a number of scams and controversies related to the government's finances. Not only this, political corruption exists in many forms and at all levels of the government. The nation has witnessed many such acts of corruption in the form of tax evasion, forcing the electorate to vote for a particular candidate, accumulation of black money with politicians and funding of electoral campaigns.

However, these educated leaders also possess the technical prowess to ensure that the nation experiences positive growth in all spheres. A few politicians have displayed impeccable skills in their area of expertise that has aided the process of development. One such example is the development of the railway sector and the techniques employed were discussed and analyzed extensively at the international platform. With the risk of a financial collapse of the railway sector, the politicians worked together and came up with dynamic solutions to counteract and ratify the issue. The economy has also experienced boom periods due to the efforts put in by these politicians.

Being the holder of a certain degree, does not guarantee that the candidate concerned will be a good leader. Therefore, being inflexible in terms of who contests elections is also ensuring the murder of the political system. With a literacy rate of 74.04% and a ranking of 105 out of the 127 countries in UNESCO's Education for all development Index (EDI), putting an education qualification as the minimum basic requirement would mean depriving a number of deserving candidates from availing this opportunity, who might end up being better leaders as compared to the educated politicians who have spent the majority of their lives locked up in classrooms and being distant from the happenings of the world around them.

It is, however, important to ensure that the candidate chosen must be educated in the field of Public Administration and certain basic

philosophies. He/she must be aware of the needs of a multicultural and diverse society to ensure that the socio-economic hierarchy that is present in society is abolished. An educated person can help better in aiding the developmental process of our country and in changing its status to that of a developed country. In addition to this, an educated person can aid in the attainment of the Education for all (EFA) goal of 100% enrolment in primary schools, one of UN's Millennium Development Goals.

Many leadership attributes are gained through acquiring formal education. By being a part of an educational institution and interacting with people on a daily basis paves the way for innovative thinking as an individual is open to the thoughts and opinions of a number of people. Due to these interactions, a person also faces a number of situations on a daily basis which require them to think innovatively and creatively. This is also the essence of a democracy which requires the proactive participation of its citizens.

An educated politician won't be misguided easily by their educated counterparts like the bureaucrats. They will apply an analytical approach when confronted by any issue being faced by the public. Educated politicians can be better policy makers, executors and can guide and control bureaucrats intelligently for the welfare of the nation. Educated politicians can conclude in a better way from the advices on any issue given by advisors. Therefore, educated politicians can prove to be better administrators, statesmen, foreign ministers, international political negotiators, etc.

Therefore, there is a need to set a basic minimum education criterion in order to avoid senseless legislations and drain of wealth which are very important aspects in the development of our nation because efficient availability of funds will ensure the smooth operation and application of the various schemes started by the government to aid development.

Just like possessing certain skills makes you a more deserving candidate for a job, acquiring educational qualifications will only help a person to grow as an individual. Education will not harm a person in

any way but will only help them grow and nurture their potential. It will also help them to identify their strengths and weaknesses as an individual. Therefore, the role of education must not be disregarded altogether. Being a leader calls for acquiring practical knowledge and ability to make quality decisions and these aspects of a leader are directly influenced by the education that they have acquired. However, a politician must not be judged solely on how much education they have received because in the end, the will power of a politician pushes them to work. We live in a country which has not yet achieved cent per cent literacy and to impose an educational qualification to contest elections would mean depriving a huge fraction of the nation from achieving its political rights and this would in turn mean the violation of the essence of democracy.

Reservations and Human Development in India



The Prime Minister of Britain Ramsay Macdonald in August 1932 gave this award known as Communal Award according to which separate representation was to be provided for the Indian Christians, Anglo-Indians, Europeans, Muslims, Sikhs and Dalits. A number of seats from several constituencies were assigned to the depressed classes giving them the privilege of voting during the election. This evolved as the extension of the 'divide and rule' policy of the British. This controversial award was opposed by Mahatma Gandhi who fasted against it but many people among the minority communities supported this Award. The Dalit leader, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar was one of the most noted supporters. This led to lengthy negotiations and finally an agreement reached between Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. Ambedkar. This agreement named as the Poona Pact detailed a single Hindu electorate with seats reserved within it for the Dalits. For other religions like Sikh and Muslim, the electorates remained separate.

The present reservation system in India holds a long history that has been debated several times before and after Independence. In the areas comprising the Presidency and the Princely states south of the Vindhyas the reservations in favour of Backward Classes were introduced long before independence. An agitation grew against the recruitment of non-natives into public service in the princely state of Travancore and it led to the emergence of the demand for reservation of government jobs in 1891. People complained about the qualified native people being overlooked.

The year 1979 showed a major change with the ratification of the Mandal Commission which aimed at assessing the situation of the socially and educationally backward classes. Without having any exact figures for a sub-caste, this Commission used the 1930 census data and classified 1,257 communities as backward further estimating the OBC population to 52%. The recommendations of the Commission were finally implemented in the Government Jobs in 1990s by then Prime Minister Vishwanath Pratap Singh.

Reservation in India is a process of reserving a certain fixed percentage of seats in government institutions for the backward communities primarily defined by caste and tribe. This is basically a quota-based affirmative action and is governed by constitutional laws, statutory laws and local rules and regulations. Its primary objective lies in enhancing the educational and societal status of underprivileged communities, thereby enabling them to join the mainstream of Indian society.

In Indian Parliament, 84 and 47 out of 543 seats are reserved for SC and ST respectively. This allocation of seats in Lok Sabha is based on the proportion of SC and ST in the concerned states to the total population.

The present caste based reservation system of Union government allocates 15% to SC, 7.5% to ST, 27% to OBC and 50.5% to general category that is open to all including SC/ST and OBC. Higher education institutions funded by the central government reserve 22.5% of the available seats for Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe students. An additional 27% is for OBCs and the total percentage for SC and ST has been raised to 48%. Religious minorities have also been benefitted by the reservation. 3.5% of seats are allotted to Muslims and Christians by the Tamil Nadu government, which has altered the OBC reservation from 30% to 23%.

On 22 December 2011, the Government of India announced establishment of a sub-quota of 4.5% for minorities within the existing 27% reservation for OBC. It was reasoned that the Muslim

communities granted as OBC are unable to compete with the Hindu OBC communities. This decision was criticized by the court stating that the sub-quota was something carved out only on religious lines and not on any intelligible basis.

In case of promotions in government jobs, the 2006 judgment by a five-judge constitution bench in the Nagaraj case had held that states were not bound to provide reservations to Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. It, however, had said that in case any state wished to make such a provision, it was required to collect quantifiable data showing backwardness of the community, as well as its inadequate representation in public employment. Now, the Chief Justice of India has set up a five-judge constitution bench of the Supreme Court to examine whether its 12-year-old verdict in the M Nagaraj and others versus Union of India case on reservation for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in government job promotions requires reconsideration.

Certain state governments also reserve all jobs for those who are domiciled within the jurisdiction of that government. For example, 85% of seats were reserved previously for Chandigarh-domiciles in Punjab Engineering College, which has been altered to 50% now. Some reservations are also made for non-resident Indians in educational institutions. There are reservations in special schools of government undertakings/PSUs for the children of their own employees (ex., Army schools, PSU schools, etc.)

The Mandal Commission was protested by the students and the masses. It saw the anguish in form of roads, highways, transportation services, schools and businesses being blocked. Throughout the nation, around 150 students endeavoured self-immolation.

The social and financial status of the reserved category is well supported by the government and has also increased profoundly. The total percentage of reserved category people – (SC, ST, OBC) working in government institutions has increased to about 40% and is also rising. The general category misses opportunity and also has

become deprived and miserable due to their place being replaced by reservations.

In spite of the considerable increase in Indian population, no official statistics and policy based on caste has been made by the government.

Several unreserved or general categories and communities too have started demanding reservation for them which is sure to surge in more turmoil and instability in the already troubled reservation hierarchy.

Corporate Social Responsibility - Nation Needs It



It is recognised that the world over integrating social, environmental and ethical responsibilities into the governance of businesses ensures their long term success, competitiveness and sustainability. This approach also reaffirms the view that businesses are an integral part of society, and have a critical and active role to play in the sustenance and improvement of healthy ecosystems, in fostering social inclusiveness and equity, and in upholding the essentials of ethical practices and good governance. Many companies have been quick to sense this development, and have responded proactively while others have done so only when pushed.

In the past, businesses primarily concerned themselves with the economic results of their decisions. Today, however, businesses must also reflect on the legal, ethical, moral and social consequences of their decisions. It is important for businesses not only to provide products and services to satisfy the customer, but also to ensure that the business is not harmful to the environment in which it operates. In order for an organization to be successful, the business must be built on ethical practices. Companies are increasingly pressurized to behave ethically. This pressure comes from customers, consumers, governments, associations and the public at large.

This also makes business sense as companies with effective CSR, have image of socially responsible companies, achieve sustainable growth in their operations in the long run and their products and services are preferred by the customers. Although the roots of CSR lie in philanthropic activities (such as donations, charity, relief work, etc.) of corporations, globally, the concept of CSR has evolved

immensely. It now encompasses all related concepts such as triple bottom line, corporate citizenship, philanthropy, strategic philanthropy, shared value, corporate sustainability and business responsibility.

The term 'Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)' came about in the late 1960's and early 1970's after many multinational corporations used it to describe organisational activities that impacted their responsibility towards the greater environment. Today, Corporate Social Responsibility is no longer defined by how much money a company contributes to charity, but by its overall involvement in activities that improve the quality of people's lives. It has come up as a significant subject matter in the international business community and is progressively becoming a mainstream activity. There is mounting recognition of the momentous effect the activities of the private sector have on the workforce, clientele, the society, the environment, competitors, business associates, investors, shareholders, governments and others groups. It is also becoming progressively clear that organisations can contribute to their individual wealth and to overall community wealth by taking into account the effect they have on the entire globe when making decisions.

One of the more contemporary definitions is from the World Bank Group, stating, "Corporate social responsibility is the commitment of businesses to contribute to sustainable economic development by working with employees, their families, the local community and society at large, to improve their lives in ways that are good for business and for development."

The World Business Council for Sustainable Development (WBCSD) defines CSR as "the continuing commitment by business to contribute to economic development while improving the quality of life of the workforce and their families as well as of the community and society at large."

CSR originated in philanthropy. Currently it supports projects external to the normal business activities of a company that are not directed towards making a profit. Typically, such projects have a strong

developmental approach and utilise company resources to benefit non-profit organizations and communities.

It is a concept whereby organisations consider the interests of society by taking responsibility for the impact of their activities on customers, employees, shareholders, communities and the environment in all aspects of their operations. This obligation is seen to extend beyond the statutory obligation to comply with legislation and sees organisations voluntarily taking further steps to improve the quality of life for employees and their families as well as for the local community and society at large.

The protection of the environment has become the center stage of many humanitarian organisations. Most of these humanitarian organizations argue that the protection of the environment should be the key concern of any corporation. This is because the environment is the only natural resource that is invaluable to the human race. The issue of handling industrial waste by many corporations has always been at the forefront of many environmental organisations. This is because corporations are guilty on more than one accord of irresponsibly handling their waste. Evidence such as the great pacific garbage patch exists to show how many corporations are not handling the dumping of waste seriously. The great pacific garbage patch is a myriad of human waste that has found its way into the ocean after being improperly dumped. The great pacific garbage patch leads to problems such as loss of aquatic life and the contamination of the water not mentioning the introduction of many pollutants into the water.

Corporate social responsibility makes it clear that it is certainly unethical for these corporations to be making profits at the expense of the environment and other aspects of the human life. It is therefore viewed as a control mechanism to ensure that multi-corporations are responsible for their actions.

The 21st century is characterized by unprecedented challenges and opportunities, arising from globalisation, the desire for inclusive

development and the imperatives of climate change. Indian business, which is today viewed globally as a responsible component of the ascendancy of India is poised now to take on a leadership role in the challenges of our times. Companies too have been the target of those perturbed by this uneven development and as a result, their contributions to society are under severe scrutiny. With increasing awareness of this gap between the haves and the have-nots, this scrutiny will only increase over time and societal expectations will be on the rise.

India is a country of myriad contradictions and diversity. On the one hand, it has grown to be one of the largest economies in the world, and an increasingly important player in the emerging global order, on the other hand, it is still home to the largest number of people living in absolute poverty (even if the proportion of poor people has decreased) and the largest number of undernourished children. What emerges is a picture of uneven distribution of the benefits of growth which many believe is the root cause of social unrest.

CSR in India has traditionally been seen as a philanthropic activity; it was an activity that was performed but not deliberated. In other words, it is referred to as teleological ethics. Though it still remains within the philanthropic space, but the Companies Act, 2013 has introduced the idea of CSR to the forefront and through its disclose-or-explain mandate, is promoting greater transparency and disclosure. It has moved from institutional building (educational, research and cultural) to community development through various projects. Also, with global influences and with communities becoming more active and demanding, there appears to be a discernible trend, that while CSR remains largely restricted to community development, it is getting more strategic in nature (that is, getting linked with business) than philanthropic, and a large number of companies are reporting the activities they are undertaking in this space in their official websites, annual reports, sustainability reports and even publishing of CSR reports.

This is evident from some of the notable contributions made by companies in Indian society. Ashok Leyland operates a FunBus in

Chennai and New Delhi. This bus, equipped with a hydraulic lift, takes differently abled children and those from orphanages and corporation primary schools on a day's picnic. Bharat Petroleum Corporation's rain water harvesting project "Boond", in association with the Oil Industries Development Board, selects draught-stricken villages to turn them from "water-scarce to water-positive". The Computer Based Functional Literacy (CBFL) initiative for providing adult literacy by Tata Consultancy Services has benefitted approx. 1.2 lakh people. This programme is available in nine Indian languages.

On recent amendments to the CSR Law, former DG and CEO of Indian Institute of corporate Affairs Bhaskar Chatterjee said, "Section 135 of the Companies Act tries to take CSR away from cheque book charity and gives it a strategic scientific shape and makes it for more transparent. The other expected change is elevating the CSR from a back room to a boardroom discussion. Every CSR activity should be monitored keeping in mind the beneficiary who should be from the poor as underprivileged community only."

As the business environment gets increasingly complex and stakeholders become vocal about their expectations, good CSR practices can only bring in greater benefits. Globally, the notion of CSR and sustainability seems to be converging, as corporate social responsibility and sustainability are so closely entwined, it is a company's commitment to its stakeholders to conduct business in an economically, socially and environmentally sustainable manner that is transparent and ethical. Thus, a major corporate thrust toward ethical and socially responsible behaviour is to go green.

The Swelling Middle Class



A group of people in the middle of the societal hierarchy or who fall between the working class and upper class socio-economically is referred to as the middle class. The criteria for measuring the parameters of what makes the middle class is variable amongst different cultures. Middle class is normally defined by the level of education, wealth, environment of upbringing, social network, manners or values.

Middle class is defined by the 20th century American Marxist theoretician Louis C. Fraina as the class of independent small enterprises or owners of productive property that derives a livelihood.

Due to the rapid growth in emerging countries, the middle class at present occupies over half the world's population. The middle was earlier class characterized as those who had a reasonable amount of discretionary income. This income allows them to save almost a third of their income for discretionary spending besides paying for basic necessities like food and shelter. They can well spend on their children's education, consumer goods and improve their health care. The emerging middle class mostly comprises of people who aren't rich but are middle-class as per the standards of the developing world. According to this definition, there has been an increase in the number of middle-class people in Asia in 2007-08. This increase in the middle class in many emerging countries has not been incremental but explosive in nature.

The estimated strength of the middle class in America is approximately 45% of the population while in Russia it is nearly 15%. The last decade has seen the fall in levels of absolute poverty and

also an increase in average incomes which have led to the even distribution of the population thereby categorizing them as neither rich nor poor but they are considered to be in the middle of the income distribution. These new data, especially on prices and growth, suggest that the global middle class, numbering about 3.2 billion in 2016, may be considerably larger, by about 500 million people, than previous calculations suggested.

The vast majority (88 percent) of the next billion people in the middle class will be Asian. Middle class has a vital role socially. It supports democracy and is progressive in nature. Particularly when middle class is strong, it will also influence economic development by actively participating in political process and expressing its support for political programs and electoral platforms. While developing countries are facing a rapidly expanding middle class, the same is shrinking in rich countries and is also incapable of defending the standards of living characterized for a middle-class lifestyle for centuries. Economic crisis has been too much of a burden on the middle-class and also their income has been shifted to the wealthier group.

The expectations of middle class in developing countries are rising with the improvement in their economic situations. They have increasing concern for quality and are not merely satisfied with public services. The quality services demanded by the middle class is rather complicated to provide than simply letting them their access; which further leads to friction, conflicts and political upheaval. Also on one hand, middle class is rapidly expanding in developing countries but their size is shrinking in developed nations where they feel incapable of defending the standards of living that characterize a middle-class lifestyle since ages.

A radical shift in wealth distribution and economic and political balance of power seems to be effective by 2030 and the effects of the expanding middle class are soon to be seen. With the emergence of a new middle class that has spending power similar to developed nations, there will arise tremendous business opportunities as well.

Talking particularly about Asia, the trending higher middle class consumption caters to two most important countries, India and China. China's middle class is already large and United States has even a larger one with 157 million people. Chinese market is hence the main attraction for retailers and businesses. With the recent emergence of China as the world's largest cell phone market, it has become a home to around 700 million subscribers. As per the surveys, it's suggestive that China's new middle class is sure to become the leading consumer of the world. At present, 150 million Chinese earn between US\$ 10 and US\$ 100 per day. If China continues to grow with the current speed, along with the economic reforms; it is expected that around 500 million Chinese will be entering the global middle-class over the next decade. One billion people in China will be middle class by 2030, which would be 70% of its projected population.

India is soon going to dominate China in the race of middle class population that is increasing surprisingly. It is estimated that the strength of the middle class in India by 2020 will be 200 million and by 2030 it will be 475 million. This shift is seismic and is altering the condition of the society in terms of quality of life, urbanization, purchasing power, inflation, level of education, number of consumer goods and so on. The improved level of education is one of the prime reasons for this mass change. The growing awareness of people towards education is also aiding in the economic growth which is further increasing the per capita income of Indians. The economic reforms in 1991 are another reason for this colossal middle class population. 93% of population in 1985 lived below Rs.90,000 a year which in 2005 reduced to 54%. Urbanization is also one of the outputs of middle class. The increasing buying power of the emerging middle class means growth in the consumer goods market. Lately there has been increase in the sale of consumer goods like mobile phones, LCDs and goods of personal care. An altogether new consumer market is going to be witnessed in India by 2025.

However, before earning the benefits of young and financially sound consumers, India needs to work really hard on infrastructure, healthcare and education sector. The financial system too needs

modernization with India becoming the fifth largest consumer economy in the near future, both the world as well as the nation is going to benefit. Many people will surely be out of the poverty margin and the work for companies will increase leading to hiring of new employees in order to fulfil the growing demands of new customers.

With the growth in consumer demands, there will also be rise in prices of household commodities. More buying habit intends to less of saving and the rise in expenses will also hamper the lower middle class undesirably.

Trust, Transparency, Tranquillity – Core Competencies of Human Resource Management



A set of individuals who comprise the workforce of an organization or economy or any business sector, is termed as the human resource. Demographics, diversity and qualifications and skills are some of the major factors that are considered in governing human resources. Demographics comprise certain characteristics of the workforce like age, gender or social class that are considered for pension offerings and insurance packages. With the shift of industries from manual to more managerial professions, the need for highly skilled graduates increases more. If there are not enough workers for jobs, then competing for employees require community investment and financial rewards being provided by the employers!

The competitive companies therefore require satisfied, loyal and motivated employees to represent them and then increase in the productivity and quality of product and service that is directly proportional to the growth in satisfaction of its employees. These employees help increase the attractiveness of the competitive position of the company in the market and help engage more potential job seekers. Many a time the management fails to know the opinion of its own employees and therefore goes on underestimating the connection between the satisfaction of employees and the success of the company in the market.

The profitability of an organization is always relative to its human resource and no machine can replace their abilities. Each individual in an organization contributes to its growth through his/her skills, knowledge and experience. Thinking of such valuable human talent in terms of human capital can lead the pathway to the development of

national economy. Organizations focus on the significance of human factor in order to pool ideas and creative inputs for improving their productivity. Recruiting plans are hence designed for approaching talented people. They are trained to meet competencies and their expectations are met in order to create a friendly workplace. This training activity involves a whole lot cost that is suffered by the organization if somehow they fail to employ a right candidate for the specific job.

It is therefore needed to manage the individuals' capabilities, time and talents in order to maximize organizational effectiveness. Human resource management handles this task to ensure that employees are able to meet the goals of the organization. It also is responsible for how people are treated in organizations and for pooling in people to work in the same. The human resource department (HRM) looks after seven vital functions: staffing, performance appraisals, compensation and benefits, training and development, employee and labour relations, safety and health and human resource research. In bigger organizations with more than 100 employees, a human resource manager coordinates HRM duties and reports directly to the CEO.

The HR unit analyses the job since the organization is first set up and looks into the requisite skills and knowledge in employees seeking job. The first and foremost function of the HR is staffing that looks into the job description and specification.

After the selection of talented candidate or individual in the organization, the Human Resource Management creates an environment of motivation for the employees that would help them grow and reward them for their exemplary performance. The performances of the employees are reviewed on a periodic basis for evaluation of their performances and this process is termed as performance appraisal. There are several appraisal methods like:

Ranking all employees in a group, use of rating scales to define above-average, average and below average performance, recording

of favourable and unfavourable performances which are known as critical incidents and managing of objectives.

Performance appraisal serves several motives, some of which are:

It guides human resource actions like hiring, firing and promotion; it helps reward employees through promotions or bonuses. It also helps identify training and development needs in order to improve individual's performance on the job and it helps in planning of the human resource by providing useful job related data.

An employee's performance often gets influenced by compensation and benefits. These compensations can be in the form of payment which is either hourly wage or annual salary, or through benefits that may be in the form of insurance, pension, vacation, modified workweek, sick days and so on. Compensation is required to be fair and equitable, cost-effective, ethical, adequate, legal and able to provide employment security.

One of the benefits served through performance appraisals is that it helps in determining compensation benefits and also in identifying ways to help individuals improve their current positions, in order to prepare for future opportunities. Downsizing and expansion leads to change in the structure of organizations which is continuous process and it therefore creates an incessant need of training and development programs.

Human capital is helpful in increasing entrepreneurial success. Everyday entrepreneurial tasks of discovering and exploiting business opportunities need a consistency. Human capital helps the employees by increasing their ability to perform such tasks.

Planning strategy is directly influenced by human capital and this planning strategy is very crucial in the positive growth of the organization. Good knowledge and adequate skills are both beneficial and needful and when a good human capital is blessed with both, then other resources such as financial and physical capital also get acquired conveniently. Financial capital might be a constraint for many entrepreneurial firms, but with the help of human capital the

lack in the financial capital can be compensated. Human capital helps in acquiring new knowledge base and learning various skills.

Young organisations are more likely to be in need of great human capital. Due to the newness and challenges which a young organization faces, there is greater access to human capital with expert skills and knowledge to take quick decisions. The companies or organizations which are very successful are indeed those who manage human capital in the most effective and efficient manner. Human capital should therefore be treated as assets and not expense.

Naturopathy - The Nature's Way of Healing Life



The naturopathic healing process is primarily guided by the philosophy that emphasizes upon the healing power of nature and vehemently believes that all healing powers are within our own body. This verily implies to the fact that there is an inherent healing energy extant within every human organism that comprises both the physical as well as the psyche, which further is responsible for the ability to heal and maintaining the health.

In the most essential respects, the naturopathic system is an alternative medical system that predominantly focuses on the natural remedies entrenched on the pedestal of the concept of vitalism, meaning the body's vital ability to heal and maintain itself. The naturopathic philosophy is in favour of a holistic approach of healing and a minimal use of surgery and drugs. The naturopathic diagnosis is generally concerned with identifying the underlying causes of a given disease. The naturopathic doctors blend centuries-old knowledge and a philosophy that nature is the most effective healer with current research on health and human systems. The therapeutic modalities used in naturopathic medicine - that includes physical manipulation, clinical nutrition, botanical medicine, homeopathy and hydrotherapy – integrate conventional, scientific and empirical methodology with the ancient laws of nature. The naturopathic medical practice pursues six principles as its most basic underpinnings which include –

- (a) do no harm
- (b) know the healing power of nature

- (c) discover and treat the cause, not just the effect
- (d) treat the whole body
- (e) the physician is a teacher
- (f) prevention is the best cure

By naturopathic rules, we fall ill only when we go against nature and then the cause of diseases (toxins) is expelled from the body to recuperate. The first condition of nature's way to recovery is fasting. Fasting along with a thorough rest is by far the most favourable condition in which an ailing body can purify and recoup itself. The second premise is based on the condition that the therapies used to support and stimulate this healing power of nature must be in "the gentlest, least invasive and most efficient manner." The third naturopathic condition is "to diagnose and treat the cause."

Naturopaths throughout the world do not simply treat the manifestation of the disease but rather delve out the cause and treat it. To accomplish the desired results, naturopathic medicine incorporates many therapeutic modalities like herbal medicine, homeopathy, nutrition, hydrotherapy, food, exercise therapy, manipulation of the bony and soft tissues, lifestyle and counselling, etc.

In India, home remedies come even prior to the doctor's counsel. Indians commonly believe that all ailments are caused by what one eats and what one does not. Thus, a traditional doctor would initially make a cosmetic variation in the dietary routine before he switches on to a proper medicine, which is obviously the last refuge. Naturopathy, to the Indians, is the principle of natural cure founded on the theory of Panchamahabhuta, which basically implies to the theory that the body is made of five universal elements – space (akash), air (vayu), fire (agni), water (jal) and earth (prithvi) and that diseases are caused by an imbalance in the state of these elements.

Naturopathy has its roots in Germany. But it was developed further in the United States during the late 19th and early 20th centuries. The term "naturopathy" has been derived from Greek and Latin and

literally translates as “nature disease”. But the term actually was coined by John Scheel in 1895 and later disseminated by Benedict Lust, famed as the “father of U.S. naturopathy.” During the period spanning from the 1970s, there was apparent a fresh revival of penchant in the United States and Canada in concurrence with the holistic health movement.

The most popular treatment modality, among the many, of naturopathy is homeopathy. Homeopathy, in sync, is convinced by the principle that “like can only be treated by like”, which elaborately signifies that a substance which causes grim symptoms when taken in large doses, can be used in small amounts to treat those same symptoms. This principle of treating “like with like” dates back to the Hippocrates (460 – 377 BC). But the current form, which has been in vogue worldwide for nearly more than two hundred years now, has been discovered by Samuel Hahneman, a German doctor in 1796.

In India, the most popular naturopathic system centres around the most revered antique ‘Ayurveda’. The foundation of Ayurveda, the Indian mode of institutionalized traditional medicine, lies in the two oldest classical Sanskrit texts known as the Charaka Samhita and the Susrutha Samhita. Indeed, Charaka and Samhita are today regarded as the founding fathers of Ayurveda. It will render us dumbfounded when we come to know that these prehistoric Ayurvedic practitioners developed assorted medicinal preparations, surgical procedures for treatment of ailments as well as surgical instruments to aid their surgeries during those unimaginable times. It is hard to believe today that not much of a specialized instrument has been discovered until this date since then that helps in processing surgical operations; only metals have changed, the rest remains the same. This more than proves the height of mettle of those prehistoric Indian geniuses. Ayurveda specifically aims at protecting health and prolonging life (Swasthyas swasthya rakshanam) and at eliminating diseases and dysfunctions of the body (Aturasya vicar prashamanamcha). Ayurveda recognizes the unhealthy by projecting the presence of three doshas (Vata, Pitta and Kapha) in the body. According to the Susrutha Samhita, “a healthy person is he whose doshas are in

balance, appetite is good, all tissues of the body and all natural urges are functioning properly, and whose mind, body and spirit are cheerful.” Nothing more than the properties shown by naturopathic ailment procedures have ever evolved in the intricate medical sciences. To add, it must be remembered that the roots of the healthy or the unhealthy lie but under one tree.

SECTION-G: SOCIAL CHALLENGES

Terrorism that Changed the World



Terrorism is difficult to define as a concept because of its pejorative connotation and its relationship with violence. The meaning of terrorism changes within different social and historical contexts. Walter Laqueur defines terrorism as the illegitimate use of force to achieve a political objective by targeting innocent people. Although the word terrorism dates only from the time of French revolution, the acts it embraces go back to Biblical times. Robespierre installed a dictatorship to stabilize France and justified his methods as necessary in the transformation of monarchy to a liberal democracy. His sentiments laid the foundations for modern terrorists, who believe violence will usher in a better system. The history of terrorism is as much European, as Middle-Eastern and as much secular as religious.

Terrorism comprises four crucial elements – it is an act of violence, it has a political motive or goal, it is perpetrated against innocent persons, it is orchestrated to create fear, suspicion in the minds of people.

All acts of terrorism are motivated by two factors, social and political justice, and the belief that violence or its threat will be effective in bringing change. Research and media suggest that the forces that lead people to militancy include experiences of injustice, discrimination, marginalization, corruption, or physical violence by the state against the innocent civilians. A lack of political inclusiveness in states or grievances against a certain political order may cause

individuals to join or create terrorist groups. Different categories of terrorism are domestic, international, non-state actors, state-sponsored, politically motivated, right-wing, left-wing extremism. Most of the people affected by the terror attacks come from countries which rebelled against dictatorial and authoritarian regimes such as the Syria, Iraq, Afghanistan, Somalia and Yemen, as well as the countries that suffered lack of democracy and good governance such as Saudi Arabia and other Arab countries.

In the 19th century and 20th century, terrorism was associated primarily with the assassination of political leaders and heads of states. This was symbolized by the killing of the Austrian Archduke Ferdinand by a 19 year old Bosnian Serb student, Princip, in Sarajevo in 1914 which led to the outbreak of First World War. After the Second World War, terrorism broadened well beyond assassinations and terrorist movements developed with two distinct purposes. The first was to put pressures on the colonial powers such as Britain, France; second was to hasten their withdrawal and to intimidate the indigenous population into supporting a particular group's claim to leadership of emerging post-colonial states. Sometimes these strategies succeeded, but not always. The 1920s and 1930s saw the emergence of yet another form of terrorism, right-wing fascist terror, as Hitler's brownshirts and Mussolini's blackshirts used murder and violent intimidation to achieve political power and attack specific elements in the population.

The 1960's and 1970's saw the emergence of a new type of nationalism called separatism. This describes indigenous ethnic groups who have long lived in a province but want to separate from their host nations and start their own country. Examples include Quebec, the Basques, and portions of Indonesia. International terrorism became a prominent issue in late 60's, when hijacking became a favored tactic. The ISI of Pakistan has been heavily involved in covertly running military intelligence programs in

Afghanistan even before the Soviet's entrance into Afghanistan in 1979. In the 80's the Intelligence services of Pakistan in Operation Cyclone coordinated the distribution of arms and financial means provided by the USA's CIA to some factions of the Afghan Mujahideen to counter the Soviet's invasion in Afghanistan. States have always used sponsored terrorism outside their own frontiers and used terrorism as a weapon against their own citizens.

For many decades the roots of modern terrorism coming from the Middle East has been due to European Imperialism, the acts of trying to westernize the Middle East and its citizens. The fight for oil and other resources played a small part as well. But one of the most important aspects of Imperialism has been the creation of Israel post-Second World War. Muslims turned to radical ways because they were forced to the pressures of westernization. In 1990's a new face of terrorism emerged with Osama bin Laden becoming a leader of a small fanatical Islamic movement called Al Qaeda. Its public statements were an odd mixture of religious extremism, hostility to US dominance and insensitivity to the effects of terrorist actions. Groups that justify their violence on Islamic grounds- Al Qaeda, Hamas, Hezbollah started mushrooming.

In the event of Sep 11, 2001, 3,000 innocent lives were lost when civilian aircraft was hijacked by Al Qaeda, demolishing a symbol of the US economic way of life: the World Trade Centre. The importance of 9/11 lies not in the loss of life but in 'global dimension' of an attack on the US hegemony, reflecting a threat to world order. Though it was an attack considered unprecedented in history of terrorism but terrorism as a tactic has been deployed by extremist groups in the global South many times before. Terrorist tactics have also commonly been employed by the LTTE (Liberation Tigers of Tamil Elam) in the North eastern provinces of Sri Lanka. The political repercussions of 9/11 have led to an erosion of human rights, civil liberties and democratic values within the US and many other nations. In the

aftermath of 9/11, domestic terrorism laws were enacted in the name of 'national security' across many nations. Examples of laws in Germany, Italy, Japan, UK include funding of security and law enforcement agencies, freezing of the assets of suspected terrorists.

Islamic state (IS) came into the global media spotlight in June 2014 and since then their group has terrorized en masse those that do not comply with its violent and extremist worldview. The recent attacks claimed by ISIS in France, Brussels, Turkey, Germany, Egypt, Istanbul, etc. since 2014 have killed thousands of people around the world. The purpose of these attacks is to instill fear and anxiety among the voters in western democracies to pressurize their governments to stop military engagements against ISIS in Syria and Iraq. It also intensifies the already existing friction between Muslims and non-Muslims, especially in Europe.

Since 9/11 there has been a five-fold increase in deaths from terrorist attacks. The majority of incidents over the past several years can be attached to groups with a religious agenda. The prevalence of Islamist groups in Iraq, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Nigeria and Syria is the main driver behind these trends. Four of the terrorist groups that have been most active since 2001 are Boko Haram, Al Qaeda, the Taliban and ISIL. These groups have been most active in Iraq, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Nigeria and Syria. 80% of all deaths from terrorism occurred in one of these five countries.

We must recognize and address the specific political contexts in which terrorism occurs, whether by states or non-state actors, whether in Kashmir or Israel-Palestine, by searching for politically just solutions in these cases. Also, we need to work for effective international laws and institutions with the powers to punish all wrongdoers, no matter how powerful, and to broaden our national laws to weaken prospects of successful refuge for leaders/people most responsible for criminal acts and campaigns.

Human Trafficking in India



Human trafficking is the most significant criminal and illegal industry in the world. Human traffickers earn over \$175 billion a year, and 80 percent of the money from human trafficking comes from commercial sexual exploitation. Millions of women, children and men are trafficked worldwide. Not only is human trafficking on the increase, but human traffickers are increasingly targeting minor girls and women.

Initially, human traffickers attract victims by the false promise of employment, on the pretext of some monetary gains, manipulation, fraud, etc. They often pose as eligible partners and develop a romantic relationship or affairs with vulnerable girls and women, on the pretext of marrying. Traffickers then exploit an existing intimate relationship and lure victims into trafficking. Human trafficking involves the use of deception, coercion, force, violence, and exploitation to obtain compelled sex, or for the purpose of the commercial sex, or forced labour or bonded labour. There is no prescribed profile of a trafficking victim. Victims of human trafficking can be anybody, regardless of gender, age, race, community, nationality, socioeconomic status, and level of education. Physical and mental disability, language barriers, fear of life keep the trafficked victims from seeking help, making human trafficking a hidden crime.

Types of Human Trafficking

Human trafficking is an acute problem in every corner of the world. Human trafficking can be classified as Sex trafficking, Labour trafficking and Organ trafficking based on the methods and purposes

victims were lured and exploited. Traffickers employ different strategies and styles to lure victims and conceal the crime. The victims of sex trafficking forcibly kept and used in brothels, escort services, illicit massage parlours, outdoor solicitation, strip clubs, pornography, and online interactive sexual recreational acts. Men, minors and women victims of trafficking are forcibly employed in agriculture, construction, factories, fisheries, forestry, manufacturing, mining, restaurants & eateries and domestic work. The victims of trafficking are made to work under inhumane conditions with little or no pay. Human trafficking victims are also being used as drug peddlers and bootleggers.

Modus Operandi of Human Traffickers

The human trafficking supply chains have become increasingly organised illegal international and they have also become more challenging to monitor. Human traffickers may frequently receive a particular area to look for potential victims who are susceptible to a variety of reasons. The traffickers often target those who are economically backward, unemployed, individuals with disabilities, psychologically ill, emotionally vulnerable, runaway children, homeless people, poor and those who lack social safety. Many of the victims are from politically unstable areas, conflict-ridden countries such as Afghanistan, Myanmar, Somalia and Syria.

A significant number of war refugees from conflict zones who have fled to other countries end up in the hands of human traffickers only to suffer the worst forms of abuse. Victims of natural disasters also usually fall prey to human trafficking. The majority of migrant workers in certain countries are often vulnerable to human trafficking and forced labour. In ninety percent of the cases, the victims are approached by an agent, who promises to find them lucrative jobs in a foreign country. The remaining ten percent victims are those who are actively looking for employment opportunities to work abroad and contact an agent to help them find a job abroad. These workers land in a foreign country after paying a hefty fee to the agent and air ticket,

only to know that their joy is short-lived. They will be kept under deplorable conditions and subjected to forced labour without pay and perks. They find it difficult to report their plight and situation to authorities, due to restrictions, and the language barrier.

It is a global menace

Globally, 70% of human trafficking victims are women and girls, while men and boys account for 30%. Nearly 50,000 people are trafficked into the United States every year and the bulk of them from Mexico and the Philippines.

The Asia-Pacific records the highest-trafficked people in the world. People from Bangladesh, Cambodia, China, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Thailand and Vietnam are becoming victims of human trafficking. The sex trafficking industry in India is very well organised. Traffickers operate from Indo Bangladesh border to lure young vulnerable girls from Nepal, Bangladesh and West Bengal and force them into the flesh trade.

Thousands of women from various states of India are being transported to Dubai from Delhi and Mumbai. The human smugglers and traffickers are increasingly becoming the tech-savvy and using internet and social media platforms to lure their targets.

India has one of the largest populations of minor migrants from bordering countries, out of which the majority are victims of trafficking. Following the 2015 Nepal earthquake, thousands of young girls were duped by agents on the pretext of employment and sold those unsuspecting victims to brothels. The largest part of sex workers worldwide are victims of sex trafficking, though they appear to consent to the commercial sex act.

Human Trafficking laws in India

There has been a rise in the number of victims of human trafficking in India, despite several constitutional & legislative provisions related to human trafficking exist in the country.

Human Trafficking is prohibited under Article 23 (1) of the Constitution of India. The Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act 1956 deals with the prevention of trafficking for commercial sexual exploitation. After the enactment of Criminal Law (Amendment) Act 2013, IPC 370 has been substituted with Section 370 and 370A of the Indian Penal Code, which provide for comprehensive measures to counter the trafficking of humans including trafficking of children for exploitation, sexual and physical exploitation, slavery and forcible removal of organs.

POCSO Act 2012 (Protection of Children from Sexual Offences) came into force from November 2012 to protect children from sexual abuse and exploitation. POCSO Act of 2012 also deals with human trafficking and the culprits and traffickers will be booked under the POCSO act too. The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act 2006 also prosecutes the offenders concerning the smuggling of women and children. Section 372 and 373 of Indian Penal Code deal with the selling and buying of girls for prostitution. Several Indian states have also introduced and enacted specific acts to deal with the human trafficking issue.

India also prohibits bonded labour and forced labour through the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act 1986, the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act 1976, Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act 2015.

Organ brokers lure poor, uneducated individuals and abduct them to remove their organs like kidney through the promise of financial gain or forcibly without any consideration. Transplantation of Human Organs Act 1994 regulates human organ trafficking.

In order to control and systematically curb the menace, the union cabinet approved the Trafficking of Persons (Prevention, Protection and Rehabilitation) Bill 2018. The Bill brings together the approaches of prevention, rescue and rehabilitation of trafficking victims.

Under the Bill, the prosecution will be made timely and efficient by special public prosecutors for offences such as trafficking to bear a child, under the pretext of marriage, for begging, administering narcotic drugs and hormones for early sexual maturity.

Intending to break the organised nexus of trafficking mafia, at the national and international levels, the bill proposes freeze bank accounts, attachment and forfeiture of property and to remit the proceeds of crime in the rehabilitation fund. National Anti-Trafficking Bureau will strengthen the intelligence apparatus to coordinate with international authorities, inter-State and trans-border. Under the bill, a separate State and District Anti-Trafficking Committees will be established to monitor crime under this Act. National Anti-Trafficking Bureau was mandated to develop, monitor and review a database on every crime under trafficking of Persons (Prevention, Protection and Rehabilitation).

Child Labour in India: Causes, Bonded Labour & Government Initiatives



Social upheavals like child labour and bonded labour have become more evident in India. India has the most substantial number of child labourers. As per the census 2011, there were over 4 million labourers aged between five and 14 in India. However, in 2020 approximately 33 million children were employed in various forms of child labour in India. These children do not get to play or study or enjoy freedom of childhood. Child labour is mentally, physically, socially dangerous and harmful to children. Child labour interferes with their schooling by depriving them of the opportunity to attend school and obligates most of the children to leave school prematurely due to workload. At the present rate, by 2030, only six in every ten children will complete secondary education and one-in-six children will not be attending primary and secondary school at all.

In most cases, children are brought by their parents to agriculture fields, tea, coffee plantations, construction sites as they cannot keep them alone at homes. So the children do not receive any labour protections from environmental hazards, injuries and accidents which may result from dust, poisonous gases, heat exposure, and other sharp tools involved.

The Bonded Child Labour

Nearly two million children are working under conditions of forced labour to produce bricks, carpets, embellished textiles, quarry stones, etc. Employment for adults is hard to find in many sectors which forces children to work. Like every country in the world, Agriculture employs more child labourers than any other industry in India. There

are not many statistics and studies that have been conducted on the number of bonded labour and child domestic servants. The bonded child labour or debt peonage or debt bondage is rampant in India, in which a child labourer works to pay off a debt.

However, the child bonded labourers who don't want to work at the master, or landlord or lender's premises are enslaved and compelled to stay under the threat of force or coercion. Most often, these children are taken out of school, and they toil in the factories, fields or at the lender's home even for up to 16 hours a day.

The Famous FIVE States

Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan are India's biggest child labour employer states. Beedi, fireworks, matchboxes, bamboo basket weaving and other industries make the children work from their home to avoid the inspections by the Labour department. When farm produce and crop prices take a dip, farm workers still have to meet daily needs; as a result, they are compelled to bring their children with them to help or send them to work at other places like factories, construction and eateries. Children, out of economic need, reluctantly endure these poor working conditions.

Millions of girls of primary school age will never be allowed to attend a school in villages, and they were compelled to work in fields or at household work like fetching water, etc.

End of Childhood Index

India's rank on the "End of Childhood Index 2018" was 161 of 172 countries. However, it bettered in 2019 as India ranks 113 of 176 countries. Save the Children's annual "End of Childhood Index" assesses and compares the data for 176 countries, to arrive at where the most and fewest children are missing out on childhood. Singapore tops the ranking with a score of 989. As expected, the Central African Republic ranks last.

In its 87th Session held at Geneva on 1 June 1999, the International Labour Organization (ILO) Convention C182 banned the use of children in many different occupations, and also provided ways for poor countries to meet these new standards. On the 20th November 1989, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the Convention on the Rights of the Child, India along with the world countries ratified the Convention to provide civil, cultural, economic, and social rights to children.

Indian Laws and Acts

The Constitution of India guaranteed the right to education, protection of the child and the government brought various schemes like mid-day meals, Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, etc. Sadly, one in every ten workers in India is a child, that amounts to approximately 14 percent of India's workforce. Anti-child labour laws exist in India since pre-independence. British India passed the Employment of Children Act 1938. Various laws and acts were adopted and enacted by the Republic of India during the last seven decades. Those are The Factories Act 1948, The Mines Act, 1952, The Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act 1986, Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection) of Children Act 2000, and The Right to Education Act 2009. These laws banned the employment of children and employment of children a punishable offence. The Right to Free and Compulsory Education Act prohibits physical punishment and mental harassment to the child.

Children between 14 and 18 years are defined as 'adolescents'. Hazardous industries were barred from employing adolescents as per the Indian Labour Laws. It is evident that even after various laws and acts; prosecutions and punishments; child labour continues to be the norm in the country. In 2017, the central government launched an online portal "Platform for Effective Enforcement for No Child Labour (PENCIL)" as part of a drive to rescue and rehabilitate child labour. PENCIL aims to bring together government officials, police, and NGOs to share information and coordinate on child labour cases. Any

individual from anywhere can lodge a complaint of child labour using PENCIL which can facilitate a speedy investigation.

The Role of Government and Civil Society

Civil society and various non-government organisations have been educating the small scale industries, small business owners and various trade organisations about the evils of child labour. The labour department officials and NGO's have been conducting raids at regular intervals to detect cases of violations by the agriculture fields, factories, shops and establishments, where employing children is practised. Children are rescued from these places and they are rehabilitated. Kailash Sathiyarthi, the crusader against child labour, was awarded Nobel Peace Prize in 2014 for his efforts against eradicating child labour.

The government in 2015 amended making two exceptions to the Child Labour Act (Prohibition & Regulation) Amendment Bill 2012. The amended act will allow children below 14 years to work in family-owned non-hazardous business after school hours or during vacations. A child can work in the entertainment industry as an artist except for the circus, provided that the school education of the child is not affected. Unfortunately, business owners have seen this as Legal opportunism or loophole and started abusing the exception.

The Root Cause of Child Labour

The issue continues to be one of the biggest challenges before the country. Governments have been taking various proactive measures to curb child labour. As per the Gurupadaswamy Committee 1979, child labour cannot be eliminated completely as long as poverty continued in India.

Child labour is a socio-economic problem directly linked to poverty and illiteracy. Therefore, enforcement alone cannot provide a solution to the problem. The Government must focus on improving the socio-economic conditions of their families. These challenges can be

overcome by a combination of intense action and more significant funding. Every state government, along with the Central Government, needs to invest heavily, allocate abundant resources, renewed efforts and exhibit sincere commitment in getting the child labour eradicated in the country. Besides, concerted efforts from all sections of society can help abolish child labour.

Honour Killing – The Concealed Evil



Honour killing may be defined as the murder of a family member (in most cases a woman) due to the self-belief of the murderer that the victim has committed a heinous act to bring shame upon the family or dishonour their family. According to such people, the heinous acts include getting married against parents' wishes, getting married in different castes, getting involved in premarital intimate relations and other acts that are against the old beliefs of the society. Honour killing has been witnessing a rise in the recent times in India and due to its gruesome nature it is now also labelled as "Horror Killing."

India is a nation of varied cultures and traditions. The traditions mean a lot to Indian people and in fact, it is not bad to follow the teachings preached by the ancestors as they keep the culture and history of the country relevant even today. It is a great thing to keep the traditions alive, but many individuals fail to differentiate between following traditions and forcing traditions. Some go beyond the extent of humanity and just in the name of "self-conceived" honour many have taken lives of their own daughters and sons.

Why Does Honour Killing Happen?

Although honour killings are a result of pure delusion on the part of the perpetrator, it is important to look into the perspective of the perpetrator to understand what goes inside his/her mind that leads to such dastardly acts. Here are the major reasons which make some individuals believe that killing their own family members is better than accepting the actions they have taken: -

- India has a culture of arranged marriages which is gradually being replaced by love marriages. But decades are needed before everyone actually accepts the idea of a love marriage. In families where the children resist the marriages fixed by the parents without their consent are considered disobedient. Some of the elders of the family believe love marriage, even in own community, to be a matter of shame and do not hesitate from going to the extent of killing their own blood.
- Many people in India are immersed in the depth of their false pride and respect. Such people often believe that love marriages or getting involved in a romantic relationship or even dating is forbidden and must be opposed under all circumstances.
- In India marriage alliances are preferred on the basis of castes and “gotras”. While traditionalists want a marriage to be solicited in their own caste, but marriage is forbidden within the same “gotra”. If anyone dares to fall in love with a person from the same gotra, delusional family members do not think twice before killing their own family member.
- Premarital sex is still a taboo for most Indians. No one wants to discuss it at all, and as a result, when any of the family members get involved in a physical relationship before marriage, he or she is even killed in extreme situations.
- This case is the extreme of all. In this situation, the victim is made to feel like the culprit. He/she is blamed for bringing upon a crime to themselves. Yes, the issue is rape or sexual assault. This is more specific for women. Whenever a woman gets assaulted, she herself is likely to blame for getting into the attention of the assaulter and the delusional family members end up killing her in extreme cases, for bringing upon shame to the family.
- Homosexuality has been illegal in India for years before getting legalized just months ago. What can anyone say on this matter when the government itself thought that getting attracted to the same gender is a criminal act? People have the habit of treating homosexuality as a crime, and as a result, in fear of dishonour

and shame, families have killed their own kids just because they turned out to be homosexuals.

It is pretty evident that one will be appalled at how can someone kill their own family members due to any of the reasons mentioned above. In such cases, instead of saving the loved ones from the wrath of society and acting as a pillar of support, the family turns hostile and kills its own members in fear of the so-called shame and dishonour.

If one talks about love marriages and pre-marital sex, it is pretty common in western countries. But in India, this has been virtually accorded the status of a criminal act. Parents usually believe their kids to be their belongings, who are supposed to do as told. When the kids do not agree or wish to lead their lives their parents' way, they are termed as a disgrace to the family.

The basic reason for all these happenings is the firm beliefs of the older generation and broader minds of the younger generation. The generation gap has become so huge that no one is even ready to talk and work out a compromise. Conflicts are a different thing, but committing a murder in the name of saving your honour is just not justified.

The worse fact is that the honour killings are not even thought of as an issue. They even have societal sanction in some remote parts of India. India, as a society, has failed to even accept the fact that honour killing is a rising crime in today's world. No matter what the situation is or what you believe, killing someone is never justified just for the sake of saving one's false honour.

Government's Take on the Issue – Are There any Solutions?

The honour killings rose exponentially in the 2000s. The issue was brought to the notice of the central government where it was found that most of these honour killings took place in northern India, in the states of Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab, UP, etc. The Supreme Court

had issued notices to the respective state governments to take strict action against the acts committed in the name of honour.

In Rajasthan, a bill was passed with the provision of life imprisonment for the perpetrators that were involved in honour killings.

What is the Way Ahead?

It is necessary to accept the fact that there is no such thing called honour killing. It is nothing but murder in the name of so-called respect and is in fact “horror killing”. It is the result of decades of encouragement going on around the orthodox elements of the society.

The thing which needs to be introduced is ‘compromise’ and ‘understanding’. It is necessary to embed flexibility among the minds of all sections of society. There is a need to understand that traditions and old ways of life should also evolve with time and the whole nation cannot be allowed to run on orthodox rules that were set down centuries ago.

Murder is not at all justified for the sake of someone not following the traditions and societal regulations. Everyone is a human being who has the right to live his/her own life on their own terms. Imposing strict rules which involve nothing but control someone’s feelings and mind is nothing but a crime in disguise.

The need of the hour is to stop the namesake honour killings and rather let every human being live his/her life with full honour and dignity.

Crimes against Women: Is India the World's most Dangerous Country for Women?



A woman is one who encompasses confidence and strength; she is an epitome of tolerance, endowed with sacrosanct, to list a few noble traits. India has always upheld women in pristine esteem even in its history, fairy tales, folklore and mythology.

Women in Indian history such as Rani of Jhansi, Razia Sultan, the first woman to rule Delhi, Chand Bibi the Regent of Bijapur, Rani Rudrama Devi of Kakatiya Dynasty, Rani Durgavati of the Gond kingdom, Begum Hazrat Mahal of Awadh, Bibi Sahib Kaur and Mai Bhago of Punjab province are known for their courage and fighting spirit. They demonstrated valour on the battlefield and fought the British, Mughals, Mongols and others. They always are regarded as an example for others to follow.

However, as the years passed, somewhere down the line, we displaced the women power through vested interests and prejudice. Our women are the victims in the hands of their own countrymen.

Rape Country

Whenever we raise the issue of women empowerment, we have got to begin with crimes against women. We must admit that our society is still languishing in agony about the growing incidents of abduction, kidnapping, brutal rape, molestation, ravishment, sexual assault, acid attacks, and retaliatory killings. Unfortunately, the country is heading towards earning the "Rape Country" tag. The cruelty of those rapists leaves behind dents on the pride of India and befouls the nation's reputation.

POCSO Act & Nirbhaya act

Even the enactment of Nirbhaya act 2013 and POCSO Act 2012 (The Protection of Children from Sexual Offences) has not created any fear in sexual offenders. Two decades ago, victims and their families shied away from reporting the crimes due to social stigma and to shield the family's honour. The parents were under the belief that the institution of marriage and prestige of the family is more important than the woman's self-respect and fundamental rights.

However, both the victim and family members have become conscious and are self-aware in recent years. Moreover, several changes were brought and implemented by the Government, police and judicial system. These developments led to the increase of the reporting of the sexual offences. On the other hand, the incidences of brutal rapes and other acts of violence against women have also risen.

In earlier days, rapists used to let off the victim after the gruesome act, after warning of dire consequences, if reported the matter. Due to the growing incidents of reporting of the sexual offences, the rapists began to kill the victims after the ghastly act. The accused cannot even get convicted when the victim is not alive to report or identify the perpetrator. The country is getting a more dangerous place for women.

The death sentence and hanging four Nirbhaya convicts is setting a dangerous precedent for rape convictions. The recent incident of the brutal killing after the gang rape of Hyderabad veterinary doctor bears testimony to it. Many girls in various parts of India were raped and set ablaze, including the Unnao rape victim. In a way, the increase in reporting of the sexual offences and enactment of various laws is turning the rapists into murderers too.

It is high time the Government got a handle on the situation, took swift action to save our girls, women and reassure them by safeguarding them. There is a pressing need to introduce draconian laws and repressive measures against these crimes.

Law Enforcement

Preparing for the worst before it happens is the best way to deal with a crime or an untoward incident. Law enforcement departments and police in rural India are still not equipped with modern technology, despite increasing vulnerability in recent years. We need to upgrade technology, men and machinery. Satellite-based surveillance can be used to assist law enforcement to track it down and save the victims before the crime takes place.

The NASA Space Scientists have created a video technology with which the Police can access satellite images and videos in the police stations and patrolling vehicles. The images can reveal clues about crime spots and help them reach in time. Our police have to adopt such technology. Various mobile Apps and pepper sprays may not come handy in case of emergency when the victim is overpowered by a bunch of miscreants.

More than thirty thousand cases of rape were registered with the police in a year, about 90 a day. More than two lakh cases relating to rape are pending at the Indian courts. Lakhs of victims, parents and families, are languishing for justice. Fast-track courts and special courts have little effect on the growing number of rape incidents and crimes against women.

Coordination between different bodies, agencies and authorities is notoriously miserable. Need to bring radical changes in our judicial system. More than seven years later, the Nirbhaya's convicts' fate hangs in limbo. Nothing has changed much in these seven years, and the incidents of rape and crimes against women have increased in recent years. Women safety at public transport, workplace, public places and even at home remains a distant dream.

The Role of Alcohol

There ought to be a correlation between alcohol and increasing crime and sexual assault against women. The majority of the rape and gang-rape cases involve alcohol consumption by the violator. Alcohol

contributes and increases the risk factors to sexual assault. Alcohol's effects on cognitive and motor skills contribute to alcohol-involved sexual assault. The Government must establish the link between alcohol consumption and sexual assault, and arrive at a solution to curb further heinous crimes and loss of lives.

Parenting Matters

The country at this juncture needs to invest in changing the system. We need to act on the growing incidents of female foeticide. We ought to correct our skewed sex ratios. We should change the way we treat our women. Parenting plays a vital role in building a character. Parents must teach boys from a young age about how to treat girls with respect.

Truck drivers and cab drivers should be counselled for moral and ethical values. This way, their outlook towards society, life and women may change for good. At the same time, the cab drivers should not be mistreated by the women passengers.

Male privilege in society disparages and objectifies women. The exploitation of women in movies directly or indirectly makes women vulnerable to gender-based violence. Our movies must start portraying women in a positive light. These movies can trigger negativity in youth. Teenage students always experience a difficult phase of their journey between childhood and adulthood. With an objective of sensitizing teenage students about the life of rape accused and convicts, every teenage student of schools must be taken for a field trip to a prison. They will get to see the plight of the rape/murder accused and convicts.

They will think twice before making a wrong judgment or decision or take a wrong path in a lifetime.

Should the Places of Worship be Opened only to all Castes and not to all Genders?



Since time immemorial, women have been fighting a battle for equality. Yet they have not been quite successful in gaining equal rights with men. It is shocking that even in the 21st century there is discrimination on the ground of gender even at the places of worship. Even in the matters of religion, their entry is denied at many places of worship.

The recent example in this regard is the temple of Sabrimala. The famous Ayappa Temple in Sabarimala, Kerala, prohibits women of 'menstruation age' between 10 to 50 years from entering the temple. According to Rule 3 (b) of the Kerala Hindu Places of Public Worship, 1965 – 'Women who are not by custom and usage allowed to enter a place of worship shall not be allowed to offer worship in any place of public worship.' This law had been a grave injustice to women.

Menstruation cycle is a natural physiological process in women. Prohibiting them to perform a normal work can't be justified in any way. This law had also been against the basic concept of our Constitution, which grants equal rights to men and women. However, after a long legal battle the Apex Court lifted ban on the entry of women in the temple of Sabrimala in September 2018. The verdict led to massive protests in the state. Some diehards have filed an appeal for the reconsiderations of the Apex Court verdict that women can't enter the Sabrimala temple due to the old traditions and orthodox beliefs.

In november 2019, the five-judge bench, responding to dozens of review petitions challenging the court's landmark judgement last year,

said that the matter would now be heard by a larger bench. With this, the court did not stay its earlier order and women can still legally enter the temple, though it's not going to be easy for them.

The Apex Court in January 2020 said that its nine-judge Constitution bench would wrap up within 10 days proceedings in the matter relating to discrimination against women in various religions and at religious places including Kerala's Sabarimala Temple.

Discrimination based on the gender continues though caste based discrimination is disappearing

In India, there had been two fundamental axes of social inequality; caste based discrimination and gender based discrimination. Caste based discrimination remained central to Hinduism for centuries. However, now such discrimination is disappearing slowly and we can say that Indian society has now got rid of such distinction to a large extent.

As for gender, in Hindu religion still there is great discrimination. Successive Shankaracharyas have been deadly against women being included in various religious activities. They argued that women are not authorised to read or interpret sacred texts. In Islam, the distinction is even greater. There are no women priests and they are segregated in matters of worship also. The religious text of both Hinduism and Islam favour strongly only the patriarchy in the matter of religion. Some selected quotes from Vedas and Quran do favour, respect and consider women as revered human beings. However, on the whole both the religions consider men much superior to women.

The religious places where women devotees are not allowed include Haji Ali Dargah, Kartikey Temple, Pushkar, Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple, Thiruvananthapuram and many more. In Haji Ali Dargah, earlier the women were allowed to visit the shrine while they were not allowed to go the Asthana – the actual spot where the saint is buried. They were also not allowed to touch the saint's tomb. In Kartikey Temple, the celibacy of the god is celebrated and thus the entry of

women is restricted to the temple. It is believed that the women who visit the temple are cursed not blessed. In Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple, the women devotees can worship the deity, but they can't go to the inner chambers of the temple. Even the women inventory officials are not allowed to go to the sanctum sanctorum. A few years ago, the temple restricted the entry of even a woman expert from the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

Places Where even Men are not Allowed

Recent rulings by the Apex Court regarding lifting ban on the entry of women to the Sabrimala temple was welcomed everywhere. However, there are some places of worship where the entry of men is banned or they are allowed to visit there only on certain select days. In Attukal Temple, the situation is the other way round. In this temple the dominant force is womenfolk. Chakkulathukavu Temple gives prominence to women. A particular ritual is followed here called 'Nari Puja', where the male priest of the temple washes the feet of female devotees. The temple of Lord Brahma at Pushkar, Rajasthan is a prominent temple of Lord Brahma. In this temple the married men can't come. The Bhagati Maa Temple in Kanyakumari is devoted to Maa Parvati. In this temple only women are allowed. The worship is done by women only. Thus we have seen that gender inequality regarding places of worship is not restricted to women only; men are also restricted to certain temples or places of worship.

Constitutional Provisions and Obligations under Law

According to the Article 14 and 15 (1) of the Indian Constitution, any discrimination, based on the grounds of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birthplace is prohibited. Article 15(1) implies that there may be discrimination on other grounds but these cannot be arbitrary or oppressive. They have to be reasonable. Article 25 of the Constitution guarantees freedom of conscience and free profession, practice and

propagation of religion to all citizens of the Union of India. India is a signatory of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) and according to it India is bound to give its citizens freedom of religion, and the rights against discrimination on the basis of gender.

It should be kept in mind that the International Convention on Civil and Political Rights 1966 (ICCPR), of which India is a signatory, says, "freedom to manifest one's religion may be subject only to limitations that are necessary and are prescribed by law and also necessary to protect safety, order, health, or morals or the fundamental rights and freedom of others". As it has been established earlier, these exceptions are not relevant to women and their access to places of worship. In addition, the right to equality and right against discrimination fall under the ambit of jus cogens --- the principles of international law which India is bound to follow. According to it jus cogens can override any domestic law, which lead to any sort of degradation to any particular community or sex.

According to the Indian Constitution coupled with all international laws, there couldn't be any discrimination on the basis of gender. Restrictions based on the gender are not only unconstitutional but also derogatory to that particular gender. Though the Supreme Court lifted ban on the entry of women at the Sabarimala Temple yet the protesters are not allowing women to enter the shrine. The need of the hour is that both the genders should be given equal rights in the matter of religious freedom. Going to the court for the entry at a particular place is not so effective until there is a total change in the mindset of the society.

Communal Conflicts in India - Causes and Remedies



India is a country which is home to various communities and religions. It is a very diversified country with a diverse collection of communities having different beliefs and ideologies. So, the possibility of communal conflicts is always there. Communal conflicts in India do not occur due to a single factor; rather these conflicts take place due to a lot of reasons ranging from political to non-political, current issues to historical, local to national as well as several other factors.

History of Communal Conflicts in India

Communal conflicts started way back in the 1940s when India was fighting against the British rule. They have survived due to multiple reasons. The vested interests are still the main cause of disharmony in the Indian society. The incidents of communal violence in India have increased manifolds with the communalization of politics and the emergence of orthodox elements. Mahatma Gandhi was its first victim of communal discord in the country followed by the killing of many other eminent personalities in the 1970s and the 1980s.

While sporadic incidents of communal conflicts are reported every now and then across various states in India, but certain events flare up the temper of the public and lead to an escalation of the situation on a wider scale. For instance, incidents following the assassination of Indira Gandhi in 1984, destruction of Babri structure in Ayodhya in December 1992, and bomb blasts in Bombay in early 1993 caught the attention of the entire nation. Moreover, instances of communal riots in sensitive states like Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Bihar, Gujarat,

Uttar Pradesh, and Kerala have considerably increased in the last few decades.

Reasons behind Communal Conflicts in India

While the entire concept of communal conflicts might seem to be a bit complicated, a careful study will reveal that there are some basic reasons responsible for this social evil. Some of the major reasons responsible for communal conflicts can be identified as:

Misconceptions and lack of communication: - The economic, social and political situations in a society sometimes create problems and crisis for the people. Even though various stakeholders try to solve these problems, but they fail in doing so. Without attempting to grasp the real causes for this failure, one community 'perceives' the other community as the cause behind their woes which flares communal tensions. Communalism is thus a social reality that is generated and reflected in a distorted way due to a communication gap.

Economic Differences: - After independence, though the union government claimed to follow the "socialistic pattern of the economy" yet in practice the economic development was based more on capitalist patterns. Here one can see that only the top one percent of our country has benefited due to this practice whereas the lower strata has got nothing out of this capitalist pattern. This economic gap creates a sense of dissatisfaction and disillusionment amongst the people leading to passions being ignited even at the drop of a hat.

Religion: - Religion is also a big reason for communal conflicts. The whole reason for a conflict is when one communal group goes against another due to opposing thoughts and opinions. These communal groups are nothing but religious groups of different faiths and different mindsets.

Major Factors behind Communal Conflicts

A multi-factor approach has been proposed by scholars to identify the prime reasons behind communal conflicts in India. They have

identified several major factors behind the rise in communal conflicts in recent times, such as: -

- The social factors include caste conflicts, ego clashes, religion-based social stratification, societal traditions, and stereotyping of religious communities;

- The religious factors comprise the communal ideology of political leaders, rising intolerance, narrow-minded religious views, falling secular values, and use of religion as a political tool.

- The psychological factors comprise fear psychosis, rumour mongering, social prejudices, apathy towards a specific community, distrust, stereotyping certain sections of the society and misrepresentation and misinterpretation by the media.

- The political factors behind these communal conflicts can be identified as a political justification of communal violence, tacit support of political parties to fringe religious elements, mob instigation during sensitive occasions, the politicisation of religious matters, vested interests of politicians, failure of administration in controlling such incidents;

- The economic factors comprise inadequate opportunities to individuals from a certain section of the society, economic exploitation, discrimination with minority groups, lop-sided economic development, non-expanding economy, displacement and non-absorption of workers of minority religious groups.

- The legal factors include the special status of certain states, reservation and special concessions for certain communities, no uniform civil code, separate personal laws for different sections of the society.

- The administrative factors include police excesses, absence of coordination amongst administration and police, the personal bias of policemen, lack of training, inaction on the part of the administration, and ill-equipped police personnel.

-The historical factors include damage to religious institutions, old disputes on land ownership rights, divide and rule policy of colonial rulers, invasion from foreign rulers, and past communal riots.

-The local factors include land disputes, anti-social elements, group rivalries, slogan raising, religious processions, rumour-mongering and local conflicts.

-The international factors include financial support from other countries for communal organisations and training of anti-social elements.

How to End These Communal Conflicts?

One way forward is political intervention, where all the concerned political parties take a common stand on not having any religious agenda but in fact base their politics on developmental issues. By doing so, they will send out a message that they are all working for the social benefit and welfare and not just to support a particular group of people who follow a particular religion. This will impact the society at large and also will play a big role in bringing back the lost harmony of the society.

Also, the need for awareness rather than education is greatly felt, people who form the society need to be aware of what they support or whom they support. Education has a role to play, but the need for awareness succeeds the need for education. Welfare is something that can be understood by anyone; it does not require going to a college or school.

Another important role is that of the media; it needs to take proactive action in spreading information about the communal unity that was once seen in the Indian society, even though they had disagreements of opinions, this helps people to get aware about how there is a possibility of a greater good even with the existence of different religions and mindsets.

The act of creating groups based on religions needs to be stopped because that leads to no good to the country at large. Any form of communalism only brings down a country's quality of life. Thus that needs to end. Being open and liberal to all simultaneously maintaining one's voice is a quality that has to be garnered by everyone. India without this form of communalism, is sure to flourish and reach new heights both nationally and internationally. The only reason India is still suffering domestically is due to these communal conflicts; they bring down the productivity to a level from which it is hard to step out of. If India has to reach its full potential, then it needs to unite and all political stakeholders need to come to a consensus regarding getting rid of communalism, once and for all.

Rising Hate Crimes, Intolerance: Detrimental to Growth



“Tit for tat, an eye for an eye will make the whole world blind.”

Mahatma Gandhi

India has been growing at a steady pace over the last few years and has been able to maintain a reasonable growth rate over the period. But there are some things which can be detrimental to this growth and can seriously affect its image in the outside world as a steadily growing developing economy of the world. Rising intolerance, hate crimes, moral policing are some factors that can seriously damage the economic growth of the nation, and up to some extent, have been able to do so.

The Prime Minister of India wants to see India as a 5 trillion dollar economy, but there are some concerns on the social front that need to be taken care of before that happens. If nothing is done to curb these social problems of the country and take care of the issues faced by the society, it can significantly impact the growth of the economy, much more than it already has. There is massive insecurity plaguing the nation and it can seriously damage the growth potential, thus preventing the people of India from realizing its actual potential.

Social Issues due to Rising Hate Crimes and Intolerance

Many studies have been done on increasing hate crimes in India and each of them has shown that increasing intolerance, social instability, violence against women, moral policing, caste and religion-based violence and numerous other types of violence are rampant across

the country and have been able to affect the economic growth of the nation as a whole. Amnesty International India has recorded more than 700 such incidents where people were hurt in hate crimes or due to intolerance. One of the most common hate crimes i.e. honour killing has been taking place in the nation for decades and now a new form of hate crimes has started taking place in the country which is in the form of cow-related violence.

Such crimes occurred earlier also but were rare. However, the frequency of such crimes has increased to a scale that is very harmful to the solidarity of the nation. In a single year alone, Amnesty International India recorded more than 200 hate crimes, of which 140 were against Dalits, 50 against Muslims, 40 against women, and 8 against transgenders. According to Hate Crimes Watch, under the last government crimes based on religious identity were in single digits but in the previous year, such crimes were nearing almost 100 cases.

Implications of the Increase in Hate Crimes and Intolerance

There are some issues that need to be fixed at the fundamental level, and if proper care is not taken, then there will be challenging times ahead for the nation. It will not be possible to take care of the economy if such issues keep on plaguing the country. Human Rights Watch has said that there is growing insecurity and fear among minority groups in India due to such hate crimes and rising intolerance. Such is the condition that people have started damaging public property on watching some split-second scenes in movies. If the country has to face problems due to such petty issues which are highlighted on a large scale by some small group of people who are hurt by some scene in a movie, then the country cannot call itself modern at all. India won't be able to progress socially as well as

economically if the people of the country have to face these problems on a daily basis.

Criticism is the essence of democracy, but the current situation is such that anyone who is seen or heard criticizing the government is immediately termed anti-national. It's like you cannot criticize the government on what you feel is being done wrongly and be a nation lover. The current condition is such that you need to be supportive of whatever the government is doing to prove yourself as a nation lover. People need to understand that they have the right to question the government on what they feel is not correct or may be harmful to the nation. If someone is challenging the government, it doesn't mean they are questioning the integrity of the country or blaming the country for something, rather it means they are questioning the government on what they feel may not be right for them.

Questioning increases accountability of the Government to its citizens. After all, it is the Government of the people, by the people and for the people and people have all the right to question the government on what they feel is correct or wrong in their eyes. But the recurring incidents of lynchings, especially mob lynching and targeted mob violence with no action from the government have time and again proved that the government has not been successful in creating an environment that is required for the growth of the country.

The Road Ahead for India

A recent report by the International Monetary Fund says that India needs to take urgent policy actions to reverse the current ongoing economic slowdown. The Government has exceeded its debt levels as well as the interest bills, and there is very limited space to boost spending to support growth. There has been ongoing cut in GDP forecast of the country and international organizations have not refrained from saying that if the current situation persists, they have

to cut the GDP forecast even more in the coming months. A nation which labels itself as one of the fastest-growing economies among the developing nations has been going through a serious slowdown in the economy.

These are dark times, not only for the democracy of the country but also for the freedom of its citizens. The condition is such that reason is being replaced by exposes, logic is being replaced by faith and democratic deliberations are being replaced by fanatic mob violence. The government has been able to shift the national concern from increasing unemployment rates which are currently at a four-decade high of 6.1% and a dwindling business environment to war-mongering, religious nationalism and silencing civil society.

The media of the country is equally responsible for creating a false impression of growth in the Indian economy while the global agencies have been continuously predicting a decline in India's GDP since the incident of Demonetisation. India needs to come out of this vicious grasp of social problems in order to grow at a fast rate and emerge as a leader in GDP growth among the developing nations. The government needs to take strong actions to curb the rising instances of hate crimes and intolerance otherwise the economic and social wealth that the nation has accumulated over the last many years will be eroded in no time.

Is a Biased Media Bad for Democracy?



The Fourth Estate

The term 'fourth estate' is borrowed from the European concept of the three estates of the realm - the First Estate (clergy), the Second Estate (nobility), and the Third Estate (commoners). In 1787, Edmund Burke, a famous Anglo-Irish statesman and philosopher, termed press and news media as the fourth estate in House of Commons of Great Britain during a debate on the opening up of press reporting. The news media is expected to be honest, accurate, fair and courageous in gathering, reporting and interpreting information. It must act independently in its explicit and implicit ability to report the news.

Media should never become part of the political system or government either directly or indirectly. When media is not part of the political system and work independently, it can gain significant power to question the system and governance. Besides, media can bring changes in policies as it wields remarkable social influence. Democracy without media is unimaginable

Media is the most potent and essential pillar of democracy. The media can shape and influence public opinion in many ways. Democracy without independent and diverse media is like a vehicle without wheels. In developed countries, people are more sceptical, and the media does not have as much influence on them. However, media always commands importance in developing and populous

countries like India. There are many issues in the country for media to focus and report like agriculture, education, employment, health care, crime, economy, etc. The media as a vehicle for cultural expression and of social change remain the dominant sources of news. Media's role is vital not only to providing information but also in shaping how people view government and what they think they can influence. It is the media only which exposes loopholes in the democratic system and helps make the government more accountable, people-friendly system. The media also reminds politicians about their unfulfilled promises at the time of elections and exposes corrupt candidates. Media brings the truth; informs the reality and helps people in electing the right person to power. The media is more powerful than politicians as it compels politicians to keep up their promises to get re-elected. Media landscape changed

For decades the media remained transparent and was heavily regulated and monitored. Media was accountable to the general public. However, the scenario changed drastically in the past decade. The media has unquestionably evolved and become more biased over the past decade. The internet revolutionized the way people communicate and share information. The World Wide Web has increased the degree of self-determination in how people gather knowledge, shape their views and engage with topics of societal relevance.

The media across the globe has been delegitimized either by the governments or opposition parties. Alongside, the use of social media and citizen journalism emerged where anyone and everyone can report news, spread lies, express their own ideas and upload their own views, thoughts onto the internet. This phenomenon gradually gained importance. Websites, blog sites, Youtube, Twitter, WhatsApp, and other platforms have become powerful weapons. Growing access to internet connectivity and affordable 4G data plans and high

smartphone penetration due to imported cheap Chinese smartphones are fuelling the growth of online media and social media platforms.

Zero Accountability with no Ethics

Unfortunately, these internet mediums of media are not following ethics and will not be bound by regulations and standards of reporting. Since the internet medium of media controls the minds of the masses, the internet media has the power to convert rumours into hard truth and the ability to pass on a piece of positive news as fake news. There is neither accountability nor transparency. Media has the option and luxury to choose a word with a positive or a negative connotation to refer to a person, an entity, a political party and the government. It can even wear the judge's hat when it wants to pass the judgement; it can make the innocent guilty and declare the guilty as innocent. Communication becomes powerful once it is accessed, consumed and discussed and used to influence masses and can also erupt violence.

Media bias can Strongly Impact the Public Perception

Various platforms of media such as broadcast media, radio, online websites and print media outlets need to improve transparency and accountability. At present, the media outlets' behaviour varies significantly in voice, tone and tenor based on the political climate and whom are they reporting or interviewing.

Curiously, most of the media outlets tend to ignore what people want to know, or report news that influence decisions on the significant issues that affect their lives, and impose biased news through slanted news coverage. Factors influencing media bias can include vested interests or ideological stance of the outlet, to grow viewership or to make profits or to gain political mileage. Media does not represent people, so the question of accountability does not arise. For the

majority of people, the news is a primary source of information. What they see or read is what they believe. Thus, media bias has substantial impact on shaping opinions and plays a central role in both individual and public perception of news. Resultantly, media bias can strongly impact the public perception of the reported news topics, and thus impacts political decisions. The public is prone to adopting similarly biased views because of the growing phenomenon of media bias. Media bias is changing the fabric of people's core social networks. People are divided by the media bias as they are more likely to be surrounded by information and opinions close to their ideology or news that matches their own views. People subscribe to the news outlet that reinforces their beliefs and supports the views in which they see the world. Consequently, the polarization of public opinion not only complicates but also becomes a waste of time. People are increasingly engaged in arguments and war of words with news that is different from their beliefs and ideology.

Millennials are Influenced by Media Bias

Sadly, media bias has an immense effect on the bulk of millennials and illiterates, which may influence electoral behaviour or voting decision and, in turn, influence election outcomes. The widespread emergence of multiple online, print and social media platforms will only add fuel to the flames. Various communities, business houses, the political parties are establishing their own print, digital, Television media outlet to serve as their mouthpiece. Numerous resources are employed for the media outlets' self-perpetuating pursuit. The more media outlets and mouthpieces the more room for bias media. In the end, media bias redefines the media's role, and its relationship between the government and the citizens.

These powerful yet adverse effects of media bias are leading to cracks in the pillars of democracy. Mainly, in the case of India, media bias is undoing of India's unity in diversity. Media bias, to our dismay,

is killing the democracy all in the name of freedom of the press. The primary role of media is to investigate, research and to inform people. However, the media bias tends to manufacture news, frame situations and misinform people. We badly need a dedicated individual regulatory body to focus on media bias and blacklist such biased media platforms.

Can Science and Spirituality Coexist?



Science and spirituality have been two great pursuits of mankind. The scientific quest is to discover the order in the external world of space, time, energy and matter, to study nature and behaviour of natural things. Spirituality is to discover the order of our consciousness. Spirituality helps us to understand what is right and what is wrong in life. It is a process of personal transformation, either in compliance with traditional religious ideals, or, increasingly oriented on subjective experience and psychological growth independent of any specific religious context. Spirituality defines how we all are connected to each other, and how we can all co-exist and thrive together. If we understand how everything is interconnected, we can make better decisions and become more aware of what impacts we are having not just on a physical level, but on a mental level as well.

Science and spirituality both have originated out of human curiosity.

Human beings have an urge to find out what is happening around and within them. The purpose of this curiosity is the by-product. For instance, technology is a by-product of science, much before technology came into existence people were investigating about the nature and the behaviour of the natural things like why is the sky blue in colour? What exists in the outer space, etc.? Similarly, the questions pertaining to spirituality include the purpose of our existence, the definition of right or wrong, what is death, is there afterlife, etc., and in this quest, religion has emerged as a by-product.

Science flourishes on reasoning while spirituality is a matter of faith.

Science focuses on facts and evidence while spirituality answers questions based on emotions, morality and scripture. Although there

are differences in the beliefs of the groups, they are ultimately attempting to solve the same puzzle that consumes the minds of members of both disciplines. They seem to be polar opposites but are mutually dependent ways of thinking that ultimately seek the answer to the same fundamental questions; how and why we exist.

Science is said to not work well with religion and spirituality, however this is not the case. Science and spirituality create a very fine balance, something that keeps the world from collapsing in chaos. Science and spirituality work together in order to keep the world in a peaceful balance between man and machine.

Science and spirituality not only can coexist, but also enhance each other.

There are many examples where coexistence of science and spirituality has done wonders. One such example is medicine. A holistic approach that incorporates the patient's individual beliefs can aid their treatment and healing process. This type of approach in medicine helps the patients to have faith and also helps the medicine students to understand and prioritize. Just as there have been great scientists like Einstein, Newton, Galileo, Darwin, and so on, there have also been great spiritual teachers and leaders like Buddha. People respect those great spiritual teachers because they came upon a certain state of consciousness which was one of love and compassion, a universal consciousness which was not divided from the rest of the world.

Science deals with what is measurable; spirituality or religion is the search for discovering and understanding the immeasurable.

A scientist may not be intelligent if he denies the existence of the immeasurable. There is nothing that is anti-science but there is a lot that is beyond science. Science and spirituality have to go hand in hand. We not only need to have an understanding of the laws that govern the phenomena occurring in the external world around us but also we need to discover order and harmony in our consciousness. Human understanding is only complete when it covers both aspects of reality: matter as well as consciousness. Indeed the division between the scientific and spiritual quests is itself the creation of the human mind. Reality is one undivided whole which includes both

matter and consciousness. Our thoughts, being limited by our experience, divide the external world from the inner world of our consciousness, in much the same way as our mind divides time from space though they are both two aspects of a single continuum.

The theory and methodology of science is obtained from mind, whereas the spiritual consciousness is considered to be beyond mind by those who have attained it. In order to attain true knowledge and consciousness, one has to follow both the disciplines. The area of action of the scientist is external world where results can be observed and made visible to others; for the spiritualist, however, a journey within, knowing of one's true self that forms one's core is required.

Science in harmony with spirituality safeguards against misrepresentation of spirituality

Sometimes people misunderstand spirituality or are duped in the name of spirituality by vested interests. We often come across cases where people kill others and sometimes even themselves by falling in the trap of spiritual gurus who mislead them and brainwash them. This kind of blind spiritual beliefs should be avoided. To avoid these kinds of mishappenings, people should be scientifically aware about the nature and everything around, so that they do not get carried away by the false beliefs or superstitions.

Our future depends on planned and combined efforts of science and spirituality because separately neither has been up to the outstanding task. Science works fine in everyday affairs without dealing with spirituality and on the other side spirituality works well in serving spiritual needs of people as they go through their individual insights, awakening and crises. However unless the two come together, we won't be using our full human capability to solve problems. Beyond providing a platform for addressing humanity's problems, the joint efforts of science and spirituality promises to be the foundation for the next evolutionary leap in human potential.

The gap between soul and brain is huge. It's the task of education to enable the mind so as to fill the void between brain and soul. An amalgamation of science and spirituality, which encompasses both brain and soul, is needed. It is also the responsibility of this domain of

knowledge to be free from hierarchy, animosity and rigidity. It must be guided by curiosity, openness and higher consciousness.

Emotions and Information Propagation in Social Media



Social media websites and applications enable users to create and share content, interact and communicate with people. In recent years social media has grown at a very fast pace. Mobile devices and interactive social media websites like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, YouTube, etc. have become an integral part of the lives of people especially of the youngsters. Regardless of all the geographical distances people stay in touch with one another. According to Forbes, there are about 1 billion social media accounts all over the world. Today social media has become an inseparable part of our lives. The introduction to social media has changed the world in many ways. It has become the fastest mode of communication and spreading a word has become much easier than ever. Today it can be used as a very helpful tool in changing the lives of people but at the same time it causes conflicts which can negatively affect a person.

With the growth of social media, people look for emotional support and social acceptance on social media. Majority of people try to gain popularity through social media by posting pictures and increasing their followers. It has become a source of emotional dependence. The social media platforms often become the deciding factor for their social status and popularity. Their social as well as emotional identity almost seems to be dictated by such platforms. Many youngsters use social media to measure their popularity against others and fall into the trap of comparing their lifestyles with random people which eventually leads to depression and emotional instability. Social media today has adverse consequences. Its main danger is that people get involved in the virtual world and forget about the real world.

Comparison on social media also leads to jealousy and envy. Many teenagers and young people post photos in search of assurance and compliments, but they are making themselves vulnerable to negative comments and abuse. In search of attention they do not realize that they are bringing down their self-esteem. Overuse of social media can cause anxiety and depression. It can also lead to poor achievements and grades at school.

Expressions via social networking sites can reduce our ability to tolerate distress to a large extent. For instance, the growing accessibility has raised the bars of our expectations to the extent that seeing that our message has been read but not responded to can itself serve as a major source of frustration, not allowing for the possibility of any other realistic reasons.

Despite so many negative impacts, social media is a place that keeps us connected across great distances and helps us to connect with people all over the world. It is also used to promote positive and productive ideas. A new study “Microblogging and the value of undirected communication” suggests that social media interactions can help people to decrease negative emotions and boost well-being. It can reduce social isolation and loneliness as it opens new paths of communication. There are so many websites, channels that promote spirituality and help people to deal with depression by posting motivational videos and stories. There are many life coaches who provide online life coaching for free and help people to go through their ups and downs in life.

With the help of social networking, we can communicate and share our thoughts with large number of people at the same time. It is easy to share pictures, texts, videos and advertisements. Social media helps people to organize protests, meet-ups to address various social issues. For example, in 2013 protests which took place in Turkey, social media played a vital role in communication. Many young men and women, students organized protests using social media. Social media has also led to creation of many useful websites like LinkedIn that help people searching for jobs. Candidates create their resumes

and CVs and upload them on these websites. Employers then search for the qualifications they are interested in. Similarly there are a lot of websites that help in real estate search, online hotel booking, holiday planning, etc. Social media acts as a blessing when it comes to spreading information example sports, election results, and election campaigns, marketing of a product and even disasters.

Despite the increasing use of social media platforms for information and news gathering, its immoderate nature often leads to the emergence and spread of rumours, i.e., items of information that are unverified at the time of posting. Rumours can destroy the lives of innocent people. Lies are spread on social media more rapidly than truth does. People usually believe whatever is portrayed on these social media websites without even verifying or checking the authenticity. The other side of social media is security and privacy issues. As security issue, the third person gains unauthorized access to the information of protected resources and the privacy issues occur when someone can gain access to confidential information by simply watching you what you type your password. The reason behind Social network security and privacy lapses exist because of the amounts of information the sites process each and every day that end up making it much easier to exploit a single flaw in the system. Features that invite user participation - messages, invitations, photos, open platform applications, etc. – are often the avenues used to gain access to private information.

User-submitted insults are comments that contain mildly or strongly insulting language against a specific person or persons. These comments range from mild name-calling to severe bullying. Online bullies often use insults in their interactions, referred to as cyber bullying. Hiding behind a screen name allows users to say mean, insulting comments with anonymity; these bullies rarely have to take responsibility for their comments and actions. At the same time, the openness of social media platforms provides opportunities to study how users share and discuss rumours, and to explore how to automatically assess their veracity, using natural language processing and data mining techniques. Children should be aware of

cyber bullying, internet frauds, difference between real and virtual life and then we will be able to perceive those networks as ideal platforms in online communication and self expression.

Social media is an indispensable element of our modern life. There are millions of users around the world that use social media on a daily basis. It does have a lot of importance but at the same time it can have negative impacts too. One must carefully weigh the positives and the negatives before engaging excessively in social media. Social media can be a boon for mankind if used in a correct way.

Modernism and Our Traditional Socio-Ethical Values



Modernism is a philosophical movement started during the late 19th and early 20th century. It included wide-scale and far-reaching transformations in western society and changes in cultural trends as well. It shows certain trends in art, writing, criticism, politics and philosophy. Modernism reflects incorporeal social values, beliefs and ideology under modernity than centralizing around material culture.

Tradition indicates an established method or practice, beliefs or customs that are passed on from one generation to the next generation. It has its origin in the past. Several rituals like in case of marriage have their origin in our tradition and are, in no way related to any logic or religion.

Modernism and traditionalism go hand in hand. Indian culture is a blend of traditional values and modern spirit. Many age old traditions are still dominant in Indian society, though, some of the harmful traditions are no longer prominent today like sati is prohibited, widows are remarrying, child marriages have been stopped in many places, dowry system has declined to a large extent. Girls are actively taking part in education and profession.

The traditional values included conservatism and superstitious approach but modernism is more open minded and based on logics. There were many stereotypes in the Indian society like female feticide, gender bias, untouchability, inequality, etc. which in traditional times were considered to be correct. Modernism does not support such stereotypes and treats everyone equally irrespective of caste, colour, gender, etc.

India faced a number of problems at the end of the Second World War, like the problems of economic backwardness, a large number of people living below the poverty line, unemployment, predominance of religion in all walks of life, rural indebtedness, caste conflicts, communal disharmony, shortage of capital, lack of trained personnel with technical skills, imperfect means for mobilizing human and material resources, and so forth. The western impact has provided alternative solutions to handle these problems.

Positive Implications of Modernism

Owing to modernism and western education, the outlook of people has broadened. They began talking about their rights and freedom. The introduction of the new values, the rational and secular spirit, and the ideologies of individualism, equality and justice assumed great importance.

Acceptance of scientific innovations increased the aspirations for raising the standards of human beings and providing material welfare for the people.

The hierarchy of political values has been reconstructed. Accepting the democratic form of government, all native states, which had been under a monarchic form of government, have been merged into the Indian State and the authority and domination of feudal and zamindars has been demolished.

There have been structural changes in social institutions like marriage, family and caste, creating new forms of relations in social life, religion, etc. Modernism has eradicated untouchability and social evils to a large extent.

The introduction of the modern means of communication and transportation, such as railway and bus travel, postal service, air and sea travel, press, and radio and television have improved man's life in various aspects.

Some traditional values were so deeply entrenched in the Indian society that people believed that there was nothing wrong with them.

There are a lot of traditional practices in our ancient customs, still practiced today and we need to abandon them. These practices are not only meaningless but even evidently harmful to the society. For example, the practice of dowry is the evil in the society in the modern context. It forces ambitious girls, whose parents are poor, to remain unwed. Another evil practice of the same magnitude is child marriage.

We need to identify and preserve the precious elements of Indian culture such as music, dance, handicrafts, and the likes. One may also seek to preserve a great deal of the colour and variety in certain aspects of Indian life such as food, dress, and festivals. However, this is not enough. It is also necessary to identify the elements that must go if the spirit of modernity is not to be crushed under their weight.

Modernism is in total contrast with the ideas or methods of the traditional ones. It is said that old things should be preserved carefully but it is also true that old is to be given up for good to enter the new era. We cannot go on sticking to our past customs traditions and roots simply because they have come by inheritance.

This modern Indian society cannot completely break itself from the old traditions. No society can do that, nor is it necessary for India. Her past is remarkably rich and varied, capable of providing a starting point for modernity. Indian tradition offers numerous instances of the spirit of free and critical inquiry of the highest intellectual order, determination to pursue truth regardless of where it leads a positive and secular approach to life and a tradition of abstract thought necessary for the growth of modern knowledge.

In order to face tradition directly, we need to remove from it what is unwanted and retain what is good in it. Then only we will be able to preserve and revive our old virtues that made the country great and famous all over the world in the past. Therefore, going ahead by preserving our values and culture is not wrong. Also, we should change with time for good as everything in this world is changing.

Is Communalism a Challenge to Peace or Propagation of Religion or Something Else?



“I have nothing of the communalist in me because my Hinduism is all inclusive.”

—Mahatma Gandhi

Communalism is referred in the western world as a “theory or system of government in which virtually autonomous local communities are loosely in federation”. Communalism is a political philosophy, which proposes that market and money be abolished and that land and enterprises to be placed in the custody of community. But in the Indian sub-continent context, communalism has come to be associated with tensions and clashes between different religious communities in various regions.

Development of communalism as political philosophy has roots in the ethnic and cultural diversity of Africa. It is characterised as, people from different ethnic groups or community, who do not interact much or at all and this has somewhere acted as hindrance in the economic growth and prosperity of Africa. However, communalism in South Asia is used to denote the differences between the various religious groups and difference among the people of different communities. It is significant socio-economic and political issue in Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Nepal, etc.

The partition of India and the long history of Hindu Rashtravad (Hindu Nationalism) express the formidable successes of this tradition. Bipan Chandra points out- “Simply put, communalism is the belief that because a group of people follow a particular religion, they have, as a result, common social, political and economic interests”.

Communalism in our country is more like blind loyalty to one's own religious group. It is described as a tool to mobilise people for or against by raising an appeal on communal lines. It is associated with religious fundamentalism and dogmatism.

If we turn the pages of history, we find that ancient India was united without any communal feelings. People lived peacefully together; there was acceptance for each other's culture and tradition. For example, Ashoka followed religious tolerance and focused mainly on Dharma. In Medieval period, rulers such as Akbar, was an epitome of secular practices and believed in propagating harmony. Same acceptance for different cultures and traditions was practised in several kingdoms throughout India, because of which there was peace and concord.

The growth of Communalism in India is result of the emergence of modern politics, which has its roots in partition of Bengal in 1905 and feature of separate electorate under Government of India Act, 1909. Later, British government also appeased various communities through Communal award in 1932, which faced strong resistance from Gandhiji and many others. All these acts were done by the British government to appease Muslims and other communities, for their own political needs. This feeling of communalism has deepened since then, fragmenting the Indian society and being a cause of unrest.

The growth of Communalism increased in later part of 19th century with Hindu revivalist movement like Shuddhi movement of Arya Samaj and Cow protection riots of 1892 and other hand movements like Faraizi movement started by Haji Shariatullah in Bengal to bring the Bengali Muslims back on the true path of Islam. Later people like Syed Ahmed Khan, who despite having scientific and rational approach projected Indian Muslims as a separate community. This was followed by the set up of Hindu Mahasabha, Muslim League and personalities like M A Jinnah, M M Malviya and Lala Lajpat Rai after 1920s.

An important feature of colonial India was the emergence of communalism as a force that guided the destiny of India into a blood bath and inevitable partition of the Indian subcontinent on communal lines. Though India was a land of multi-religions, creeds and faiths, pre-colonial India was never plagued by the worm of communalism. It was the purposeful colonial policy of divide and rule that laid the seeds of communalism which grew into a huge tree that disturbed the solidarity of the age-old mosaic of India and it is still haunting to sap the vitality of the newly won independence.

It was thought that partition of the country would resolve the problem of communal violence in India, and in the post-partition period, the people would be able to live without facing the ill-effects of the communal violence. However, it was a false hope and except the decade of fifty, people could not live in without communal violence. And this was just the beginning; post independence India witnessed even more communal violence – the Anti Sikh riots of 1984; the ethnic cleansing of Kashmiri Hindu Pundits in 1989; Bhagalpur riots in 1989; Babri Masjid demolition in Ayodhya in 1992; Gujarat riots in 2002, recently Muzaffar Nagar riots in 2013 and many more.

Communalism or communal ideology consists of three basic elements or stages, one following the other. Firstly, there is a belief that people who follow the same religion have common political, economic, cultural and social interests. Secondly, in multi-religious society like India, the common interests of the followers of one religion are dissimilar and divergent from the interests of the followers of another religion, and thirdly, the belief that the interests of the followers of different religions or different communities are seen to be mutually incompatible, antagonistic and hostile.

In India, throughout the past century, communal forces have tried to capture the political centre stage. By various means, they have sought to disrupt the unity and integrity of the country, tried to gnaw at the very secular foundations of Indian culture and history. But, every time they have failed. Yet, the consequences of such thoughts have often traumatic. The spectre of growing communalism is the most

threatening issue facing India today. The nation is becoming increasingly intolerant when it comes to communist issues.

Furthermore, it is not always Hindus or Muslims spreading the communal violence, sometimes other forces operating in the name of religion are responsible. This is evident from the fact of large-scale violence that followed after the conviction of a self renowned godman, Gurmeet Ram Rahim in Panchkula. It was almost a war-like situation, when the godman's hysterical followers ran amok pelting stones and set vehicles, buildings afire and created havoc. The mayhem raised numerous questions not only on the current law and order situation in India, but also that Communalism becoming a serious issue, even at the cost of human life.

Wearing Patriotism on Your Sleeve



At his farewell speech, America's erstwhile President Ronald Reagan warned his countrymen in a stringent note that, "unless Americans taught each new generation what it means to be an American, we risk losing our memory as a nation – and along with it – the American spirit." The spirit of patriotism is evident also when the former American President Barack Obama cathartically exclaimed, "America is not a bunch of individuals or blue states and white states – it is the United States of America." And one can see that America, the nation topped the list amongst the most patriotic countries of the world, according to a Forbes 2008 survey.

In the case of India when it comes to patriotism, it appears to be merely circumscribed to the game of cricket. We live within constricted alleys of varying ideologies while consistently failing to identify our own selves. It's been more than seventy years now after our independence and we still hover around the labyrinthine dogmas of Regionalism, Casteism, Secularism, Marxism, Communalism, et al, only leaving apart our zeal for the doctrine of patriotism. As a matter of consequence, the way to recognition of being an Indian tends to lose its strand ludicrously.

The idea of patriotism is something above and beyond region, caste, religion or for that matter any ideological hegemony. It is congenital in terms of belonging to the nation. Everyone in a country is emotionally attached to the pride, success and well-being of the same. A mere frenzy at the victory of the Indian cricket team cannot be defined as patriotism. Patriotism is counted when we blatantly litter our surroundings and also when we cast our votes to the wrong person. It

is the anxiety to see the country progressing like Ferrari wheels. It is not limited to the saluting of the national flag or a 52 seconds statue stature during the national anthem which also often overburdens us.

Patriotism does not demand one to be in the defence forces or in sports or to be a politician. It is the zeal ensued by the commitment to do some good work for the fellow countrymen. Short and small deeds matter most when we think about patriotism. When Indian patriotism comes under purview, it is seen that the backward classes are often ignored to be playing a better hand at ameliorating patriotic feelings. They are pushed aside as the socially frigid groups. But for that matter, we also have to take into account another pertinent saying here that “an empty stomach cannot blow the seditious sound of the war bugle.” It is correct that a person devoid of family upbringing and good school education cannot inculcate in himself the greatness and pride of the political, the cultural and the economic history of his own nation. Patriotism requires the same zeal in the educated class and the deprived section. But even the educated class now falls short of recounting the pride bestowed on us by those martyrs who sacrificed for our glory today.

History speaks that India had been invaded and attacked several times since as early as 300 B.C. primarily due to the reason that there existed diasporas of disunited principalities dispersed hither and thither, that were always fighting with each other and therefore not being able to conglomerate under one common banner and essence. Now centuries have elapsed and we live in the era of absolute liberalisation and globalisation of market as well as culture. Yet it seems history has reiterated itself for we are not still capable of recognising our own culture, heritage, history and all those akin to the roots of the nation. This portrays nothing more than a lack of representation for the cause of the nation. India nevertheless is a citadel of education, philosophy, mathematics, medicine, astronomy, fine arts, music, dance and numerous others, but the leaders holding the helm of the nation are yet not able to realise the representational potentials of such a nation.

With a grim note, it must be stated that the discovery of a nation that was once motivated by a single utterance of "Vande Mataram" has now come to a cul-de-sac. The educated coterie is apathetic and only lends a cold shoulder to the problems afflicting the country. It has rather become preferential for them to use their brains abroad. As a matter of fact, the nation's roots comprising of its culture, heritage and tradition have failed further discovery, exposition and focus. The age is so governed solely by the evil aspects of the occidental system that the youths today are easily swayed by conspicuous consumption, self-centered consumerism, corruption and separatism. That is why we can easily see today in every nook and corner of the country, riots have been only supplanted by riots, let apart peace and resolution. It has become quite dubious now to hope for a patriotic fervour among countrymen. We very easily incline to undo the plain Aesopian fable that still carries as much weight as in the ancient times, "United we stand, divided we fall." Losing patriotism in India is ominous of the fact that the country is very soon expecting to see the decay of its very backbone. Freedom for this nation was not easily achieved; we must also remember that it is even difficult to maintain that hard earned freedom. To ensure inclusive prosperity and development in a fast moving economy like India, patriotism and unity is a sine qua non. At a time when we often remain entangled with self-centered businesses, we may at best internalise the words of patriotism spoken by the great American politician Adlai E. Stevenson, "Patriotism is not short, frenzied outbursts of emotion, but the tranquil and steady dedication of a lifetime." These words of fervour may at least be a goading beacon for people moving astray from the rooted doctrines and let patriotism, an innate behaviour among countrymen, be restored in replete.

Religion May be Bigger Business than Ever Before



Religion per se is no more limited to a way of life, a faith or a philosophy. It has far extended its domains from just a disciplined path of life to eye-snatching extravagant ceremonies and further to someone's luscious business doings. Today it is very much more than a set of beliefs pursued as a means of bringing holistic piety in a person. Religion, so to say, has now become a trade, a profession and a handsome source for some people's employment.

Nevertheless the fact that we have heard about the interaction between religion and business throughout history when one influenced and affected one another, today's is a different ball game altogether. Notably a considerable number of people have set up ashrams, matths, deras, et al in India with a view to amassing huge lump sums of money from their gullible devotees. It is said that in India, the religious organizations not only operate as business organizations, but their business model has now seen diversification of activities to retain the loyalty of their followers and to attract new devotees. Religion verily plays a pivotal role in Indian society and culture and considerably influences its businesses and the economy.

It will be too parochial to confine the business of religion to the Indian subcontinent. Throughout the world, religion has been branded as one of the highest carriers of business and economy to the state. In the United States, the Organized Religion Industry (O.R.I.) is considered too big to send "swirling down the economy's drain." Author Martha Woodroof writes about the O.R.I. in America, "For an industry of which the major American branch (Christianity) uses as its mission statement the anti-materialist words of a poor carpenter, the

O.R.I. has done all right in the rapacious fray known as the American economy.” It is clear from such words that how large a contributor to the state economy is the business industry called religion, take anywhere in the globe.

Be any religion, in today’s age of late capitalism, everyone is surrounded by a halo of business-making driven by the sole avaricious desire of minting pennies. It is known fact that the religion called Judaism “outlines requirements of accurate weights and measurements in commerce, as well as prohibitions on monetary deception, verbal deception and misrepresentation.” It is scarcely credible that the Islamic halal products comprise a US 2 trillion dollar business industry. Furthermore, the Jewish dietary Kashrut system has recommended food products which have sale values of 165 billion US dollars annually.

In India, religious business ceremonies are common sights. A Hindu is always seen setting off with a thing only after dedicating the beginning to the Gods, for their blessings matter the most. Some of the very common business events that comprise of the most coveted religious ceremonies are opening of new offices and breaking of ground for new facilities. A muhurat or the finale of a business-related religious ceremony is one to reckon with and never to be missed on any account.

Max Weber, the most renowned German sociologist and philosopher was one of the first in modern times to observe the interplay between religion and the market place. He believed that components of the Christian Protestant theology were catalytic and elemental in the emergence of entrepreneurial activities. In his book ‘The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism’ (1905), Weber posits the most enigmatic question, “what explains the peculiar circumstance of a drive to the accumulation of wealth conjoined to an absence of interest in the worldly pleasures which it can purchase?” Weber then argues that this kind of a novel outlook is a distinctively moral one, demanding in fact unusual self-discipline. He indeed believed that the

process of rational organization of capitalism in the West, the first of its kind, was derived from religious sources. A disciplined labour force and the regularized investment of capital are implicit elements of a rational organization of capitalism. And the religious industry has today these elements working together to build it up as a proper business establishment driving the state economy.

Facts astonish everyone. In the name of religion, startling activities are being carried out that further help in bringing high business yields. The Tirupati and other South Indian temples have traditions of collecting hair from their devotees which when traded in the market costs anywhere between Rs. 5000 and Rs. 25000 for a kg of raw remy hair. These hairs moreover help raking up huge returns in the US and the European markets. In the age of the ubiquitous internet service, today entrepreneurs have also started distribution of temple prasad online for devotees who are not able to visit the shrines. The online Prasad website, which does over 200 bookings daily, has a network of around 50 temples across India and charges around Rs. 501 to deliver prasad anywhere in the country in 7 – 10 days. Again there's another venture known as the Vedic Vaani that runs a business by offering items related to all the religions like Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, etc. There's also a website, ProudUmmah dealing with items and pilgrimages of the Muslims. The Tirumala Tirupati temple and the most popular Vaishno Devi temple each is known to collect Rs. 5000 crore as donations annually, while a few hundred of mediocre temples collect an annual lump sum of around Rs. 20000 crores in donations. A capitalist would certainly drool out his tongue at such amounts.

Founders of the religions could never have imagined then what a fate mankind could actually carve out of a pious instrument called religion. There's no more to the old definition that people actually read out in the texts, about "religion." This again proves the extent to which capitalism can actually penetrate given its organizational tactics and investments and not the least, usage of the internet.

Indians have Spiritual Liberty but not Social Liberty



Liberty in terms of spiritual liberation from the cycle of birth and death was a key idea in Indian thought. Individual liberty in social or political society was foreign to classical Indian mindset. The idea of liberty came to the fore of Indian thinking with the encounter with the modern West. It was first epitomised by the intellectual contributions of Mahatma Gandhi for political liberty. Gandhi's idea of liberty was framed in the idea of 'swaraj', a multifaceted concept of the utmost importance in his thought. Swaraj, literally meaning "self-rule," was also used to signify national independence and the political, economic and spiritual freedom of the individual.

Liberty, another word for freedom is an essential concomitant for development and growth. Nonetheless, just to get liberty is not enough, in how we use it lies at the essence of achievement by liberty. Liberty wipes out inequality from the roots of the society. However, even after more than 70 years of Independence, Indians don't really feel truly liberated. They are living in a world where they are forced to stand for National Anthem at a movie theatre, they are told what they can or cannot eat what they can and cannot see, and what they can or cannot speak. Dissent, especially in the university space, is being curbed and sloganeering and flag raising have become tests for nationalism.

On the contrary, religion has long been considered the central motif of Indian life. India, a multi-religious, multilingual and multi-racial nation, has dependably delighted in the vital solidarity of society in the midst of diversities that kept her kin joined together. It is a boundless nation

where individuals of various spiritual mindset and groups live one next to the other.

The Article 26 of Indian Constitution gives freedom to manage religious affairs subject to public order, morality and health, every religious denomination or any other section thereof has the right to establish and maintain institutions for religious and charitable purposes and manage its own affairs in matters of religion. However, this provision is only valid for Indian citizens. India is a place that is known for religious or spiritual diversities. All the significant religions of the world, viz. Hinduism, Christianity, Islam, Sikhism, Buddhism and Jainism are found in India.

India has mostly had a religious culture, where ephemeral material pleasures such as sex and wine which are detrimental to our quest for lasting peace, have not had a place of respect that they occupy in materialistic societies. Albeit religion, in India, has achieved what common people have failed to, like employment and humanism. Right from the Kanwariya yatra, to sound of prayers over loudspeakers and religious processions every now and then, religion is becoming more of a nuisance in everyday life; yet raising a voice against this becomes a matter of pride and hurts the sentiments of millions. Indians willingly turn blind to such predicaments as it will be considered ungodly act. But, when it comes to social matters, Indians have the habit of poking their nose into other's business.

Social liberty and equality are complementary to each other so that both should maintain their vitality. The Constitution commands justice, liberty, equality and fraternity as supreme values to usher in the egalitarian social, economic and political democracy. Social liberty, equality and dignity of person are cornerstone of social democracy. The concept of social liberty which the democracy of India engrafted consists of diverse principles essential for the orderly growth and development of personality of every citizen.

The beauty of living in a democracy is the freedom which comes with it. People should understand that everyone is different, especially

when it comes to the social or moral aspect and nobody should be judged for that. However, moral policing is becoming a very predominant phenomenon in India. For example, Valentine's Day always creates a fuss in India. Certain political party workers threaten and beat up girls and boys ahead of this so called "Western Culture Day"; they raid shops and burn cards or even threaten to marry off couples seen together on Valentine's Day.

India once had a proud heritage of free speech and open discourse. Unfortunately, during British rule much of this was lost and India has still not recovered. India is in the throes of what author Salman Rushdie rightly said a "cultural emergency." Writers and artists of all kinds are being harassed, sued and arrested for what they say or write or create. The government either stands by or does nothing to protect freedom of speech, or it actively abets its suppression.

Furthermore, recently the government has cast a watchful eye on the Internet, demanding that companies like Google and Facebook prescreen content and remove items that might be deemed "disparaging" or "inflammatory," according to technology industry executives there. In India today, it seems, social liberty is itself an atrocity. A film, for example, might pass the Censor Board, but then be summarily banned by a state government. That's what happened with many films such as "Padmavat," an epic period drama film based on the epic poem Padmavat by Malik Muhammad Jayasi; "Aligarh", the story of a gay professor teaching in the Aligarh Muslim University faced protests from both the Muslim community as well as the University; "Udta Punjab", highlighted the drug nuisance in the state of Punjab, saw huge outcry from natives of the state.

India cannot hope to be a true democratic and free society until it firmly protects the right to social expression. Without an unqualified constitutional amendment that guarantees this freedom, the country cannot fairly claim to be the "world's largest democracy." Indians must understand that free speech — the right to think and exchange ideas

freely — is at the core of the democracy they cherish. If the former is weak, the latter cannot help but be as well.

Goodwill, Tolerance and Brotherhood: Three Pillars of a Pluralist Society



“A secure pluralistic society requires communities that are educated and confident both in the identity and depth of their own traditions and in those of their neighbours.”

—Aga Khan

Any society of the world consists of people, individual, community, race or groups having different beliefs, faith, ideologies, and views. For pluralist society, it is not only the matter of beliefs, faiths, or ideologies, but also the matter or choice of food they eat, choice of clothes they wear and how to wear, types of drinks, structure of houses, living style, languages, customs, practices and many other such things. Earlier, it was easy for a society to continue with limited ideas, thoughts and views because there was less migration. But in the time of globalisation and concept of global village, it is not possible for any society to sustain with particular or limited specific practices or views and so constitute a pluralist society. For this pluralist society, people and society have to be tolerant and have goodwill towards other views, faiths and cultures to maintain the brotherhood of the society.

Over the period of time, it is seen that people are fighting for their possessions. Many a time, they are intolerant towards other's culture, language, food, belief and many such other things. In the view of creating influence and hegemony, they start walking on the path of inhuman activities like they threaten others, loot them, and kill them. They try to harm each other to the extent they can. They fill their souls and hearts with negativity for others. There are numerous examples of intolerance and unacceptance. Here are some examples

- (a) Racial discrimination- black people are treated in inhumanitarian ways by white people across the globe.
- (b) Intolerance towards ideology- like capitalism vs. communism, Shia vs. Sunni, catholic vs. non catholic.
- (c) Intolerance of language - English vs. French, Hindi vs. Non-Hindi in India.
- (d) Intolerance of religion - rights between Islam and Christian in Europe, Hindu and Islam in south Asia, Islam and Jews in Middle East.
- (e) Intolerance of cast- this was the problem especially in south Asia region, where the upper cast became intolerant towards lower caste people.

There are various examples of intolerance and lack of acceptance of the people and society.

For the avoidance of clash between the people or group or community, every society must learn a bit of tolerance and acceptance towards others. For any developed society tolerance is not the sole thing. Along with tolerance there are also other pillars of pluralist society i.e. brotherhood and goodwill. By means of tolerance, one cannot only avoid the clash but the tool of brotherhood and goodwill makes the society full of joy and happiness. Brotherhood is not only about accepting others along with their thoughts, beliefs and values, but it is also helping them during crisis in the best possible way. This brotherhood comes from goodwill to do something good for others and for society despite their differences.

In the context of Indian society, there is great diversity across pan-India in terms of language, culture, belief, religion, cast, practices, customs, Geography, History and Economics almost in every field. This is the beauty of Indian pluralist society where people live together from ancient time despite huge diversity and differences. This makes India the world's largest as well as longest pluralist society of the world.

But there are also few small cases where people become intolerant and do not show the brotherhood and goodwill towards others values, belief and religion. The cases of intolerance were rare or very few found in ancient and in medieval era. As British came in modern India, they introduced the policy of divide and rule and they sowed the seed of intolerance which led to the concept of communalism in India. They introduced the concept of minority in religion. Along with the problem of communism, there are also few cases of lingual intolerance like Hindi vs. other language, Gujarati vs. Marathi, hilly area and plain area, racial intolerance like states of north-east vs. other main land of India. But, despite some differences and few cases of intolerance people are living together from thousands of years.

Indian society is very mature in nature. Here people give more preference to goodwill, tolerance and brotherhood over their personal faith, values and beliefs. Indian society is therefore often symbolised with the slogan - unity in diversity. That's why pluralism is not the weakness of Indian society but it is the strength of the Indian society.

It is difficult to survive for any society or civilisation without these three values especially for a country like India where language, customs, values and beliefs get changed at every mile. The tool of goodwill, tolerance and brotherhood not only secure the survival or co-existence, of pluralist society but it's also needed to create good environment for living where coming generation of society can learn and act for making better tomorrow. The main goal of every human value, ideas, belief and other tools is to make society better and suitable for life.

Our experiences in life are determined by the framework around our society. This framework thus needs to be one such that inculcates positive attributes for nurturing our growth and betterment. One cannot simply imagine living life without any interaction or cooperation with the society. This interaction needs to involve goodwill for development of good relationship on both ends. One can gain the trust and faith of another person through the basic human tendency of doing good for others. You just can't expect the society to be kind and helpful to you without your positive contribution to it and its fellow beings.

Our interaction with the society should be such that it not just seeks personal gain and achievements; but also hopes for and works towards the upliftment of the different elements of the society. For this betterment of society, goodwill, tolerance and brotherhood play very important role.

Selfish motives and hatred lead us nowhere, for once we inculcate such negative feelings within us, we keep on digging potholes for our detriment. A society is worth living only when garnered with the seeds of love, belongingness, cooperation, brotherhood, selflessness and goodwill for each other. A society where every individual sees his/her fellow compatriot as one's relative is a heavenly one to reside in. Our philosophy of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" teaches us the same values and we emerge as one of the most culturally grounded and diversified yet united nations in the world.

Road Rage - Emotional Intelligence is the Need of the hour



“When involved in a road rage incident, take a deep breath and ask yourself if the actions are worth your life.”

—Grant Boles

Road rage or angry behaviour exhibited by a driver of a road vehicle which includes rude gestures, verbal insults, physical threats or dangerous driving methods like speeding, tailgating, weaving in and out, honking vehicle's horn, etc. targeted toward another driver in an effort to intimidate or release frustration is dangerous. Road rage can lead to altercations, assaults and collisions that result in serious physical injuries or even death. It can be referred to as an extreme case of aggressive driving.

In India, the road rage is also due to people not following traffic rules; they will break the traffic lights and speed limit at will, not because they are in emergency but they are in usual hurry and always fighting the time clock. We are so concerned about our car that if something or someone nicks it, we act as if one of our limb has been broken and nobody respects for each other while driving, we will honk, not give space to ambulance, will do wrong side overtakes and try to push our vehicles even when there is no place to stand. Why we do this, because we are least bothered about the law and we know by bribing law enforcing authorities, we can escape any punishments. Along with this we carry our ego, social position and dominance in the road, many a time, giving way to one of the passing by car is taken as a defeat and huge ego issues, also a sense of defeat or arrogance creeps in.

A stressed driver's behaviour depends on that driver's coping abilities. Generally, drivers who scored high on aggression tests used direct confrontation strategies when faced with stress while driving. Strategies include long horn honks, swerving, tailgating and attempting to fight the other driver. Many drivers who experience road rage have admitted that they believe they commit more traffic violations. Driving causes a lot of stress any time a person is behind the wheel because of high speeds and other drivers making different decisions. As stress increases, the likelihood of a person having road rage increases dramatically, and if a person has road rage, their stress levels increase. Typically, younger males are most susceptible to road rage.

According to one study, people who customise their cars with stickers and other adornments are more prone to road rage. The number of territory markers predicted road rage better than vehicle value or condition. Furthermore, only the number of bumper stickers and not their content predicted road rage.

How the World Reacts to Road Rage and Penalties They Impose

Road rage is a relatively serious act. It may be seen as an endangerment of public safety. It is, however, not always possible to judge intent by external observation, so "road ragers" who are stopped by police may be charged with other offences such as careless or reckless driving, or may be fined. Road Ragers may be considered as criminals.

Australia

In New South Wales, Australia, road rage is considered an extremely serious act. Any person who chases another motorist or shows intimidating and/or bullying towards another road user can be charged with predatory driving, a serious offence that can leave the culprit in jail for up to 5 years. Offenders can also be fined \$100,000 and disqualified from driving, whether or not he or she intended to

harm the victim physically. If the rash driving results in a physical assault or harm or the victim's car was intentionally damaged, penalties can be much more severe.

Additionally, most common-law countries prohibit common assault, which could apply to road rage where the personal safety of the victim is seen to be threatened. The common law regards assault as both a criminal and civil matter, leading to both public criminal penalties and private civil liabilities.

Germany

Road rage, insults and rude gestures in traffic can lead to fines and even prison sentences to drivers who shout insults or make offensive gestures while driving.

New Zealand

In New Zealand road rage is in itself not an offence. However, when another road-user is physically assaulted or killed, then the offending parties are prosecuted for the specific offence committed. Drivers have a legal duty to take reasonable care to avoid endangerment of human life when operating a vehicle (s 156 Crimes Act 1961); failure to discharge this duty, such as an act of aggressive driving, can give rise to liability in criminal nuisance (s 146 Crimes Act 1961). Ramming a vehicle constitutes intentional or reckless damage to property, a criminal offence, with a maximum penalty of 7 years imprisonment (s 269 Crimes Act 1961). The New Zealand Police generally regard "road rage" complaints as a low priority and the courts currently have no powers to disqualify drivers who physically assault another road user.

Singapore

Road rage is a criminal offence in Singapore. When found guilty, the offender may be jailed for up to two years and/or fined up to \$5,000 for causing hurt.

United Kingdom

In the UK, road rage can result in criminal penalties for assault or more serious offences against the person. The Public Order Act 1986 can also apply to road rage. Sections 4A and 5 of the 1986 Act prohibit public acts likely to cause harassment, alarm or distress. Section 4 also prohibits threatening, abusive or insulting words or behaviour with intent to cause a victim to believe that violence will be used against himself or another.

United States

In some jurisdictions, such as the Commonwealth of Virginia, it is easier to prosecute road rage as reckless driving instead of aggressive driving simply because the burden of proof does not require “intent” to successfully convict. In April 2007, a Colorado driver was convicted of first-degree murder for causing the deaths of two motorists in November 2005. He served a mandatory sentence of two consecutive life terms.

Death and Accidents in India through Road Rages

A Report on Road Accidents in India 2016, published Transport Research wing under Ministry of Road Transport & Highways, Government of India, has revealed that more people died on roads accidents in India last year as compared to the number of deaths in 2015. The data has further revealed that the states of Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu have accounted for maximum number of deaths this year.

As per the data cited in the report, the country recorded at least 4,80,652 accidents in 2016, leading to 1,50,758 deaths. The number suggests that at least 413 people died everyday in 1,317 road accidents. Further, breaking down the statistics, the data reveals that at least 17 deaths occurred in road accidents in 55 accidents every hour in the given time period. Comparing the new recordings with data from previous year shows that in spite of recording fewer accidents in 2016, more deaths have occurred this year as in 2015. In 2015, 1,46,133 people had died in 5,01,423 accidents. The accident

severity, which is measured as the number of persons killed per 100 accidents was recorded at 29.1 in 2015 which is lower than 31.4 in 2016.

As they say hurry makes a bad curry, so we can really see for ourselves that the figures speak for themselves. Is it not more prudent to leave home early, plan your routine, look out for others, share cars or use car pool and drive with patience, because if we are not safe there is no use of reaching a destination with bruises and injuries, many a time our anger or bad behaviour or insults do not just stop but play around in our mind which keep us agitated longer than usual or longer than we want. The serious question to ask oneself is it worth - I am sure the answer is no in 90% of cases, be safe than sorry.

Relevance of Gandhi in Modern Times



Mahatma Gandhi is a household name not only in India but also throughout the world. People have always questioned the pertinence of Gandhi since his death. Certainly, Gandhi's principles are not something that could be sidelined even at an industrially and technologically advanced age today. Throughout the world, he is revered because of his seminal principles that are based on the bedrock of nonviolence. At the death of Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru prophetically said that, "The light is gone and yet it will shine for a thousand years."

A physically frail man, Mahatma Gandhi had the inevitable courage of Satyagraha (firmness of truth). To Gandhi, "Satyagraha is the vindication of truth not by infliction of suffering on the opponent but on one's self." This is one of his major principles propounded to the masses. He coined this term when his social consciousness first awakened as a young man dazed of suffering a racial discrimination for being coloured in South Africa in 1893. Gandhi later fought and strove against untouchability, the rampant notions in society of high and low in birth, he also rendered all his services to the emancipation of women in society. It sounds easy but hard to practise the austerity that Gandhi had actually led in his lifetime. It was a pure life of saint that he had; he followed a strictly vegetarian routine, abstained not only from alcohol and tobacco, but also from mild stimulants like tea and coffee.

The relevance of Mahatma Gandhi's principles today is a subject of perpetual polemic. We all agree that the deeply encrusted natures of commercialization, extravagance and conspicuous consumption that

have grossly enveloped our societies today have made it intricate for Gandhi's foundational principles to thrive. But there also had been instances in the world when principles of Mahatma Gandhi had been zealously implemented and the desired results achieved. Gandhi's life was a passionate adherence to non-violence practised to its perfection in an age driven by modern, liberalized economy. For the Tibetan spiritual and political leader, the present Dalai Lama, Gandhi has always been a source of guiding beacon. He casually says, "Many ancient masters have preached ahimsa, non-violence as a philosophy. That was mere philosophical understanding. But Mahatma Gandhi, in this twentieth century, produced a very sophisticated approach because he implemented that very noble philosophy of ahimsa in modern politics, and he succeeded."

Gandhi's principles and his success thereupon was a result of his impeccable blending of faith, action and populism. He called himself a practical idealist and did never forget that man essentially is a social being. Going by the needs of the man for all sentient beings and also his relationship with the material things in the society, Gandhi proposed a philosophy on the relationship between the individual and the society called the sarvodaya – the rise and well-being of all. As it is the society's duty to plan for the best in the individual, it is also the duty of the individual to return what he owes to the society. Gandhi was a genuine leader of the people. The Japanese Buddhist leader Disaku Ikeda drawing real inspiration from Gandhi, said, "His activism is not mere action but contains many aspects of a spiritual practice that is inspired by the inner urging of the conscience."

Gandhi's principles significantly worked during the apartheid in South Africa when leaders like Nelson Mandela followed real Gandhism to fight for civil liberty and human rights of the black people. The South African President, De Klerk was also an avid follower of Gandhi's principles. Not only this, the famous Bishop Desmond Tutu, a Nobel Peace Prize winner, who in his book 'God is not a Christian: And other Provocations' said that the holy saint Mahatma Gandhi walked close to God.

Likewise, the former President of the United States of America, Barack Obama draws a great deal of inspiration from the embodiment of Gandhi as an apostle of peace and transformational change that happens when ordinary people come together to do extraordinary things. The Burmese leader, Aung San Suu Kyi who was under house arrest for many years learnt from Gandhi that for peace and reconciliation to be translated into practice, an absolute condition needed is fearlessness.

It can be now entrenched that Gandhi continues to be an endless inspiration for the modern world. Many people from different walks of life like Joan Baez, the American folk singer and human rights activist, the American social activist Caesar Chavez, and also people like Joanna Macy, the environmental activist or Mubarak Awad, the non-violent Palestinian leader and also uncountable others have at different times drawn inspirational philosophies from the Mahatma. The Vietnamese Buddhist leader, Thich Nhat Hanh even goes on to define non-violent Gandhism as such, "...we may fail in our attempt to do things, yet we may succeed in correct action when the action is authentically non-violent." This actually preaches Gandhi's great principles in real action.

Gandhi always emphasized on the integrity of the body, mind and soul. To him, the body must be controlled by the mind and the mind by the soul. It is verily claimed that Gandhi's greatest achievement was the spiritualization of politics. He conceived of spirituality as an illumination or fragrance that must accompany every thought or action.

The modern twenty first century being an age of the common man has the absolute need and pertinence of Gandhi to battle against the prevailing societal evils. Today, when we conclude that there is a dearth of Gandhism in Gandhi's own country, it is not because of any flaw in the Mahatma's principles, it is only because of the absence of a strong leader's courage and conviction. Gandhi will certainly be a beacon for thousand years, only if his steps are particularly pursued. It seemed true when the great scientist Albert Einstein expressed his words of gratitude towards the Mahatma, "Generations to come, it

may be, will scarce believe that such a one as this ever in flesh and blood walked upon this earth.”

Cyber Bullying – More Extreme than Face-to-face Taunts



Cyber technology has evolved over the years. Internet has reached new heights. Technology is the craft-designer. Today physical atrocities can still be tolerated, but a technological atrocity is another name for doom. The youth uses the internet now more than ever and most of them have internet access at home. The internet, for most of the youths, is not just a convenient way to research or a fun-filled activity; it has acquired a bulk part of their social lives. Simply put, their lives are revolved around a pivot called the internet for any social purpose involved. They comfort themselves e-mailing and chatting with friends after studies. But things are not circumscribed only to this. The venomous snake raises its head to pout out its fangs.

The term cyber bullying, originating from such contemporary deliberate malfunctions and blatant flouting of the behavioural code of conduct while using the internet, is defined as the harm or harassment caused to other people in a deliberate, consistent and hostile manner through the weapon of information technology. In the eyes of the law, cyber bullying could also be limited to posting rumours or gossips about a person on the internet bringing about hatred in other's minds, or it may go to the extent of personally identifying victims and publishing materials severely defaming and humiliating them.

Cyber bullying happens through the medium of electronic technology, which generally comprises biquitous devices and equipments like cell phones, computers, tablets as well as the communication instruments which include the social media sites, text messages, chat and

websites. Some frequent examples of cyber bullying are text messages or e-mails, rumours splashed across social networking sites or e-mails as well as uploading of disconcerting pictures, videos, websites or forged profiles and images.

The deliberate application of social media to excruciate someone psychologically and physically is another simple explication for cyber bullying. The kids who are being cyber bullied are often bullied in person and most of the time, it is observed that, these kind of kids have a harder time detaching themselves from such behaviour. Cyber bullying is reiterative, waspish and persistent. As it happens through the medium of internet, it can happen at any time. The real source of distress lies in the fact that the messages or images can be sent anonymously and then distributed to a wide audience at a meteoric manner. And once posted, these sorts of inappropriate and harrowing messages and pictures cannot be properly deleted.

There can be assorted problems endemic of kids facing cyber bullying. They might incline towards alcohol and drugs, skip school, experience in-person bullying, reluctance in school-going as well as studies, poor grades, lower self-esteem, health problems, etc. According to the recently released Intel Security's "Teens, Tweens and Technology Study 2015", 81% of Indian respondents between eight and 16 are active on the social media networks. Of these, 22% have reported being bullied online — the highest in the four countries surveyed (Australia, USA and Singapore being the other three). That's not all. As many as 52% of Indian children indicated that they had bullied people over the social media — again the highest of the four countries surveyed. A whopping 65% of respondents report witnessing cruel behaviour online.

It has been surveyed and authentically proved that today nearly 81% of people think that bullying online is easier to get away with than bullying in person. And current statistics say that India ranks highest among a few Asian countries in cyber bullying with 53 percent currently utilizing the internet between the ages of 8 to 17 and have

faced some form of online bullying more than once. This is in contrast to a sizeable 49 percent children who face cyber bullying in Bangladesh, 33 percent in Thailand and only one in 4 children in Malaysia, according to the Norton Cyber security Insights Report by Norton by Symantec. One can imagine how volcanic information technology can be if and when human intelligence wishes to deliberate and play with it.

Among teens and youths, girls are even more likely to become victims of such bullying. There can be repeated threats, sexual remarks and pejorative labels or hate speeches trying every time to disconcert the target victim. But all these can be prevented if and only if parents become aware of such sinister happenings and warn their wards about it. Parents should be always aware of what their kids do online. They must set up some rules to use technology for their kids. First and foremost, they must teach kids the appropriate usage of technological devices like the computer, the cell phone, etc. In order to ensure a healthy internet use, they must clarify their kids on the websites to be visited and what is to be done when they are online, thus ensuring safety.

The kids should actually know what posts should they upload and what they must not in order to not embarrass or hurt anyone's feelings. All these must be clear to their minds. And the duty of the parents lies in monitoring their wards so that they do not go astray while online. Kids must know to be smart with technology, rather than getting tampered by it. They must remember the Biblical saying of King Solomon, "A wise son maketh a glad father, but a foolish son is the heaviness of his mother." It is for the posterity to decide how capable they are to bring gladness for their family.

SECTION-I: EDUCATION

Education is the key Driver of Economic success and social mobility



A recent OECD report suggests that if every child is provided with access to education and the skills needed to participate fully in society would boost the GDP by an average of 28% per year in lower income countries and 16% per year in high income countries for the next 80 years.

Nelson Mandela rightly said that “Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world” and even our Constitution provides for the Right to free and compulsory education to all children in age group 6-14 years. It’s a fundamental human right irrespective of race, gender, nationality, ethnic or social origin or religion or political preference.

In spite of this, more than 120 million children do not get complete primary education. Many children and youth, across the globe are denied this right and so they lose on opportunities of getting a decent job or battling poverty or develop their communities.

As the Millennium Development Goals (MDG) of the United Nations is coming to its deadline, the world has to ensure that boys and girls everywhere complete a full course of primary schooling. This goal is instrumental to all other goals prescribed under the MDGs.

Why Educate?

Education improves the quality of life and leads to broader social benefits to individuals and society. It enriches people’s understanding

of themselves and world. It raises the productivity and creativity of people and also promotes their entrepreneurial and technological advances.

As Laozi, the Chinese philosopher and writer, stated – “Give a man a fish and he will eat for a day. Teach a man to fish and he will eat for a lifetime,”– it very subtly suggests that education is an investment. Achieving sustainable development without substantial investment in human capital is not possible for any country.

A complex process like economic development has given the economists tough time in identifying its fundamental factors. Financial and human capital when combined in sophisticated and productive ways leads to rapid economic growth. Out of the four types of fixed capital that contribute to production in a national economy, the human capital is one significant pick. So, investment in human capital is an important element in economic development process. It has been supported by strong and consistent evidences of Econometric studies that more educated workers are more productive and they can earn higher salaries. This further leads to a simultaneous rise in average levels of national income.

When children are provided with primary and secondary schooling, then human capital is created at initial stage. Highly developed countries have a long history of providing free or highly-subsidized education to the poor.

Social mobility improves through higher education

Movement of individuals or groups in social position is termed as social mobility. It may measure health status, literacy or education and refers to classes, ethnic groups or entire nations. Universally, it refers to individuals or families and their change in income or wealth that is economic mobility.

Higher education is not just a key to find opportunities to transform one's economic condition, but it also holds potential to increase

equality of opportunity and social mobility. Education is a strong driver of social mobility. Educational scores are lower in less equal countries and so the social mobility may also be reduced there.

Countries that have higher levels of income inequality also have lower levels of social mobility. Children of highly paid people are more likely to be paid highly and children of low paid people are more likely to be low earners.

It has also been proven through studies that if students overcome the admission barriers, then young people from a low socio-economic background could bridge the gaps to complete their academic studies and also reach successful positions with potential salaries.

With the transfer of technology, requirement for knowledgeable managers and engineers keep rising. They need to know how to operate new machines or get to the production practices effectively, so that they can lend this knowledge to the human capital.

Having known that education plays a pivotal role in securing economic growth and social progress and also in improving income distribution, India has made progress in terms of increasing primary education attendance rate. It has also made significant improvement in expanding literacy to approximately two thirds of the population.

Challenges to be Faced

An additional 280 million jobs will be required by 2019, as per the latest report of International Labour Organization (ILO). It thus demands from policymakers to ensure that right frameworks and incentives are created.

This can be handled through robust education systems. An education system that is fortified with qualified, professionally trained, motivated and well-supported teachers will prove to be the foundation stone of this initiative.

On the other hand, returns from schooling are high on average and so better information is required for such students who don't perform

well. They need greater support networks which can help them complete their tertiary level education.

Moreover, there are children who remain out of the school and they are the hardest to reach. Many of them have no means to connect to the outside world as they are held back by conflict, disaster or epidemics.

With the rapidly changing workplaces and workplace requirements, students need the skills of 21st century. These skills include critical thinking, problem solving, creativity and digital literacy. Thus, it is required that learners of all ages are well-equipped with these technologies so that they can cope with the demanding occupational requirements. Investments by government and state entities are thus required in technological education in early stages of education.

Governments working with parent and teacher associations on one hand and with private sector and civil society organizations, on the other hand, will be the best way to find a concrete solution to quality education.

New partnerships must be welcomed and innovations must be appreciated and encouraged. Here comes the role of physical capital that is money. Also, human capital and physical capital are complementary. National income is both directly and indirectly affected by education. So, besides putting in the needful resources for building up educational infrastructure, political will is also a prerequisite.

The least developed countries indeed require financial aid, but aid alone cannot replace domestic-resource mobilization. The national governments should better take the responsibility of providing citizens with a quality education. Everyone at global and national level needs to come together to intensify the efforts of bringing the poorest and hardest to reach children into the education system.

With many countries closing in on gender parity at the primary level, the future of providing every boy and girl with primary education seems clear. It's time to redouble all of our efforts and finish what we have started.

It also has to be ensured that girls aren't kept at home when they reach puberty and are rather allowed to complete education on same footing as their male counterparts.

We must acknowledge that those societies and countries that have succeeded in achieving gender parity in education have shown to reap considerable benefits concerning to equality, health and job creation.

Higher Education in India since Independence: UGC and its Approach



Education is the strength of every country. Success of the nations is inevitably determined by their education systems. Since independence, India is contentiously progressing in the education field. There have been both enormous challenges and immense opportunities to overcome these challenges in order to make higher education system much better.

India's Higher Education sector has witnessed a tremendous increase in the number of Universities and Colleges since independence. With enactment of 'Right to Education Act', which laments free and compulsory education to all children within the age groups of 6-14 years, has brought about a staggering change in the higher education system of the country. Today private sector promotes over 60% of higher education institutions in India. This has led to accelerated establishment of institutes, making India home to the largest number of higher education institutions in the world. The number of Universities has increased from 20 in 1950 to 789 as of February 2017. Despite these numbers, Indian institutes find no place within the best by international education rating agencies. Sudden increase in number has failed India to produce world class universities.

UGC and its Functioning

University Grants Commission (UGC) is a statutory body that was established in 1956 through Parliament enacted law to play a pivotal role in the education sector. Besides co-ordination and evaluation, it is responsible for maintaining standards of higher education in India. UGC funded through Ministry of human resources (MHRD) is responsible for establishing central universities and recognizing

Deemed to be Universities run by privately funded trusts and Universities established by the 28 Federal State governments across India. UGC has established statutory Councils to promote, provide grants, set standards which float through the entire structure of higher education system in India.

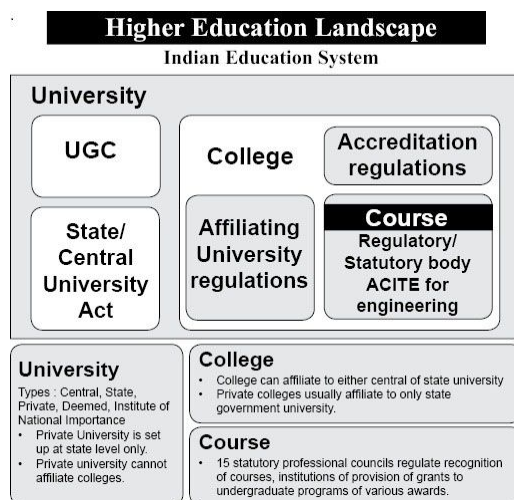


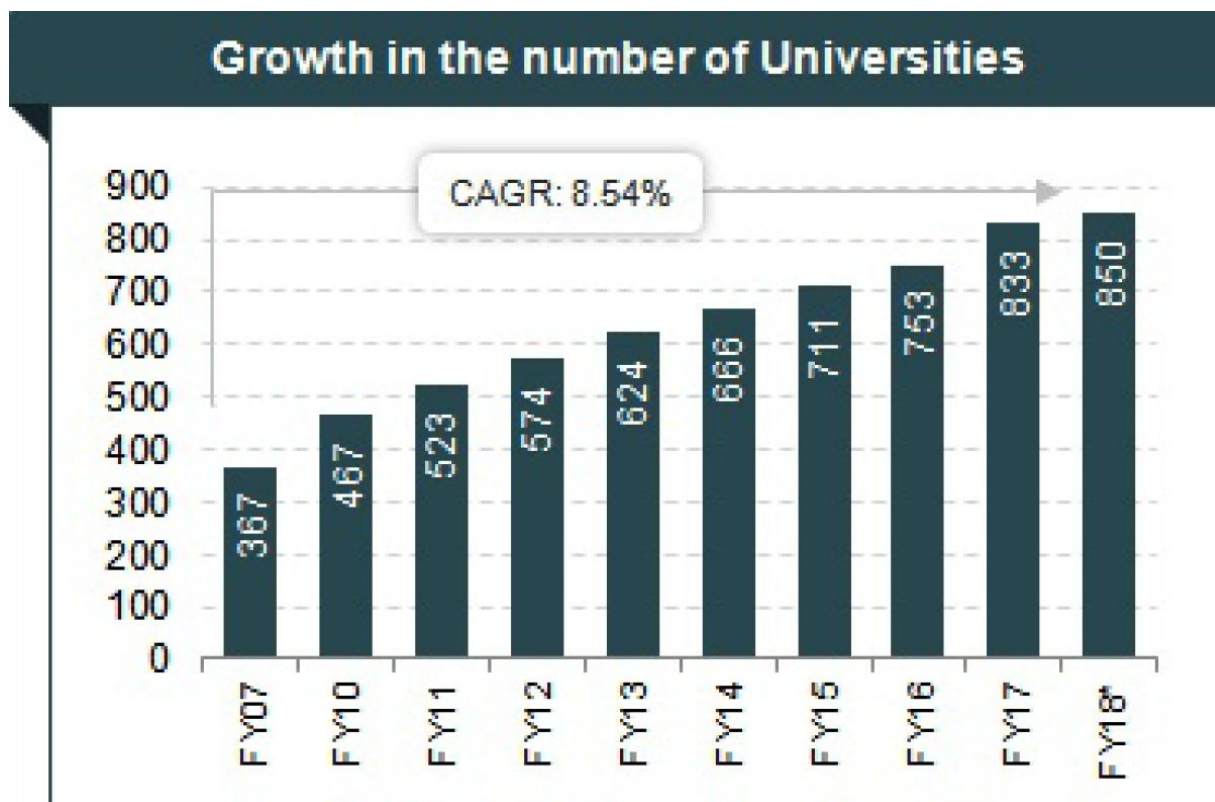
Figure 1 explains the overall structure of higher Education system in India:

UGC and its educational development plans

There were 27 universities at the beginning of the 1st plan. The number increased to 32 by the end of the plan. The number of students increased to 7.20 lakhs receiving university education in 772 colleges. But the rapid increase of colleges as well as students greatly affected the standards of education. For improving the quality of higher education and discouraging wastage and stagnation of unqualified students, various measures were undertaken by the UGC under second plan. The measures included that the institution of three year degree courses, improvement of buildings, laboratories, libraries, provision of hostel facilities, organisation of seminars, stipends and scholarships and increase in salaries of university teachers. In the third plan of UGC, various facilities were provided to divert students to vocational and technological education. Despite the measures taken by UGC, education system is still facing enormous challenges in the line of growth in higher education domain.

UGC and Challenges in Higher Education in India

It is our 72nd year of independence and still our education system has not been developed fully. Today, we see our country flourishing with a huge number of universities and colleges. The increase in number has become more of a problem than an advantage to the education system. The widespread of number of colleges and universities makes it difficult to monitor the quality of education. Recent years have shown a steep growth in the number of colleges. Despite the growth in number, we are not able to list a single university in top 100 universities of the world. The figure shows growth in increased number of Universities in India from 2007 to 2018:



Source: UGC, PWC, AISHE 2016-17

UNIVERSITY GRANTS COMMISSION

Total No. of Universities in the Country as on 01.11.2019

Universities	Total No.
State Universities	404

Deemed to be Universities	126
Central Universities	50
Private Universities	340
Total	920

UGC has been working continuously on quality education in higher education sector. Still, we are facing lot of problems and challenges in our education system. One of such problems is Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) and growing (CAGR) compound Annual Growth rate of colleges at the same time. GER of India in higher education is only 15% and CAGR of universities is 8.54%. Increase of enrolments at school level has made it difficult for higher education institutes to meet the growing demand in the country. Second problem is compromised quality of education. However, government is continuously focusing on the quality education but still large number of colleges and universities are unable to meet the minimum standards laid down by the UGC. Faculty shortages and failure of state educational system to retain efficient teachers pose challenges to quality education. Despite lots of vacancies, a large number of NET/ PhD candidates are unemployed or underemployed which is the biggest blow to the higher education system. As a result of increased number of affiliated colleges, the burden of administrative functions of universities has significantly increased and resulted in the dilution of the core focus on academics and research.

Opportunities in Higher Education

India is a country of estimated youth population of around 150 million aged between 18 to 23 years. During the last seven decades, India has made tremendous growth in terms of number of colleges and universities. Higher Education sector offers immense investment opportunities in both non-regulated and regulated segments. If India's huge population is properly educated, and knowledge is imparted using advanced digital teaching and learning tools, then it will emerge as one of the most developed nations in the world. This engagement

is the source to strengthen relationships by increasing participation in platforms (seminars and conferences) which enables debate and dialogue on international platform.

Higher education in 2018

The Rashtriya Uchchatar Shiksha Abhiyan (RUSA) focusing on equity, access and excellence in higher education has observed very slow progress of below 25% in terms of fund utilisation. It is estimated that more than 1,000 additional universities are needed in the country to achieve the gross enrolment ratio (GER) target of 30% by 2022. On one hand, there is a stern competition to get admission in top notch institutions, on the other hand, many institutions are unable to meet students expectations and have to revisit their models to improve the quality. The government's push with initiative like grooming 20 universities as "Institutions of Eminence" is a welcome step. This will enable Indian institutions to compete on a global level and enter the elite list of top 100 world institutes. Along with it, the present govt has announced to replace UGC with HECI.

Replacement of UGC

The Human Resource Development (HRD) ministry is likely to pilot the Higher Education Commission of India Act 2018 in the Parliament. Enactment of HECI brings in provisions to 'mentor' deficient institutes. If HECI is able to break out of the UGC shell and bring in practical solutions, it will have a great impact on higher education. Apart from this major development, education sector requires many reforms which can further give direction to expansion of facilities, quality part-time education, post-graduate education and research, education of women and inter-university collaborations. Steps taken to reform the system of education should be directed to bring the change that is relevant to the existing ecosystem.

Education is the process that brings head, heart and mind together and thus enables a person to develop an all round personality bringing out the best in him or her. There is no denying the fact that

India is facing a great deal of challenges in various sectors but to tackle these challenges, a planned boost to higher education is of utmost important. UGC has played a significant role in India since independence. With passage of time, many limitations crawled into the system making the impact limited. Introduction of reformed committee HECI seems to be a new ray of hope to take India education system to new dimensions universally. Educational progress has the utmost potential to achieve the future endeavours.

Education is a Weapon that Can Change the World



“Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world.”

-Nelson Mandela

Education plays an important role in transforming the lives of people. It is not just concerned with academic learning and does not restrict itself to textbooks, but extends itself to include the application of values, knowledge and skills that have been acquired by the individual over the years. Education can bring changes in the world in two ways, i.e. through the empowerment of individuals and the generation of knowledge. Byproducts of education in the form of empowerment and knowledge generation are the most powerful weapons that can change the world in different and effective ways.

Education can bridge the socio-economic divide that is present in our society as it equips the people with necessary skills and abilities that would help them to strive for themselves and to provide themselves with the basic necessities of life. In addition to this, education can be used as a tool to eradicate poverty. Education that targets marginalised and poor populations will bring change to many of the systemic factors that have contributed to the delay in poor communities' development and can prevent the transmission of poverty between generations. Acquiring basic skills such as reading, writing and numeracy have a documented positive effect on the income of the marginalised sections. Furthermore, poverty can be eliminated by promoting equality of opportunity, which is provided only when everyone is given a chance to get educated.

Education can bring changes in the health profile of an individual, family, society, nation and mankind all over the world. Researchers found that there is a 50% chance of an educated mother to protect herself and her children from illnesses if she is educated and it is more likely that her child could survive past age five. Education works as a guide to awaken people and make them more aware of the causes of various diseases. Education creates weapons like doctors who cure these diseases. Moreover, a better education ensures that people are more aware of the repercussions of various illnesses and diseases.

According to the World Bank report on Civil War, it is estimated that the risk of war reduced considerably with an increase in education. This is because education inculcates the practice of independent thinking that leads to the creation of new ideas. Independent thinkers do not blindly follow the beliefs of others and draw their own conclusion on issues related to the world. Any problem being faced by the world can be resolved practically and logically with the help of these individuals. Equipped with impeccable communication skills, educated individuals will not be hesitant to work with groups to solve a plethora of problems. Therefore, education fosters peace.

Not only this, education has made a huge difference to the lives of disabled people. Education equips these students with increased levels of confidence and problem solving abilities. By being a part of an educational institution, children learn to understand the differences and similarities between people in the real world. They learn to respect and appreciate diversity as they interact with students of differing abilities and cultures. It helps them to forge new friendships with people as they gain social skills. Education helps them to develop a positive understanding of themselves and others.

India, being a patriarchal society, is still plagued by a number of issues. The practices of female foeticide, female infanticide, child marriage, dowry and child trafficking still exist. Female children are looked down upon due to the inferior status that has been attached to

them since centuries. One of the few ways to eradicate these practices is by educating the masses and making them more literate. They need to be made aware of the fact that when women are provided an equal opportunity to live and get educated, they can succeed in life as well and not become a “burden”.

Education also has a positive impact on women empowerment as it equips the female population with an increased level of confidence and rationality that helps them to fulfil a number of economic, social and cultural functions which can in turn bridge the gender gap, along with the socio-economic hierarchy that persists in society. Through education, women can respond effectively to opportunities and challenge the traditional roles that have been assigned to them. An educated woman can contribute towards the betterment of society by challenging the mal-traditions targeting women. By providing women equal opportunity to get educated, she will feel more motivated to bring about change in society. An educated woman is a guiding light for her children, family members and society as she knows how to live a happy family life and promote healthy relations with others.

Food insecurity, under-education and poverty form a vicious cycle in developing countries. People with a minimum level of education can capture and elaborate information better, as compared to their uneducated counterparts. Education plays a key role in accessing public information, especially concerning health, nutrition and hygiene. By acquiring education, individuals can follow a proper and diversified diet along with good hygiene practices that can help reduce morbidity and mortality. Education is fundamental to promote agency which expresses the capacity of rural poor to escape from poverty and hunger with their own power. The people get benefitted from education due to increased levels of rationality that enables them to judiciously use the resources they possess. Education also leads to an increase in agricultural productivity and efficiency and benefit economically from a number of non-farm activities.

Education also has a positive impact in the realm of climate change and environmental degradation. It equips the younger generations with skills that will help in combating climate change while instilling the philosophy of sustainable development. Education has the power to show the youth of the world that they have wider responsibilities and are entitled to make decisions regarding the environment in which they have to live. The youth can realise their responsibilities only when they are adequately educated about the consequences of climate change and environmental degradation. Only educated individuals can suggest sensible and practical mitigation measures and strategies. In addition to this, educated individuals are more aware of the disasters and calamities that can occur at any given time and are better prepared to face it as they are aware of the effective response mechanisms that can be employed.

The developing third world countries have been the chief benefactors of primary and elementary education. Educating the masses guarantees the eradication of a number of problems being faced by these nations. Many developing nations such as Africa have immensely benefitted through education even when they have not achieved a hundred percent literacy rate. Education leads to improved health, positive economic growth and political stability in these improved countries. It also leads to rational and logical thinking during decision making through proper contribution of the society in general and nation in particular.

Education is the most powerful weapon that can change the world and make it a better place. Every nation will reach its zenith when education and equality of opportunity is provided to all. It equips the youth with employable skills that can help them in shaping their lives. In addition to this, it has transformed the lives of women and disabled people, all around the world, by empowering them and educating them about their rights. Therefore, education is the tool that can make everything possible and correct all the wrongs that plague the world.

Right to Education - Challenges & Prospects



The basic right of education is a universal human right. It promotes individual freedom and empowerment. Education is the only instrument through which economically backward children are able to uplift themselves out of poverty and take complete part as citizens. United Nations and the UNESCO have laid down international legal obligations for the right to education. These obligations enable in promoting and developing the right of every person to enjoy access to good quality education without discrimination or exclusion. As per these norms the government must fulfil their legal and political duties of providing good quality education for all and to effectively implement and monitor the educational plans.

The Eighty-sixth Amendment Act inserted Article 21-A into the Constitution of India to provide free and compulsory education to all children from the age group of six to fourteen years as a fundamental right. The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE), Act, 2009 envisages that every child has the right to full time elementary education of satisfactory and equitable quality in a formal school.

The Right to Education was passed on 4th August, 2009 and came into action from 1st April, 2010. India had passed the Right to Education Act after sixty-two years of her independence. This Act incorporates in it the words “free” and “compulsory”. Free education defines itself as the type of education where no child shall be liable to pay any kind of fee or charges which may prevent him/her from pursuing and completing elementary education. This does not

however apply to a child who has been admitted by his/her parents to a school which is not supported by the appropriate government.

The basic right of child education as provided by the RTE specifies the duties and responsibilities of appropriate government, local authorities and even parents in allowing free and compulsory education. It lays down particular norms relating to student teacher ratios, buildings and infrastructure, school working days, working hours of the teachers, etc. It provides for a rational deployment of teachers in schools by ensuring that the specified student teacher ratio is maintained in each school. This is to ensure that there is no urban-rural imbalance in postings.

This Act strictly prohibits physical punishment and mental harassment, screening procedures for admission of children, capitation fee, private tuition by teachers and running of schools without recognition. It also provides for development of syllabus synchronous with the values enshrined in the constitution and which would ensure the all-round development of the child, building on the child's knowledge, potentiality and talent.

According to a UNESCO-2010 Education for All Global Monitoring Report, still, there are around eight million children in the age group of six-fourteen years out of school in India and the majority of them are girls.

Unfortunately it has been seen in recent reports that till date no state has met the basic RTE norms of trained teachers, infrastructure requirements or pupil-teacher ratio. The Right to Education Act's implementation has also remained grossly unfunded. The student enrolment has although improved, the quality of education still remains to reach the notch of the desired. The state governments have also been lax on their part in implementing the RTE. There are still lakhs of untrained teachers and posts vacant across the nation. Much to the surprise and very much against the Act, it is observed that there is only a single teacher in one among nine schools. It is

reported that only one in twelve schools comply with the RTE norms and often the basic requirements like classrooms, toilets, drinking water and boundary walls are not in place. There are still eight percent of habitations in India that do not have a school within three kilometres; seven percent children in slums do not have a school within one kilometre and twelve percent of schools do not have all-weather roads leading to them. The right to education also remains a dream for millions of children from the tribal and minority communities and in conflict zones.

It has been of late come to notice that the Supreme Court has sought reports from all states and union territories on a petition against the violation of the RTE Act. The petition has also appealed proper implementation of the Act. Despite all flaws, the Right to Education Act is a ground breaking law enforced by the Government of India. It is a formidable law in granting the children their fundamental right. The day seems not far away when we will realize total educational development by implementing it in replete.

Importance of Value Education



“Values’ the term may sound small but it covers a lot of aspects. We all hear about how this term defines a human being, but do we actually know what it means? Values are the principles that help in improving the quality of our life and society as well. They summarize the do’s and don’ts of proper code of conduct and behaviour. They are the fundamentals of how one’s character and personality shapes up. Values that originate from within our hearts such as love, compassion, empathy, tolerance, sympathy, etc. define our external behaviour. But in today’s fast paced world, values have lost their essence. It is important to instil in humans that valuables are priced but the values are priceless.

There is an ever increasing need of value education to bring back humanity in the human race. Value education is the process by which values are transmitted in people. This education begins from your home and can also be taken at schools, colleges, seminars, youth organisations, and religious organisations and even in jails. Value education is inculcated in human beings by two approaches - first is when people learn and grasp a set of values that come from societal or religious rules or cultural ethics. Second is when people examine their surroundings, environment and people and realise on their own what is the correct ethical behaviour that is good for themselves as well as the society. It can be conducted as a seminar or an activity in any organisation and system wherein people who are older, experienced and in a position of authority assess and evaluate unambiguously the values that underline their and others behaviour, determining the effectiveness of such values and associated

behaviour for their own and society's long term general well-being and inculcating the ones that are more effective and useful for everyone. Nowadays people have become more materialistic. In a bid to earn and possess more wealth, they are compromising on their values, principles, character and honesty. This has resulted in flagrant and rampant corruption, immorality, illegitimate activities and violence, which is gradually destroying the foundation of our society, country and world. Thus, there is an immediate need to re-introduce the education dealing specifically with human values. There is an urgent need to fabricate an education system which also focuses on values, morals and life skills that build the basic structure of humanity.

The best time to start with value education is at the very tender age when a child's mind is like soft clay and can be moulded to any desired shape. Thus, adolescence is the best time and age to impart value education so that the correct impressions formed in the child's mind can guide him throughout his life. Values define the thin line between good and bad. Human values can be easily evoked in a child in his school where he spends a maximum of eight hours by making him "experience" and "live" the values. Love is the most substantial facet in implementing the value education in three ways: the independent approach, the integrated approach, and the subtle approach. Children learn more by observing, perceiving, experiencing and their intuition, instead of being told or taught about values. They grasp and assimilate the nuances of codes of behaviour from their immediate environment at home and school. Thus parents and teachers need to present themselves as efficient role models if they want the child to develop good moral values and character. It is them whom the children look up for guidance.

Realising how important it is to instil values in children at an early age, schools should emphasize on value education as part of their curriculum. And for that, trained educators and teachers should be hired who are specialized to provide values through various fun activities and games. It is essential to always have the teachers of high esteem and moral. The self-respect of the teachers should be

supported strongly by the society. Then no doubt it is possible to inculcate these values effectively as per expectations.

Over the last few years in Maharashtra, efforts are being made at all levels to inculcate these values. Maharashtra Government introduced paripath in all schools. Paripath is a morning prayer in the beginning of school day which consisted of national anthem, pledge, devotional songs, moral stories, good thoughts, news, maun, etc. The teachers were of the view that paripath is essential and impact of moral stories is more effective. Even some positive changes in the behaviour of the students were observed. In another study undertaken, it is observed that co-curricular activities which are necessary for inculcation of values are arranged in most of schools but rarely arranged in colleges and at the university level. In another survey based upon the study of value education through co-curricular activities in Jalna district and on the basis of findings of this survey following recommendations were made:

1. Cultural education must be included as a component.
2. The teacher trainees should be cultural resource and should have a proper background of history, culture and artistic heritage of that area.
3. A networking of institution involved in such activities is essential to maintain high standard of training such as CCRT, NCERT, SCERT.
4. As moral education is introduced in the first period in the timetable, grade should be given for the assessment of value education.

To achieve the expected goal it becomes highly essential to concentrate on important aspects namely the teachers, the administrators and the society.

In our country, several religious organisations like Sathya Sai Organization, Art of Living, Brahma Kumaris, etc. have initiated many value education programmes. Here, irrespective of the religion and culture, universal values like honesty, trust, responsibility,

compassion, etc. are given utmost importance. These organisations are secular in their approach. NCERT has set up a National Resource Centre for Value Education (NRCVE) for promoting value education in schools or in the form of informal or formal classes.

Upcoming Careers – Turning Passions into Professions

Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—I took the one less travelled by,
And that has made all the difference.

—Robert Frost

One who habitually wastes energy in regretting any choice made: belatedly but wistfully he sighs over the attractive alternative rejected. If the choice goes wrong, the entire life is not sufficient to cover the lost ground. But this is ironical that despite the change in the entire thought process in the sphere of choosing a right career, Indian students stumble here and there. The coming of liberalisation and globalisation brought some unexpected challenges for which the archaic mindset of our students and scholars was not prepared. Many unheard and new professions are coming up. We need to be open and ready to accept the superimposing stress to make a perfect choice.

Proper guidance and skill developing is the mantra to achieve success if not today, tomorrow must. Gone are the days when it was a Holy Grail for almost every Indian parent: that their son or daughter go to medical college, become a doctor or take up a career in Engineering. On one hand, medical profession has become a pitiless, mercenary profession, money ripping vocation where doctors treat patients as revenue generators rather than human beings; keep patients in hospital longer than necessary to bill them more, order needless tests to generate profits. On the other hand, more than a million students graduating out of India's engineering colleges run the risk of being unemployed. At this junction, young population of the country tends to move in the pursuit of new career options.

Career opportunities are no longer an issue in the twenty first century. There are no limitations to what one can do. In fact, the basic challenge that one faces when making career decisions these days is to choose from the spectrum of career opportunities that are available. The very first question that arises is that, "How does one even begin to explore career options that satisfy the heart and soul as well as the wallet?" What opportunities are out there? Surprisingly, it is not as important to know about the market strategies involved as it is to know about yourself.

With the advent of career options in the field of Accountancy, Banking, Programming, Animation, Sports and Entertainment, any aspirant has access to a huge variety of career opportunities to choose from, you can even find appropriate resources and the required funding to pursue the career of your choice.

It has become a prerequisite for every company to maintain a book of accounts and they depend on CAs and CFAs to keep their books handy for the audit and for financial planning. Thus a wizard at accounts and numbers has phenomenal job options at his hand. A career in coding and programming is as enthralling as it sounds. As the computing business matures, any programmer can obtain high salary. A software programmer offering SAP services can easily fetch up to 12 lakhs per annum.

The animation industry across globe has shown signs of splendid growth. Blockbuster movies such as Kung Fu Panda, The Chronicles of Narnia, Wall-E, Coraline, Up, Bolt, Ice Age and Monsters vs. Aliens are striking examples of the miracle that is animation. Indians too are opening up to exploring such lucrative career options.

This is the right time to make your passions, your profession.

BPOs and KPOs have thrown open exciting job opportunities to youngsters in India. This is a field that has employed thousands of professionals and given them international working environment with great salary packages. An unforeseen boom in the advertising and fashion industry has created a huge and continual demand for fresh models. Every company needs glamorous models to start and

endorse a variety of products or to flash the creations of fashion designers. Moreover modelling is a very alluring field with innumerable opportunities to travel and earn handsome money. Models also get to meet people from different walks of life. An established model can get a handsome pay for every assignment they do. All these aspects have made modelling a desirable, attractive and lucrative career for the youth in our country. Students are showing tremendous interest in biotechnology. The primary reason behind this interest emerges from the fact that the technical and procedural application of biotechnology touches a vast array of disciplines. This in turn opens a lot many job portals for students who are seeking a stable career in their lives. Biotechnology along with its many sub-fields finds uses in so many applications that many new fields have and are being derived from within it.

Public Relations is a career avenue for those who have excellent soft skills and who wish to pursue a career that offers an opportunity to interact with lots of interesting people. This is a profession where you need to understand the listener's psyche and mould it in your favour.

Earlier, the traditional role of a company secretary was limited to providing support to the board of directors and managing administrative affairs of an organisation. However, the horizon of the roles and responsibilities of company secretary has expanded exponentially. Apart from their traditional tasks, company secretaries now have to take care of corporate governance and even legal matters of a company. As the position of a company secretary has steadily become critical to the smooth functioning of a corporate entity so has the demand for this job profile. In this role, you not only hold a high position in the management hierarchy but your role is highly accountable both within and outside your organisation.

Body art as a craze amongst the crowd and the tattoo industry is gaining much recognition and is blooming fast. The tattoo artist works up to his satisfaction and earns decent. If you love to emote through your voice, then the career of Voice over Artist is the best option for you. The most interesting aspect of this career is that you get to live a new character every day. As an interior designer, you will be trained to design exclusive furniture artefacts and fittings besides learning

managerial skills. With the help of a course in interior designing, you will come out with a professional designing solution that is efficient, eye-catching and at the same time safe. In the IT sector, blogging is emerging as a lucrative profession for students having flair to write with original and innovative way. Increasing popularity and tremendous financial benefit calls for image consultants to fill the huge space.

Jewellery industry calls for innovative computer savvy gemmologists. Equally potent is a career for a jewellery designer.

Opportunities have never been so ripe. The opening up of new avenues has also widened the arenas that are yet to be explored.

This is the right time to make your passion, your profession.

SECTION-J: SOCIETY & CULTURE

Impact of the Internet in Creating Informative Society is Dangerous for India's Rich Culture



Internet is an example of how technology has grown over the years. Internet has made the world smaller and closer. It has resulted in creating a more technology-friendly and informative society. Society has always been accepting of the new technologies that come. Internet is one such technology. People across the globe have accepted this with open arms. This is the reason for its tremendous growth over the years. Internet is a connection of networks joined together. It can be accessed on computers, smartphones and other supporting devices. It is a tool which has brought the world closer. It has become the most useful way of communication as it connects you to various social networking sites.

The internet and mobile technology has transformed the way people interact, work and learn. It is impacting our lives in every possible way. People are using this technology to stay connected, study about anything by searching on the search engines like Google.com, produce their own music, blog their thoughts, sell online, publish their work, create a website and talk also using video and voice calls over internet. It is an important tool used by companies across the globe to indulge in e-commerce and do marketing. It is through this medium that they are able to reach to a larger customer base.

The internet is like an addictive drug. With so much to learn, search and know from the internet, people are glued to it throughout the day. They are hands on with the latest news and updates from across the world. Banking sector too is totally dependent upon it to conduct

transactions and provide services of e-banking. This technological advancement has become the bare necessity for people in both developing and developed nations.

But does this technology teach one to respect and value each other? The answer certainly is NO. With the boons comes the bane too. The internet might be helpful in creating an informative society but it is drifting us from our basic value system. With the large number of people involved, the growth of technology affects how it is used and sometimes misused.

Internet has played a crucial role in globalisation process. Interchange of world views and ideas are very easy and quick using this service. This has to an extent also been reflected in the Indian culture. With the emergence and spread of internet, the deep rooted traditions and customs have been shaken up. India is known for its rich cultural background and pride of its culture is famous across the globe. People from around the world visit India to get a flavour of its culture. Internet has also helped in spreading cultural impact globally. So, if westernisation has touched India through the internet and globalisation, Indian culture too has touched the parts of the world via the same route. Any geographical region is defined by its culture and traditions which hold a great importance in respect of its uniqueness. This is also the differentiating factor for a population of one geographic boundary from another. The charm of Indian culture has somehow been disturbed to varying degrees in lieu of internet creating an informative society.

Indian culture is known for its rich heritage, resources and warm hospitality. Diversity in aspects of religion, food, tradition, customs, music, art, architecture is prevalent and bundled into a single unit of patriotism and unity. Irrespective of being so different, Indians are the same in their mindset of greeting and celebrating in a united way with tremendous love, affection and togetherness. The rich essence of the Indian culture makes it a hotspot for tourists from around the world who want to have a taste of it. However, when the culture of India is analysed with the internet and globalisation point of view, many loop

holes can be noticed with Indian culture being amalgamated with western influence. Thus, internet certainly has proven to be dangerous for the rich tradition and culture of India.

With internet becoming the new rage, the joint family culture of India has greatly suffered with nuclear families mushrooming throughout the country. The country is becoming metropolitan day by day and the values of patience with grandparents and elders are vanishing resulting in old age homes developing at a fast pace. Institution of marriage has also lost its significance in the Indian culture with rising number of divorces and extra-marital affairs. This is a direct repercussion of social media being so handy because of internet. Live-in relationships are also a result of this. The breakout of restrictions and adultery has spoiled the Indian mindsets. Internet is an easy way to access adultery which is being reflected in increasing number of rape and sexual abuse cases in the country because of the perverted minds which indulge in the illegal act of watching adultery online.

Indians are also losing the social values of greeting and celebrating. The interaction among people is becoming more diplomatic on the basis of their financial status. They are happy celebrating a westernised concept of Valentine Day instead of Diwali or Holi which are considered auspicious in Indian culture. Internet has also put an effect on the language of the people in the country. Hindi, the popular language of the country is taking a back seat and foreign languages like English, Spanish, French and German are coming upfront. People are learning the basics of these languages using the Internet. Westernisation through the internet in terms of food and clothing can also be seen. Pastas and Noodles are more enjoyed by people instead of their regional and staple food. Packaged food has taken over the entire Indian market. The change in clothing is also a distraction for the perverted minded people. Indians were predominantly involved in agriculture. But with internet paving the way for globalisation, MNCs culture has set up in India offering lucrative deals and employment opportunities to large number of manpower in the country.

Internet has played a major part in impacting the rich cultural heritage of our country. The impact has rather been alarming. Internet is a technology and should thus be only used when required. It should be used to spread awareness about the beauty of diversity which the country has to offer rather than getting foreign values imbibed. Thus, we as responsible citizens of the country need to be more cautious with the globalisation and westernisation which are the result of internet preserving the pride and maintaining the cultural prestige of the country.

Only the Youth can Make 21st Century the 'Century of Peace'



The 21st century is characterised by globalisation and urbanisation. The world today is becoming more technologically advanced and highly integrated. The world is also becoming smaller and fragmented. With people lacking unity, it is a less peaceful and unsafe world for the current and future generations. Sustainability in terms of peace and love needs to be nurtured so that the future generations can also live in harmony and comfort. In today's scenario, the nations of the world are fighting for their own selfish good. The environment across the globe is highly heated with tensions, stress, violence, diminishing moral values, reduced tolerance, injustices and no respect for human rights. Countries are making war and the gun culture is at its peak in most of the developing countries. At the receiving end of all this chaos, is the youth of the present and future who deserve a peaceful and better quality of life.

For any country, its youth is one of its richest resources. They define the growth of any nation by developing a universal acceptance of integrity, personal discipline and open mindedness. Youth is the time when passion, emotions, activities and vigour are at their peak. They are ready to take on the world. They have an opinion and do not shy away from expressing it. They are liberal but can also be rigid. They know the language of black or white and are not sugar-coated to see things around the globe becoming worse. The educated youth can be considered the richest wealth of the world. They can take their stand and know what is right and what is wrong. They are upfront and selfless enough to think about the issues which need attention on the

priority basis. As they constitute the frontline positions of all the nations, their inputs in development programmes are highly useful in achieving desired objectives. The issue which needs utmost attention of youth at the moment is 'World Peace'. In the 21st century, only the youth can make it as a century of peace.

Youth are rational in their approach. They are practical and do not believe in putting things for the next day. They are quick in their actions and are open to change. To create a culture of peace and conflict free environment, only the youth can lead as they are susceptible to changing their beliefs, attitude towards people, traditions and cultures. The youth can achieve their goal of peace making by 'BECOMING THE CHANGE'. Youth have the advantage over their older counterparts who are rigid and inflexible. The power of youth can be multiplied manifold, if they learn to combine their enthusiasm with patience, realising the importance of living together and to defend the frontiers of non-violence and peace.

Efforts should be made at mass level to enhance the leadership and decision making quality of the youth. They should understand their leadership capacity by educating themselves on the need for community leaderships. Youth living in rural and backward areas should also be channelised, trained and educated by conducting various leadership development programmes. These programmes will make the youth to become more vocal and aware as the lack of knowledge about basic decision-making often acts as hurdle in the road to progress and thus results in conflicts.

Youth have the advantage of creating connections with the young and old. They can play an active role in making world a peaceful place by forming a troop of peace missionaries with likeminded and eager people to join in their process. NGO networks can also be developed to work at the grassroot level such as to educate the children of today build their values and spiritually awaken them about their responsibility towards the world.

In the backward countries with prevalent ethnicity and lack of education, youth belonging to different ethnic groups can build up links between cultural minorities and popularise shared values, traditions and culture which have been handed over from generations to generations. They can be trained and educated to eradicate the incidents and acts of violence. To ensure good governance, accountability, citizen participation and transparency in the system, the youth should come forth and engage and join political awareness building programmes. By being in the bureaucracy, they can easily get their voices heard at a larger scale. More participation of youth in the political system of the country will bring in the desired change at a larger prospect.

On the international front, the youth can join hands with peace-making organisations like United Nations and others and become peace ambassadors of their respective countries. This can be a great platform for promoting exchange programmes in education, sports and games, culture, science and technology and in tourism promotions to link all the youth of the country and the world in pursuit and maintenance of peace. Peace-making programmes and seminars should be conducted across the world at various levels to justify non-violence and learning about the skills to deal with matters of conflict in non-violent ways.

The Youth is the leader of today and tomorrow. In this era of globalisation, the youth can act as the vehicle to transport the socio-economic shared values of freedom, equity and solidarity, tolerance, non-violence, respect for nature and shared responsibility. The youth have the dreams and a vision, the social media and the influence to promote peace and make a positive change in the world. To reflect peace in the world, the value of unity and solidarity should also be inculcated such that the people understand that they owe respect to the world and the universe on the whole of which they are a part of. The day they start to appreciate the little things and get them out of the so-called rat race to be on the top of the materialistic world, they

will succeed in making the 21st century tolerant, conflict-free, peaceful and united.

Marriage - An Institution of Great Social Relevance



“Marriages are like fingerprints; each one is different and each one is beautiful”

—Maggie Reyes

Maggie Reyes’ quote defines the beauty and depth of one of the most important social institutions of human society - MARRIAGE. It is a universal phenomenon that brings two persons together in a bond of love and relationship. It has been the backbone of human civilisation. For years, people around the world are getting married and producing babies. Certainly, before the concept of marriage was developed, man and woman lived together, produced babies and moved on similar to how animals and birds do. Marriage comes forth to formalise the union of man and woman. However, the institution of marriage has also developed gradually. Now, it has been accepted as a measure of social discipline and as a manoeuvre to eliminate social stress due to the sex rivalry.

Human beings have various body urges. Hunger, thirst and sex top these basic body needs. To satisfy these urges, society has worked out certain rules and regulations. The rules relating to the sexual life of human beings have been encompassed in the institution of marriage. It can be rightly said that marriage regulates the sex life of human beings and paves way for starting of family. Sex is generally considered a taboo in the society. But marriage culminates it into family. Marriage and family go hand in hand. With marriage, comes the family. Marriage and family are both vital institutions which form the base of our society and are of great social relevance. However,

dynamics of marriage is dependent upon culture, attitude, beliefs and behaviour of the persons involved in it.

Marriage is effectively rooted socially. Different cultures have different ancestral standards which are prevalent since many generations. Culture, assets, dynamics and ethics all play a crucial role in shaping of family beliefs. The bond created by marriage consents a sexual relationship especially in countries where having sex before marriage is a sin. Marriage becomes a basis of having children in such cultures as having babies outside of marriage and fornication is considered a taboo. It is thus obligatory for them to grow a family. However in western countries, more importance is given to love. According to their culture and belief, personal happiness is of utmost importance and if anyone is not happy in their marriage, they are free to move out. This is also the reason why the percentage of divorce in these countries is higher. Marriage not only has a social significance but also has physiological role. Married couples across the globe are healthier, happier and enjoy longer lives. The rate of depression and heart related issues is also lower in married people. They also have a positive outlook towards life which reflects in their parenting too. Thus marriage creates social, economic and effective conditions to raise children with effective parenting.

After marriage, the lives of man and woman change personally and socially. With marriage, they enter into a new life where responsibilities and commitment await them. For husbands, they become more caring and responsible to raise their families, caring towards their spouse and more emotionally stable. They tend to become more productive in their work also. For women, marriage brings in a feeling of completeness. They become more giving, happier and emotionally sound. Social support for women increases with the spousal support. Thus marriage changes people's lifestyles and habits in ways which are personally and socially beneficial. Marriage is a "seedbed" of pro-social behaviour.

Some people across different societies and cultures feel that marriage is a social trap. It's all in one's opinion and attitude towards

this institution. Marriage is a tradition that has been going on since ages and will continue to do so. Younger generation nowadays having high ambitions tends to consider a marriage as a blockage in their path to success. While others who are way successful in their careers credit their spouses for their achievements. How one perceives marriage is all in the mind and attitude. 'Why a person chose to get married?' is prominent. If a person is able to answer this question and has clarity about the same in his mind, then it will reflect in his commitment, body language, happiness and living. Answer to this question determines one's personal, social, emotional and economic attributes too.

There is no formula of a happy marriage. If you are happy in your state of being, the person you chose as your life partner will be a repercussion of the same. Society makes rules and regulations but it is the individual and his mindset that moulds these rules according to be happy and content in the institution.

Marriage is a trial and error which one plays throughout with their better half and the society. A marriage of a Hindu man with a Muslim woman may not be acceptable to the society, but if the man and wife are happy and can fight the odds then the society will have no option but to ultimately accept them. Perpetuating hatred in this sacred institution is all a game played in the mind of people defined by the rules that the society makes. The society has moved on from accepting arranged marriages only to now accepting love marriages also.

With generations, the mindset of people is getting broader. Education has brought in the commitment factor in younger people today who are perfectly balancing different areas of their life. A fine sense of balance is created in their work and married life. With time, there has been a change in how people perceive the concept of marriage, but even today it has not lost its social relevance.

The institution of marriage makes the society and not the other way round. Marriage gives the society family and children which forms the foundation of any culture and society. However, it is time now that

people across the globe are more empathetic and liberal towards the concept of union of two people in marriage and start treating both the man and woman equal in this institution. With social acceptance of equality of man and woman in marriage, the divorce rates will decrease considerably and the world will be one happy place to live in.

A Girl Child is an Asset not a Liability



“Don’t be cold, girls are worth more than gold”. This quote has a deep meaning to it. It highlights the two important issues - ‘girls are usually treated coldly’ and that the ‘girls are precious’. Even in today’s day and age with education being the root of so many countries, girl child is still discriminated. It is often sidelined that how a girl child contributes as a daughter, sister, wife, daughter-in-law, mother, mother-in-law, grandmother, granddaughter, etc. She has an important and significant role in the society. Even after she plays all the roles in an efficient manner in the modern society, she is weak because men are still strongest gender of the society.

When a child is born, celebrations follow. Parties are thrown and religious rituals are done to welcome the beautiful new life into the family. Happiness, excitement, enthrallment and tears of joy surround this joyous occasion. However, this environment is seen only if a son is born. Clouds of disappointment can be seen if it’s a girl child. This kind of discrimination still persists in many parts of the globe. The male child is believed to carry forward the family legacy and also take overall responsibility of the family. But with changing times, women have proved their worth and equality. Though, still, many have not accepted this revolution.

Women play a very important role in each and everyone’s lives. They give birth and nurture life on this planet. In a country like India, earlier, girls were considered a liability by the parents. They were not given the love and importance which the son of the house got. They were barred from education and were confined to household jobs of cooking food, cleaning home and taking care of the whole family

alone. But with education and awareness, things are improving slowly. Women across the country have stepped out of their homes and have started taking part in many activities other than family, household chores and kids. They have excelled in all the fields that they have touched. Women are teachers, scientists, presidents, chief ministers, engineers, politicians, drivers and have gone in the space too. You name the field and they are into it. They have broken all the stereotypes and have come a long way.

A woman can be regarded as the basic unit of society. They make up the family, family makes homes, homes constitute a society and finally societies make a country. A girl child is an asset and not a liability. She is dependable and responsible and can take over the world with her panache. Multitasking comes naturally to them. They manage home and outer world and ace all her roles as a friend, daughter, sister, wife and mother. She seldom demands anything in return of her roles. She performs all her roles and responsibilities politely all through her life. She is an epitome of sacrifice. She faces various challenges and sacrifices which she needs to overcome, yet she never complains. A girl tries to make everyone happy at the cost of her own health, happiness and will.

A girl child is the pillar of strength for her family who supports and glues them together. Their moral, emotional and financial support binds everyone in the family. Their point of view and decisions are mostly practical and rational which are helpful in the long run. The strong attitude and will power of girls make them a constant support of encouragement to the family during all the atrocities. Their optimistic nature helps the families to cross biggest tides in the bad times. They are born with a positive aura around them. They bring in light and contentment in the family and strengthen the thread which binds all the relations in the family together. They are honest, loyal and more obedient towards her family. She instils life in her parents and in-laws' house with her sheer presence. She takes care of her parents and in-laws, supports her husband through thick and thin, nurtures her children and makes them able and valuable humans,

manages her work with full devotion. A girl child as a daughter always aims to make her parents proud, she weighs all aspects before taking any major steps for any repercussions may affect her and family. She beholds the family reputation and takes full control over it. Because of the biased norms created by our society, boy's actions are often justified primarily because he is considered superior than girls. His acts of putting a family status and reputation down are under-covered by this disgraceful inequality based on gender.

Even though a girl dons various hats, but the best example of her selfless and giving nature is best described in a mother. She acts as a perfect mentor who justifies how you can be someone's daughter, mother, wife or a sister and still be on the top, professionally, at the same time. They are idols for others from whom you gain moral values that guide you throughout the life. They are perfect as friends and give the best advice always. Her conscience never allows her to disappoint anyone in the family. They are meticulously more responsible towards their family, society and aspirations. They are also mindful of her surroundings, restraints and conditions which make it easy for her to adapt and react.

The girls of the 21st century are way ahead of boys and have gained excellence in every field without any exception. She can balance her personal and professional life with equal ease. They have changed the norm that made men the sole bread earner of the family. An educated girl child is a valuable asset who is no less than any male child. She has more capabilities of conquering the world. Their hard work and dedication helps them in juggling between different roles they play in life. It is time now that the world realise that a girl child is precious. Worth of a girl child needs to be recognised so that the world could become a better place to live in.

Humans Should be Cooperative Rather than Competitive



When asked what works better – cooperation or competition, we would definitely say cooperation. It has also been verified by scientists in hundreds of studies since 1800s, still we find it surprising how big businesses, parents, institutions and our education system go on promoting competition and almost ignore the power of cooperation. But what is important to know and understand is that no human can live or survive in isolation. While competition brings out the ‘beast’ in us; cooperation brings out the ‘best’ in us; as demonstrated by research.

Human nature is both cooperative and competitive depending upon the context. In primitive environment, surviving alone was not feasible and signals like physical pain, hunger, etc. pushed humans to alter undesirable states. Soon, humans evolved to feel loneliness as pain to encourage teaming up in order to escape loneliness. But rationally speaking, we are not essentially cooperative and that cooperation happens only when we find it useful in our evolutionary process. For that matter, we need to learn the art of cooperation from ants that are super-organisms and die for the colony which they are a part of. But, they attack ants that are genetically different from them. They are the best examples of community cooperative living.

Too much competition can lead to poor health. The question of nature or nurture is not an issue as asserted by anthropologists and psychologists. Though we are born with certain tendencies or instincts, we can still transform our conduct, nature and personality through education, upbringing and our own conscious choices. After having tested every kind of occupation, skill and human behaviour,

one thing that has been inferred is that cooperation has yielded much more in terms of positive growth and creativity. Businessmen who work in cooperation with other businesses, gain perks and earn higher salaries and cooperative students from elementary grades to college have higher grade point averages. But the irony is that many people are unfortunately not taught cooperative skills.

Classroom students are taught to stay apart and quiet which fosters competition indirectly. On the contrary, when people work cooperatively with each other, they learn best. This type of learning when nurtured in early age is carried along by a child till he matures. People must therefore, learn to be cooperative and education and psychology must work in coordination to teach people to cooperate. In a particular setting, when people come closer to interact and cooperate with each other, they tend to feel good about themselves as learners. They have a better sense of community, belonging and acceptance besides their self-esteem going high.

But what we find today is surprising. The means by which individuals once learned cooperative skills are eroding and there are a lot of reasons to ponder upon. Churches, homes, communities which once used to be the standard ways to teach cooperation to people do not function the same old way. Young people being taught how to cooperate do not exhibit the requisite level of interest. This results in unabated competition.

Cooperation serves the individuals working together in several key areas such as creating fluid leadership, allowing everyone to participate actively without fear of censor and influencing an individual's perception of the work environment. It also impacts health and according to a research, it has been proved that cooperative individuals are better adjusted psychologically and are physically healthier than their more competitive colleagues. On the other hand, competition or the constant feeling of working against something leads to unhealthy physical side effects. Cooperative environment facilitates the quality of the outcome by increasing the number of

ideas and cooperation as a valuable commodity works best when it's freely given and indirectly encouraged.

While natural competition between men of any group provides a system of checks and balances, and healthy competition can be a positive incentive in the workplace, too much competition can be deadly and may kill morale, cause stress and foster backstabbing. On the flip side, working together and helping each other releases brain chemicals that enhance motivation, pressure and bonding. While competition benefits only certain people, it leads many to drift towards stress and make them work in highly tensed environment. We can't trust one another if we are thriving in an atmosphere of cutthroat competition; instead of trust, fear will prevail. This fear further induces various kinds of negative behaviours from passive resistance and political manoeuvring to self-problem.

Turning everything into a competition leads to unnecessary conflict, while cooperation evolves beneficial relationship skills that further help us to be good at teamwork and collaborate with others in the real world. Working in cooperation with others and using cooperative skills such as listening, sharing and negotiating teaches us beneficial relationship skills and helps us to be good at teamwork. Ideas and strategies are used to win together.

War is an obvious example of the deadly competition within the human species, but most of us do not realise that the same continues even during the times of "peace". People lacking the skills, education, talent or opportunity to compete in our competitive economy become poor; and this results in death; rates of which are at least six times higher than the rich.

So, instead of deadly competition, what works better is cooperative competition. It is also suggested that by working together, people can push each other to be more productive and produce stronger work. This further releases chemicals in brain that enhance motivation, pleasure and bonding. These 'feel good' chemicals make people more intrinsically motivated. Thus, students in their primary education

must be taught cooperative games so that they evolve into persons with established cooperative social behaviour.

In the end, what stands out most is our exceptional capacity for generosity and mutual trust and those moments in which we act cooperatively to establish the human race as the best species on the earth. Even the good leaders manage competition by creating an environment that encourages cohesion, cooperation and collaboration. Cooperative competition is a sure way to define roles, encourage free speech and keeps the people honest and open which ultimately leads to an atmosphere full of productivity, creativity and trust.

Chandrayaan 2 - Hits & Misses and the Road Ahead for ISRO



Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has earned the status of a premier space research and exploration agency after launching and completing various successful missions. Chandrayaan 1 and Mangalyaan being the major landmarks in the illustrious list of achievements accomplished by ISRO. Riding high on the success of these missions, ISRO decided to take a big risk with the Chandrayaan 2. Soft landing on the southern pole of the moon, orbiter part of the Chandrayaan 2 was designed to take high-resolution images, conduct analysis of the surface and find out the presence of water. The Vikram lander and Pragyan rover were designed to demonstrate the scientific capability of ISRO by conducting experiments on the surface of the moon for one lunar day, i.e. 14 earth days.

The orbiter part of the mission achieved the desired orbit, 100 kms above the surface, and started conducting the analysis for which it was designed. Though everything was going as planned with the Vikram lander on the fateful day, i.e. 7th September 2019, the mission control lost the contact just 2.1 kms above the lunar surface. Although ISRO tried to re-establish the link with the Vikram lander and Pragyan Rover, all efforts went in vain. The news came as a heartbreak to the entire nation. While some people labelled the mission as a failure, some declared it only a partial success; others termed it as a great achievement. In order to analyse if the Chandrayaan 2 mission was a

success or failure, it is important to look into the hits and misses of the coveted project.

Achievements

The expectations created by Chandrayaan 2 were incredible. It captured the imagination of the nation as well as the entire world. Everybody wanted the mission to be 100% successful in all its objectives for it would not only place India as a leading space agency but would also lay the groundwork for establishing an international space station on the moon. Some of the major achievements of Chandrayaan 2 mission are: -

Cost-effectiveness

The total cost of the Chandrayaan 2 mission was Rs. 970 crores wherein the mission cost was Rs. 603 crores and the cost of the launch was Rs. 367 crores. Compared to the costs incurred by NASA and ESA, this Chandrayaan 2 mission can be termed as an extremely cost-effective mission, opening up various future opportunities.

Successful launch

The GSLV (Global Satellite Launch Vehicle) Technology is crucial for India's future with deep space exploration. The launch of heavier satellites will also open a new commercial market for ISRO. During the launch phase, the GSLV MK-3 performed exceptionally well. This has given a tremendous boost to the launch capacities of India for various deep space exploration missions designed for the future. In the future it is expected that the GSLV technology will be further improved to achieve success with the proposed Gaganyaan mission and Aditya L-1 missions. All critical stages of the mission went successfully except the soft landing. Launch, orbital manoeuvres, lander separation, de-boosting, and rough braking went successfully.

Successful Orbiter Mission

While the mission was not 100% successful, it can be termed as 95% successful. The major objective of the mission was to analyse the lunar surface as well as locate the quantity and presence of liquid

water. These objective were to be accomplished by the orbiter mission and by placing the orbiter into the lunar orbit successfully, this objective has been achieved. The orbiter is expected to stay in the lunar orbit for a period of 7 years, as compared to previous estimates of 1 year. This has been possible due to the additional fuel being saved during the orbit insertion manoeuvres. The orbiter is conducting the experiments and making startling revelations. Recently, as per a newsletter published by ISRO, the lunar orbiter mission detected the presence of Argon-40 in lunar exosphere. Many such discoveries are expected in upcoming days.

International space co-operation

The complex nature of the Chandrayaan 2 mission made it a challenge for ISRO. By achieving almost 97% success with the mission, ISRO has now become a force to be reckoned with in the International Space Exploration Community. India is now collaborating with other countries for future missions. NASA was a part of the Chandrayaan 2 mission through its retroreflector being present as one of the payloads. The Russian space agency, ROSCOSMOS is providing technical know-how and collaborating with ISRO for the Gaganyaan mission. The next Chandrayaan mission is being worked on with help of the Japanese space agency, JAXA. These international collaborations have now opened up new avenues for ISRO.

Misses

While the Chandrayaan 2 mission managed to achieve many of its objectives, still there are some aspects of the missions which were left unfulfilled such as:

Missed opportunity

India would have been the first country to make a soft landing on the south pole and the overall fourth space agency to make a soft landing on the lunar surface. This opportunity was missed due to the hard landing of the Vikram lander, and subsequently the Pragyan rover could not show its capabilities. If it had been successful, the

technology demonstration would have further strengthened India's credentials as a leading space country.

Hard landing

The hard landing of the Vikram lander, though within 500 metres of the target site, could be attributed to the higher reduction in velocity during the fine braking phase. As the deviation was beyond the designed parameters, the lander suffered a hard landing. This has raised some questions over the planning of Chandrayaan 2 and doubts are being raised as to why these deviations were not taken into account.

The road ahead for ISRO

Whatever the detractors say, the capabilities and credentials of ISRO have been further strengthened with the Chandrayaan 2. Soft Landing on the lunar surface has never been easy, and that is why only 3 agencies have managed it so far, i.e. NASA, ROSCOSMOS, and CNSA. Now, the opportunity to be the fourth country to soft-land on the moon would have to wait for the next Chandrayaan mission which is being developed in collaboration with Japanese space agency JAXA. That mission is expected to launch in the next five years.

The two major missions proposed in the near future are Gaganyaan Mission and Aditya L1 mission. The Ganagnyaan Mission will be the first indigenous mission to take an Indian astronaut into space. The unmanned flight will be launched in December 2020 while the manned flight is expected to take off in December 2021. The Aditya L-1 mission has been designed to study the Sun and its corona. The planned launch for Aditya L-1 mission is April 2020.

Meanwhile, ISRO has been successfully launching commercial satellites for agencies and corporations across the globe. 100% success rate and economical pricing have made ISRO a preferable option for satellite launch amongst various space agencies.

Science is all about learning from past mistakes and correcting them in the future. So, a small setback suffered in the form of hard landing of the Vikram lander should not distract ISRO from its future missions.

Achieving success and improvement in every stage of the Chandrayaan 2 mission and that too at such lower costs is an achievement in itself.

Genetically Modified Crops: A Boon or Bane?



Genetic modification is a process that alters the DNA of an organism and inserts a foreign gene in the plant's own original gene to change its characteristics by making it resistant to disease. Often referred to as 'genetic engineering' or 'recombinant DNA technology' or 'modern biotechnology', this technology provides a quicker and more precise way to achieve some desirable traits which is usually non-achievable through the traditional hit and trial method of breeding crops. Crops produced through this technology are called as GM crops.

GM crops first appeared commercially in the mid-1990s. As these new crops were resistant to pests and herbicides that used to control weeds, they soon became popular with farmers and by the turn of the millennium, millions of acres were planted by them.

As per the reports of the International Service for the Acquisition of Agri-Biotech Applications (ISAAA), an international nonprofit organisation that advocates the technology - the world's top five producers – the US, Argentina, Canada, Brazil and China – account for 96% of global GM cultivation. Of this, more than half is in the United States alone.

GM food and organisms go beyond the selective breeding which has been in practice since the dawn of agriculture. Also called as transgenic organisms, these genetically-modified foods include soybean modified for herbicide resistance, corn modified for herbicide and pest resistance, cotton modified for pest resistance.

These crops produce increased yields and decreased costs that push them as a second 'Green Revolution', in a world with billion of hungry mouths to feed. However, GM crops suffer a poor reputation among the general public, to some extent because they are made in ways that can sound scary when described to consumers.

How they come in existence and how they continue to exist

With the help of biotechnology, scientists can combine genes from totally unrelated species of plants, microbes and animals through several methods. One method includes deploying the bacteria and viruses as delivery vehicles to shuttle genes directly into plant cell genomes as they are naturally able to penetrate cells. Other method comprises the propelling of tiny particles coated with a gene at high speeds into cells to deliver the gene. In another method, electric shocks are used to destabilize cell membranes so that they become permeable to delivered genes.

All these methods besides several others enable the scientists to evade natural barriers that cells use to protect themselves from foreign DNA. This means that genes from bacteria can be introduced into a plant, for example - a fish gene can be introduced into a tomato.

Virtually all the GM crops grown today are different varieties of the same four crops that became available before 2000, mainly pest or herbicide-resistant varieties of corn, cotton, soybeans and mustard. These crops were made for and marketed particularly to farmers, who form the key buyers of the industry. The GM technology has been embraced by farmers because it saves them time and money.

But, in the initial marketing efforts, the companies barely considered the consumers who would buy and eat GM foods and this proved to be a mistake. The introduction of Bt Cotton revolutionized the cotton growing areas. The estate for cotton crop grew by almost 65% between 2002-03 and 2014-15. It now claims over 95% of cotton estate.

The commercialization of GM crops in India was permitted by the Genetic Engineering Approval Committee and Bt-Cotton is the only crop which has been commercialized till date.

In 2009, Bt-Brinjal was given green signal for commercialization but citing its adverse implications, it was put under indefinite suspension. Likewise, Bt-Mustard that was developed in Delhi University's labs was banned by Genetic Engineering Approval Committee.

At the core of the concerns is safety. It is debated that there hasn't been enough testing of GM foods to ensure that they are safe, for people or for the environment. Another concern related to human health is the allergenicity. Certain individuals may grow allergic reactions to GM foods.

The greatest concern related to GM-Foods is the environmental concern and the prime concern is the phenomenon of Outcrossing. Genes -pollination of genes of GM crops with conventional crops may have adverse effect on safety and stability.

Other environmental issues according to World Health Organization, includes persistence of genes in the ecology even after the harvesting of the crop. The susceptibility of non-target organisms which are not pests, such as insects would also get exposed to GM crop's gene. The stability of the gene may also get hampered after engineering in the process. Further, loss of diversity in gene pool may be caused which occurs due to natural cross-pollination.

Insights on GM crops – positives along with negatives

Right now the world is facing the burden of food security with the exploding population and if the population continues to expand and if plant diseases continue unchecked, soils are depleted and our supply of traditional food sources is depleted by overconsumption and slow renewal, we may face severe food shortages in coming decades.

It comes as insight from scientists and food producers at such a time that genetically modified (GM) food crops could help solve problems of matching food supply to demand. At the same time, many other

researchers and health advocates are opposed to the further development and widespread use of GM foods as they feel these carry health risks and could have a negative impact on the ecosystem.

These foods are tested for safety and there has never been a proven claim for a human illness resulting from consumption of a GM food. Moreover, by modifying the DNA in foods that cause allergies, many food borne allergies can be prevented. Seeing the environmentally-damaging practices at present, the insect-and weed-resistant GM crops can actually allow farmers to use far fewer chemical insecticides and herbicides.

They can be created to grow more quickly than conventional crops and increase productivity and allow for faster cycling of crops. That means they yield more food and also address malnutrition and crops engineered to resist spoiling or damage can allow for transportation to areas affected by drought or natural disaster.

Genetically modified crops are also under development to produce and deliver vaccines which is very important for protecting the health of people in developing nations and preventing epidemics.

Looking to the other side, as genetic modification involves selective breeding, it transfers genes between species in unnatural ways and there haven't yet been enough studies of GM products to confirm that they are safe for consumption. Accidental cross-pollination could lead to the creation of 'super weeds'; insect and disease-resistant crops could prompt the evolution of even more virulent species, which would further require more aggressive control measures.

More so, as corporations create and patent GM seeds, they will control the market and poor farmers in the developing world would become reliant on these corporations. This can lead to increase in world hunger rather than alleviate it. The seeds of GM crops require permission for breeding and are costly for farmers to produce. MNC's involved in genetic modification have monopolistic tendencies and can affect economic policies of the government by lobbying.

Any artificial intervention may confine the gene pool and some studies have shown that with time, they also become resistant to pesticides and so more chemical pesticides, fertilizers are needed for its effectiveness which in turn will affect the ecological health.

Artificial Intelligence and its Challenges



Artificial intelligence (AI) is a branch of computer science that pertains to the creation of intelligent machines that work and respond like humans. In the words of the father of Artificial Intelligence John McCarthy, Artificial Intelligence is “the science and engineering of making intelligent machines, especially intelligent computer programs”. Some of the activities computers with artificial intelligence are designed for include speech recognition, learning, planning and problem solving. The latest intelligent machine is human robot that can emote and also change facial expressions.

Types of Artificial Intelligence

Reactive Machines

This form of AI recognizes its environment and situation directly and acts accordingly. It does not have the power to memorize or recall past experiences to affect present decisions. IBM’s Deep Blue, a chess computer that defeated chess champion Garry Kasparov, could identify the chess board and the pieces placed on it. This form of AI is designed only to perform specific tasks and can be easily fooled.

Limited Memory

This form of AI contains machines that have limited memory and can recall past experiences. They can take proper decisions and plan appropriate actions. For instance, self driving cars observe the speed and direction of other cars and move accordingly. They have pre-built programs for lane markings, traffic lights and other important elements, like curves in the road.

Theory of Mind

This form of AI has the capability to understand emotions and thoughts that affect human behaviour, though it is still in the developing stage. It anticipates machines that can identify eye and face movements and act accordingly. Sophia, the latest generation human robot can emote and imitate 62 facial and neck expressions.

Self-aware

This is an extension of theory of mind AI. These types of machines are aware about their internal state and can predict the feelings of others. This type of AI has not been developed as yet but is in progress. Self Aware AI is the future of machines which will be super intelligent, conscious and self aware.

Advancements in Artificial Intelligence

Artificial Narrow Intelligence, the most common technology that can be found in our day to day lives, is present in smart phones like Cortana and Siri. They help users to respond to their problems on request. It is called 'weak AI', because it is not as strong as it is required to be.

Artificial General Intelligence is known as 'strong AI'. Most of the robots fall into this category. Example of this is Pillo robot which answers all the questions related to the health of your family.

Artificial Superhuman Intelligence has the capability to achieve or do anything that a human can do or even more than that. Example of ASI is Alpha 2 which is the first humanoid robot developed for the family. This robot has the capability to manage a smart home and can operate the things in your home. It can also notify about the weather conditions and tell interesting stories too.

Challenges Faced by Artificial Intelligence

Artificial Intelligence works on science and algorithms. So it is difficult to understand for those people who don't have a technical background.

Funds required to set up and implement AI are very high, so most of the organizations and business owners refrain from investing large

amounts of money.

Software malfunction is a serious problem faced by AI. When any software or hardware fails, it is difficult to investigate what went wrong and which part of the software or hardware has failed. On the other hand, errors in tasks performed by humans can be traced.

Security is a major concern. AI systems can cause damage if used maliciously. The Terminator movie trilogy, for example, featured Skynet, a self-aware artificial intelligence that served as the trilogy's main villain, battling humanity through its Terminator cyborgs.

As AI development is speeding up, more robots or autonomous systems are getting created and replacing human labour which has serious implications of unemployment .

When it comes to Indian start ups, Artificial Intelligence is a problematic space as Indian start ups lack access to large data sets which require mass storage and high performance computers.

Another challenge faced by India in AI is absence of collaborative efforts between different stakeholders. For example, India has adopted electronic health record (EHR) policy which is designed to share data between various hospital chains but it is still a work in progress as different hospital chains have adopted different methods and interpretations of digitizing record.

AI techniques such as machine learning and deep learning require huge number of calculations to be made very quickly. This means the computers use a lot of processing power. Processing power determines the speed at which the computer can pull data from its memory and perform calculations.

Artificial intelligence is generally created to carry out specific tasks and to learn to become better and better at it only. Multitasking is not yet possible.

AI carries out complicated technical tasks which require skilled resources. The lack of skilled resources is also a disrupting factor in

the overall development of the global market for artificial intelligence.

AI can pose a threat to the society via autonomous weapons. These are weapons that AI systems are programmed to use to kill. In the hands of the wrong person, these weapons could easily cause mass casualties. This could even lead to an AI war.

AI has the potential and power to be more intelligent than humans; we have no certain way of predicting how it will behave.

Four core areas of applications of Artificial intelligence in India and challenges faced by them

Healthcare

It is one of the most dynamic, yet challenging, sectors in India. Cancer screening and treatment is an area where AI provides tremendous scope for targeted large scale interventions. Other uses of AI in healthcare include training, diagnosis, decision making, treatment, research, early detection, keeping well, etc. It faces major challenges of quality, accessibility and affordability for a large section of the population.

Agriculture

AI will have significant global impact on agricultural productivity at all levels of the value chain. Some of the applications of AI in agriculture are soil health monitoring and restoration, crop health monitoring and providing real time advisories to farmers and increasing the share of price realization to producers.

Infrastructure

Smart mobility and transportation form the backbone of the modern economy due to interlinking of different sectors which is important for both domestic and international trades. AI introduces intelligent transportation system – sensors, CCTV cameras, automatic number plate recognition cameras, speed detection cameras, signalized pedestrian crossings, real time dynamic decisions on traffic flows such as lane monitoring, access to exits, toll pricing, community based parking which helps cars in traffic to collect data on vacant parking spaces and allocates cars to spaces such that the demand is always met, autonomous trucking, etc. As of now, AI faces challenges

including congestion and road accidents, lack of public transportation infrastructure, need for sustainable transportation, etc.

Education

An effective education sector has the ability to transform a country through development of human resources and increased productivity. Content Technologies Inc. (CTI), an AI research and development company, develops AI that creates customized educational content. Some challenges faced by India in AI are low retention rates, poor learning outcomes, low adoption of existing technologies, etc.

The sole purpose of artificial intelligence is to make human lives easier. It aims to bring in the emotional quotient to the machines along with the intelligence quotient. Artificial intelligence has become a part of human life. It has made human life comfortable. However, as we create and find new applications of artificial intelligence day by day, we must retain control. If it goes beyond human control, it can spell disaster.

Science & Technology is the Panacea for Growth and Security of a Nation



The modern age is the age of science and technology. While science is the theoretical study, technology is practical application of this knowledge in our daily life to make our lives more convenient and comfortable. Science and technology hold the key to the progress and development of any nation. Technology plays a fundamental role in wealth creation, improvement of the quality of life and real economic growth and transformation in any society. Science and technology promotes new ideas, removes all superstitions and conservatism. It makes the society open to change which is essential for development. It plays a very important role in the development of economy of any country.

Areas that undergo development with the advancement of science and technology are higher education, scientific research and development, advancement of agricultural system, development of space science, infrastructure development, information technology advancements, development in various fields of engineering (software, chemical, mechanical, civil, electrical, electronic, etc).

Indian industries started flourishing post 1990, i.e. the landmark era. Globalization, liberalization, and privatization, facilitated this growth. The industries catering to Information & Technology, Atomic Energy, Automotive, Biotechnology, Nanotechnology, Pharmaceutical, Petroleum, etc. have increased at global level.

Science helps in ensuring food security by increasing productivity. Irrigation facilities have been made better by introducing micro irrigation techniques. Science plays a major role in disaster warning,

crop survey and marketing. It can help to reduce poverty as the development of agriculture has the highest impact on poverty.

With the development in science and technology, there has been a significant change in medical field. Continuous technological development in healthcare has saved countless lives and improved the quality of life. Not only has the technology changed experiences of the patients and their families but it has also had a huge impact on medical procedures and practices of healthcare professionals. Several important works have been done in the field of Microbiology and in the fields of special medicine to get rid of many fatal diseases. It has also benefitted medical education. Advanced Life Support (ACLS) simulators and Haptics “the science of touch” simulators are used in medical education to develop various clinical skills such as ECG interpretation, appropriate intervention such as ABC, drugs, injections, defibrillation without working on a real patient. These days, highly sophisticated simulators “virtual reality” with highly advanced medical simulation technologies and medical databases are available in the advanced medical schools that expose the medical students to the vast range of complex medical situations.

Another prominent example is Information Technology (IT) revolution. This sector has significant contribution in the growth of any country. The use of information technology in governance, company, management, banking, advertising, entertainment, insurance, medical, education, engineering and industrial fields is increasing day by day. This has also contributed towards the growth of the economy. Applications of science and technology in other service sectors include banking, insurance, transportation, tourism, etc. for example, banking solutions (CBS), automated teller machines (ATM) etc. have made banking convenient and easier. The E-Governance is another application of information and communication technology for delivering government services, exchange of information communication transactions, integration of various stand-alone systems and services between government-to-customer, government-to-business and government-to-government.

Security of a country is directly related to development of technology. CCTV cameras at various locations are the example of keeping crime under surveillance and it also provides a sense of security to people; the job of police has become easier as they can track criminals easily.

To secure and maintain high growth rate of the economy of any nation, security of the nation is of significant importance. As for India, it is facing many internal security problems like naxalism, terrorism, fundamentalism etc. Involvement of many external state and non-state actors have made the security scenario more complicated. All these can have a destabilizing effect on the economy. The most prominent example of how can science and technology be a panacea for the security of a nation is nuclear weapons. It has the potential to destroy the entire human race. Other important applications of science and technology to ensure security of a nation include improved surveillance, ballistic missiles, cruise missiles, etc.

Various initiatives have been taken for consistent and efficient growth by establishing many organizations like Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) centre, Department of Science and Technology (DST), Central Institute of Agricultural Engineering, National Institute of Oceanography, etc.

Science and technology is considered to be the panacea of growth and development of the nation but it has also led to various undesirable consequences. Increasing quantity of chemical fertilizer and pesticide has degraded the quality of soil and its water holding capacity. Large scale multipurpose river valley projects have displaced millions of people and deprived them of their livelihood resources. Large scale industries have contributed to air pollution, water pollution and have polluted the entire ecosystem.

Global warming is changing the global climate, melting the polar ice caps and raising sea levels. These evil effects are not the result of science and technology but humans are responsible for the application of science and technology. Application of these in the

wrong direction can spell doom for the humankind and instead of being the panacea for the growth and development of a nation, can hamper the growth of that very nation.

Exploring the World of Communication



Communication is a very integral component of daily existence for all beings. Not only humans, but animals also do communicate with each other. Without communication, the world would have been a bigger conundrum, an anarchic planet. Talking with the means of a language is communication, yet within a limited periphery. But over the centuries, humankind had tried and developed a lot of devices and means to talk or communicate over distant places. Since the early ages until today, there had been an array of means tried, used and evolved for better and faster modes of communicating.

The telephone appeared in 1876, which was definitely a ground breaking revolutionary step for the world of communication or perhaps telecommunication. The first cross continental telephone call was made in 1914. Television appeared in 1925 and the commercial radio in 1920. The first internet started in 1969, which was known as the ARPANET and in 1966, the first successful fax machine was invented by America's Xerox multinational corporation.

Means of communication always appeared slow for the generations of people who have always been heading towards a fleet-footed world. It is with the development of the e-mail that the world of communication received its ultimate push of rapidity and instantaneousness. With the e-mail, any message could be sent and received within the pulse of a heart time. It is so fast that its invention had truly made the world a microcosm. The significance lies in the evolution of e-mail from a file-sharing medium for a limited number of people to a remarkable medium of worldwide communication.

It was in 1961 when the first file-sharing system was demonstrated by some developers at MIT, where users could connect to an IBM host computer through a dial-up connection, and then store and share files with other users who would connect to the same host computer. Four years later, modifications were applied to the system that allowed users connecting to the system to send messages to other users and thus appeared the electronic-mail mode of communication.

With the commencement of social networking, there also appeared alongside the communicating system of chatting. Chatting allows two or more individuals to come together to talk inside chat room, which is a virtual software or instant messenger. Chatting is today a very popular medium over internet that helps people living miles away stay connected whether it is business friends, family, personal friends, etc. People here often get to meet and introduce themselves to new people from near and far places and befriend them. But there is also a spook of stalkers and predators that may be detrimental. A careful eye is therefore always indispensable while chatting.

This wonderful creation of chatting also has a history that goes back to 1988, when a person named Jarkko “Wiz” Oikarinen of the University of Oulu, Finland created the first chat client.

Chatting can be done through various methods on the internet. A few are web-based chatting which involves websites and chat rooms to chat amongst each other. These types generally require an account with a username and password to enter the website. Chatting today can also be done through webcams where the users can see each other and chat.

While using the chat, people should always bear in mind few things which in the language of the internet is known as the chatiquette which defines the basic rules of online communication. For example, it is considered rude to write in the upper case as it appears like the user is shouting at the other. One must also not use vulgar or disrespectful language while chatting with another user.

Now-a-days there are users who use the chat room to prey on younger children or girls or to steal user information. There is also room for identity theft or internet stalking which can be fatal. The children must be counseled on the use of the chat room and monitored carefully. One must therefore be a little more careful to look around and distinguish the evilness among everything. It is often better to keep the identity details clandestine and confined to oneself in order to make a safe use of the chat.

Communication has progressed formidably since the age of the smoke signals and flying pigeons. It is a fast moving world and communication facilities also need to be quite rapid. The e-mails and chats are faster versions of communication for a rapidly moving world. They are today no more confined to only fun and entertainment, but to an indispensability communicating at an instant from one corner of the globe to another while making lives easier and better in this evolutionary world.

Cloud Computing: Concept, Challenges & Limitations

Cloud computing has been an innovation that hit the headlines to displace many of the established traditional computational methodologies in a very short period of time. A model service similar to electricity and water has caught the attention and focus of many researchers and scientists. This advancing technology witnessed setbacks and disapproval at the very nascent stage. The criticism demanded better concerns on security, privacy and governance. However, the famous Gartner hype curve has been hailing Cloud computing as the most hyped technology in their last two years projections.

To put it briefly, Cloud computing is “a model for enabling convenient, on-demand network access to a shared pool of configurable computing resources (e.g. networks, servers, storage, applications, and services) that can be rapidly provisioned and released with minimal management effort or service provider interaction”. On the one hand, cloud exploits the set inventory of technologies; there is nothing new as it uses the established processes, concepts and approaches. On the other hand, it is a new-found concept because it has revolutionized the way it hosts and caters the service to the customers.

Sixty years ago at the dawn of computers, there worked a warehouse-sized machine gulping coils of paper tape. Users were captive to the limitations of data and applications provided. This gradually got replaced by Local Area Network and very lately emerged the technological advancement with the name of wireless applications (Wi-Fi). This couldn't suffice the insatiable growing population of global users. Cloud computing, at this juncture emerged as a boon. The most famous use of Cloud computing is social networking sites, including Facebook, LinkedIn, MySpace, Twitter, and many others. The Cloud has slowly taken the central position for data, applications, mobility and source of social media, multimedia and entertainment. The capacity of a Cloud is beyond any company to own it single-handedly. Thus, they operate in collaboration. Social Networking is mainly used to share information with others. Of course, while doing this, you are also sharing the information with the people who run the service. There are technological, economic and communicational advantages of using Cloud computing. Technologically, it is a step forward and economically it is less expensive. The sole area of concern is the security.

The unimaginable petabyte size storage and riveting speed has amazed many companies. This indicates that millions of people can download multi-billion-byte, high- definition, feature-length movies at the same time without slowing down or straining the internet. The first promising advantage of cloud computing is its cost-effectiveness. For example, Amazon offers Cloud computing services to web developers through its Amazon Web Services. At the time of writing, one could store 100 gigabytes of data a month and transfer in and out 20 gigabytes per month for just \$20.60 (based on Amazon's own

calculator). That is enough to service a sizeable agency. There is no need for individual maintenance, backup and updating. There are no sunk costs for applications like Microsoft Office. The Cloud is an excellent replacement for hard drives. The data on cloud is safe and stored while there are chances of crashing in a hard drive. The only hindrance in the widening of Cloud computing is its security restrictions. The data shared is prey to hacking and stealing.

Cloud computing has already penetrated into the everyday territory of internet and networking. According to Gartner's Hype cycle, Cloud computing has reached a maturity level that can enhance productivity multiple number of times. Most of the issues concerning Cloud computing are now resolved. However, there is enormous scope of exploring this arena to its fullest.

Cybernation: A Threat or a Opportunity for Employment



In the era of globalization, people are immersed in technological advancement. They are the spectators of a phenomenal transformation in day to day life. Recent technological inventions have refurbished almost everything. Computer is one of the most spectacular technological tools which have become the backbone of modern world. It is a helper of man. If a job needs precision, a computer can easily outsource a person. While humans are prone to errors, computers are accurate and capable to deliver close to zero percent errors. Rest of errors are caused due to faulty programming by humans. It reduces manual labour, expenditure and time span at workplace.

Cybernation revolution has been brought about by the combination of the computer and the automated self-regulating machines. It is already recognizing the economic and social system to meet its own needs. During the phase of Great Depression in 1930's, it was felt that advancement in technology were taking a toll on the employment trends and eliminating the need of human resource. It was the time of economical pessimism and collapse. People realized that computers hit hard on low skill jobs as warehouse clerks and basic data processing that belonged to the first sector replaced by automated computer technology.

If we look at the larger picture, there is always a phase of change in which people adjust with new wave of technology. To be at par with the world, it is important that we keep the pace with others. At such

hour of need, people have to work hard to get into new technology and acquire new skills that would make them employable when their previous jobs are eliminated by advance technology.

We can't close our eyes to the profound impact of computer technology on employment trends and modern economy. It is true that due to computers, manual efforts are taking a back seat and causing unemployment in manual labour. People are becoming slave to computers and human life is getting more mechanical. The use of computers reduces manual labour and expenditure. It makes our jobs comparatively easier and sophisticated as well. People make lucrative profits with computer aided machines. Computers have minimized the risk to human health and accident hazards in manufacturing activities.

Computers have changed the equations in the employment sphere by both creating as well as destroying job opportunities, more than anything by changing the nature of the jobs available. Computers tend to create high paying, high skill technical jobs and destroy low paying, low skill jobs. Computers accelerate the productivity rate at work place with greater flexibility and open the door to new fields like programming, designing, animation, online marketing and publishing etc. Computer technology, like any other technological innovation is a symbol of modernity which generates new jobs and gives efficiency to our work.

In high-tech savvy world, computers pervade almost every aspect of life but it's wrong to presume that computerization is responsible for job loss. Initially with the advancement of computers in job sector, unemployment rose greatly but it was just a one side of the coin. In fact the computer oriented IT sector provides a great number of opportunities in India as well as in other countries. It has given birth to MNC culture. In India, we have TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, etc. which in return, reward us with good deal of employment

opportunities. Today the IT sector is the largest job providing industry, contributing to the economy of our country. It has brought about a boom in BPO sector too. It showed the way to high profile jobs in 3-D animation, hardware, software developer, system analyst, technical support, web master and blogging etc.

Computers are often blamed to harness the economy by creating unemployment but the truth is other way round as it may streamline some jobs and make others redundant. On the other hand, they create jobs that would not exist without them so it balances out.

Implementation of computer solutions demands the expertise in employment sector. As it is expensive to be a computer literate, poor people find it difficult to afford computer education. It may hinder some job opportunities but ultimately the truth is that computers can't work on their own as they still need human handling so basically they are facilitating human beings. We can say in conspicuous way, human brain is always needed to assemble, program, debug, maintain and operate the wonder machines. They only multiply efficiency and industry profit. Enhancing the standard of living, computers have made the world a global village today.

Aadhaar: World's Largest Biometric ID System



With the desire to curb fake and duplicate identities in the country, Aadhaar came as a sigh of relief. Aadhaar was introduced by the UPA government in 2010 with the basic intentions of making subsidy and benefit deliverance more effective and eliminate leakages in the process. It also aims to achieve social inclusion and more efficient public and private service delivery. Aadhaar gives each individual a 12 digit Unique Identity number (UID) based on their biometric and demographic data that include photographs, fingerprints and retina scans. This UID is insusceptible to fraud and theft as it never starts with a 0 or 1 is not loaded with profiling or intelligence into identity numbers. The statutory body responsible for collecting and issuing the Aadhaar is Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI). This body was established on 12 July 2016 by the Government of India, under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, under the provisions of the Aadhaar Act 2016.

Aadhaar is the world's largest biometric ID system with over 1.22 billion enrolled members as of July 2018. About 90% of the Indians of the total estimates population had been enrolled in Aadhaar till date. World Bank Chief Economist Paul Romer has described it as "the most sophisticated ID programme in the world".

Need of Aadhaar as Digital Identity

Today, many Indian residents hold several forms of identity proofs for different purposes such as a voter ID card, a ration card for accessing the public distribution system, a Permanent Account Number (PAN) card for tax registration, a driver's license, and a passport. The

application and verification process for each of these IDs is different and procedurally complex. The government proposed creating a single biometric identification system that would define Indian residents and their access to public services. Aadhar Card is in sync with the Digital India Initiative of PM Narendra Modi. Several features of Aadhar card facilitate digital identity.

1. The document of the card itself is electronic in PDF format which can be printed online.
2. A QR Code gives digital XML representation of some core details of the card.
3. The number and some limited details can be validated online (name being excluded),
4. Details can be updated electronically using a mobile phone number and/or email as the second factor of authentication,
5. The system collects a photo, all 10 finger scans, and both eyes iris scan.

Benefits of the Aadhar Card

Apart from being used in a wide range of identification proofs, the Aadhar card has lots of other benefits, too. Using Aadhaar card as identity proof, one can get LPG subsidy directly transferred into one's bank account under the PAHAL scheme. With it being a digital ID proof, it is accepted as ID in getting new SIM, vehicle registration and many other things. With Aadhaar card being linked to DigiLocker, Aadhaar holders can scan and save their documents on the cloud, and can share them with the government officials whenever required without any need to carry them.

Aadhaar Applications in Public and Private Service Delivery Employee Absenteeism

Nowadays, many central and state government offices are using Aadhaar authentication for (clocking in) employees. There is a central

record of every employee's clocking in and clocking out time with each ministry. Finger impression and four unique digits of Aadhar card are used for the authentication system. As a result, the government employees are more punctual than ever and are spending 15 to 20 minutes more on their desks.

Aadhaar and Financial Inclusion

According to various stakeholders, Aadhar has been found to play an important role in speeding up the "Know Your Customer" (KYC) process. The Central government has recently announced Aadhaar card as a mandate document for opening new bank accounts and for transactions above ` Rs. 50,000. All existing account holders also submitted their Aadhaar details by December 31, 2017. This will further ease the present cumbersome KYC process of India.

Providing an identity to previously excluded populations

Aadhar has been proven to introduce the process of shifting from relational to individualized personal identity. Its value as a form of identity indicates that those who were previously marginalized can now be included in a number of welfare programs. For example, the most common identity card ration card is issued to the whole household in the name of the male head of household. Segments of population which were earlier excluded from individual identity, like women, migrants, transgender individuals, sex workers and tribal populations in remote areas have now been given their unique identity proof UIDAI which has adopted a wide approach of being as inclusive as possible in order to reach the remotest parts of the country. The government has encouraged all the citizens of India to get the enrolment by setting up stalls in nook and corners of the country for documentation purpose.

Exclusions

Aadhaar doesn't confer the citizenship nor guarantees rights, benefits, or entitlements to anyone. Non-resident Indians, overseas citizens of India and other resident foreigners may now find it difficult to avail services they could previously freely obtain, such as local SIM cards, despite assurances to the contrary.

Now the government has formulated new rules about Aadhaar – The income tax department has made it mandatory to link the Permanent Account Numbers (PAN) with the Aadhaar card. The linking deadline has been extended till December 31, 2019. After the last date i.e. January 1, all PAN cards which are not linked to Aadhaar cards will become inoperative or invalid.

Aadhaar has been found to have direct value in creating digital infrastructure through which social and financial transfers can take place. To enhance transparency and realise its potential as a game changing tool, Aadhaar should be accessible and relevant to all urban and rural population and the rich and the poor. However, on the flip side, the Aadhaar - built on a mammoth biometric database comprising fingerprints and iris scans – has its own limitations. This huge database was open to compromise; there have been a number of instances of data breach that had triggered a huge debate.

In March 2018, the Supreme Court extended the March 31 Aadhaar deadline till it delivers its final verdict on the entire case and said that the UIDAI card is not mandatory for banking, phone and passport services for now. However, the UIDAI or Unique Identification Authority of India card will be mandatory for social welfare benefits under Article 7 of the Aadhaar Act. To make the system foolproof, more research needs to be done using economic and sociological analysis and law on privacy protection must be passed to make it more secure and trustworthy.

A Home without Books is like a Tree without Birds



According to William Shakespeare, books are the nutrition of the whole world; life without books as if there is no sunlight; wisdom without books, just like a bird without wings. There is a very deep connect of books with humans. Ever since the invention of paper, humans have penned down their thoughts, scriptures, stories and various instances on it. Stacks of papers were bind together and kept for references by the great gurus in earlier times. With time, several authors started writing fiction and reality based stories, novels, religious context based on real events and educational and scientific conceptual books. Slowly and steadily, books became an integral part of people of all age groups. Young children and students read education text books and story books, adults read novels and magazines and elderly tend to read more of religious writings. People gather books and keep them in their homes to go back to them whenever they want.

A home without books can be considered synonymous to a room without windows. Similar to how the latter can be suffocating, dull and difficult to live in, a house with books brings in liveliness and character. As a window brings in a breath of fresh air and light into the room, the books bring in the knowledge to enlighten the housemates and also give them an opinion and perspective towards life. A home is defined by the people who live in it and not the materialistic items that decorate it. One may buy expensive rugs, furniture, paintings, ornaments and other décor stuff to beautify their

home. All this is a reflection of how much money the owner has got. But if there are books in the house, it signifies the mind and character of the owner. As author Anna Quindlen puts, “I would be most content, if my children grew up to be the kind of people who think decorating consists mostly of building enough bookshelves”, describes how books should constitute a defined place in one’s house.

In modern day and age, however, people tend to drive towards luxuries of life like car, house, cell phones etc. which cost a bomb on their pockets. But their mindset won’t let them buy a book which will cost only a few pennies. This is because they are engrossed in the artificial passion for collecting expensive and rare things which define the luxuries of liver. However, they don’t understand how a good collection of books will bring in character and meaning to their lives which will define their taste, attitude, personality and psychology. The habit of reading thus, should be inculcated in early years of growth. Apart from the context books which are mandatory for their school curriculum, young kids should be introduced to story books, novels, magazines and comics which are appropriate for their age. This habit will churn out their overall personality which will be reflected in all areas of their life – be it their work ethics, attitude towards life, moral values and social mindset. No matter how big or small a house is, but if it has a little space for books there, the house will bloom with fresh ideas and thoughts.

Books can be considered as the great lighthouses which are erected in the great sea of time. Reading a book takes you to another world. It connects you to the author, the time and era the story talks about and moves you along with it. Life is limited and it is difficult to experience all the wonders oneself, but books can enlarge the experience of being alive.

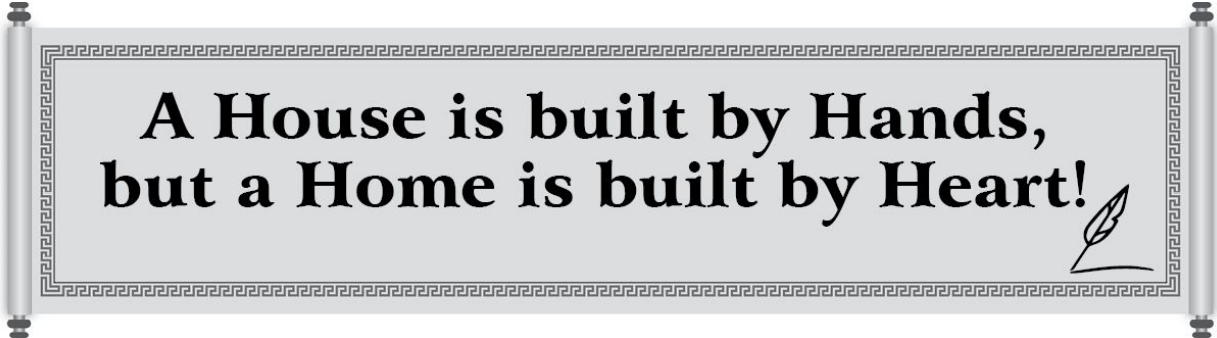
House without books can also be considered as a body without soul. As a soul defines a person and its overall character, similarly books give meaning and character to homes. The word BOOK can be

expanded to stand for each letter: B, bridge that connects one to K, knowledge. Between them are two Os, Objects and Opinions. Books are diverse in nature and consist of all kinds of objects in the world. Authors put them into words and we learn from them through reading. But understanding what is read is utmost otherwise it's like roaming in a circular motion and constraining oneself. Critical thinking of what is read is essential to absorb the contents. This is how one is able to respect the author's view and also create one's opinions. Thus, books act as a bridge which build objects and opinions to knowledge. Knowledge is power and to be powerful, one must cross this bridge.

Books thus act as a ladder for human progress. Books can be considered to be the quietest and most constant of friends whom you can trust blindly; they are also most accessible and wisest of counsellors; and the most patient of teacher. Books are our friends in a real sense. They demand nothing from us and give us immense joy. We also learn a lot from them. They take us into a different world of imagination. They built up one's mental well being and broaden the mind.

Books let us travel the world without moving our feet. They teach us the norms of the society and show the pathways of life. Books make one lively, content, knowledgeable, enriched and sharp. They thus, should be an integral part of one's life. A tree is defined by its qualities of giving shelter, food and wood. It is an epitome of strength and growth. Similar to how a tree keeps one grounded and connects one to the roots, books bring us closer to our inner self and make us calmer and beholder of deeper things. Trees are shelter to birds. Without birds, trees look deserted. Birds fly all day but at the end come back to the tree. They bring in the life in trees with their chirpiness. Same way humans may wander all around, but it is the books where he will find ultimate solace.

**A House is built by Hands,
but a Home is built by Heart!**



“A house is made of bricks & beams, but a home is made of a feeling of belongingness.”

“**H**ome”, without doubt, it’s one of the most symbolic words in any language. Whether it’s a suburban semi, igloo, yurt or a particular patch of desert, the familiarity and domesticity of home usually provides relief when you arrive. No matter what place one calls home, the very word strikes a chord deep inside every one of us. It revives specific memories and sparks a familiar essence that we are able to recall just by thinking of the combination of four simple letters. Home means sanctuary, the place where we can rest, relax, enjoy time with friends, learn, grow and just be. Our homes say a lot about who we are and what we think is important in life. Home holds a value way beyond anything that mere bricks and mortar might normally represent.

But why is this so? What is it about being in a specific place that makes one feel so good? Why is being away from home so stressful for some that some psychologists once recognized homesickness as a potent progenitor of mental illness.

If one looks upon the dictionary, the word home means “the place where one lives permanently, especially as a member of a family or household.” But the true meaning of word ‘home’ goes beyond this. Home is where the family is, it is like a nest, the nucleus of one’s life, the hub from which all daily experiences extend. Both as children and adults, our home and family are where we should feel most

comfortable in the world. They determine how you make your life decisions; they shape our attitudes, our awareness, and our self-esteem. A healthy home life is a vital ingredient in the pursuit of a meaningful life.

Home is more than just a mere structure of architecture that is composed of walls and a roof, which we consider to be our shelter. It is supposed to be where we find tranquillity and where we can feel like our most comfortable selves. What make a 'house' a "home" are the simple actions of people, the love and affection they put in. A house is full of meaningless objects; a home is filled with memories. There is a reason why, we say, 'hometown, 'homeland' or 'home country'. It's the feeling of belongingness that one comes from home.

A house can never be a home because it is just a structure you live under but a home can be anywhere. Home is vital to human beings as it's always with you when you're happy, sad, angry or excited; it is here where you spend your best moments. Home is where you eat, sleep, work and play. It's where you get loved. It is defined by memories, contents and people as much as it is by physical form. It is an evolving idea that continues to change as memories and inhabitants come and go.

Different parts of the world have very different inclinations towards building a house. In the United States, the predominant method in constructing a house is timber-framed construction, where structural timber is used for the load-bearing part of the walls. In the United Kingdom, masonry construction, also known as brick and block construction, has been the method traditionally used, but timber-framed construction is currently the fastest growing construction method. However, in India, bricks and mortar are used widely to build houses. Though, whatever maybe the size or construction of a house, it is still called a house, not home. It is partly the name and the

function that unites houses and homes across the world, rather than their structure.

Today we have interesting and unique houses from around the world, from cave dwellings and tree houses to soccer-ball-shaped shelters, toilet-shaped homes, and portable domiciles. There is a toilet-shaped house, Haewoojae; which means the house for satisfying one's anxiety, in Suwon, south of Seoul. South Korean sanitation activists marked the start of a global toilet association by lifting the lid on the world's first lavatory-shaped home that offers plenty of water closet space. However unique or weird these buildings or houses may be, still they are living spaces for people and called a 'home'. As home is not defined by the architectural structure rather it is the reflection of people living there.

In India, home is also associated with religious practices to remarkable degree and this fact is abundantly evident. Religious images are found in many rooms in the house, often integrated with images of deceased loved ones. Homes may feature religious pictures, small or larger brass oil lamps with a cross on top (a variation on the brass oil lamps ubiquitous in Hindu homes) and dedicated shrines with a whole array of images on a tabletop or wall. Many families gather to pray together in the evening, often with a scripture reading, before or after dinner.

Also, a home represents more than financial assets; they have a deep and unique emotional meaning. One of the earliest memories of home is often connected to childhood. The importance of the home environment is something that has been acknowledged as vital to a child's learning and development. For better or worse, they also represent the success of one's parent. Homes are an outward expression of family wealth, providing comfort, safety and a sense of community. But as much as we define them, our homes also define us. There is a popular quote "Home Sweet Home", which portrays

home as a place where people are able to go back, relax and cherish each and every moment.

An important sense of who you are and where you belong, where you will always have a place to call home is built by family and the bond that comes from family. Everyone has different family experiences. Some families work very coherently, whereas some families have a love amongst their chaos. Some families have the whole unit but don't work and some have an incomplete unit but work wonderfully. Families differ in the degree to which they reorganize themselves and their living spaces to accommodate care for each member, with different tolerance and strategies to minimize any disorder.

Nonetheless, the definition of home varies for different people. Many a time the places one may consider home aren't even places where they have immediate family, nor where they currently reside, or where they grew up. Instead, home might be a bookstore full of shelves stocked with classics and modern publications, a coffee shop where you're most able to zone in on work or the place where you and your friends get together when you feel bored.

It may be the dirt pathway through the park where one takes their morning walk each day, the cycle they take out on the road when the weather permits or the track where one pushes them to do better than last time. Home is where everything sort of clicks and where weight can be temporarily lifted from your shoulders, even if for a few hours.

Those who do not learn from History are bound to repeat it



There is a famous quote - 'Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it', given by George Santayana (philosopher, essayist, poet and novelist) in 1905. In a 1948 speech to the House of Commons, Winston Churchill changed the quote slightly when he said (paraphrased), 'Those who fail to learn from history are condemned to repeat it.' This quote is hard to disagree with. It is evident from the fact that wars ended with confiscatory terms of surrender inevitably breed more wars. Brutal dictatorships are the inescapable consequence of revolts that gave an individual consummate power. This holds true for individuals as well. Couples who do not learn from their fights, break up and those who don't learn from their mistakes ever grow. History helps us understand what it means to be human. One can't fully understand anything unless they have background information.

Renowned novelist Mark Twain proposed a modification to the above mentioned proverb. He said, 'history doesn't repeat itself, it rhymes'. Although history does not repeat itself in the sense that exactly the same things happen over and over again, it does have a recurring theme. The most widely accepted theory is that it was mentioned by Karl Marx who said, "History repeats itself, first as tragedy, second as farce." But, is it farce – some stupid, clichéd line or is it a fact that holds the statement together? How true is the statement in today's context?

Like when we eat ice cream too quickly, we get a headache and so next time we slow down. Although history is full of cautions, we don't really pay heed to them. There are ample examples where people

made the same mistakes as their predecessors and suffered similar consequences. These cataclysms are more saddening since these were so preventable.

History is inescapable. It studies the past and the legacies of the past in the present. It is such an important subject and plays a very vital role when it comes to shaping of our society. History helps us understand what led-up the actions of those before us. Sometimes we try to understand why certain things happened in the past, or why particular individuals who greatly affected the course of history acted in the manner that they did. It helps us understand the reasoning that informed such actions and thus we can try to use the lessons learnt to do better.

After repeated wars between Germany and France, France still demanded that confiscatory terms of surrender be imposed on Germany after The First World War in 1914. As Germany unwillingly signed the Treaty of Versailles because they considered it too harsh, the people voted to power a man who promised to rip up the Treaty of Versailles; Adolf Hitler. Then The Second World War happened in 1939 when Britain and France declared war on Germany following Germany's invasion of Poland.

Hitler also had an example of Napoleon's defeat in front of him. Napoleon is well known for his collapse after attack on Russia and it is astonishing that Hitler would do the same mistake. The reason for defeat of both is that they attacked Russia when winter was coming in. The Russians are more adapted to winters than the foreign armies and thus in both cases, several people in foreign armies lost their lives to cold.

Another example of history repeating itself is of RMS Titanic. Ninety years prior to sinking of Titanic, there was the sinking of Tek Sing in the South China Sea. Tek Sing was a cargo ship sailing from China and Jakarta along with 1600 emigrants. The Tek Sing sank after crashing into a small barrier reef, resulting in massive loss of life. Tek Sing is occasionally referred to as "Titanic of the East" as both Titanic

and Tek Sing committed serious flaws prior to beginning their voyages. Just like Tek Sing, Titanic too did the same mistake of not carrying enough life boats. Furthermore, Tek Sing was speeding its way towards the destination and so was Titanic, moving more rapidly than it should have been.

Decades later, in December 1987, the ferry Doña Paz repeated similar mistake. It took off from Tachloban in the Philippines for Manila for Christmas holidays. Doña Paz was overloaded with 4,000 passengers on a ship built to carry only about 1,400. Disaster struck in the Tablas Strait when the ferry collided with an oil tanker, causing a massive explosion that quickly sank both ships. This was the world's peacetime maritime disaster and has even been called "Asia's Titanic".

So, why do we need to study history? The answer is – to gain access to the laboratory of human experience. Its only after we study it well, we attain some usable habits of mind as well as data about the forces that affect our lives. Studying history can help one develop literally "profitable" skills, however, its study must not be pinned down to the narrowest utilitarianism. It also helps build experience in dealing with and assessing various kinds of evidence and thus drawing most accurate conclusions. This skill can also be applied to information encountered in everyday life.

By looking at history, we have a better understanding of how to live in the world. We can study patterns in international relations and learn more about other countries, the way they developed and what's important to them. Countries can learn from history about how to prevent a war by studying historical personages who are seen to be very similar in their deeds to other historical personages. Learning the lessons of the past allows you to build personal testimony on solid bedrock of obedience, faith and the witness of the Spirit.

Each passing moment weaves a tapestry for the modern world. We are standing upon the ruins of the old world and looking forward into the future. Besides, no civilisation could exist without the past. Each word we speak or write reverberates with the voices of those long

gone and forgotten. Our speech or language is also imperative to our history and our very own existence. Forgetting one's history, on the other hand, is similar to a ship without a rudder, a journey without a destination, and a human being without a navel.



**“Don’t limit a Child to your
own Learning, for he was Born
in Another Time.”**

“The goal of early childhood education should be to activate the child’s own natural desire to learn.”

—Maria Montessori

This is a famous quote of Rabindranath Tagore that means that the questioning nature of young mind should not be changed or suppressed, just because the knowledge of elders is limited to their specific time and so this does not mean that the question does not have an answer. Elders try answering the questions in their own limited learning, which should not be the case otherwise. So, the child should be allowed to learn, the young mind should be allowed to blossom by questioning and continuous learning. Children are exceptionally talented and they learn in different ways to the way their elders learnt at school.

The single thing that is simple but seems complex and differentiates the generations over time is ‘change’. It’s the beauty of this change that makes us adapt to the changing environment, habitat and time. Change allows us to be accommodative to the new conditions, thereby adding new attributes to our personalities. Thus, without this change we can’t stand alone as the leading survivors in the Darwin’s ‘Evolution of Life’. With every advancing day, new opportunities, ideas and challenges are thrown up. Unless we constantly adapt to the changing needs of the surroundings, we can’t compete, advance and sustain. A person therefore cut off from the mainstream way of living is considered archaic and backward.

Today’s young generation is always a step ahead than the old generation in terms of its thinking and application of knowledge and

so will be the next generation as compared to us. Time and again, the young generation raises questions and doubts regarding certain traditional rituals and superstitious beliefs based in their own reasoning and scientific interpretations. At this point of time, they either get answered to in an unconvincing manner or are asked to follow the traditional beliefs without any arguments. This puts them in a situation where they start doubting everything told by their elders and in lack of proper answers to their doubts, their faith starts fading sooner or later.

Old generation, in fear of losing its supremacy tries to stop the younger ones to question, argue or raise doubt as they are unable to answer their questions or they do not want their misinterpretations to be uncovered. Thereby, this leads to brutal murder of the scientific temper and enthusiasm in the younger ones. The society grows when the inhabitants are willing enough to put in some effort to the well being and development of the young generation. If the society believes that it has conquered all the knowledge and the young ones should blindly follow the existing beliefs, then the scientific temper starves and the society as a whole faces downfall.

At some point of time in the past, traditional professions were hereditary. The livelihood activities were practised in the family chain through generations and this represented the character of self sustained village economy. But, with advancement in time and with beginning of modern era, the situation transformed. With growing level of modernisation in production, administration, spread of education, overcrowding and more emerged the change in conditions of a revolutionary character. Migration to the towns and cities led to emerging of a population of a new generation of educated youth who aspired for jobs in administration, new ideas blew far and wide. All of this remained intact and broke the shackles of confinement.

Then the world of such people remained small, backward and uncivilised as compared to the present way of living. They expected their kids to carry forward their pursuits, their lineage and confine to the narrow way of living as they and their fathers did. The knowledge

and wisdom gained by them through their seniors was limited and they failed to sense the changing needs.

The Indian society was rife with rituals, superstitions and old beliefs around the six century BC. Then the people starved still were not allowed to question the existing beliefs and look for other avenues of survival. The class system became very rigid and the priestly class left no chance to exploit the masses. Then with the arrival of Buddha, the eightfold path of life was proposed to the people which led to the path of end of suffering in life. This helped in breaking the chains of the past and look to the future. But, again in medieval times, the society became weary with no innovation. This stagnation brought in several superstitions and fear of the unknown which were exploited by the British to subordinate the country. But, through the efforts of social reformers and several young leaders; the existing superfluous rituals were challenged which led to new progressive path for the Indian society. The scientific temper and reason in the masses was brought in and this led the wheel of growth going. Education on scientific lines was started and India was made aware of its glorious past. It was only after the society was mobilised this way, that the freedom struggle of the Indian National Congress left its impact.

This teaches us a very important lesson - that change is very important in order to grow. The society is structured out of individuals and individual growth is equally important. This growth is attainable by entertaining and encouraging the questions of children. Through this the proper knowledge will be passed to the younger generation which has the responsibility of future resting on its shoulders.

The child should be allowed to grow under watchful eyes and the teaching should be confined to basic values rather than being imposed with one's ideals. He should be provided a proper avenue to exhibit his potentialities. And the society and humanity progresses only when a child grows into a rational being; for he is the future from whom one borrows the present. Questioning the conventional or traditional way will lead to the envelopment of scientific temper and the question provided with right answer develops rationality and in

quest of answer research is born which fuels the seeds for growth of a nation. This is how a society progresses and a progressive society needs progressive young generation. So, encourage the child to learn, question and grow; rather than restricting him or limiting him to your own understanding.

History Without Political Science Has No Fruit And Political Science Without History Has No Roots

The relationship between Political Science and History is very intimate and abutting; these two are contributory and complementary to each other. The closeness between Political Science and History is well-brought-out in the statement of John Seeley, an eminent English author on History and Political Science; "History without Political Science has no fruit, Political Science without history has no root." According to Professor Willoughby, "History gives us the third dimension of Political Science." History provides us with the raw material of Political Science. It serves as a best kind of laboratory to Political Science.

The study of politics has had a long tradition. As a matter of fact, Political Science has its roots in ancient Greece. The Greeks used the term "politika" to describe the numerous activities of the "Polis" or city-states in which they lived. It was the Greek thinkers who laid the foundation for the development of a systematic science of politics and were mainly concerned with questions of morality and ethics and tried to define an ideal state. The first efforts to systematically study politics can be traced in the works of the two famous political thinkers from ancient Greece- Plato and Aristotle. Later, Christian religious thinkers St. Augustine and St. Thomas Aquinas also dwelt upon the idea of an ideal state and sought to derive moral and ethical principles regarding the same.

In the fifteenth century, Niccolo Machiavelli, an Italian political thinker, started the tradition of studying existing and historical political institutions. It marked a departure from the classical and Christian traditions of political philosophy. Efforts were made to identify

institutional arrangements that would maintain social order and political stability. Accordingly, political thinkers subsequently tried to deal with the historical origins of different political institutions and their structural frameworks.

Political Science has always been closely related to History. In order to fully understand the origin and development of political institutions, we have to take the help of history. For instance, a mere history of one hundred years of Indo-Pakistan before Independence will not tell us much, unless we also know that these events were occurring under the influence of the political principles of nationalism and freedom struggle against British Imperialism. It was only after their struggle with British rulers, and independence of India in 1947, India paved its way for the establishment of a democratic, republic and secular nation. Thus, we find that the political institutions that exist today in a particular form have their roots in the past. At the same time, it must be mentioned that History is not merely a record of past events and institutions. The study of History becomes fruitful only when the political significance of various historical events and movements is properly appreciated.

History, in its turn, has so much to borrow from Political Science. Our knowledge of history is meaningless, if the political bearings of events and movements are not adequately evaluated. The history of the freedom struggle of India, for example, is an incomplete narration of facts unless full significance of political events and movements like the Jallianwala Bagh tragedy (1919), Non-violent, Non-cooperation Movement (1920), the Civil Disobedience Movement (1930), and the Quit India Movement (1942) are well studied. These all have been the handiworks of political leaders and history of India stands determined by these. The actions of rulers and power-holders always create history. It is Political Science which provides meaning to History and makes it interesting and rewarding. History and politics go hand in hand, both not only influencing but complementing one other.

Historical events forge political opinion, and politics guide civilians creating social and cultural history.

On the other hand, Political Science has always been influenced by the discoveries, concepts and theories of other sciences, for instance by mathematics and geometry in the seventeenth century, by philosophy in the eighteenth, by economics in the first half of the nineteenth century, which gave rise to socialism and Marxism, and by biology in the second half, especially after the discovery of evolution by Charles Darwin, while it has always been influenced by History.

Many political problems have various aspects, which can be properly understood only if we also study them from the viewpoints of the concerned social sciences. What is more, there are many problems which are loosely called 'political', such as poverty, crime or unemployment, but they are susceptible in the evolution and growth of Political Science and history has played an important role. According to the German philosopher, Schopenhauer, history has been the fact-gatherer for political Science, as also for other social sciences. It has been a storehouse of facts and events, from which many political theorists take reference.

For instance, when political scientists try to predict the likely direction, which the global political economy takes, they would be relying on history to predict political behaviour. All political institutions such as State, Government, Legislature, Executive, Judiciary and others have a history of evolution behind them. Without studying their history, Political Science cannot really study their contemporary nature, position and relations among these. Hence, Political Science always takes the help of History for studying political institutions i.e. the history of their evolution from their emergence and gradual evolution into their contemporary forms, powers, functions, mutual relations and relative positions.

History also learns much from Political Science. Political Science furnishes such guiding principles and laws of development and evolution on the basis of which historical events and movements can be properly evaluated and understood. Mere history is a dry testimony of past events. A study of Political Science indicates the nature of the trends in history and the tendencies and directions in which historical events were evolving.

Accordingly, the study of History essentially needs a study of the political implications of all historical events and developments in each society. Without such an exercise, History gets reduced to a mere narration of events, episodes and developments. History depends upon Political Science for getting knowledge about the political dimensions of historical events. History of political institutions constitutes a rich area of study to History. Political Science gives meaning to historical facts and uses these for answering the questions what should be done and what should not be done? History without Politics is fruitless.

The affinity between Political Science and History is such that Seeley maintained: "Politics is vulgar when not liberalised by History, and History fades into mere literature when it loses sight of its relation to Politics." Another pioneering Political Scientist, Professor John William Burgess said "While there are parts of History which are not Political science, and while there is an element in Political science which is not strictly History, yet the two spheres so lap over one another and interpenetrate each other that they cannot be distinctly separated. Political science must be studied historically, and history must be studied politically, in order to form a correct comprehension of either. Separate them and the one becomes a cripple, if not a corpse, the other a will-o'-the-wisp."

No One can Win Alone but Unity Can



“We are only as strong as we are united, as weak as we are divided.” This quote by J K Rowling puts forth how unity brings strength with it. In today’s day and age, where everyone is fighting everyone, the stance to be united is required. People are running in a rat race to go ahead of others in terms of the life they lead, education, jobs and standard of living but not realising the fact that they are in a race against themselves only. In a competitive scenario, unity is taking a backseat. It is high time that the moral value of unity be nurtured so that the world can become a better place to live in.

Unity can be described as being the state of being united or together. It is the feeling of oneness, togetherness and harmony for a common objective. Unity doesn’t mean to jeopardise the individual interests of the person. It means to move together in a direction with other people without compromising on anybody. ‘No one can win alone, but unity can’ in itself is a clear statement which puts emphasis on how strength underlies unity. It is to be remembered that when people act in unison with each other, their strength increases manifolds. The significance of unity can be very well depicted by the nature also. Thin fibres of jute when twisted together into a rope can control the hugest of living being. Similarly, little drops of water together make up the seas and oceans and each grain of sand together makes up the whole world. Unity reigns supreme in every walk of our life. To achieve any goal professionally, the boss needs the support of his staff at all the hierarchical levels. If there is difference between the colleagues and if the team doesn’t work in unison, the goal can never be accomplished. Each and every person in a united team takes

charge of the success of the company. No big achievement can be made without unity on side. While playing a game of cricket or football, if the players don't have a united goal to make their team win, then irrespective of how much hard work the players pitch in, they won't be able to succeed.

Unity is very important as it pays in every sphere of human activities. The moral value of unity is often taught to the young ones through fables. A fable of a farmer and his quarrelsome sons points out how unity can defy all odds. The farmer asked his son to break a bundle of sticks. None of his son was able to do it, but each one of them could easily break the sticks when the bundles were open and untied. The farmer pointed to his sons about the importance of living united and the danger of living divided and separate. He further explained that unity has an inherent strength to it which has the power to protect them against all the harms from outside. Thus, it is evident that unity binds us whereas disunity leads to rack and ruin. Unity is a beast in itself. If two young boys are playing along and on the other side is a giant strong man, the wolf will run towards the man and not the young boys. Thus, it is necessary for the mankind to stay united, standing shoulder to shoulder so that no external evil can ever cheat and divide them.

The importance of unity is well described in the fight for independence of our country, India. The British applied the policy of 'Divide and Rule' to disintegrate the base of the nation for their own good. But over the years, many freedom fighters struggled and fought for the freedom but couldn't attain it because unity among Indians was absent. Initially, they were too apprehensive and timid to fight their opponents. But with constant motivation and encouragement by Gandhiji and other freedom fighters, the whole nation stood together to ultimately remove the foreigners from the country. The significance of unity in a nation can never be over-estimated. The complex belief system of the nation to say the least about the usefulness of unity cannot stand until and unless there is unity at the grassroot level. A society can be considered as a small unit of nation. People of

different mindsets, priorities and backgrounds constitute a society. Opinions and beliefs also vary among people. But when the essential unity is the organisation of a well-ordered society, it will without a doubt contribute to the organic unity of the nation in a way by which it will prosper and grow and of which it is an indivisible part of. National integration is thus the need of the hour, especially in days of extreme terrorism and extremism. Steps should be taken to eradicate social evils like caste system, dowry system, gender inequality and child labour so that our country can sync together in unison. Unity is certainly the strength of our country and Unity in diversity is an important feature which reflects that irrespective of varied diversity in the country, the countrymen are committed to their motherland.

Thus, it is for the people of the society to understand that the habit of cultivating unity should be inculcated among the young ones from the very beginning. Families should set up examples to define the concept of unity to the coming generation so that it reflects in their overall conduct and attitude towards the society and the nation. The habit of unity instils strength and power in the overall persona of the individual. It is important for each one of us to understand that forming strong and durable links with one another is essential to create a society, wherein unity prevails and prevents the citizens from disastrous consequences. 'United we stand, divided we fall' sums up the importance of staying in unison in every aspect of life to lead a happy and pompous life together.

You Cannot Believe in God Until You Believe in Yourself



Since the inception of mankind, human beings have believed that miracles are done by God. More often than not, people underestimate the role that self confidence plays in leading a successful life. Not only this, the belief in oneself is what makes miracles happen. In light of this, Swami Vivekananda rendered the statement “You cannot believe in God until you believe in yourself”. It highlighted the fact that belief in oneself is of prime importance and in order to believe in God, one must believe in himself. The power that they wield as they are the only ones who can make miracles happen and only when these miracles happen, we can believe in God. According to him, each soul is potentially divine and the only way to achieve this divinity is controlling both internal as well as external nature. He felt that belief in anything else is secondary.

A person's mind is the most powerful tool that can help to determine their future. Self confidence is a direct consequence of the assessment made by an individual about themselves, based on the successes and failures that they have endured in life. By placing blind trust in themselves, persons can achieve the goals that they want to achieve a hundred per cent as this belief will motivate them to work harder in order to achieve their goals. For many people, the belief in God overpowers their belief in themselves and they use this as an excuse to run away from solving problems using their own ability. Therefore, self confidence and self motivation are the pillars to a successful life.

Innovative minds have provided the world with answers to questions that were previously unanswered. These inventions have been made

by human beings themselves and have emerged as a result of extensive research spanning decades. Now, a number of diseases can be cured with the help of advanced medical and health care technology. Science has provided answers to the physical world around us. It has provided solutions to a plethora of problems and is the basis of modern civilization. With inventions like the bionic eye and 3D-printers, the face of the earth is changing. Access to information has been revolutionized due to the World Wide Web. Richard Feynman has rightly said “Religion is a culture of faith; Science is a culture of doubt.” Science advocates reason, empiricism and evidence; whereas religion advocates revelation, faith and sacredness.”

Human beings, aka the Homo sapiens are at the top of the animal classification due to their innate ability to meditate which acts as a key instrument while taking decisions. Meditation is the thought process that involves the engagement in mental exercise for the purpose of reaching an appropriate solution to a problem. Meditation has a profound effect on the human brain. It changes the way a person feels and thinks. Meditation has the power to change the physical structure of the brain which changes our subjective perceptions and feelings. This has a direct influence on the confidence level of an individual which enhances their performance in all aspects of life. Through meditation, a person develops self-awareness that helps them to gauge their strengths and weaknesses at a metaphysical level.

Throughout history, mankind has managed to come up with astonishing inventions that have changed the face of the earth and reinstated the belief that anything is possible once you set your mind to it. The things that had been deemed impossible then, are now turning into reality. Hundreds of centuries back, the concept of flying was only associated with God. According to Indian Mythology, Pushpaka Vimana or a flying chariot was mentioned in the Ramayana which was used by Ravana and then by Lord Rama. However, the Wright brothers who were fascinated by the concept of flying made this a reality for the people in the 20th century by inventing the

aeroplane which enabled the people to travel from one corner of the world to another revolutionizing the 21st century experience.

The invention of the incandescent bulb by Thomas Edison drastically changed the lives of people all over the world. It has become a basic necessity for people living in the 21st century. Alexander Graham Bell, in the 1870s invented the first practical telephone that revolutionized the way people communicated, transcending all geographical boundaries along with saving an enormous amount of time and effort. Louise Braille devised a unique system for reading and writing for the visually impaired, achieving what had been deemed impossible by people then. As time passed, the invention of computers and the internet offered a new way to access and store information. In the past few centuries, many people challenged all the odds and came up with inventions and discoveries that have revolutionized the world today. It is crucial to understand that these inventions would not have existed today if these people had not believed in themselves and their ideas, which in turn pushed them to utilize their potential efficiently.

The bone-chilling experiences of Arunima Sinha and Malala Yousafzai are truly inspirational for millions of people. Even though these two women endured hardships in their lives, gruesome consequences followed in the aftermath of the disastrous events that unfolded. These two brave women overcame their fears and emerged as even stronger human beings. Getting shot multiple times or losing a leg did not deter them from their mission. Arunima Sinha went on to become the first female amputee to climb Mount Everest. Even though Malala was always an education activist, her campaign intensified after her gruesome experience and she went on to win the Nobel Peace Prize in 2014. Their belief in themselves is what pushed them to achieve this great feat. Escaping the trap of death, they emerged as even stronger individuals, pushing themselves to make the most of what they have.

There are a number of people in this world who have achieved such great feats solely based on the belief they placed in themselves. Without belief in themselves, APJ Abdul Kalam wouldn't have

transitioned from a newspaper hawker to the missile man or Bill Gates wouldn't have become the youngest richest man. India wouldn't be free today without Mahatama Gandhi's use of non violence. Nelson Mandela's struggle against the brutal apartheid policies wouldn't have succeeded. The belief in themselves is what pushed all these people to make miracles happen. The path followed by all these people to success has not been the same; however, they carved their own paths and the only prerequisite to achieve this is self confidence in their ability which in turn fosters self motivation. The belief in oneself is of prime importance and serves as a way to believe in God. This is why Swami Vivekananda rightly said that you cannot believe in God until you believe in yourself.

The Greatest Sin is to think Yourself Weak



Swami Vivekananda said, “If faith in ourselves is more extensively taught and practised, I am sure a very large portion of evils and miseries that we have would have vanished”.

What we are discussing is to think oneself as weak, but when does one think oneself as weak, is when we are down, but this phase is the real test of character, mettle and grit one has within oneself to face adversities. People who wilt during adversities will always be unsure of their own success.

Usually we feel we are strongest, when we are going through highs, we feel we are weak when going through the lows. Both the emotions are wrong and misrepresent the truth.

Rather, when going through bad or low phase, one should always feel strong and remind oneself that he has battled many a battle and will win over this phase too, plus it's a challenge which everyone has to face in life. Sometimes we are critical of even the Almighty but we fail to accept that his decision is for our own good and betterment; hence, it's the time to feel stronger.

Similarly, when we are at high we are more prone to make mistakes; sometimes our vision is blurred by the brightness and glitter the success brings to our life, it's difficult to stand firm and unaffected by the glory and rewards.

In life, we have countless examples where high and mighty had a huge success or terrible falls but folklores are made of people who come back like sphinx and re-write their own success stories.

The most difficult aspect remains to garner one more fight and motivate oneself to pick up oneself from the deep depths of despair and sorrow to motivate and give it all. What is important is fair assessment of oneself in times of both good and bad.

“Hold yourself responsible for a higher standard than anybody expects of you. Never excuse yourself.” Henry Ward Beecher, the worse I believe is when people rather than accepting mistakes and failures and try to weed out the reason tried to blame people, situations, luck and every one, other than oneself. The reason is we are not always keen and ready to accept truth, own up our mistakes and work to remove them, as we feel it will question our competencies and prove us worthless and sometimes make us feel or answer uncomfortable questions. Thus, we try to run away from truth.

What is weakness, unable to deal with the situation we find ourselves in, maybe due to emotional or financial reasons, maybe due to social stigma or maybe we do not know how to deal with it? But weakness can be only dealt with truth which will lead us to strength, from darkness to light.

Thus, to be weak is a sin; it means we are not able to accept truth is also sin, hence no sinner is loved by any. Being grounded and understanding one's weakness is also strength, understand and marking ones are of improvement is also strength. As in life to succeed, it is important that we are aware of our strengths, weaknesses, threats and opportunities, it's also welcome to make real time assessment of the same, which is needed and helps us to create a road map, but do not get bogged down by the weaknesses or threats, as Albert Einstein said “Never judge a fish in its ability to climb a tree”, thus we should make correct assessment and also know “What is achievable and What is workable”, like any one with 5 feet 3 inches and 44 yrs male still cannot bat like Sachin Tendulkar, but one has to understand one's capability and then absorb or practice all the requisite hours of effort, grind and toil with single

mindful devotion and focus. This is what actual assessment is. This means one is prudent to accept the reality and ready to work towards improvement.

The only one way to overcome our weaknesses is to work towards our strengths and it can work wonders, like Mahatma Gandhi, improved his IQ late in life; so many real life examples around us where people late in life took education due to social, financial or family pressures yet excelled in them, so it's all in the mind.

Who and what motivates us from history, politics, movies, sports or say culture are the people who are winners but also who have faced odds, hardships and challenges and have conquered over them; they are also mere mortals like us, only difference is they have herculean self-believe and like many mythological figures done the impossible. Impossible is a state of mind, where somewhere we tell ourselves that we cannot do it. But my feeling is impossible means I have not given it my best shot, I have not given it all I got and after I have gave it all, I am sure I have not got anything more to give in form of effort, in form of focus, in form of determination or devotion, then only it's impossible for me.

Weakness in itself is not a crime, it is not a disease and it is not a calamity, until we fail to accept it, work towards it and try to overcome it to maximum. God has created human with weakness as well as strength but has left to the human to overcome it and strengthen his strength.

Be the Change You Want to See in Others



“Only I can change my life, No one Can do it for Me.” said Carol Barnett, this talks about the sheer will power to fight, and accepting one’s life needs to change or improve and then taking the responsibility to make changes rather than blaming all and sundry for any mishaps or any wrong or anything unexpected happening with our life.

In Life we always resist change, expect people to change and enjoy anything which changes to our advantage, be it climate or destiny, hence we prove only we do not want to change rather expect everyone to change to benefit us from it.

If you just wear your watch on the different hand than you usually wear, it will make you feel uncomfortable and create uneasiness in your being, whereas it does not harm you nor affects your physical health but gives you a feel of unease.

This above mentioned point gives us peek at the mindset of the people and how does change affect us. We as human are the best and most intelligent of species but we always have evolved and improved in due course of time so we can stay relevant on the planet and thus we have intrinsic ability to change but what prevents us is our mindset.

We love to see all the 4 seasons, that is God’s way of telling us the time to change and change is evident, even when we plant the tree, it takes us a full cycle to see it grow.

Human beings have always been adoptive to change and last 2 decades nearly saw our change in leaps and bounds and the rate of influx had been faster in 21st century, from 1984 onwards our lifestyle did change but last 20 years even our thought process,

patience and mode of communication, lookout towards life has changed.

Coming back to the topic, after all this change we feel the human values, humanity and love and affection has been now depleted and is being looked at as a weakness of people or weakness per se, somehow we have seen values are being deteriorated and people have become selfish.

But then the moment of truth arises that what have we done to change this discourse or change the course of action, rather than looking for some Messiah to come and solve the issue, what had been our effort, I may point out the best possible excuses will be :

1. What can I do? I am a simple person.
2. What can I do? I am neither a businessman nor a celebrity, who will listen to me?
3. I am stuck in my day to day grind of earning my livelihood? Where is the time?
4. There is no support from any agency at State or Centre level?

The above are the 4 most heard, said and listened to excuses, but still it does not talk about most important things which a human has, i.e., heart and compassion.

In life, we have seen, heard and read its only one person who started a journey towards a goal, changed the discourse of the world, from Mahatma Gandhi, Mother Teresa, Nelson Mandela we have long list of people, but I will not delve into that, I will rather talk about passion and heart and things we can do.

Can we not keep our Mohalla clean? Can we not stop from spitting be it cough, be it Paan, Gutka? Can we not throw our household garbage in the bins? Ok, you may feel I am talking something which is very minor and inconsequential, but you would see, if your mohalla is clean, roads are clean, it will look better than today; there will be less unhygienic conditions around you.

Visiting government buildings, you will see some walls painted red with beetle leaf juice, any number of white wash or paint is not the solution, but solution is not to spit. Similarly people driving two

wheelers at breakneck speed in areas filled with children, elderly, not doing so can also help us to reduce the number of accidents, hence, we can be the change.

If we do not waste electricity and water in our house, thus we can not only save money but also saving consumption and wastage. We can help the excess to be used by the deprived ones, we can also make sure optimum use of it, as we end up using lot of resources for each drop of water and electricity; thus, we can be the change.

Can we not be the change by being nice and good with others? Can we not be the change by sharing others grief and sorrow or can we not be the change by not accepting dowry or creating an awareness against it, also can we not make the street safe for females.

The answers to all these are - Yes. They may sound very minor but will create huge impact in the life and society per se in next one decade. This was the thought process which made Raja Ram Mohan Roy, Vidhya Sagar, revered and pioneer of modern India.

It's not what others do, it's what we think, we believe and act, will change the things around us, just being critical and being ignorant and being dumping the problem on others will not solve the issues. The country comprises of people, living, breathing, people who form the government, who form the beauracracy or who form different administrative bodies - these people, these members come from the society only. Thus we can say if we take steps and change then the people around us will change.

We give Raman Magsaysay award, Nobel Prize for Peace to individuals who have taken the initiative, worked relentlessly, faced uphill task and conquered the unconquerable mountains which others got panicked or lost heart. We read about them in papers, we talk about them and then we forget, but there is learning from it, if he can I can too.

This one effort will change the world around us, surely it will be slow and gradual but do understand that anything that is good and beneficial takes longer time than something that's destructive, it takes years to grow a Banyan tree and it takes from few hours to cut it, similarly it takes ages to build a city, town or place, it takes few bombs

to destroy the life and humanity in it, thus let's be the change which can bring smile to people than tears in their eyes.

We can safely conclude that the history is filled with characters who started on their own, their work and worth made them a hero for centuries. It is a lonely path, long walks, filled with failures, heart breaks and ridicule, where people around you will underestimate you for your passion and effort, but when you achieve success, it's just not for yours or the people around you, it is for the mankind and for centuries, be it Wright Brothers, Issac Newton, Jessie Owens or John Gutenberg. So, let's be the change that the change we expect others to be.

Failing to Prepare is Preparing to Fail



“I never could have done what I have done without the habits of punctuality, order, diligence, and the determination to concentrate myself on one subject at a time.” —Charles Dickens

The above heading is taken from Benjamin Franklin’s quote, “By failing to prepare, you are preparing to fail”. It is true that if you do not set goals beforehand or plan ahead in life, you cannot succeed in life.

Life in itself is a preparation for many a battle. Life is always a battlefield and only the ones who win remain in the memory. Did we meet Alexander the Great, Hercules, Tarzan, but we heard so many fascinating stories about them, did we meet Akbar, Rana Pratap or Ashoka , still we talk about their heroics. I do want to emphasise on the fact that these individuals remain etched in our memory for their success and for their bravery but for also never giving up while facing hardships and situations which were beyond their control or situations which were not normal thus what we do, we prepare to tackle the inevitable to win and conquer over them.

What is inevitable in life is to face tests, challenges and calamities, we all human have to face them in equal measures, be it king or pauper, all have to face the wrath and turbulence of time, but only those who survive are the ones who are well prepared. Those who believe it’s all destiny are correct partially but we can and we should give our share of toil, labour and sweat to prove to ourselves that we deserve this success and also we have earned it in hard way. Even if we are not successful then also we can at least take solace from the

fact we have tried our best and we could have not done anything better.

There are many people who have succeeded suddenly and then failed to live up to expectations, many might feel they are flash in the pans, it is not the case then they would not have succeeded in the bigger stage, but what faltered them was they were not prepared for the success or they took the success too casually or easily, this is a classic case of “Failing to Prepare is Preparing to fail” syndrome. The success brings with it limelight, entourage, fans, expectations and responsibility, again if you are not prepared for it, then you might fail to live up to the expectations and thus again reduce to or get lost in the darkness of anonymity.

The best part of Life that it is not static and it does not come with any syllabi, thus we complain when we are not able to make the best of an opportunity, this is the reason, we should always be prepared and we should always have plan A, B or C, many a time destiny has bigger things stored for us than we can ever think of.

People who are able to sustain their success in their Life and career are no doubt more prepared and more pragmatic, they act not react. It is not that Life does not throw them challenges, situations and difficulties, only these people are better prepared. They also have concern of performance and success, they are eager to succeed and will put more and more efforts to sustain this success, hence, they will be always prepared.

The very logical and relevant examples of this are in present world, students preparing for IIT–JEE, Medical entrance or IAS exams, the successful candidates who have qualified in one shot are few and far in between, it means they are hugely talented, hard working and focused but people who have cleared in few more attempts are mentally stronger and tougher as they have withstand failures, poor mental and financial (in some cases) constraints, ridicule and criticism of all to win over their challenges and conquer the unconquerable.

What make them stand out is the following:

1. They accepted their failures, which is most important to achieve success.
2. They never blamed anyone else for their failures, not got depressed.
3. They learned and accepted there is a better way to prepare and they will have to prepare in the other way, so they can get coveted success.
4. They gave their all again and again till they achieved it.

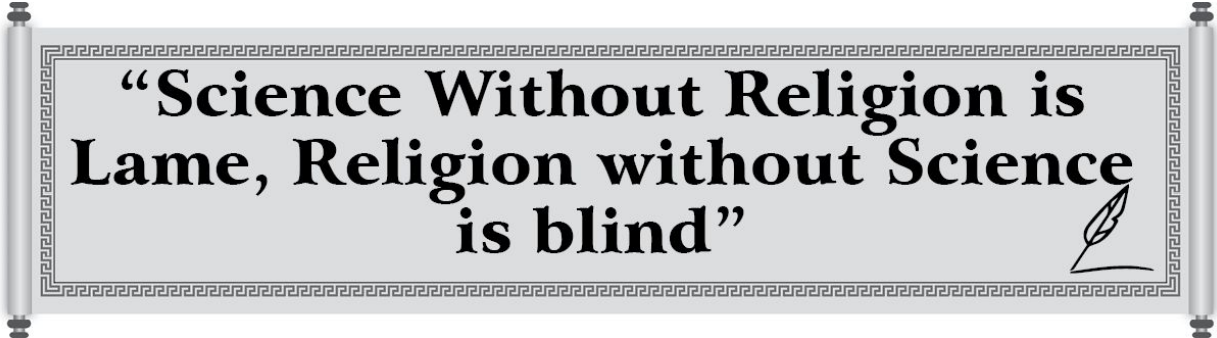
Thus the first thing they had to do was to plan, if the plan is not Right or appropriate, just execution can never be good enough to give desired results, also if the plan is not accurate then execution will leave something untouched, something unattempted thus will reduce the chances or odds of success. Thus, anyone who plans well gives himself chance of succeeding as it will make a person strive in the right direction.

Anyone who has prepared a plan in right place at least knows the destination and will make more scientific and strategic effort to reach the destination.

Compare this with a person who is working hard but without prepared plan, his efforts will not only be chaotic but also will be full of loose ends, as he will have something or other missing from his list of things to do or things to cover.

Then we will find the person without any plan will have some bright idea which will sometimes distract or keep him away from his daily schedule, as he is more of a maverick trier than constant pursuer.

This person will also succeed and also will do well but when a person with plan works hard, he has more settled approach, more stability, more fall back on his plan and hence the chances improve and there is method and credibility than chaoticness to be successful.



**“Science Without Religion is
Lame, Religion without Science
is blind”**

This quote “Science without religion is lame, religion without science is blind” was given by Albert Einstein and it talks about the equality in value of both science and religion. It suggests that one is not more important than the other, nor more correct than the other. They just express different ideas. There is a common point between the both. The creation of the universe followed an order, it was not created accidentally. Religion and science in this way complement each other as the world seems too beautiful for it to be created by pure coincidence. Both have different viewpoints of looking at the world.

This quote is taken from an article titled “Science, Philosophy and Religion, A Symposium” in 1941. In the published article, Einstein is being philosophical and abstract in an era where non-religion and pro-science were far less mainstream than today. The vast presence of religion within his audience was known to Einstein and other scientists and so he being an engineer of words tried to speak truthfully and objectively about a highly emotional and subjective topic without tripping wires in best possible way.

While science permits to see what is proven day to day, religion is based upon the belief in something that cannot be seen, but experienced. This belief is accepted by faith and spreads out because of having heard from someone who claimed it to be true. Religion and science throughout many years have been thought to be two rival forms of knowledge, but with time people have realised that science and religion have been more united than they have thought previously.

Science and religion are described as being different ways of looking at the world that complement each other and do not contradict each other. Both though have been in war during a long time and the conflict between the two can be easily explained through two incidents that have occurred in past. Galileo Galilei who was an Italian astronomer studied the planets and stars and discovered that the earth orbited the sun, which swapped the already existing notion of the people which suggested the earth to be the centre of the universe. This was taught until then and the Catholic Church reacted to Galileo's findings as they taught what the Bible said and put him to trial. Later, however the Church realized that Galileo was true and so it apologized but then what was done was done. This created a notion amongst people that religion and science were in competition.

Charles Darwin, a British scientist put forward the theory of evolution and stated that all life on the planet had evolved and living beings adapted to the environment in which they lived. People then believed that life was created in six days as quoted in the book of Genesis in the Bible. As both of these ideas contradicted each other; Darwin was hugely condemned. He explained that human beings were as important as other living creatures while Church taught that human beings were more special than other living creatures. These two incidents clearly depict the conflict between reason /science and faith/ religion. These views have now changed and people have accepted Darwin's theory.

In order to believe something, one needs to understand and rationalise why it is correct. A claim when made has to be defended and demonstrated to others in a proper understandable manner. The process of demonstration is though a scientific task, religion comes helpful in making people rely upon something greater in order to convert it into an acceptable faith.

Though their realms are clearly demarcated from each other, yet there exists a strong reciprocal relationship and dependency between the two. Religion might be the one determining the goal; it has learned the means that contribute to the attainment of goals set up by it, from science. Science can only be created by those who are

thoroughly imbued with the aspiration towards truth and understanding which are feelings springing from the sphere of religion.

The faith that belongs to this understanding believes in possibility of rationality of the regulations valid for the existence of the world. This rationality is comprehensible to reason. Any genuine scientist cannot be conceived without that profound faith. This quote therefore presents a clear picture where existence of religion or science in isolation is not conceivable.

Science teaches us to keep an open mind, to be curious and to ask questions. And in this quote, when Einstein said, “religion without science is blind”, he probably meant that we should not accept anything blindly. We should be careful in reading the theories presented by religion, we should analyse them critically, question them and look for contradictions. We ought to see if those theories should be applied and then decide if we want to believe or accept them.

As true science means knowing the truth and this feeling of knowing the truth, the longing to know the truth is a derivation of religion. Science cannot explain everything and it is also difficult to follow the blind faith in religion. So, without the foundational faith in the universal order, Science will not be able to function. And this universal order is maintained by the energy of God, the almighty.

The blindness of religion without Science means that to verify what is written in scriptures, Science is a requisite. Science ascertains what is and does not what should be. Value judgements of all kinds remain necessary outside of its domain. Religion, on the other hand, deals with evaluations of human thought and action. Thus, speaking of facts and relationships between facts is not justifiably spoken by religion.

This quote reflects upon the thought of personal development going hand in hand with scientific progress. That is, people who strive to

understand the universe should also look to improving the character through which the universe is experienced. Religion is the pursuit of the highest qualities of an individual – it's a striving to improve one's thoughts, speech and actions. It is about overcoming the smallness of individualistic and petty thinking by cultivating a more expansive, enlightened state. Where religion teaches you to use your faith instead of using logic and knowledge; there science demands gaining knowledge to understand the logic behind everything.

Peace – Not Merely the Absence of War but the Presence of a Better Life



“Peace cannot be kept by force; it can only be achieved by understanding.” —Albert Einstein

History is a testimony of wars, and peace is still a dream yet to be achieved. Countries talk about world peace but they prepare for war by inventing newer weapons in the name of defence budget. World Wars have now subsided to give way to smaller ones which are still uglier. The world wars continued for years, however, these small wars may last for even longer.

Mankind or human race has been surviving on planet earth for over fifty thousand years or perhaps much longer and during this period of man's 'evolution' he still hasn't found peace. He's since been living in conflict, not only with his neighbour, community, family, society but with himself as well. He's been struggling and fighting against other men.

Humanity's concern for peace is apparent from the fact that around the world all religions and their scriptures and ceremonies preach the practice of peace and the need for elimination of war. The Hindus recite Shanti Path, Christians follow the verses of Bible and the sermons of Pope, Muslims follow the holy Quran and all other communities globally have a sacred commitment to peace. There have been many talks such as 'pacem in terris' or 'peace on earth' and goodwill among men; however, it has not truly come around.

It makes one question 'Why man kills another human being?' either in the name of god or religion or some ideology or maybe for their country. After living on this beautiful planet Earth since centuries now,

why it is that man cannot live peacefully. For over two millennia, the dominant paradigm of the most influential civilisations has been led by the desire of possession or avariciousness, conquest, voracity, militarism, violence, inequality, injustice resulting in war.

It really makes us wonder whether we as human beings, individuals or a family or a community can live peacefully with one another. There are many organisations working towards the goal of 'world peace' but they may never succeed as human beings are in conflict – individually, collectively and nationally. And these organisations cannot possibly bring peace, as each individual is different with a different set of beliefs, which no one is ready to bend. Because a lot of people do not respect each other, it will require a great deal of strength to bring about peace in this world.

It was only after a disaster that the international community learned the prime importance of virtue of peace against the evil of war, when we suffered the cataclysm of most ill-fated and highly lethal two world wars in the first half of the 20th century. Humanity bled a great deal with its pieces lying around hundreds of battle grounds, especially on the lands of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. People cried only for peace – peace on earth.

After the World War concluded, the military industrial complex began their work to achieve some outstanding technological breakthroughs. Across the globe, nations were engaged in a competition to produce the best technologies and people saw the inventions of man-portable missiles, spy satellites, and a plethora of other gadgets that are still used in today's combat operations. Even today, undesirable qualities such as distrust, greed and ego are apparent, leading to even more chances of unnecessary disasters. This is precisely why world peace plays an important role in maintaining a harmonious relationship among people.

Following the havoc caused by World War II, the United Nations was set up in 1945 with core mission: the maintenance of international peace and security. Since then, the UN has been tremendously

working towards preventing and resolving conflict among member nations and thus creating peaceful conditions. The UN Security Council has the primary responsibility for international peace and security.

Pope Francis recently sent a message to Elayne Whyte Gomez, president of the UN Conference to negotiate a legally binding instrument to prohibit nuclear weapons, leading towards their total elimination, held at UN headquarters in New York on March 27-31, 2017. The Pope questioned the UN meeting on nuclear arms saying “How sustainable is stability based on fear, when it actually increases fear and undermines relationships of trust between peoples. Today’s threats to global peace and security must be countered through dialogue and development, not nuclear weapons.”

However, many nations, several of which already possess nuclear weapons boycotted the discussions for banning such weapons. The United States, France, The United Kingdom and approximately 40 other nations were included in this. However, some nations persisted on supporting the Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons and weapon technology.

One tool to assess the current peace scenario is the Global Peace Index (GPI). It is an attempt to measure the relative position of nations’ and regions’ peacefulness. It is used as a benchmark for global peace using three broad factors: the level of safety and security in society, the extent of domestic and international conflict and the degree of militarisation. Both internal and external factors are viewed. Internal factors such as levels of violence and crime within the country and external such as military expenditure and wars.

The 2017 GPI indicates Iceland, New Zealand, Portugal, Austria, and Denmark to be the most peaceful countries and Syria, Afghanistan, Iraq, South Sudan, and Yemen to be the least peaceful. It also stated that the world slightly improved in peace last year but has become less peaceful over the last decade. There has been a decline in

militarisation over the past three decades and globally, the economic impact of violence on the economy is enormous.

Though findings from GPI look assuring, the ongoing wars across the world speak something else. The war in Syria continued for more than six years and has claimed the lives of more than a quarter of a million people. The fight for one person being in power has caused havoc and made millions escape from their home in search of a new home, a 'safe' place. The images from any major Syrian city in 2017 reflect the typical intensity of damage in modern warfare. Destruction is evident not only in private houses and businesses but crucial infrastructure including electricity, water supply, telecommunications, schools and health facilities, everything turned to rubble.

Another example of a country in dire need of peace is Africa. Africa is faced with rampant conflicts in some of its countries with consequent negative effects to the economic, political and social lives of their citizens and neighbouring countries. A study by Africa Action, an activism website for Africa, states "It is important to note that most of Africa is not at war. However, where conflicts do exist, they affect not only the stability of the countries involved, but also their neighbours and the entire sub-region."

Today we see a lot of people who have been uprooted in many parts of Africa. It has the highest population of refugees and orphans. Since decades, many people have not experienced normal life. During the seventies, regimes in Africa were seen promoting strife and conflict, creating massive upheavals in the life of the people, creating huge numbers of misplaced persons who are moving around with no place to go. And the infrastructure, because of this ongoing conflict in Africa, has destroyed many of the communities, destroyed our mission stations. Many of our economies in Africa are dysfunctional because of this ongoing regional conflict. Furthermore, the number of people living with AIDS has increased with no care provided by governments. The problem of AIDS has been so

devastating that the potential labour force is being destroyed. So we face a crisis, a deep crisis, in many parts of Africa today.

Another static, long-distance trench war is ongoing in Europe along the 250 miles of front lines in eastern Ukraine with tanks, artillery, machine guns, snipers, land mines, and trenches give a tremor down your spine. Ukrainian servicemen are fighting pro-Russian separatists in Avdiivka, Donetsk region. Furthermore, the terror attacks of London Bridge outside Ariana Grande concert in Manchester, England, Saint Petersburg Bombing and Champs Elysees attack in Paris, all highlight the importance of nations working harmoniously and fighting out terrorism to achieve global peace.

Thus, the popular thought that absence of war is peace is myopic and defective. It is similar to thinking that absence of disease is health. Health is a positive state of complete physical, mental, and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease, or infirmity. Similarly, peace is a positive state where exists social justice and brotherhood in an enabling environment and not merely absence of war.

Peace is the mother of progress. Without peace a nation cannot make any progress. So, peace is ever desirable. For all those who inhabit the earth, face this choice – whether peace is to be achieved only after the unimaginable happenings as a result of human's stubborn behaviour or it is to be adopted now as an act of consultative will.

**Without Conversion of Mind and Heart,
the Social Structure that Perpetuate
Inequality, cannot be Destroyed**

“We may have different religions, different languages, different coloured skin, but we all belong to one human race”.

—Kofi Annan

The human society is inflicted by many social evils. The social structures of the nations have imbibed these evils in a way that they have now become a crucial part of it. Inequality is one such thing which has become a part of the society to which we belong. It is prevalent in all areas of the society. Social inequality is referred to as the existence of unequal opportunities and rewards for different social statuses within a society. Inequality in terms of power, religion, age, kinship, prestige, race, ethnicity, gender and class has been brought up in the society. On the basis of the same, people of the society behave in a certain way. Discrimination is often seen as a consequence of inequalities.

To make this world a better place and to inculcate good values in the future generations, these social evils of inequality need to be diminished. Equality is the need of the hour if the human society needs to live a sustainable and peaceful life. However, without conversion of mind and heart, the social structure that perpetuates inequality cannot be destroyed. To root out this evil, combined effort of the people of the society across the globe is required. A society without such evil may seem a distant dream but it is certainly not impossible. It is time that the citizens of the world get ready to mould their minds and be more accepting. It is time that they realise their responsibility towards the society. It is time that they understand that social evils can destroy the beauty of mankind and make it a horrible

place to live in. It is by practice and constant corrections that they will be able to loosen the hold of inequality that clutches their mind. To weed out this evil, we need to start from the grassroot level.

Inequality weakens the society. The society is made by the people and for the people. And discriminating a group on the basis of some aspect makes one extremely low. In this man dominated world, women are at the receiving end of inequality as well. Gender inequality is a part of all other forms of inequality. Discrimination is often done on the basis of sex, gender and gender roles. Not only can it be seen in backward and developing nations, but it is also present in the developed nations. Even today in the age of globalisation and education, women are not getting their dues. They are still considered the weaker sex in comparison with their male counterparts despite them proving themselves repeatedly in all areas of life.

Women face exploitation right from the time they are born. They are considered a liability instead of an asset. Being the basic unit of the society who is responsible for actual run of the life on Earth, women are merely treated as a subordinate to men. The other form of inequality is on the basis of status. Rich are usually treated with high regard and respect while the poor faces the flake. Discrimination on the basis of colour is also easily evident when one travels abroad. Racism is a direct repercussion of the dying humanism. Inequality is everywhere. But one as a responsible citizen of the world needs to take the step forward to change.

Change in mindset is very important if one seeks equality. Over the years, our minds have been trained to behave and accept the inequality and wrong that is growing in our society. Only few take the leap to stand for the right, rest are either not bothered or not too bold to take any stance for right and wrong. Inequality in all aspects is wrong. One needs to accept that all human beings are equal. It is God who decides their sex, colour, caste, race and religion. The soon we start accepting everyone as equal, the world will start becoming a

beautiful place. It is all in our mind. The upbringing, the real life scenarios that we come across that define inequality in all forms, the moral values we have inculcated all needs to be refurbished. And this acceptance can only be possible if we open our heart to everyone with the approach of equality for all irrespective of factor that perpetuates inequality. The road is certainly long, but every step will count. There needs to be change in the education pattern, the folk and regional stories which manifests inequality in some or the other form needs to be changed, the importance of equality should be defined so as to make each and everyone know how bad it feels to be treated unequal.

To abate inequality from our society is not that easy but not that difficult too. We have the power of social media these days. If this platform is used correctly, it can be highly beneficial to spread the word about equality. But before that, each one of us needs to make up our minds to cut this evil from the society. If we pledge to root out inequality and join hands to counter this problem by treating everyone at the same level, we will have half game won. It is to be noted that it is for the citizens of the Mother Earth which gives equal rights to live, use water, share land and breathe the same air. If She doesn't treat the living beings unequally, then who are we as humans to define equality and inequality. This small message should be perpetuated across lower sections of the society to make them aware of this evil which they think as a way of life. The children, the youth and the old - all need to be awakened with a converted mind and open heart to a world where only equality and righteousness prevails.

Without Conversion of Mind and Heart, the Social Structure that Perpetuate Inequality,

Socio-Political Philosophy of Vivekananda



“I have faith in my country and especially in the youths of my country...With an immense amount of feeling and enthusiasm in the blood, will come heroes who will march from one corner of the earth to the other, preaching and teaching the eternal spiritual truths of our forefathers.”

Swami Vivekananda firmly believed in the spiritual and physical awakening of the Indian youths for their achievement of a glorious future ahead. He had all throughout his life spoken to boost the youths from the core so that they could become the vehement catalysts in shaping the destiny of their nation. Vivekananda wanted the youths to instil tremendous faith in themselves such that India could be revived to the fullest and Indian ideas spread far and wide and be a component of the “many forces that are working to make up every nation in this world.”

It is universal to believe that youth is that period of time when the reservoir of energy flows perpetually, creativity is at its zenith and the indomitable spirit never appears thrashed and exhausted. These are the actual resources for the building of a nation. The Swami’s clarion call to the youths is that they must invest their collective energies into the restructuring of this nation and place it at a sky-high pedestal. He calls upon the youth to set off and conquer the world with Indian spirituality and philosophy and he convinced everyone that it is a condition of do or die.

Vivekananda inspires the Indian youths to be dauntless in their approach to the world. The moment one fears, he is nobody. Fear, he

believed, is the greatest cause of misery and woes in this world. Of all superstitions, fear is the greatest. A man with no fear can even bring down heaven at his threshold. The holy ascetic asked the youths to be morally so affluent that they could live for the sake of others because life is too transient and the vanities of the world would not be hovering for long. He believed that one really lives who lives for the others, the rest are more dead than alive. The youths must at the inception realize what there is within them, the power to do anything and everything; what is considerably indispensable is merely the belief that the self is not weak and can at any time stand up and express divinity.

Youth is the only time when the future is decided and the future could be decided only when there is freshness and vigour, rather not when one is jaded and worn out. Like the Vedas, the Swami also believed that “It is the young, the strong, and healthy, of sharp intellect that will reach the Lord.” Of many things spoken by the Swami, the focus and internalization on the three H’s apparently proves pertinent for the youths. The first H is the heart which is very necessary to feel for the poor, the downtrodden and the marginalized. It is only with the driving force of the emotions that one can inspire oneself and the others to think beyond the ordinary mundane existence. But there may still be limitations at times when the emotional reaction acts in isolation. Thus, there is a second H which refers to the head. For sorting out solutions to the intricate political, social, economical and poverty issues, the youths need a healthy head to think and strategize upon the problems afflicting India. And only feeling and thinking upon the problems would not suffice. They must be accompanied by the hands, the third H, to implement the plans and strategies into concrete structures. With utmost discipline and strong will, the youths must work their hands to translate emotions and thoughts into pragmatic actions. Only then can the youths help in realizing Vivekananda’s dreams of a strong and better India.

And the youths really responded. The anti-corruption demonstrations in India in the recent past were witness to the very fact. But had that

been carried out through an organized procedure of the three H's as shown to us by Vivekananda, it would have made a huge difference and a far better impact. To honour this great ascetic and sincere well-wisher of the Indian youths, the Indian government had in the year 1984 declared 12th of January, the day of birth of the Swami, as the National Youth Day and since 1985 it has been celebrated every year. The inspiring, poignant words spoken to the convened youths by the former Indian Prime Minister Dr Manmohan Singh on the occasion of the National Youth Day in 2011 are worth noting, "What Gandhiji said captures the great importance of spreading Swami Vivekananda's ideas and ideals among the youth in our country today. He personified the eternal energy of the youth and their restless quest for truth...We must work to rekindle the eternal message of this great patriot and son of India."

The message is like crystal, the only prerequisite is the sole aspect of awakening, the belief in the power of the self, the belief of rendering the fearless hero what Vivekananda preached years ago in his seminal speeches. Above all, the youths to bring forth their inert power and to keep marching forward inevitably, must only recollect the simple, plain words spoken by the great Swami, "Arise, awake and stop not till the goal is reached."

What You Really Need to Succeed – EQ or IQ



Research has suggested that some people are more successful in their careers than others even when they have had equal educational and experiential opportunities. One explanation for these disparities may relate to differences between intellectual intelligence (IQ) and emotional intelligence (EQ). IQ measures academic competencies or one's ability to use knowledge in making decisions and adapting to new situations. On the other hand, EQ is a measure of emotional and social competencies or one's ability to identify emotional expressions in oneself and others. Although both can be improved through training and are changed over time, EQ is distinct from IQ in a sense that it is one's ability to regulate emotions in response to environmental stimuli. EQ has been popularised as a learned skill that is a better predictor of life success than intellectual attainment or technical ability.

This anomaly threw a massive wrench into what many people had always assumed was the sole source of success - IQ. Decades of research now point to emotional intelligence as the critical factor that sets star performers apart from the rest of the pack. Emotional intelligence is that "Unique Something" in each of us that is a bit intangible. It affects how we manage behaviour, navigate social complexities, and make personal decisions that achieve positive results.

Emotional Quotient (EQ), also called Emotional Intelligence Quotient, is a measurement of a person's ability to monitor his or her emotions, to cope with pressures and demands, and to control his or her thoughts and actions. The ability to assess and affect situations and relationships with other people also plays a role in emotional

intelligence. This measurement is intended to be a tool that is similar to intelligence quotient (IQ), which is a measurement of a person's intellect.

Emotional intelligence taps into a fundamental element of human behaviour that is distinct from the intellect. There is no known connection between IQ and emotional intelligence; one simply can't predict emotional intelligence based on how smart someone is. Intelligence is the ability to learn, and it's the same at age 15 as it is at age 50. Emotional intelligence, on the other hand, is a flexible set of skills that can be acquired and improved with practice. Although some people are naturally more emotionally intelligent than others, one can develop high emotional intelligence even if it's not innate.

When psychologists began to write and think about intelligence, they focused on cognitive aspects, such as memory and problem-solving. However, there were researchers who recognized early that the non-cognitive aspects were also important. For instance, David Wechsler defined intelligence as "the aggregate or global capacity of the individual to act purposefully, to think rationally, and to deal effectively with his environment". He referred to non-intellective as well as intellective elements, by which he meant affective, personal, and social factors. Furthermore, Wechsler was proposing that the non-intellective abilities are essential for predicting one's ability to succeed in life.

Wechsler was not the only researcher who saw non-cognitive aspects of intelligence to be important for adaptation and success. Robert Thorndike, was writing about "social intelligence" in the late thirties. Unfortunately, the work of these early pioneers was largely forgotten or overlooked until 1983 when Howard Gardner began to write about "multiple intelligence."

Gardner published a book called *Frames of Mind* in which he argued that the dominant forms of intelligence associated with linguistic, logical and mathematical ability should be supplemented by five (later seven) others. The new intelligences included (as well as musical, spatial and kinaesthetic intelligences), interpersonal and intrapersonal

intelligence. Interpersonal intelligence was defined as ‘the ability to understand people, what motivates them, how they work, how to work cooperatively with them’; while intrapersonal intelligence involved ‘access to one’s own feeling life’, and ‘the capacity to form an accurate, veridical model of oneself, and to be able to use that model to operate effectively in life’.

For decades, researchers studied the reasons why a high IQ does not necessarily guarantee success in the classroom or the boardroom. By the 1980s, psychologists and biologists, among others, were focusing on the important role other skill sets - needed to process emotional information - played in promoting worldly success, leadership, personal fulfilment and happy relationships.

In 1990, psychologists John Mayer and Peter Salovey theorized that a unitary intelligence underlay those other skill sets. They coined the term, emotional intelligence, which they broke down into four “branches”:

1. **Perceiving Emotions:** The first step in understanding emotions, to accurately perceive them, it involves understanding nonverbal signals such as body language and facial expressions.
2. **Reasoning with Emotions:** The next step involves the use of emotions to promote thinking and cognitive activity which help prioritize what we pay attention and react to.
3. **Understanding Emotions:** The emotions that we perceive can carry a wide variety of meanings. If someone is expressing angry emotions, the observer must interpret the cause of their anger and what it might mean.
4. **Managing Emotions:** The ability to manage emotions effectively is a key part of emotional intelligence. Regulating emotions, responding appropriately and responding to the emotions of others are all important aspect of emotional management.

As a science reporter for the New York Times, Daniel Goleman was exposed to Mayer’s and Salovey’s work and took the concept of

emotional intelligence a step further. In his eponymous book from 1995, he argued that existing definitions of intelligence needed to be reworked. IQ was still important, but intellect alone was no guarantee of adeptness in identifying one's own emotions or the emotional expressions of others. It took a special kind of intelligence, Goleman said, to process emotional information and utilize it effectively - whether to facilitate good personal decisions, to resolve conflicts or to motivate oneself and others.

Goleman broadened Mayer's and Salovey's four-branch system to incorporate five essential elements of emotional intelligence or EQ:

1. **Self-awareness:** Self-awareness means having a deep understanding of one's emotions, strengths, weaknesses, needs, and drives. People with strong self-awareness are neither overly critical nor unrealistically hopeful. Rather, they are honest - with themselves and with others. People who have a high degree of self-awareness recognize how their feelings affect them, other people, and their job performance.
2. **Self-regulation:** Controlling one's impulses - instead of being quick to react rashly, one can reign in the emotions and think before responding. It can also be defined as extrinsic and intrinsic processes responsible for monitoring, evaluating, and modifying emotional reactions.
3. **Motivation:** A passion to work for internal reasons that go beyond money and status which are external rewards such as an inner vision of what is important in life, a joy in doing something, curiosity in learning, a flow that comes with being immersed in an activity; a propensity to pursue goals with energy and persistence.
4. **Empathy:** The ability to understand the emotional makeup of other people; a skill in treating people according to their emotional reactions. This is only possible when one has achieved self-awareness as one cannot understand others until they understand themselves.

5. Social Skills: Identifying social cues to establish common ground manage relationships and build networks. Social skill, rather is friendliness with a purpose: moving people in the direction one desires whether that's agreement on a new marketing strategy or enthusiasm about a new product.

These qualities may sound “soft” and unbusinesslike, but Goleman found direct ties between emotional intelligence and measurable business results.